

VILE
HOUSE I



IN SICKNESS
WE FIND
HEALTH

SICK BARGAIN

NORDIKA NIGHT

SICK BARGAIN

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OceanofPDF.com

SICK BARGAIN [VILE HOUSE BOOK 1]

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ISBN: 978-1-0691308-0-8

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SICK BARGAIN

VILE HOUSE

BOOK 1

NORDIKA NIGHT



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For anyone who has ever been cursed

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CONTENTS

[Mind Your Mentals](#)

1. [To Vile House](#)
2. [Deals With Danger](#)
3. [Template For Destruction](#)
4. [Sick](#)
5. [Left For Dead](#)
6. [Trigger Words](#)
7. [Burn Or Run](#)
8. [Irrational Asshole](#)
9. [Unmasked](#)
10. [Show Me What's Mine](#)
11. [Sorrowful Songs & Breakfast](#)
12. [Midnight Diner](#)
13. [Infect Me](#)
14. [You Trust Too Easily](#)
15. [For Better or For Worse?](#)
16. [We Hunt](#)
17. [Feelings I Can't Name](#)
18. [Space & Friends](#)
19. [Am I Important To You?](#)
20. [Failure](#)
21. [Not Even Death, Remiel](#)
22. [Play, Remiel](#)
23. [I Feel](#)
24. [Playing Reaper](#)
25. [Love is Obsession](#)
26. [Sicker Together](#)
27. [Conflicted Freedom](#)
28. [A New Enemy](#)
29. [Don't Be Naïve](#)
30. [This is a Human Brain](#)

31. [Cut Here](#)
32. [Who Am I Now?](#)
33. [The Mad House](#)
34. [Haunting & Lovely](#)
35. [Give Me Fear](#)
36. [Epilogue](#)
37. [+++ Rank+++](#)

[+++Devil's Night Bonus Scene+++](#)

[Instrumental Music Played](#)

[Thank You!](#)

[Also By Nordika Night](#)

[Nordika Night](#)

[CONTENT GUIDE](#)

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MIND YOUR MENTALS

Please take note of the Content Guides at the back of the book. Mind your mentals and jump to the list here:

[Content Guide](#)

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TO VILE HOUSE

REMIEL

TERROR HAS a taste and fear makes us irrational. The speed of my feet matches the pace of my rapid heart, and the horror crawling up my spine spurs me down the street even faster.

I'm trapped between two fears: the one chasing me, and the one I'm irrationally running towards. Both gag me with a bitter aftertaste, complemented by the prickly feeling at the base of my skull.

There's a house in the middle of town. A big house, old and gothic, with an ominous air that has opposite effects on people—it repels them, or it draws them in. For years, I've firmly sat in the repelled category, with absolutely no desire to know if the myths and rumours about its occupants are true. I'm not the type to go looking for trouble.

But tonight, trouble has stalked me. Trouble has *caught* me.

The hairs on my nape stand up and the fear that crawled up my spine shoots back down like an electrical warning signal, making my legs pump harder. I've seen the movies, know the rules, and under no circumstances should I look behind me to see how far back he is. I keep my eyes forward and my steps steady for a whole block before the creepy feeling intensifies.

The cognitive distortion makes me more irrational and I look.

The street is vacant. Most of the streetlights don't work, so the shadows are the most menacing thing, but he's there. I know he is. I know it in the soft patter of stalking steps and the phantom whoosh of air that breathes down my neck every time I slow down. I know it in the way my palms sweat and my heart ticks quicker. I might not be able to prove it, but my body has always been good at giving me warning signs.

I'm not someone who will ignore the chills. I can't write off the shaking as anything but fear. I won't discount the alarm bells that have been going off in my mind since I stepped foot outside my shop. He's following me, and I don't know where else to lead him.

I have no other choice.

The house sits at the end of a cul-de-sac, and despite it being a dead end, I'm taking the risk. I'm luring him there in the hopes the rumours are true. Because the man chasing me has done enough damage, and I'm finally at my breaking point. He needs to go, the man who haunts me. I need to take the power away from him, even if it also takes *my* power away from *me*.

Vile House started as a sanatorium for tuberculosis patients, but over the years, it became a psychiatric facility. The need to expand into a bigger hospital turned Vile House into only a small portion of it, and now the main building, a fully functioning asylum, sits on the edge of town. Back then, it was called VILE for a different reason. *Virtuous Innovations for Living Exceptionally*. It was a place that healed as much as it hindered, conducted non-sanctioned experiments, and created an even darker history. Now, if the rumours can be believed, VILE stands for something much different. I don't know if the acronym is true, and I've never wanted to, but tonight, I'm putting my faith in the whispered meaning.

Virtue In Lives Exchanged.

They're a society that has lived and breathed in Moros since the beginning of time, weaved into Moros' history just like the asylum. Respected as much as they are feared. Well-known while remaining a mystery.

Something metal clanks off a lamp post behind me. Too close behind me. I pick up my pace and hold back a whimper, refusing to let fear fail me again. Up ahead, the blackened yard of Vile House waits for me, luring me like it never has before. Not a single light is on inside, and the porch is just as dark as the street. It always looks shadowy, but that doesn't mean it's unoccupied. It means the occupants are comfortable in the dark, slinking around in the dead of night, keeping the locals in check and remaining mostly hidden under the cover of their unknown identity.

"Remi."

Fucking fuck. I start to run faster, fleeing from the sound of my name on the wind and the imagined breath against my nape. I sprint past the

neighbours' darkened houses, my eyes on Vile House. I could be making the biggest mistake of my life, but I rapidly weighed the pros and cons on my sprint here, deciding that if I don't take the risk, I'll be dead by morning. Dying is the one thing I refuse. Not yet. I have something to do first. And if the man at my back catches me tonight, he'll force me to succumb to my family curse.

Our town isn't named after the personification of impending doom for nothing. Moros, a secluded town with a daunting, depraved kind of history, is a tourist trap for sinister minds and occult fanatics, and I've lived here my whole life without taking its bait. Tonight, I'm the tourist lured to the honey trap in the dead centre of town.

"Remiel Sauder," the wind carries my name in his voice, skirting down my back and quickening my last steps.

The iron gate is open, and I run through it with no resistance. I don't have time to fear the covered windows, the slipping shutters, the gargoyles and the statues that sit in the yard like watchdogs. I don't even fear the eyes I feel drawing me in, the promise of protection in its worst form. No, I run through it all and bang my fist on the door, sparing a single glance behind me.

Emptiness. *But I know.* I know he's there. And he's not alone tonight. I sense the second person, nostalgic and full of betrayal.

"Vile House!" I shout, banging on the dark wooden door. "Help me! I have a bargain!" Because they permit no one entry without a bargain. "I want to exchange a life!"

I bang both fists on the door, trying not to cry at the sound creeping up the porch steps behind me. Not footsteps, but something smoother, slinkier. Someone dangerous and unhinged. Someone comfortable in the night. I recognize the movements because they've been pursuing me for years.

"Vile House! Please!" I bang harder.

The one trailing me is right behind me, steps away from snatching me. From turning me into another missing person statistic in Moros. From snuffing out the life I've barely lived. He won't kill me, but he won't stop until I kill myself. It's a sick game we play, and I'm done being a chess piece.

Moros is a town run by cults, societies, and gangs, but the individual after me is more dangerous than a cult, and he is the wicked reason my lifespan is dwindling by the month.

My trip to madness has already begun, and holding onto my sanity gets harder by the minute.

“Please! I have a bargain!” I bang again, fear creeping into my voice.

No lights turn on and no one stands in the doorway, but it opens and the presence behind me drifts away into the night. The threat at my back vanishes for now, but the one ahead of me is just as dangerous.

Pick your poison, Remi.

I stare through the blackened doorway, trying to make sense of the hallway and the absence of any people. I may not see them, but I know they’re in there—I feel them. Moros has given me a sixth sense, and I trust it. I feel people more than I see them. I sense their energy and their presence, and I know for an absolute fact that at least a few sets of eyes are on me right now.

Chancing a look behind me, the street has turned calm. The persistent stalker at my back is lingering elsewhere, but I know he’s biding his time, waiting until I’m alone and away from Vile House.

Did I lure him here or did he herd me? The second man I sensed... did he lure me?

“Whose life are you exchanging?” a voice asks from inside.

The biggest mistake of my life happened when I was seventeen years old. Bred and brainwashed into a family that worshipped the town’s violent history, I mistakenly gave my loyalty to the beliefs of a cult. Tonight, I’m putting it in the hands of Vile House.

“Mine,” I say, head high despite this becoming the new biggest mistake of my life. “Remiel Sauder.”

No one says anything or invites me inside, but the atmosphere changes, and I know what it means. It means I’m permitted entry to Vile House, and once I step inside, my life will no longer belong to me.

Because Moros has secrets, and Vile House is its best-kept one.

DEALS WITH DANGER

REMIEL

DEATH ISN'T SCARY. To die means to stop existing. The absence of life means the absence of feeling, and to be snuffed out is almost a gift. There's no suffering in death, no pain and no fear. It's the complete obliteration of sensation and feeling, a freedom so infinite I often wish for it.

But Moros doesn't offer death as freely as it offers something worse, and because of this choice, life as I know it will end, and tomorrow, it'll be a nightmare of my own making. Because I've never even tried to get out and make a better decision.

Why didn't you leave?

Why can't you leave Moros and start somewhere new?

Get out while you still can!

The town is a black pit. Why do so many stay?

Because our blood is here. We're weaved into the roots of the trees and fed by the nourishment in the soil. We're trapped in a town that owns us, but it's trapped by us just as harshly. Moros offers a circular pattern of life with no true moment of birth and no finite moment of death. It's existence and nonexistence. It's a lifestyle few would choose but so many are consumed by. It's home because we are addicted to it.

Simply put, if you are bred by Moros, you remain in Moros. Not many get out, and if they do, they aren't fit to survive in the regular world. Our town is a death trap that tourists visit willingly, but for those of us who are born here, our willingness isn't up for negotiation. We become as contemptible as our home.

As the front door of Vile House closes behind me, my eyes take a moment to adjust to the darkness of the entryway. My fear from earlier isn't gone. It's just different now. More ominous and less imminent. Still brutal. But living in fear is a distinctive part of who I am, so I'm comfortable enough in it.

"This way," someone says.

I follow the voice and the footsteps without seeing the person. I'm not ready to see them, anyway. My mind is having too hard of a time meshing every bit of lore and gossip I've heard about the Vile Boys with the understanding that I'm about to meet them. Or some of them.

It's said they're grotesque and deformed, a product of inbreeding and generations of seclusion. I've also heard that they're general members of the public, but their involvement in Vile House is kept secret. It's been rumoured that they're town officials, sons of council members, or friends I've known all my life. The only fact I know for sure is that they go through an initiation process annually, and when it's complete, the town wakes up to a partially cleaned bloodbath. On initiation nights, if you're caught outside of your home, you're fair game. And since I've never wanted to be fair game, I've stayed the hell inside.

I don't know what I believe and what I don't, but one thing is certain: I've always been afraid of this house.

Its sounds chill me to the bone. The clanking and shrieking are either a figment of my imagination or real and dulled. I don't know, and I mostly don't want to. I'm here either way. I don't need to know what else is real.

As I follow a shadow through the halls, the darkness recedes incrementally. Furniture becomes clear in the living room, doors and hallways are dimly lit as we pass, and the man ahead of me takes form.

He's dressed in black and has a hood over his head, and since he's leading me, I can't make out anything descriptive about him. But that's the least of my worries. The house itself is... daunting.

Still set up as a sanatorium, there are patient rooms and massive wings for multiple patients. There are doors that probably once led to offices, which have likely turned into bedrooms. The furnishings are as old as this place, and it's giving off an asylum vibe. I shiver, knowing that in another life, I would have been a patient strapped to one of these tables. If I lived anywhere other than Moros, they'd have had me committed when I was a kid. We all would have been.

They must be expecting me, because when we walk into an open room, there are ten figures standing in silence. Glow-in-the-dark Purge masks in ten different colours stare at me, their hands clasped in front of their waists. Dressed in black but not in any uniform, they wait until I'm all the way inside the chamber of the room before the door shuts behind me. Whoever led me here is gone now, and I can't decide if I'm more comfortable without him or not.

I'm sweating but chilled, my palms rubbing together just to give them something to do. I don't know how these things work. Other than bowing down to the conformities of my so-called family curse, I've never made a deal with danger. As far as people who grew up in Moros go, I've been fortunate thus far. Dabbled in a cult against my will, and have been stalked for years, but everything changes tonight. The deal I'm about to strike will set my life on a new path, and to be fair, no path leads out of Moros. To be even more blunt, if it ends in death, I'll be lucky. As long as my bargain is met first.

I step forward, unsure how these deals start or if I'm even worthy. None of them have moved, but they aren't all still either. One is jittery, another is shifting from foot to foot, and someone else is leaning against the wall, crossing and uncrossing his arms. Most of them are standing with their legs apart, hands still clasped in front of them, defiantly still.

"Uh, I'm Remi. I'm... I'd like to make a bargain." I don't want to do it, but I add my last name. "Remi Sauder."

That makes a few of them stiffen or jostle. The Sauder name is notorious in Moros. Not because we're powerful, but because we're intriguing. There's a curse on the Sauder family, specifically the men, and despite being morbid, it's the topic of several studies and dissertations.

"Mine," someone claims me. A deep voice, muffled by the mask but jittery too, like the word wanted to come out faster than his tongue allowed.

Coloured masks turn towards the purple one at the end, the one leaning against the wall. The teal mask grabs him by the front of his shirt, hissing threats and something sinister from beneath his mask. I obviously can't see their faces, but they appear surprised. A few of them look like they want to fight him on it, and hushed whispers fill their side of the chamber. I can't make out any of the words, but my palms continue to sweat until they hush.

The door behind me clicks locked from the outside, making my throat clog, and then every colour except purple leaves through a door to their left.

The teal one looks back, shaking his head at purple. When it's just him and me, the room grows bigger. My breath echoes around the cavernous space, the beat of my heart creates a rhythm his doesn't match, and my legs tingle, weakening with nerves. It's nothing new for me, but the intensity of it is crippling.

His mask, all black but the purple that forms a neon face, tilts as he cocks his head at me. I have no idea what comes next, but I don't have the ability to speak. I've done all the talking my voice will provide, and now it's up to him to accept my life in exchange for the ones I want... dealt with.

"Sauder," he says. It's not a question, but my chin jerks to nod anyway. "Hmm." He pushes off the wall, arms uncrossing.

I can't help but tremble when he nears me. Or that my knees wobble and my back straightens at once. It's hard to keep my eyes forward when he walks around the back of me, making my nape prickle again. I've been studied and scrutinized most of my life, but this feels like an eye-rape. He's tearing me apart bit by bit with his gaze, shredding my well-intact armour to expose my vulnerabilities. My walls are fortified, but he rips through them with ease, stripping me bare until my spine is no longer straight and my weakened knees are threatening to give out. I thought I'd be more capable of withstanding scrutiny.

I choke. On nothing. Air and breath and fear obstruct my throat, forcing a sound out that draws him back around to my front. The bright purple of his face mask draws my attention, that feeble part of me trying to hold on to something bright within all the darkness. Reality settles in as he tilts his head again. I'm in Vile House. I'm offering my life to him in the form of a bargain. I'm exchanging my free will for the death of someone else's, and I have no idea if he'll find my bargain desirable. Or what happens if he doesn't.

"Are you legal?" he asks, voice still shaky.

"Twenty-six," I tell him. "With identification." Which is what he wants to know. Because many who live in Moros aren't legal citizens. They're ghosts the governments don't know about, and they like it that way.

"Show me."

I unclasp my sweaty palms to pull my wallet from my pocket. I hate that my hands shake when I hand it to him, and I hate it even more that my breath catches when his gloved hand grazes mine. He steps back to read it, but the energy of his body doesn't stop shrouding me. He's volatile and

calm about it. He's churning with something that has the ability to explode but lacks the capacity to rue the effect. He's dangerous while judging my worth.

When he looks up from my driver's licence, the glimmer of his eyes peeks through the mask. Pale and vibrant, they pulse. Something lives within them, and if it ever rattles its chains enough to break free from the confines of his eyes, I'll find myself in a fate worse than death—the one Moros hands out more freely than a finite ending.

My teeth chatter.

"Your life for... what?"

I've never considered striking a bargain with a Vile Boy, so I haven't had a lot of time to word my negotiation. All I know is that I can't fall prey to the man stalking me earlier tonight, and if I do, my body won't be the only one missing. My brother will be next.

"Three lives exchanged for mine," I tell him, voice sure and chin high. "You take three lives, and I give mine to you."

He cocks his head again. "Forever?"

"Do I have a choice?"

He thinks about it. I've heard that lives and the rights to them are given forever, and that the Vile Boys won't accept anything less than a lifetime. Honestly, I once heard that someone who had struck a bargain with the red-masked one died from an illness, and the red-masked man forced the person's son to fulfill the rest of the bargain. After a few months, that son was never heard from again.

"Mine. Until I free you," he says. It's not much better than forever, but I nod to accept it because I don't have the illusion of another choice. He pockets every piece of identification in my wallet before handing it back. "If you succumb to the Sauder curse, I will end it by eradicating your family."

My eyes drop to the floor, and dread consumes me. I can't promise him that. I can't guarantee that I won't end my life. Because that *is* the Sauder curse. Every man with the Sauder last name, spanning back hundreds of years, has died by suicide. We're all driven mad eventually. The age varies, but the end result is the same—a cemetery full of Sauder men who have taken matters into their own hands. Some think it's control, a way to die on our own terms, the absolute death we all hope for around here. Others

believe we're cursed, pledged to repeat the past because our inferior genes have continuously created ticking time bombs.

Me? I believe we're doomed from the moment we're born. Because the life of a Sauder man isn't a good one, and eventually, when it gets to be too much and we can't take it any longer, the prospect of death is such a welcome embrace that we flock to it freely. It's not a supernatural curse by any means, but there's only so much one mind, conscience, and soul can take, and when we hit that limit, it's better to end it before it swallows someone else whole.

"If I succumb to the curse, you can end my bloodline," I agree, because there is no other choice. "All except my sister. You have to agree to get her out. Out of Moros."

When his hand darts forward, fingers clamping around my throat, my knees finally give out. I crash onto them, the impact of the stone floor travelling up to my stomach to make me sick. I choke for real when he squeezes my throat, bile filling my mouth.

"If you succumb to the Sauder curse, I will kill off your bloodline. Are we clear?"

I should have known not to negotiate, but I had to try to save my sister. I nod in his grip, the edges of my vision darkening with black spots. My fingers grasp at his, trying to pry them open while panic sets in. My head fills with pressure and my eyes struggle to remain open while feeling like they're popping out of my skull.

"Agree," he demands.

Croaking out an agreement, I sway on my knees. When he lets go, I buckle forward on all fours, coughing spit and bile onto the floor.

"Names," he demands while I'm hacking.

"Reeven Matterson." Cough. "Gregory Malone." Choke. "Soren Sauder." Defeat.

If he's surprised by my brother's name, he doesn't react. "Dead?"

"Dead or... missing," I correct. "But Soren just... gone. Temporarily."

"Deal," he agrees. "Until I free you. Bargain struck?"

Deep breath. "Bargain struck."

With that, the bargain is etched into my future. My life belongs to the Vile Boy in the purple mask.

TEMPLATE FOR DESTRUCTION

REMIEL

THE VILE BOYS have a calling card. Everyone around town knows it, but now that I'm staring at it, seeing the purple that marks it from *him*, I'm hesitant to flip it over.

The symbol is always the same. The skeletal system of a torso. Ribs, a spine, the pelvic bone. It's the splashes of colour that differ. Ten colours, and although I've never seen a purple one around town, I know I'm about to become vividly familiar with the bright shade.

It's still sitting on my nightstand. With no idea how I got here—after waking up with a throbbing headache and a bump on the back of my head—I blinked at my room and saw the card. From him. I haven't moved since. I'm not usually such a chickenshit, but I *did* sign my life away last night, so my hesitation is justified.

"Remi!" Mom shouts. "Breakfast!"

Does she know why I'm here? I don't even live here. I moved out of my parents' house four years ago after my dad's death. Haven't stepped foot in this house since my younger brother's death six months ago, and our other brother even longer ago than my dad. Just me and Soren left to the curse now, and I hate knowing he's stronger than me. That he'll outlast our race to suicide. That I'll break my deal with the man in the purple mask and he will wipe out my bloodline because of it.

Regret is almost worse than the curse.

"Remi!" Mom shouts again, her feet stomping up the stairs. I snatch the card and hide it under the blankets just as the door opens. "Morning." Her smile is empty, but it's artificially bright, and I don't know what to think of

her anymore. She's different now. "It's been a long time since you've been here, so I thought we could have breakfast before you go."

Her eyes are pleading. She's a mother who has lost two sons and a husband to suicide. She's a brave woman—or maybe a stupid one—who married a Sauder man and thought she could prevent the self-inflicted mortal wound to his life. She didn't fail. The curse is just too strong. I can see it when she looks at me now. She's memorizing me, taking me in, committing the good parts of me to her mental recall because she *knows*. She knows I'll be next, and even though she loves me, she's long given up on trying to save us.

"I'll be right down," I tell her with a forced smile.

She wants to say more, maybe to ask why I'm here, but she doesn't. She leaves the bedroom door open and heads back downstairs.

I don't look around my childhood bedroom. I know the room by heart, and there's a reason I never come to stay in it. I shared it with a brother who no longer lives in this world. I don't want to see it, so I pull the calling card from beneath the blankets and hold my breath while I flip it over.

Midnight. Your father's grave.

Great. Exactly where I want to go. I exhale dread.

I get dressed, stuff the card in my jacket pocket, and head downstairs to have breakfast with my mom. When I get to the kitchen, I see my younger sister sitting at the table with her nose buried in a book. She's not a voracious reader of novels. She's a stubborn studier who thinks she can break our family curse by studying psychology. Been there. Tried that. But she goes to the university in the next city over and often comes home on weekends because... she never knows when our last day of life might be.

"Morning, hun," Mom says again, handing me a plate of eggs and potatoes. "It's nice to have you here. How are you feeling?"

I sit opposite my sister Selena and pick bacon off the platter on the table. "Feeling?"

"You were wasted when they brought you here last night," Selena says with a laugh. "Honestly, Rem, I haven't seen you that drunk since you took me to my first high school party."

Drunk? Funny, because I don't remember drinking, and I don't feel hungover. This should scare me more than it does, but getting knocked out, drugged, and carted home isn't that dire compared to what I actually did last night. "Who brought me home?"

"Soren and Keegan," Mom answers. "Keegan found you passed out on the lawn of The Misfits' party, so he called Soren and they got you home."

I didn't even go to The Misfits' party, so how the fuck did I end up with my brother and his best friend? I look at Selena, who's eating, reading, and talking all at once. "Did you go to the party?"

"Yeah, for a bit."

"Did you see me there?" I ask.

She shakes her head. "But it was packed. This is the last weekend before the Vile initiation, so people went wild knowing they'd be locked at home next weekend." She flips a page. "I'm thinking of pledging."

Mom smacks down a pan of sausages, glaring at Selena. "No. We just got out of one mess. I don't need you stepping into another."

"Why not?" Soren asks, walking into the kitchen in nothing but black sweatpants. His tattooed chest and full sleeves make up the rest of his outfit. He slips on a t-shirt before turning around, covering his torso but leaving his gang tats on display. "Selena's badass enough to make it." He grins at our sister before offering me a more evil one. "Hungover, Rem?"

"She'd have to murder people!" Mom shouts. Her hand wraps around a knife, and the three of us glance at each other. It wasn't too long ago that Mom lost her mind and... I rub the scar on my wrist. Soren takes the knife from her, and she snaps out of it, focusing on her cooking. We all just look at each other again, unsure what keeps happening to her. Because this isn't the first time.

Murdering people on Initiation Night is just a rumour, anyway. I mean, the bloodbath the next day is usually a surefire sign, but no bodies are ever found, so we can't be one hundred percent sure that murder is part of the initiation.

"I could off that bitch Sally Davies. She's a cunt if I ever saw one." Selena grins while Mom shakes her head at her.

"Preach," Soren agrees, sitting next to her.

She shoves him. "Pretty sure you hooked up with her like three months ago."

“And got a real up close and personal experience of her cuntiness,” he agrees. “Pledge, girl. You got this.” He’s gaslighting her into initiating for a ruthless society? Why? Does he wish her death, too? And he’s from The Misfits, so again, why?

No one even knows if they accept female members, and I have no idea why they’re accepting initiations when they’ve never, in the history of Vile House, had over ten members. I counted ten last night. You must have to be a lower-ranking member for a long time before you get anywhere close to a coloured mask.

“Where’d Keegan really find me?” I ask Soren.

“The Misfits’ party. Said he watched you stumble down the front steps and face plant on the lawn, so he helped me get you home. We couldn’t find your house key or any of your shit in your wallet, so we brought you here.” He shrugs.

So, was I knocked out and dropped off at the party or...?

It doesn’t matter. The purple calling card in my pocket is all that matters. Because from now on, when he calls, I run. And Soren’s name is the third on my bargain list.

He doesn’t try to hide his gang affiliation. He’s never spoken about it to us, his family, but his gang tats are right there on his arms, silently speaking for him. I think it broke Mom’s heart, but she’d never say anything about it because the gang life, despite being dangerous, gives him a better chance at survival than our family curse does.

Soren isn’t top dog in The Misfits—a crew that often rivals Vile House—but he’s working his way up, and he’s narcissistic enough to think he just deserves to run the damn place. The weird thing about our town is that gangs, crews, cults, clubs, societies, and brotherhoods don’t hold animosity toward one another. They all have their roles and reasons, and mostly, they coexist because chaos breeds more chaos, and Moros thrives on chaos. So, even if Selena does initiate for Vile House and get accepted, she and Soren would be fine belonging to opposing groups. In Moros, grievances are between people, families, or friends. But mostly, it’s Moros against the tourists. It’s history against the future trying to change us.

It bothers me that Soren can sit across the table from me this morning, not at all affected by stalking me last night. I know he was there. I know he was one of the shadows following me because I sensed him—nostalgia and

betrayal—which means he knows I went to Vile House, not the party. But there’s no point in drawing attention to it.

The grin on his face tells me he knows. So I offer him one in return to let *him* know that *I* know.

It’s the *why* that fucks with my head. Why he herded me there, or maybe why I led him there. Maybe I’m wondering what he was even doing there because he’s not the one I was outrunning.

“It’s so nice to have you all home,” Mom says, sitting with us.

There might be a world of misunderstanding between me and my brother, and Selena is mostly aware of it all, but none of that infiltrates breakfast because we all have a tepid love for our mother, despite what she did to me. When Dad died and she freed herself from the cult we were raised in, she proved to all of us that she’s stronger than we are. But that cult won’t let us go quietly, and over the past few years, our family has dwindled because of it. It’s why Reeven Matterson’s name is the first on my list.

When I’m done washing up, I kiss my mom goodbye, wave at Selena, and head out front, where Soren is smoking on the front step. When I walk out, he walks with me, our arms swaying between our bodies and our lips pressed tight together. I wish I didn’t resent him. I wish I didn’t want to include his name in my bargain. I wish our family was different and our lives were more stable. But nothing is ever that easy in Moros. I’m doing it *for* him, and someday, he’ll understand. It’s the only way I know how to love him.

Because Selena is trying to stop our family curse by studying it.

But me and my brother? We’re trying to end the curse by killing another Sauder—maybe even each other—before we have the chance to kill ourselves. Or he is, anyway.

I made a sick bargain instead.

“Do anything interesting last night, Rem?” Soren asks as we walk down the street.

“Like what?” I play along.

“Make any deals with devils?”

I grin into the foggy morning. “Nah, just got wasted at the party.” I glance at him. “Apparently.”

“Apparently,” he echoes, smirking. “Have a good day.” He turns the corner, going in a different direction than I am.

Soren doesn't work for anyone other than The Misfits now. I don't know what he does for them, but he's an unremorseful sort of person, so whatever he does, I'm guessing it's brutal. I hold a level of resentment towards him because, before he joined the gang, we worked together. Owned a business together. Got along and wanted to beat this curse side by side. Fate eventually won out, and now we're pitted against one another in a world so cruel our blood bond doesn't matter. Soren might kill me or I might kill him, and whichever way it turns out, I hope it ends the curse on the Sauder men.

Now I own the shop alone. I run it with my best friend Cain, who excels at instrument repair.

Musical talents in a town this small are usually one in a million, but Moros breeds deceptively talented people. It's sad how many of us turn to music as our escape, but it's even more depressing how many of us excel at creating darkness with our instruments. It makes my music store a busy place.

Unlocking the front door of my shop on the main street, I enter the dim room to hear the serene sound of the cello. Piano joins it, and together, the harmonies are so haunting my heart stops for a moment of appreciation. My eyes close in remembrance, and nostalgia sweeps through me.

It's a recording, more than four years old, from when my dad would play along with my cello. He never questioned the gloomy vibe of my music, he just matched it, adding a second sound to make the sadness brighter. I keep it on while the shop is closed, afraid to listen to it while I'm here, but not wanting the music to be wasted. So, I play it for the emptiness of my space—the space willed to me and my brother after our dad's death. The space Soren walked away from to join The Misfits.

I can't help but pause with my back against the door to listen. Maybe if I don't move, it'll be like I'm not really here. Like I'm just one of Moros' ghosts who listens to chilling music in the dead of night at vacant little music shops. I can almost picture him playing. I can scarcely see myself from years ago, my cello between my legs and my bow gliding across the strings of its own free will. I never made music. Music made me, and I followed its muse.

But I've been cut off from it lately. Since Soren left.

The front door chimes a second before it slams into my back. "Sorry. Didn't see you standing there," Cain says, coming inside and taking a

moment of his own to listen to the recording of me and my dad. “You okay, Remi?”

Furthest thing from it. I nod, offering him a smile he knows is fake. “Yeah, good. You go to the party at The Misfits last night?” I move through the shop to shut off the music, killing the nostalgia along with it.

“No, but I heard you were there.” He laughs. “Why didn’t you call me? I would have come with you.”

“It was a last-minute decision,” I say. “There are, like, fourteen repairs booked this week. What’re you doing here on a Sunday morning?”

“Wanted to get a head start on some of them. The parts for that grand piano are supposed to come today, and I want to be here when the delivery guy shows up.”

Out-of-town delivery drivers tend to get spooked in Moros, so more often than not, our parts end up at the post office on the edge of town. If Cain is here to greet the driver and promise nothing bad will happen if he walks inside the shop, things go over easier.

“What’re you doing here?” he asks me the same thing.

I bargained away my life and needed to come somewhere I felt safe.
“Same reason. Wanted to get ahead.”

And distract myself. I haven’t visited my dad’s grave since the day we buried him, and tonight isn’t the night to start. But at midnight, I’ll be there despite my wishes because I’m no longer in charge of my life.

The whole thing is a template for destruction and I know I’ll be the one ruined in the end.

SICK

KRYPT

THE TOWN THINKS there are only ten of us. The history of Vile House has always worked in tens, so the theory remains mingled with all the other myths about the house, its occupants, and what we actually do. We're more than a gang. We're a society, one only possible because of the town itself.

In the real world, we might be considered a *secret* society, but in Moros, we're just a fact. In a town already brimming with sinister people, wicked intents, and history so dark it draws attention from the outside world, we're the bottom of the barrel.

Which makes us elite. Royalty, even. A belief that locals rely on and everyone else fears. Because we're an offshoot organization that works in corruption. Not because we balance it, but because we challenge it. We're that thing that goes bump in the night and acts like it's nothing come morning. We are the literal definition of two wrongs *do* make a right.

And we're run by a selective team of past members, almost like alumni. Our director, the only man who keeps us in check, comes from a long line of leaders who have run Vile House since it switched from an insane asylum to what it is now.

Virtue In Lives Exchanged.

Regardless of my moral compass, I understand what virtue is. I know goodness when I see it. I know goodness when I *force* it. I used to think the name was a pathetic attempt to keep the letters of the house the same, but over the years since I joined, I've come to appreciate the goodness that comes from exchanging one life for another. For taking one life to protect others. That's virtuous.

We aren't the judge of good and evil, but fuck do we enjoy playing the part.

Leaving the house in the hands of our lower-ranking members, the ten of us walk through the tunnels that connect Vile House to the asylum. It's an old portion of the sanatorium that got expanded and made into a modern-ish facility that still contains some of the original asylum. The world frowns upon that word, but here in Moros, it's accepted willingly. Our asylum attracts as many tourists as it does patients.

Our director is a well-known scientist, responsible for creating a lot of the pharmaceuticals used by mental health patients, and now he sits on the asylum's board of directors. But those who praise and award him don't know he's the leader of one of the most notoriously deadly societies in our area of the world.

"Director is going to flip his shit when he hears you made a bargain," Ghost tells me as we walk. His voice echoes through the tunnel to join the sound of footsteps.

"Like *you're* flipping *your* shit?" I counter.

Ghost snarls at me. "The fuck were you thinking, Krypt?"

I wasn't. It was an impulse as soon as I saw him. And Ghost is pissed about it.

I've been in the Vile House society since I was a teen, but I've only been masked as one of the ten for three years. In those three years, I've made exactly one bargain. And it was last night. It's not a requirement of the rank, but most of the others have made at least one, if not multiple bargains with locals, some outsiders. I typically prefer to keep to the dirty work, keeping Moros protected, and working in the cells with those we bring in.

But making deals with Vile House is a safeguard that Moros knows about. It's always been a thing, and I think Director will be pleased that I'm doing my part.

Remiel Sauder is my first bargain, and fuck me, I still don't know what I was thinking.

"I'll figure it out," I tell Ghost. His feelings about it mean little to me.

"How?" Menace asks with a laugh. "Once he finds out who you are—"

"It won't matter," I snap at him. "I fucking own him now. It doesn't matter who I am. His life is mine. He agreed to the bargain."

"Better get that in blood," Menace says, grinning at me.

Yeah, I will. And I'll etch it into his flesh to mark him as mine forever. Even if I eventually free him, he will never be free of my mark on his skin.

"You gonna tell me what the bargain was?" Ghost asks as we fall to the back of the group. He can't hide his hatred for this situation. Rightfully so, but fuck him.

"Eventually."

Ghost is someone I can be around without becoming overwhelmed by his energy, so in the most basic sense of the word, he's my best friend. His feet don't make a sound as he walks, and his movements are so fluid you'd miss them if you blinked. He's the same age as I am, and we initiated together when we were both seventeen. It's hard to believe that was eleven years ago.

When we near the end of the tunnel, everyone straightens up to act their part as soon as we enter the asylum. Without our masks, our identities are only known to Director and the other Vile leadership.

We've all got a cover story to be at the asylum. Some of us work here, others are technically patients, and some, like Ransom and Facts, are on the board of directors, despite still being in their thirties. I just work in security. Well, I don't, but that's my cover story for coming and going from the building. It keeps people from seeing me leave Vile House.

"Have fun tonight, Krypt," Menace says. Ghost gives me a nod of warning, and with that, we all part ways, spreading into the lower levels of the asylum tunnels to enter the main building from different places.

Before I reach the side exit where my vehicle is parked, Director runs up to stop me.

"You good?" he asks, wearing his lab coat. "Heard you made your first bargain."

"I'm good. Handled." I pull my keys from my pocket.

He's a middle-aged man who treats us all like family, but I've known what it's like to be on the receiving end of his brutality, too. I respect and appreciate him, especially for bringing the ten of us together, but I don't love him. I don't love anyone. I'm more likely to obsess.

"Well, I'm here if you need anything," he says. "We all are. Don't forget to use us."

I nod, slipping out the side exit before he can say more.

The sun is setting, giving way to a grey night. Moros is a misty, foggy town where the weather always drizzles and the landscapes are wet and

soggy. Forests, bogs, and swamps make up the flatlands, eventually drifting up the slopes of mountains that contain us in a protective bowl. There's one road in and one road out, and I've never understood why tourists don't see that as ominous. Especially since it's lined with crows and ravens.

Horror lovers, occultists, history buffs, and those intrigued with the history of mental health and mad scientists flock to town to experience its pull and tour the asylum. We encourage it, luring them in with our strange history and unusual lifestyle, but it's not always up to them whether they get back out. Crime junkies love Moros for the mystery it is. For such a small, secluded area, there are just as many missing persons cases here as there are in the country's entirety. The world has tried to solve and fix us, but once they get spooked by being here, they pretty much leave us alone. The feds barely even step foot in Moros anymore. We're like the Bermuda Triangle—no one looks for the things that go missing here.

Driving down the main street, aptly named Death Row, I watch the signs of shops flip to *closed* as the locals lock up for the night. We don't fear the dark, but we consider any business conducted after the sun sets as nefarious, and we'd rather not tie it to our actual businesses. Dealings in the dark are meant to be made person to person. That's an unstated Moros social contract.

Remiel steps out of his music shop with his tattooed friend Cain, locking up for the night. The Ambient Raven sits in the middle of Death Row, and it's one of the busiest shops in town because there are so many musicians here. It's been in the Sauder family for generations, passing hands as often as their lives pass. I don't know how, but I will put an end to the Sauder curse. Remiel will not die before I permit him to. I hold his life to no value, but it's in my hands now, and I'm nothing if not prideful about my belongings.

I'll see you at midnight, Remiel.

Driving out the far side of town and into the misty mountains, I pull down a narrow lane and come to a stop. Monster is waiting and he climbs in the front seat, shaking off the dampness. We're never allowed to leave the asylum together, but we meet out of sight to complete jobs.

He's jittery, currently caught in a manic episode he's struggling to shake. When the darkness takes over his mind, he's hard to be around. Only Ransom can pull him back to reality so far, but none of us are allowed to know how. Today, he's not too bad. As long as he gets to maim someone

and let off a little crazy, he'll be fine. At least he's talking instead of mute at the moment.

"I've been waiting for this all week," he says, pulling twin blades from holsters in his jacket. "Don't rush me tonight, Krypt. I fucking need this."

I try to grin as I start driving down the lane. Monster is tiny and batshit crazy, and when he gets lost in his mania, he really does become a little monster. Hence, how he got his name. He's the shortest and smallest out of all of us, but he's the most deadly with a set of blades. The guy has no gag reflex, no queasy stomach, and no off switch. But he has a few triggers, that's for sure.

He flicks his dark choppy hair from his forehead. "And don't even tell me you invited Ransom. He'll only hold me back."

"I didn't invite him, but you know he'll be here." I look at him as he jitters. "Director always has him on you when you're like this."

"Like what?" he snarls at me, blades flashing. He has scars all around his mouth, dotted white lines like his lips have been sewn together, and he never talks about them, so I've never asked.

"I gotta be somewhere at midnight, so we aren't dragging this out that long. You'll get to shed blood, Monster. Don't worry. I'll even hold Ransom back."

"You fucking better."

Parking at the head of a hiking trail, we meet Ransom at the entrance to yet another tunnel. This one is an old mining tunnel, and if we walk another fifteen minutes through it, we'll end up in a chamber that has the best acoustics. Kyd, one of us, loves bringing people here to scream. We call it the Mad House. It's a vast network of chambers, caves, and tunnels under Trigger Mountain, and people tend to lose their minds in it. Maybe I'll bring Remiel and his cello sometime.

"He's not restrained," Ransom tells Monster when we enter the tunnel, his light brown skin sweaty from dragging the prisoner. "Left him wide open for you, Monster."

Monster's eyes glimmer, and his smile is downright sickening. "Time to hunt." He puts on his yellow-faced mask and hollers into the tunnel before he takes off running. Tonight, we're going to scare, intimidate, and capture a man who needs to be taught a lesson before we send him on his way with a message for his rich friends.

“Good luck restraining him tonight.” I snort at Ransom. “He’s fucking nuts right now.” I pull on my purple mask.

Ransom tries to act serious, but I can see the delight in his dark eyes. “Isn’t he always?” His red mask comes down and then we run after Monster, and neither of us can deny the thrill thrumming in our blood.



HIGH ON A BLOOD rush isn’t how I should meet with Remiel for the first real time. I’m early, but I need the time in the night air to cool down the heat rushing through me. There’s nothing quite like a hunt through the tunnels, and when Monster leads the charge and really lets his dysfunction shine, it makes it even more thrilling. Not even Ransom could tame him tonight.

The cemetery in Moros is massive and gothic. Full of ancient tombs and crypts of families long since passed, I walk among their spirits with ease. I’m not alone here, so my mask stays on my face and I let the shadows of the trees and mausoleums conceal me. Moros is a town of the night, and graveyards are our playground. We’re deranged and criminal like Gotham, but historical and darkened like Salem. A reporter once described our town as a death trap and its occupants as its hellhounds. I thought that fit pretty well.

I quite like being a hellhound.

The Sauder plots are expansive. They take up a whole row of headstones, have their own crypt, and span back many generations. Sauder men far outnumber the women, but there are a few sprinkled in with the men. The women died of natural causes or tragedies. But the men? Every single one ended his own life. The prospect of a suicide curse intrigues me, and I’m blaming that for my rash decision to take Remiel’s bargain.

A group of teens trying to Necromance the dead look up from their huddle as I walk by, recognizing my mask and its meaning. They dip their heads in respect, fisting their hands over their hearts, and I don’t bother them. I hope they succeed someday. An elderly woman sits on a stone bench in front of her husband’s grave, whispering words at the ground like

they'll enter whatever plane of existence he lives in now. I press my hand to my heart and bow my head to her. She repeats the gesture.

When I get to the row of Sauders near the forest's edge, I take a deep breath and remind myself why I'm here. My first bargain. Remiel Sauder and his list of three names.

"Excuse me?"

I turn, facing a woman I don't recognize. A young and naïve tourist, dressed in a cocktail dress with Neon Demon stamps glowing all over her body. She must be a city chick who came to Moros for the week-long Demon Week celebrations. The Neon Demon is a club in town. It's the main attraction of Demon Week, turning our small town into a rave after dark, luring club-goers into its games. They think they're here to partake in an annual tradition to celebrate the upcoming initiation, but they rarely realize how dark it is.

"Have you seen this headstone?" she asks, holding up a calling card. It has the club's logo on it, and they usually give the tasks out with the promise of a prize once they come back to the club with photo proof of completion. Coincidentally, the plot she's looking for belongs to my grandfather. "I've been trudging through this disgusting cemetery for an hour and can't find it." She shivers. "So many creeps out here, my god."

I glance around to see if any of her friends are with her, and when I see she's alone, I shake my head. What sort of skinny, defenceless little lamb actually comes to a cemetery in Moros at night on her own and talks to a masked stranger? Could she be any dumber? She obviously knows the town's reputation. It's what drew her here in the first place, but like so many, she doesn't take it seriously.

"Did you hear me?" she snaps. "And what's with the creepy mask, man? This place gives *Stranger Things* a run for its money. If I knew how weird this town was, I never would have come." She rubs her bare arms and shivers.

"You should leave then."

She narrows her eyes at me. "This gravestone. Do you know where it is?"

"Are you alone?" I ask her.

"What kind of stalker question is that?" She levels me with a look of disgust.

"You shouldn't be out here alone at night," I tell her. "It's not safe."

“I can handle myself, thanks. Bunch of fucking sickos here anyway.”

I bristle. The tremors start in my fingertips and slither up my forearms. A haze clouds my mind, and the blood rush that had been fading sparks back to life. She notices.

I taste her terror, but she’s severely lacking in survival skills. “God, you’re just like the rest of them.” She’s goading me when she should be running. “Fucking sick. All of you.”

I have three things I hate and one trigger word. And she just pressed my big red button.

“Sick,” I repeat.

She’s backing away from me now, her heels sinking into the grass of the plots she steps on. “I’m... I’m just gonna go. Fuck this contest.”

I don’t want to kill someone when their back is to me, so before she has the chance to turn and run, I grab her by her slender throat and inhale her scream.

“Sick,” I repeat a second time. I’m shaking all over, lost in the frenzy and triggered by the word. When her big eyes meet mine through the mask, I lift it and show her just how sick I really am.

Her second scream never leaves her throat. I snap her neck and listen to it gurgle to a halt.

LEFT FOR DEAD

REMIEL

I THOUGHT I'd be better in a crisis. I grew up here, witnessed more horrific shit than anyone should in one lifetime, and know how to thrive in fear.

But this isn't fear. It's a morbid fascination that's rooting me to the spot and rendering me useless. Because although I've seen a multitude of dead bodies, I've never seen the moment of death. I should go over there, figure out where all the blood is coming from, and try to support her twisted neck until emergency responders get here. But I'm not doing that because the rattling inhale of her lungs has drawn all my attention.

"I give her six minutes."

He steps out from behind a tree, his black mask with a purple face is lit up by the moonlight coming through the canopy of leaves. I'm so enraptured by the dying girl that I barely even stiffen at his arrival.

I don't recognize her as a local, but the glowing stamps on her skin mark her as a clubgoer from The Neon Demon. She's dirty, as if she was dragged through the forest or thrown down an incline. Her head is cracked open somewhere, spilling all that blood, and her body is covered in gashes. How did she get here?

"What do you think she's thinking about?" he asks.

Her lungs rattle again, and then her leg twitches, and I don't know which one to focus on.

When he shifts, I finally startle, but my feet still don't move. I don't know if I recognize his slightly modulated voice, but his presence seems familiar. A smell I can't place but feel nostalgic about. Maybe it's because of last night, or maybe I know who hides under the mask. From the corner

of my eye, I can see his black clothing and the glow of the purple spotlighting the space next to me. His boots don't crunch the leaves, and he's otherwise still, but a waft of weed clouds the air in front of him when he exhales silently, the mouth hole in the mask wide enough for smoking.

"Six minutes isn't a lot of time when you think about it," he says, watching the disaster in front of us, not doing anything about it either. "Barely a drop in the time of her life. What do you think, she's nineteen? Twenty, maybe? All that life comes down to these six minutes."

That should jar me. The reminder of life and death and the six-minute expiry date she has on her should get my feet moving, rushing across the forest floor to staunch all the blood. At the very least, comfort her in her time of death. Logically, I should call the fire department and try to keep her alive long enough for their paramedics to get here.

But my hands stay at my sides, and my feet stay in place because, again, I've seen a dead body, but never a death. Does she feel anything, or is her neck completely broken?

"Wanna look?" he asks.

I don't know what's wrong with me. Shock? Am I in shock? Would I know if I am?

I don't answer him, but when he takes another inhale from his joint through the hole in his mask, moving just enough to jolt me into motion, I take a step forward. He follows.

It's the early hours of a new day, this girl probably only living ten minutes tops of the first day of September. The night is cool but wet, rain hanging in the air and a fine sheen of mist dampening my clothing. The moon peeks through the leaves every few steps, but it doesn't show me anything worth latching on to. I don't know why I'm so... calm.

"A blond," the guy says. "Tsk. Can never trust a blond." There's a mocking cruelty to his voice, but I can't tell if it's directed at me, the situation, or the girl herself. I'm a dirty blond...

I can't see her face, but her neck is bent at an angle that defies the natural movements of her skeletal system. Her hair really is blond, but only in some sections. The rest is bright crimson and dripping, or dirty and tinted from her fall. Her dress, a cocktail-type thing in a golden hue, is ripped open to expose the side of her hip and most of her stomach. More blood. Her knees disgust me, so I don't look at them, letting my eyes shift down to

her calves and ankles. High, dainty, strappy heels in the same tone as her dress, if the random moonlight can be believed.

“Why would she be wearing heels out here?” I ask no one. It’s the least logical question for the situation. “One of the club’s games?”

He doesn’t answer, but I don’t care because the girl takes another rattling inhale. Again, this should jar me into upset. I should bend down, check her vitals, move her hair from her face to see if her eyes are open. I should stop whatever is bleeding and hold her head steady so no more damage occurs to her cervical spine.

Instead, I’m intrigued by the rattle of her lungs. Are they failing, slowly shutting down, full of blood and drowning in it? Or are they simply not getting enough strength to properly work as a muscle? Maybe her diaphragm is damaged, and that’s the reason her lungs aren’t expanding fully.

“What do you think she’s thinking?” the man I gave my life to asks again, a cloud of smoke following the jittery words through his mask in my peripheral. “Regrets? Do you think people really see a highlight reel of their lives in their last moments? All the good parts, and all the things they regret?”

I’d never thought about it before. I am now. What would I regret? Everything, probably. Everything and more.

Her leg twitches, drawing my gaze. Was she dancing? Sent out here by the club’s owner to complete a fun task that put her in harm’s way? On purpose? There are always miscreants in the cemeteries at night.

“Maybe she’s incapable of thinking,” I find myself saying, obliging his questions like they actually matter. “Like her brain is shutting down.” Why am I engaging with this in the middle of the night while a dire situation unfolds and I do nothing about it? Where is my panic? Where is my fear?

His inhale is long and slow, but it comes out a little shaky. “Shame.” His voice is strained, choked, almost. It nearly draws my attention more than the dying girl, but then he says, “Are you going to help her?”

I stare at her, wondering why I’m not helping her. Is it worth it? How many of those six minutes have ticked down? What would I even do if I could move?

“She’s going to die anyway, right?” I ask. “Her time is almost up.”

“Why don’t you comfort her?”

“Why don’t you?” I turn my head, but he’s facing away from me. His hood is up, covering his hair, showing me nothing but black. “What are you even doing out here? We were supposed to meet at my dad’s plot.”

He flicks the ash from the tip of his joint before pinching the glowing tip off. It falls to the ground, hissing for a split second in the foliage’s dampness before it disintegrates into nothing. Whatever is left of it disappears into his pocket.

“I could ask you the same thing. Something draw you into the trees, Remiel?”

Yes, the girl’s rattling lungs. I heard them and... walked here in a daze.

He steps over the girl’s body, using a stick to slide her hair to the side. I gasp when her face comes into view. Partly because I recognize her, but mostly because she’s purple and puffy. Strangulation? By what or who? Maybe her broken neck. The column of her throat is slender, but it’s twisted in a way that looks horrific, splotched red. If the moon was brighter, I bet I would see all the burst capillaries in her skin and eyes. Which are open. Staring at the guy standing over her body.

Is it me, or does fearful recognition flash in her dying eyes?

“Ophelia Hargrove,” I whisper her name. “She’s in my sister’s psychology class.”

“Probably goes around campus trying to psychoanalyze people, calling them sick when she doesn’t know shit,” he says harshly, but I can’t tell what the harshness means. “Can’t trust a blond,” he repeats. “Come here.”

I don’t know why I do, but I move towards him. His request is more motivating than the twitch of her calf or the rattling of her lungs. Maybe I want a closer look, to see the moment life leaves her body and death consumes it, and he just gave me an excuse to get nearer.

Thunder cracks overhead, but it doesn’t startle me. The clouds are thickening, blotting out the stars and moon. Stepping next to him, wedging my socks and Crocs between where her small hand and her hip are, I peer at her from above.

“Does she turn you on?”

I splutter at the question, trying to look at him. But before I can even turn my head, his hands push on my shoulders and I’m kneeling in the mud, crushing her hand beneath my knee.

“Let go!”

“Look at her,” he demands, voice right next to my ear. Dark and daunting, ominous but playful. “Is your dick hard, Remiel?”

Finally jarred by something, I panic. My palms sweat more and my fingertips go numb, all my blood and energy rushing to the vital parts of my body as my survival instincts kick in.

“Why would you ask—”

“Mine is,” he says, pressing the front of his crotch against the back of my head. His cock is as hard as iron, and the hand he fists in my hair makes me a slave to the sensation of it. “So fucking hard for this shit. What do you think that says about me, Remiel? You were a psych major, weren’t you?”

I was. A long time ago. Yet another thing I started and quit.

On first instinct, I’d call him a sadist, but I don’t know enough, or anything, about him. I can’t think about that right now because the numbness that blanketed me when I found this girl is gone, replaced by a panic so strong my bladder feels loose.

“Spit on her,” he says. When I don’t, he rubs his cock against the back of my head, yanks on my hair, and growls, “Spit on her.”

“I can’t!” Because DNA and crime scenes and my lack of helping this poor girl are finally catching up with me. “I can’t! Please!”

“I can lay you down next to her with a twin injury, if you like. The media will eat it up. Lovers Pact: Union in the Afterlife. Moros takes another pair of young lovers. What do you think?”

Ophelia’s body jerks, spasming slightly. My eyes prick with tears, but I restrain them, refusing to let them fall on her. Am I crying for her or for myself? I’m selfish, so probably myself.

“Please. Let me up so I can call 9-1-1.”

He laughs wickedly. “Oh, now you’ve found your morals?” He grinds against my head. “Too bad her six minutes are up, hero. Her brain is gone, and her muscles are relaxing. That’s what the twitching is.”

My exhale is shaky and terrified. “We should call someone to come find her. Direct them to the body.”

A sharp blade presses to my throat, nicking my skin and turning me to ice. Warmth spreads from the crotch of my pants, darkening my jeans to pool around my knees and Ophelia’s body. I don’t even have the dignity to feel embarrassed about it.

“Oh, no.” He clicks his tongue. “Still want to call someone? Your DNA is all over this crime scene, hero.”

I'm crying fully now. Tears fall down my cheeks and urine soaks the ground beneath me, making me sink into the earth with a dead girl's body. It's poetic, in a sense. In her time of death, I failed her, and now she's dragging me down with her. My life is over. Whoever this psycho-sadist is, he's going to either kill me next or pin this murder on me. But that'd be breaking our deal, right?

I'm in my final six minutes. The clock is ticking.

"It's regret," I tell him.

"What is?" he asks, still holding the blade to my throat.

"What's going through my head right now. In my moment of death." I swallow, cutting myself on his knife. "It's regrets."

"Hmm," he muses, making my breathing turn into hyperventilating. "And what do you regret?"

"Everything."

"Be more specific. If you pique my interest, I'll sweeten the pot."

I don't say anything. I keep my eyes on Ophelia's dead ones, my knees sinking with her body and my neck against his knife. Do I want to die? What if I just lean forward a bit? Turn my head really fast? Could I slit my own throat? Would it be considered suicide if his hand was the one holding the knife? Have I always been so morbid?

"Tell me something real, Remiel Sauder, and I'll let you live till sunrise."

I hate that it takes me a minute to decide if spilling my regrets is worth my life. When did I get this dark? Until he forced me to my knees, I'd been feeling numb and lost for... years. Now I'm vividly scared, wishing for the situation to end. It scares me more that I don't have a preference on how.

The honed edge of his knife digs into my skin, and I watch as he removes it from my throat. Holding it above Ophelia's body, a crimson drop of *me* falls, splattering against the centre of her forehead.

Urine. Tears. Blood. Probably spit, skin cells, and hair. So much of me is already here despite how absent I feel. When I say nothing, I'm shoved from behind. He thrusts his hips against the back of my head so hard that I brace my hands on Ophelia's hips. Her dead eyes stare straight into mine, pulling secrets and sins from the chamber I locked them in. I can't look away.

Until I'm forced to. A hand in my hair cranes my neck up, but instead of being behind me, he's in front of me now. I can't see his face from the

shadows and the mask, but the whites of his eyes glint at me from the depths of the purple.

“Open your mouth, hero.”

“Please, let me go,” I beg without gumption.

His snarl is impatient. “Open.”

My painful scream parts my lips for me. With his hand in my hair, my neck damn near breaks with the force of his tug.

“Do you want the twin injury, or are you going to give me your regrets? Your six minutes are winding down, Remiel.”

“Okay,” I gasp. “I’ll tell you.”

I choke and scream together when he buries my face in the crotch of his pants. He holds me there, and I’m completely helpless to move. Suffocating against his erection, my regrets become clear.

“Speak.” He frees me.

I cough. “Having no fucking idea who I am. Following the path of my family. Never being good enough.”

“So boring. Most people have those regrets.” His zipper is loud, intensifying my panic.

My hand braces on the dead girl’s thigh when he parts my lips a second time. This time, the hard flesh of his cock is forced inside, ramming into the roof of my mouth. I cough again, trying to scream. But he doesn’t contain the remorse required to let up. A sadist, I remember. Not that it matters anymore.

“Give me something real.” He fucks my face, making me drip drool and tears all over the corpse.

My throat burns and my eyes bulge. I sputter and gag, almost vomiting as the tendons in my neck strain, when he finally pulls out. My lungs rattle almost as loudly as Ophelia’s when I force them to inhale. The assault of oxygen brings a moment of clarity. As if he’s summoned my biggest regret by choking the lies from my vocal cords, I shout, “Not stopping my brother from killing himself! My own death by suicide because it should have been me!”

“There we go,” he purrs darkly. “Weren’t such a hero then either, eh, Remiel?”

I get no chance to answer, even though I don’t have one. His dick jams between my lips, and even the brutal scrape of my teeth doesn’t deter him.

He fucks my throat with no remorse, no gentleness, and no enthusiasm. A motion. A domination. A fear tactic. It hurts, but the terror is worse.

“You bought your life,” he says to me, but I barely hear it over my blood rushing in my ears and my sobs around his dick. “You will swallow. If a single drop of cum lands on her body, I’ll do worse than kill you.”

All I can think about is getting through it, surviving it.

My eyes squeeze shut and my fingers dig into Ophelia’s thigh. This nameless monster takes no mercy on my inexperience, instead feeding on my fear. His hips don’t change tempo, his breath barely quickens, and the only sign I get that he’s about to come is the increased firming of his cock in my mouth.

My gag at the first spurt almost ends my life. His release coats my lips as I cough, and some part of me must want to live because my hands come to my face, ensuring that it all stays in my mouth. He doesn’t moan or groan, fucking me through his orgasm, and when he finally slows, I swallow what I can without choking it back up. My raw throat stings, but I force my lips shut around him, sucking him clean all on my own because I’m afraid of what is worse than death. I’m afraid to let a single drop spill.

I’m realizing that the verbiage of our bargain isn’t clear. Until he frees me could mean anything. Freedom could be death, and I stipulated nothing within my deal to protect myself. I’ve never felt like more of a failure.

When he pulls out, I use my fingers to slide the dripping cum up my chin and against my tongue, swallowing it down with another gag. I’m panting, falling forward, trying not to land on the dead girl.

“Your life is in my hands now, Remiel. You aren’t the hero.”

Something slams into the back of my head, and the last thing I see is Ophelia’s dead-eyed stare as I fall.

TRIGGER WORDS

KRYPT

I WATCHED him wake up from the nap I forced on him. After calling Ransom, Seven, Menace, and Riot to help me clean up the crime scene, I left Remiel there to wake up in her grave. He cried a lot. Looked under his nails, wiped at his mouth, threw up in the foliage and then tried to bury it. He looked confused when he couldn't find any trace of her body, but he must have had some sense to survive because he left the forest and walked all the way to his shop. It still isn't open. His friend Cain went in a few hours ago, but I haven't seen either of them since.

Now we're back at Vile House, and I'm about to get ripped apart ten ways to Sunday for what I did. We might be a ruthless society with a violent history, but we don't kill at random. After I came down Remiel's throat, I was so jarred by it that I knocked him out because I couldn't stand for him to look at me while I felt so confused. Slumped over the girl's body, he looked calm, almost comfortable in her grave. It pissed me off because I was so rattled by my reaction to him, and he had the fucking nerve to sleep so soundly after.

Director storms into the room, glaring at me. "The fuck were you thinking, Krypt?" he snarls. "Line up!"

We're the farthest thing from an army, but we run on rank. Not because it matters, but because competition is the best way to get us to participate the way he wants us to. I stand in the middle of the lineup, between Menace and Riot, waiting for the shit-talking that will accomplish nothing but make me itch and waste my time.

"Someone wanna tell me why there's a dead blond in my morgue?" he asks, staring at me. None of us say anything. "And does anyone else want to

comment on the van full of religious fanatics that blew up on the highway? Huh? How'd that happen?"

"Sometimes shit goes our way," Kyd mumbles, drawing a grin from the rest of us.

"They weren't the fucking job!" Director shouts. "Neither was the girl! We have enough shit to handle with this billionaire asshole and initiation coming up next weekend, and now you fucks wanna throw this at me?"

"Sorry, Daddy," Monster says.

"End of the line!" Director snaps at Monster.

"Hey! He back-talked first!" Monster rats Kyd out, but all it does is earn him a massive smile from Kyd, the youngest and most vividly deranged of us all. Monster moves to the end of the line, making the rest of us shuffle up a position. Rank earns us perks, and fuck Ransom for holding the top position for so long. He and Seven have been the top two for too long, and the rest of us are itching to knock them back down. Ghost, Menace, me, Riot, Facts, Glitch, and Kyd make up the middle, and now Monster sulks at the end.

"Why'd you kill the girl?" Director asks me.

I have nothing to lose and even less to prove, so I lift my chin and say, "Because I wanted to."

"She looked like Gia," Riot adds.

I stiffen and glare at my brother. "Fuck you."

"Gia is dead, Krypt. You can't kill her again," Director says, pinching the bridge of his nose. "Give me a better answer than that."

I'm not about to admit that I got triggered, so I repeat, "Because I wanted to."

Director glares, and then he tilts his head towards Monster. Took me fucking forever to get back to the middle! For nothing. I barely breathe as I move to the end of the line, ignoring Monster's sick smirk as I join him at the bottom.

"This bargain too much for you?"

"No."

"Good. Stop fucking up then. Sit down."

Everyone scrambles to the massive table in the centre of the room, fighting over pastries and baked goods like they're precious. I'm not hungry. My appetite gets morphed by other cravings, making it hard for me

to determine what I'm actually hungry for. I could be horny and think I'm starving; it's always been hard to tell.

Today, it's annoyance and frustration clouding my mind. Because I tasted him. Pressed my lips to the cut in Remiel's neck and licked the blood away like a fucking crazed lunatic. I touch my lips, getting a dopamine hit from the memory. I'm so put off by what happened because having a sexual reaction to something isn't me. I'm not comfortable being physically close to anyone. I'd rather fuck a silky pillow than a person, but something came over me in the cemetery's forest last night, and when I give into my impulses like that, I can't escape them until they're seen through.

"We need to talk about initiation," Director's voice butts into my thoughts. "There are a lot of applicants this year, and since we're short on understudies, we need to decide who we're bringing in. We're going to be hunting Benton Wentworth. Moros doesn't want anyone buying the town, and we're going to feed them this billionaire for breakfast. He's up to something, and it's time we find out who he's working with. So, he's the prey on initiation night."

I'm shaking again. Unsure why. Agitated and jittery. My ears muffle and my vision blinks and darkens until I'm seeing nothing but the terrified look in Remiel's eyes as I fucked his face like he was nothing.

"Krypt," Ghost calls, nodding at the door. Director gives me a nod to leave, and I follow Menace and Ghost out the door.

I light a joint as soon as we step onto the back patio. Weed does nothing for me except signal to my brain that it's time to chill out. It's an auto-response I've trained myself to accept, so as soon as the herbal tang hits my lungs, I'm able to inhale a full breath and stop jittering so much.

"What happened?" Ghost asks, sitting on a partial stone wall that faces the misty forest behind Vile House. Menace leans next to him, reaching out for the joint.

I pass it to him. "I raped him."

Both their eyes widen. Ghost glares at me, but Menace laughs. "What? You suddenly sexual?"

"His mouth," I add.

"And?" Ghost asks, unsure how to feel. "Did you come? Fuck, I don't wanna know."

I nod anyway and look into the forest.

“Never again, Krypt,” he warns, and I know it won’t be the first or last warning I get about Remiel from Ghost.

“The whole night went off the rails. I was supposed to meet him at his dad’s grave to go over the first name on his list, but then this fucking chick...”

“Did she really look like Gia?” Ghost asks, taking a drag and passing it back.

Gia is my mom, and she’s one of the things I hate. Or, she was. “No. But she... *fuck!*”

“Said your trigger word?” Menace fills in. I hate confirming it, but I nod. “So you killed her and Remi saw it?”

“He didn’t see it, but he saw her after. She was dying, and I watched him walk up just to see what he’d do.”

“What’d he do?”

“Nothing. Just watched her die like he was seeing it second-hand or through a movie instead of experiencing it in real life.” And fuck, did that speak to me. To be intrigued by the death of a body is exactly how I react to people dying. Not in some sense that I caused the death, but in the fascinating way a body goes from living to dead, how everything shuts down, how it just... ends. “Was weird.”

“You like weird.” Menace grins.

“He’s nobody. Just the guy I have a bargain with.”

“Krypt,” Ghost warns again. Fuck him.

“Just the guy you throat raped!” Menace shouts. “What the fuck, Krypt? We’ve been friends forever, and I’ve never even seen you willingly touch someone. And him, of all people?” Menace glances at Ghost, cringing a bit.

Yeah, I’ve always figured I’m asexual or just fucked-up, but last night, something surged through me and I couldn’t stop it. It was the fear emanating from him, acting like such an aphrodisiac that I became a slave to it. My god, it turned me on when he pissed himself. Reactions to fear differ from person to person, and I fucking loved how Remiel got scared.

“What’re you going to do about him?” Ghost asks. “When he finds out...”

“He doesn’t get a say. This is my bargain, so he can fuck off about it. And so can you.”

“Until you kill him.” Ghost scowls. He’s personally invested in my bargain but he doesn’t get a say.

I ignore that and finish the joint. “Should I feel bad about the rape?”

They aren’t the right people to ask. Menace is a torture and pain junkie, and Ghost is a narcissist who lives and breathes in the grey area of life. I mean, we all do, but his grey area is often sexual, whereas mine never has been before.

“Yes,” Ghost snaps at me.

“If you want to,” Menace says. “Or you can revel in it. You finally have a life in your hands, and he willingly made the bargain, so it’s yours to do what you want with.” His grin is sick, but it makes me feel better. When Ghost shoves him, I almost feel bad. Not quite.

“Krypt,” Director calls from inside. “Let’s go. Morgue.”

Time to clean up my mess, I guess.

CURRENT RANK

1. Ransom
2. Seven
3. Ghost
4. Menace
5. Facts
6. Riot
7. Glitch
8. Kyd
9. Monster
10. Krypt



I HATE that her body has me hard. I don’t see her mottled flesh, greying under the fluorescent lights of the morgue’s cold room, or the crimson and blond hair that has turned a rusty brown.

No, I’m fixated on the bruises on her thighs. The ones that happened post-mortem from Remiel’s fingertips while I forced my way into his

throat. I'm transfixed by the dried and browning drop of blood on her forehead, the one that dripped from my knife after pressing it to his throat.

I'm freaked out by my sexual reaction, unsure what it means.

"Anything I need to know about?" Director asks from behind me. "Your DNA all over this?"

"Not mine, no." Her eyes are closed now, and someone, probably Menace or Monster, because they're both filthy fuckers, snapped her neck back into place and glued her mouth shut.

"Whose?" he asks, stepping up next to me.

When I look at her, I see him. The physical response is what shocks me. I don't try to cover my erection because it's fascinating me more than anything. I'm not typically one to get aroused because of a dead body, but then again, it's not really the body that's doing it for me.

"Necrophilia isn't you, Krypt. What's going on?" Director asks. "You've been more compulsive lately. Talk to me."

Why? No one ever listens.

I like Director. He's good to all of us, brought the ten of us together, and put up with a lot of bullshit from us ever since we reached this level of authority within Vile House. Ever since we became the ten.

When we reach a certain level, we're tested based on our training after initiation. I was loaded down with so many secrets and bits of information from the leaders, literally bursting at the seams with all of it, and for two weeks, I never once cracked. I learned the power of silence. I strengthened my mental walls so firmly that nothing got in and nothing leaked out. I learned the strength that came with endurance. Because, holy fuck, did I endure some of the worst shit of my life during those two weeks. Torture, in its worst forms, couldn't get me to crack.

It's why they named me Krypt. I held onto the K because of some attachment I'd formed to my birth name, but mostly because the letter C angered me. Couldn't stand to look at it. I was a vault of information, and when testing was done and I was allowed to vent and release that information, I couldn't do it. I'd grown protective of it. And since no one in my life had ever been protective of me, aside from my brother, it felt like my duty to hold on to something dear. Of course, the information came out in phases, given to the group by our superiors. Since then, I've had nothing worth protecting.

But now Remiel...

“She called me sick. Just like Gia used to,” I tell Director. “Am I?” Because everyone has labelled me as such. My mother, Gia. My father. The homes I spent time in before joining Vile House. Teachers, doctors, and coaches. Friends who weren’t really friends.

“What even is sick?” he asks. “Your mind works differently from most. Doesn’t make you better or worse than any of them.”

“I’m the only one here without a solid diagnosis,” I remind him. “My sickness can’t be labelled.”

“Half of their diagnoses aren’t accurate either, and it’s not a sickness. It’s a mentality, and it doesn’t need a label. Do you want a label?”

Sort of. Because if I know what’s wrong with me, maybe I can understand why everyone thinks I’m sick.

I lack a normal attention span, yet I fixate and obsess. ADHD got slapped on my file.

I don’t really understand the concept of love, feel next to no regret or remorse over my actions, and have very little ability to suppress my impulses. Psychopathy showed up in my file.

I can’t differentiate or name all the emotions I feel, often confusing one for another. Alexithymia entered my file.

I like causing pain, not because it turns me on, but because it’s fascinating to witness how others react to it. Sadist.

I used to cut myself and watch my blood leave my veins, self-harming because it made me feel alive. Masochist.

I anger quickly, have very little tolerance for others, have zero patience, and tend to place blame on everyone else for that. I control people without fully intending to. Sociopath.

I’m smart in a selection of subjects, yet incompetent in others. Autistic, maybe neurodivergent, or somewhere on the Spectrum.

I range from mute to vocalist, happy to sad, angry to elated within the blink of an eye. Borderline personality disorder. Bipolar disorder.

I mention feeling like something else lives in my head. Schizophrenia. Dissociative identity disorder.

Asexual. Demisexual. Non-identifying. Numb. All of it describes me, yet doesn’t.

They’re all there and more, stamped in red and signed by doctors and specialists. Some conditions counteract others, and some cancel others out altogether. None of them are right. No one knows who I am or what is

going on in my brain, least of all me. I'm not one thing, and I don't fit the bill for anything particular, so labels get placed on my file as a way to appease the doctors. Not me. No one actually cares what I think, how I feel, or how their labels affect me.

It's weird living in a brain that I don't understand, and it causes me to feel disconnected from myself. Like I'm a passenger inside my own body, only letting the demons inside me rattle their confines enough to peer through my eyes as tiny windows to interpret the world we see.

"You crave understanding," Director says when I don't answer. "From yourself? Or from someone else?"

I don't know. I like chaos, but I don't like it inside me. I like mysteries, but wish I could solve myself. "Not sure."

"We can do more testing if you want," he says. He steps close to me but doesn't touch me because he respects my comfort level. "But trust me, Krypt. When I look at you, I see someone unique and perfectly tainted. You wouldn't be in Vile House if you weren't. At some point, you need to let go of specific labels and learn to embrace everything different that makes you you. The guys love you."

Half of them don't feel love, but I get what he's saying. I look at the body of Ophelia Hargrove, a psychology student from the city next over. I'm not sorry she had to die, and I'm not sorry about the way she died, but I am sorry Remiel had to witness it. Not because it hurt him, but because it links him to me more than I'm comfortable with after the sexual assault last night.

"She needs to burn," I tell Director. "Remiel Sauder's DNA is all over this, and I'm in charge of his life now."

Director smiles. "Incinerate her then."

BURN OR RUN

REMIEL

I'M STARING at another calling card. Thick and expensive woven cardstock with a deep, vibrant ink. The skeletal torso splashed in purple with only five words written on the back made to taunt me once again.

See you tomorrow night, Remiel.

"What's that?" Cain asks, coming from the back of the shop.

I shove it into my pocket. "Nothing. Done with that piano?"

He nods, sighing. "What's wrong with you lately, Rem?"

Oh, nothing. I only sold my life and then almost died on top of a dead city girl by my owner's very hands. I bargained myself in exchange for my brother because I have my own plan to stop our curse. I woke up in a muddy, wet forest where I know for a fact a woman was murdered last night, but can't say shit about it to anyone without incriminating myself.

My mind is all messed up, unsure what the worst part of it all is. The sexual assault? The dying girl? My inability to do anything about it? The fact that I threw up his cum on the forest floor?

"I'm almost twenty-seven," I say instead. "Three of my male cousins and a few of the uncles I've never met died at that age. I guess it's just freaking me out. Like my clock is ticking down."

Cain frowns, knowing all about the curse on my family. "But no suicidal thoughts yet, right?"

Yet. Like they're inevitable. I guess they are. "Not yet. You staying in tomorrow night? You fucking better, Cain."

"Yeah, wanna hang and ride out Initiation Night together?"

Probably best, so I nod.

Then the chimes on the front door ring, and I look up to see my brother and his best friend Keegan enter the shop. Through the front windows, the town is turning into a nightmare. In honour of Vile Initiation Night, everyone decorates their storefronts and yards with tributes to Vile House. I don't. Ravens flock to my storefront every day, so it's already decorated with them and their shit. Coloured *Purge* masks are everywhere, and skulls in all ten colours line the streets and hang from the lampposts. I think some of them are even real skulls, painted to match the ten.

But each colour of mask has a fan club. People place the Vile Boys on pedestals, and they're basically celebrities around town, so each house and place of business becomes a vigil for their favourite Vile Boy. Cain likes the blue-masked one, but whenever I ask why, he shrugs.

"Boys," Soren says with a nasty grin. "Taking care of my shop?"

"My shop. You gave it up when you joined The Misfits." I've never outwardly called him out for joining the gang, but he doesn't deny it. "What do you want?"

"He's here for me," Cain says. "Wanna see it? I've fixed all the strings, but you have to pick the tension for the last few."

"Lead the way, handsome."

Handsome? I glare at Soren and stop him from following my best friend. "Leave him the fuck alone, Soren."

"Don't think he wants to be left alone." He smirks, heading to the back room. My brother and I look alike, but there's nothing timid about him like there is me. He's exceptional at reeling people in and then gaslighting them into whatever shell of a person he desires them to be, but I've long since learned to block his attempts to meld me into a husk. Sometimes, it's exhausting.

Keegan comes to lean on the counter I'm sitting behind. I've known him for most of my life, but I've never been close to him. He's an intense guy who has little to no social skills, always seems on edge, and doesn't form attachments to anyone. Except my brother, somehow. Pretty sure he killed his own parents, but no one could ever prove it, so he walks around as a maybe-murderer, which seems to garner him even more respect.

“Do you still play?” he asks, nodding at a cello on display. His voice wavers slightly, but otherwise, he’s stark still and staring at me.

I swallow under the power of his gaze, not looking at him fully. “Only when no one is listening.” I fiddle with the calling card in my pocket, and he looks, glimpsing the corner. “Do you need something?”

Keegan scares me. He’s unpredictable and uncomfortable to be around. His dark energy isn’t tamed, and the way he looks at everything so intensely freaks me out. His pale silver eyes stand out strongly against his tanned skin and dark brows, almost hidden behind his unruly dark hair. He doesn’t smirk or smile often, stuck with a mostly bland face, but it fits him. Suits his vibe and makes him hauntingly beautiful. He’s a tall man, over six feet, but his strength comes as lean, honed muscle rather than bulk. He’s elegantly strong, chiselled to stony perfection, and threatens people just by noticing them. Everyone I know, apart from my brother, is afraid of Keegan to the point of respecting him for it. He belongs in Moros, and it’s obvious to anyone who sees him.

My body is strong, muscled enough to keep me fit and ready to outrun my curse, but music is the only place I fit into Moros.

When Soren says something in the back and Cain laughs at it, my eyes shift there, but Keegan’s never leave my face. I *feel* them on me. “Just waiting,” he answers. “Do *you* need something?”

I gulp nerves and shiver at the chills running down my spine. “To make it to twenty-seven,” I tell him.

“You will.”

“How do you know?”

He almost smiles. Almost. It’s there, ghosting under his features, unable to meet the light of day. It makes my chills worse. Soren comes out with his violin, shouting a goodbye to Cain.

“See you tomorrow night, Remiel,” Keegan whispers, lips somehow right next to my ear. When did he get this close? My blood turns to ice. His eyes don’t shift down to my pocket where the calling card is, but... my instincts, those very same ones that have kept me alive for twenty-six years, are screaming at me to see what is right in front of me.

I must go pale, because for the first time in his whole life, Keegan smiles at me as he backs away and out of my shop, following my brother. His best friend. The third name on my list.



IT'S INITIATION NIGHT, and I'm hunkered down in my small house with Cain. But the usual anxiety that comes with Vile's initiation is nothing when combined with the third calling card.

Burn or Run, Remiel. Either way, you're mine.

I don't know what it means, but it's got me on edge. Almost as much as the clues and hints swirling around in my mind since seeing Keegan at the shop yesterday. Is he the purple mask, or did he merely say the same thing coincidentally?

There's no way it could be him. Keegan is too... apparent in Moros. He's with Soren a lot, and I've known him since they became friends in their early teens. I would have noticed if he changed his whole lifestyle to become one of the ten Vile Boys. Right? I would have noticed him missing from the house more often, disappearing for days at a time, or showing up with wounds and blood all over him.

Keegan has an older brother named Killian, and surely, he would have mentioned something if he started disappearing more often. Come to think of it, Killian isn't around all that much lately...

No. I'm spiralling. Dipping into hypotheticals that mean nothing and keep getting more and more dire the longer I spin out into the middle of oblivion. There's no possible way Keegan is the purple mask. If he was one of the Vile boys, I'd know. I'm the type of guy to notice the details. So, no. It isn't possible.

But he called me Remiel...

And I don't believe in coincidences...

"Just anxious?" Cain asks, handing me a beer and flopping onto the couch next to me. He's shirtless because he got a tattoo after work, so he's letting it air out. "Initiation Night is always fucked up, but we're good here. We've survived it here for the past few years, right?" He nudges me with his knee to calm me down, rubbing his hand over his close-cropped hair.

He's right. For the past few years, we've ridden out Initiation Night together in my tiny house. I live on a back street that isn't too busy, but we hear things. See things through the windows. We used to look, trying to catch glimpses of an unknown night, but now we shut the curtains and try to block it out. But this is the first year of initiation I've been chained to a Vile Boy. I don't even know his name, but my life is his.

When someone yells outside, I turn up the TV volume and refuse to look out the crack in the curtains. "What is it?" I ask him, nodding at his new tattoo. I'm trying to ignore the fact that my house smells different than it usually does. Like I said, I notice details, and the eucalyptus and wintergreen diffuser I run isn't subtle like it usually is. It's glaringly obvious, running at full tilt, and I don't remember turning it on. I never turn it on to full strength.

Cain sits up, showing me the front of his body. Along the underside of his ribs is a new design. Tribal like most of his others, it runs from left to right in harsh black lines with pointed tips. "It's my grandpa's design." There's a glaze over his eyes when he talks about it, and I know what he's remembering.

Cain is someone who associates pain with pleasure, and the tattooist in town, a guy named Mason, has no trouble mixing the two. A few years ago, when Cain got the balls to admit it to Mason, they started working together to make his tattoo appointments just a little *more*. Now Cain goes for ink and an orgasm.

"Looks awesome," I tell him, choking on eucalyptus and wintergreen.

He blushes, but I'm not sure what he's remembering, so I don't ask. That's his business, and other than me and Mason, no one else knows. Especially not his girlfriend. She'd be pissed if she found out he got off while getting inked.

"Where's Sadie tonight?" I ask.

"With her sisters. Tried to talk her out of it, but they're in the crypt." Sadie's family belongs to one of the many small cults around here. They're called Death For Life, and they worship their dead and believe in their ancestors to protect them. Outside Moros, their beliefs might be admirable and traditional in some cultures, but here, they're a cult. Mostly because they sacrifice one another to their dead relatives in the belief that they'll come back to watch over the living. It's fucking nuts to me, but I can't say shit about it when I'm locked in the clutches of a suicide curse. Nothing

makes sense in Moros the same way it would anywhere else, and once you accept that, life gets a little easier. So, Sadie and her sisters will ride out Initiation Night in their family's crypt, trusting the dead to keep them alive until sunrise.

"Does it smell strong in here to you?" I ask Cain.

"Yeah, a bit." He shrugs, swigging the rest of his beer. "Another?"

While he's getting more drinks, I play with the frayed edges of the calling card in my pocket. Burn or run? I still don't know what it means, and since there's no time or sign of another meeting on it, I don't know how to protect myself from it. I'm still reeling from the last run-in with him. A girl died, and now her face is plastered all over town on missing person posters.

I can't say a thing about it. The Moros PD will look, but they're as twisted as the rest of us, so they won't look hard. They just like the attention it brings from the outside world. Even negative attention is good attention in Moros—keeps people intrigued but afraid.

"Are you burning incense or something?" Cain asks from the kitchen. "I'm getting a smoky floral smell over here."

I try to sniff the air but only get wintergreen. Heading into the kitchen, I look around for anything that might be burning. "No. I never burn incense." But I smell it now. Campfires and something more chemical. "The fuck is that?"

Cain opens drawers and looks at all the electrical cords of my appliances while I sniff around, trying to figure out where it's coming from. Outside, sirens blare to remind residents to stay the fuck inside. Screams follow the sirens, and booms echo through town. Through my kitchen window, I see the orange glow of something on fire in the distance.

"Nothing in here," Cain says, confused and still sipping his fourth beer.

I pull open the door to the basement and slam it shut again. Grey smoke slinks up the stairs, slipping out the crack at the bottom of the door.

"Fuck." I press my back to it. "Is there a fire extinguisher under the sink? I keep one there."

Cain's eyes are panicked now, but he opens the cupboard and throws everything in there onto the floor. He's taking too long, so I step away and run upstairs, where I know I keep another extinguisher in the linen closet. But I don't get far.

“Fucking fuck!” I shout, watching more smoke curl from under closed bedroom doors. “Cain! There’s a fire! Hurry!” I pull open the linen closet and reach for the extinguisher. But it’s not there. It’s not where I normally keep it. With my shirt over my mouth and nose, I rip out towels and sheets and pillowcases, rooting through the closet because I fucking know it’s in here. *I know!* Because I put it there a few months ago when the cord from my coffee maker sparked up and blew a fuse.

“I can’t find it!” Cain shouts. “It’s not in here. Remi, what the fuck is going on?” I hear him turn on the sink to fill pots with water, but what are they going to do when my whole house is on fire? “Remi! Get down here,” he shouts, sounding more alarmed than a second ago.

Fuck. I sprint down the stairs, skipping three at a time. Smoke is drifting down from upstairs, creeping down each step like silent death. In the kitchen, Cain’s eyes have turned blank, and real fear lines his face. In his hand, he holds up the fourth calling card. A skeletal torso splashed in purple.

“It was under the sink,” he says, voice cold. “Where the fire extinguisher should be.”

All the blood drains from my face, every alarm bell inside me going off at once.

Burn or run, Remiel.

“What’s it say?” I ask, hesitant to touch it.
Cain flips it around to show me one word:

prey.

Burn or run, Remiel.

Run? On Initiation Night. My house is about to turn into an inferno, and anyone caught outside on Initiation Night is fair game. I look at my shirtless best friend, and he sees the panic in my eyes, but he also sees my guilt. Because of me, he’s going to have to go outside on Vile night, and if he doesn’t live through until morning, I will succumb to my family curse far sooner than planned.

“Anything you want to tell me, Remi?” he asks, flicking the card at me.

It hits my chest and flutters to the wooden floor, the kitchen now filling with smoke. “I’m so sorry, Cain.”

We both jump when something explodes outside. Through the kitchen window, that orange glow from a car fire is closer now. Because it’s my car on fire, right there in my driveway. In front of it, two black figures stand with weapons in their hands. Glinting blades reflect the fire, but their masks are easy to make out.

Purple and blue.

Cain looks at me, and I grip his hand. “We have to run,” he says. “Out the back door. Just fucking run through backyards until we get to my place.” He spins me while we choke on smoke. His hands grab the sides of my face, and something bangs against the kitchen window, shattering it. We both jump. “We can make it, Remi. We can fucking make it.”

Trying is the only option we have.

Burn or run, Remiel.

Prey.

IRRATIONAL ASSHOLE

KRYPT

THAT LITTLE FUCKER touches *my* Remiel. Hands on either side of his face through the window while they strategize their next move. I throw a rock at it, shattering the glass to get them moving. Cain's hands drop, but I don't breathe easier.

Menace laughs beside me, his wicked smile hidden beneath his black and blue mask. Menace has a history with Cain, and he was more than willing to join me tonight. Because I need Cain out of my way, and Menace is an eager hunter when it comes to the tattooed one.

"They're gonna go out the back," he says, pacing in anticipation of the hunt. "Fuck, I hope they can run."

"Remiel is mine," I remind him.

"Like you burning his house down in order to chase him through town didn't make that obvious," Menace mocks. "You ready, Krypt?"

I'm trembling with restraint. Waiting until my scared little hero makes a run for it. He's going to try to save his friend, unable to live with the guilt if something happens to him, but Menace will keep him busy. Remiel is all mine, and I can't wait to capture him.

I smile behind my mask, the only place I'm comfortable smiling. "Been waiting for this all day."

Menace howls into the fire-lit night as Remiel's house is almost totally engulfed by flames. Through the window, the two of them scramble, grabbing anything they can use as weapons to protect themselves. Smoke fills the kitchen now, and with one last look in my direction, Remiel runs through the house, pausing only once to mourn the loss of everything he owns.

My turn to howl. *I'm coming for you, hero.*

Menace stalks at my side as we make our way to the back of Remiel's dying house. He looks at me as we glimpse them skirting through the gate at the back to weave through the neighbour's backyard.

"Cain Carson!" Menace yells, just to scare him. "I'm coming for you!"

Remiel whimpers up ahead. It makes my dick twitch.

Through the gate and into someone else's yard, I watch them slink through to the side of the house. The owners peer through their windows with fearful eyes, but they're safe in there. I usually follow the rules. *Usually*. Burning a house down just to force the owner outside isn't considered rule-following, but fuck it. I've been an irrational asshole since my deal with Remiel Sauder.

When we get to the front of the house, Remiel and Cain are running down the centre of the street. People in horror costumes creep under the streetlights and run at them, but with a growl from me, they back off. They're adrenaline junkies, people who want to tempt fate and take their chances on the streets during Initiation Night. Anyone actually initiating is wearing a black mask like ours but with a black face, no colour assigned to them.

We pick up our pace, jogging after them. Their anxiety makes them clumsy, slowing them down enough that it's easy to catch up.

"They're going to Cain's house," I say.

"We'll catch them before they get there," Menace answers, looking at me. "We'll cut them off on Crucifix Street." He veers to the right and I follow, cutting through a playground and a few yards.

Camped in the shadows of Cain's house, I watch a small person in a black mask stalk a girl from her car. She's just trying to get to her front door, but the initiate throws a dagger, and it embeds in the girl's back.

Selena Sauder stalks her prey, standing over Sally Davies' bleeding body. The youngest Sauder kid has a good chance of making the cut this year.

"Time to separate them," I tell Menace when Cain and Remiel come down Crucifix Street. "I'm taking Remiel back to Vile House."

"Don't worry. I'll make sure his friend has a good time," Menace says, and then we part ways. I stay in the shadows and Menace walks right out onto the street, snatching Cain from behind. "Look what I caught," Menace

shouts while Cain flails, trying to hit him with a bat. “An artsy one!” He runs his hands over Cain’s bare, tattooed chest.

Remiel has a kitchen knife, swinging it at Menace to free his friend. Silently walking up behind him, I grab his wrist and twist it until he cries out in pain and the knife falls to the sidewalk. Remiel hits me, his fist landing against the front of my shoulder. The pain radiates up my neck and turns my vision crimson.

“Fuck. You!” he seethes, trying to break free of my hold on his wrist. “You fucking cheated!”

I did. But winners don’t always win by playing fair. I wrap my arm around him from behind, snugging it up to his throat until he can’t breathe.

“Calm down,” I whisper in his ear.

“Let Cain go!”

“Mmm, this one is mine,” Menace says, dragging Cain away. “Have fun.”

“Cain!” Remiel shouts. “Fuck! I’m sorry, Cain!”

I glance across the street, but Selena Sauder already sees us. She sees me with her brother, and she’s unpredictable enough that I don’t know what she’s going to do. When she takes a step in my direction, I tilt my head at her in warning. Her fingers tighten on her dagger hilts, but she bows her head and drags Sally by her hair, taking her to the backyard of Vile House.

Remiel is crying now. “Please,” he begs. “Please don’t hurt Cain.”

“Cain is fine,” I tell him. The way he squirms in my hold is almost as hot as when he pissed himself over the dead body. My cock thickens, and I don’t hide it. I press it against his ass and firm up my grip. “Ready to run, Remiel?”

He sobs but tries to choke it back. “Fuck you. Fuck you and your fucking bargain. This isn’t what I agreed to!” He lets anger win, and I like that even more. Scared and pissed off about it is sexy.

I bend down, press the hilt of a blade against his palm, and whisper in his ear, “Run.”

But he does something that surprises me so much I stumble back a step. Remiel spins, pressing that blade to the fabric covering my neck. “You fucking run,” he snarls at me.

Oh, fuck me. Yes. For the first time in my entire life, arousal so strong and so violent consumes me, filling me until I’m shaking and hard. It damn near renders me useless, but when Remiel steps forward to press the dagger

to my throat even harder, I almost come in my pants. I wrap my fingers around his trembling wrist.

“Fight me all you want, hero. Maybe I’ll bury you with Ophelia Hargrove after I’ve had my fun with you.”

Remiel is about to reply when someone in a Krampus costume rushes at us. I snatch the dagger Remiel has against my neck and fling it, hitting the Krampus’ head dead centre. He falls to his back, dead on impact, bleeding out at my hero’s unsteady feet.

“Oh my god,” he whispers, shocked.

“It’s Krypt, actually,” I give him my name and grab his hands, tying them behind his back. “And I’ll be your devil. Not your god.”

“Kryp... Keegan?” he asks.

I knock him the fuck out.



BECAUSE IT’S INITIATION NIGHT, I have a job to do. I leave Remiel bound and gagged at my feet and stand with the other nine Vile Boys in the clearing behind Vile House. Random people litter the ground at their feet or lean against their legs with rags shoved into their mouths.

The lower-ranking members are out cleaning up the town and removing any *evidence* they find, protecting our secrets from Moros citizens who will wake up in the morning to blood staining the streets.

Director wears his mask, black with a gold face, and greets all the initiates who made it back.

“Congratulations on surviving Initiation Night!” His modulated voice echoes through the clearing despite the mist hanging in the air. “And welcome to Vile!”

A small army of black-masked initiates stare back at him, their offerings on the ground beneath them. Murder is not required to join Vile House—it’s not even encouraged—but a sacrifice is. Not that we’re going to murder their sacrifices, but they need to prove their hunting abilities. Vile House keeps Moros going by being feared. We’re here to keep the town in check, to build onto the history of it, and keep outside forces from infiltrating our ranks. And while they’re hunting for a sacrifice, we’re breathing down their

necks and scaring them until they either succeed or quit, not cut out for it. So many quit, running home to give up.

This year, the hunt wasn't just for sacrifices. It was for a man named Benton Wentworth. A billionaire trying to buy Moros from the county—the county doesn't want our crime stats on their reports, so they're trying to sell us off. We've had Wentworth in the cellar for a bit now, and earlier tonight, just as the sun was setting, he was set free to try to earn his way out of Moros for good.

Unfortunately, he didn't make it. He sits at Monster's feet, bloodied and broken. He's whimpering, trying to beg for freedom because he learned a few valuable lessons tonight. One, Moros can't be bought. Two, his money won't save his life. And three, Monster is the last person he'll ever want to see again.

"For generations, Moros has remained ours!" Director goes on, his voice warped. "And this man tried to take it from us. But like all others before him, he failed, didn't he?"

The initiates cheer. Selena Sauder cheers loudest. Her blond-ish hair trails down her back from beneath her black mask. She looks at me, noticing her brother at my feet, but it doesn't stop her cheering. Atta girl.

"And you're here to initiate because you want to become a protector of Moros. Like them." Director motions to the ten of us, and every head in the clearing swivels to take us in. Our identities aren't known, but our masks are, and we're like royalty around here. Everyone who makes it through Initiation Night wants to be one of us. One of the ten. We've all stood where they are, thirsting for where we are now.

I remember my Initiation Night. The ten at the time were so feared that my knees were weak and my heart beat so hard it made my teeth chatter. But the adrenaline had been everything. The hope, the desire to be something more than a person with a dead family and a sick mind. I wanted to be put to use, gain a purpose, and revel in the town that morphed me into who I am. I know that's what every one of the black masks is feeling tonight. That spark of hope that they'll get to become a part of Moros history that so few do.

"Tonight, we celebrate! And we show this man what Moros really has to offer." After tonight, if he survives the party, he'll be set free to warn others away from here. His claims will draw attention to crimes that can't be

proved, and like always, we'll survive it. "Monster, bring him here," Director demands.

But Monster doesn't give up his prey easily. He's possessive of the billionaire, snapping at anyone who dares take him away. Director can't control Monster, but Ransom can. In his red mask, Ransom steps in front of Monster, tilting his chin with two fingers. The tiny maniac is wound tight, but whatever Ransom says to him has his body stiffening but his chin dipping. Director takes the man at his feet, and Ransom stays at Monster's back, arms tight around his chest to keep him in check.

"Masks stay on, and no one is permitted inside the house, but everything else is a free-for-all. Let's show this man a good time and give him plenty of stories to take home!"

It's nearly three in the morning, but the party will go until the sun rises and a new day falls on Moros. Menace is ready to leave to get back to the tattooed one he has tied up in his room, so I give him a nod as he pushes by me. Remiel groans as I pull him from the ground, but before I get far, his younger sister is in front of me. Her blond hair bothers me, but her audacity to approach me bothers me more.

"What will you do with him?" she asks.

"Whatever the fuck I want." I pull a calling card from my pocket, Remiel's name written on the back. "He gave his life to me."

If she recognizes my voice, she doesn't show it. With a nod, she crouches down, face in front of her brother's. "What have you done, Remi?"

He groans but says nothing, not coherent enough to form real words.

"Keep him alive," Selena says to me. "He's already battling a curse."

With a nod, I throw Remiel over my shoulder and carry him inside Vile House. On my way to my room, I bump into my brother, wearing his black mask with a white face. We're the second set of blood brothers to ever be a part of the ten at the same time. The first was our great-grandfather and his brother.

"You know what you're doing with this one, Krypt?" Riot asks.

I nod. "Might need your help with one of the names on his list."

Riot nods and hands me a joint. "Soren?"

"Soren," I confirm.

Riot lifts his mask and looks at me with a face so similar to mine, eyes full of storms instead of monsters. He grins, nodding. "Soren Sauder," he

repeats. “Dead?” Riot has always had something against Soren, so this will be interesting.

“Controlled.” I walk past him and take Remiel to my room.

It’s about time he learns whose face hides behind my mask.

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UNMASKED

REMIEL

THE TASTE of smoke and fear still lingers in my throat. My first coherent thought is for my house, which is probably burnt to the ground by now.

Everything I own is in there, reduced to cinders and ash. Everything I worked hard for, earned all on my own, and paid for with money made from The Ambient Raven. My memories and secrets are in that house, but like my life, it now burns. I don't even have a vehicle anymore.

Blinking, my eyelids are wet and heavy. My lashes all stick together, and when I rip them apart with another blink, a darkened room with a single glowing light greets me. The light is a neon sign on the wall, a purple skull shining down from one corner of the room.

I immediately know we're in Vile House because the walls are made of old stone and the draft in the air makes me shiver. The window beside me looks down over the backyard area, the party still going loud and strong.

My lungs hurt when I inhale, making me cough hard enough that a rag shoots out of my mouth and lands on my lap. My almost naked lap. My red boxers are all that cover me, my toned torso naked and my legs and feet bare. Something is written all over my skin—letters and lines snake around my arms and up over my shoulders. Even my thighs are covered in black marker, but it's too dark to make out the words.

Movement draws my eyes to the glowing purple sign. He's here. Krypt. The man in the purple mask.

He's shirtless, standing with his back to me in a pair of black pants and boots. His entire back is tattooed with one design. A skull face in black ink that stretches from the curve in his neck down to the waistband of his pants.

The eyes are black and the bones are cracked, the teeth jagged and chipped. KRYPT in block letters is written on a curve below the jaw, and at the very top of the skull, VILE HOUSE glows under the light. Splashes of purple mingle with the design, and it's so daunting yet so beautiful that I can't take my eyes off it. Especially when his muscles ripple and the words move with his body.

His mask is on, the strap of it tight around the back of his head. Dark hair waves down to his nape, shaggy and longer than I thought. It should comfort me that I think I recognize his hair, but it only scares me more. I don't know what he's doing over there, but his hands are busy and his attention is focused.

"Where's Cain?" I ask, my voice hoarse and weak.

"You shouldn't ask about other men while you're half naked and your body belongs to me," he says to the wall opposite me.

"It's not my fault I'm half naked."

My body isn't as defined as his. I'm muscled and a little bulky, but not as toned. Tall, but not as tall as him. And he's clearly proven he's more dangerous than I am.

"Cain?" I ask again.

"Alive," is all he answers.

My mind is slow and my body is stiff. I can't move my arms because they're tethered to the chair, but I roll my ankles to get the blood moving in case I get the chance to run. All the while, my eyes take in the back of his body. "Why spell Krypt with a K?"

"I don't like the letter C," he says. Then he turns around. His chest is bloody from whatever he did after knocking me out, and his mask covers the features of his face, but that doesn't mean I can't feel his eyes on me. That sixth sense I have sparks to life, and whatever he's about to do to me will be ruthless. My nape prickles and my thighs clench, anticipating what my brain considers the worst. It probably isn't even close to what he has in mind. He's already sexually assaulted me once, and I haven't had the time to process it yet.

"What's wrong with the letter C?" I ask, stalling. Instinctively, my arms thrash and try to break free the closer he gets to me. Something buzzes in his hand, and my throat dries. "What're... what're you doing with that?"

His head tilts as he studies all the drawings on my body. Now that he isn't blocking the light, I can see what they are. Krypt. His name, written all

over me. My stomach, chest, arms, and thighs are covered in his name, written in different fonts and styles and sizes.

He pulls up a stool and a small cart with black ink pots on it. “To complete our bargain, it must be etched into the skin,” he says. “And blood must be drawn.”

I thrash harder.

“Having second thoughts about the deal we made?”

Yes and no. I’m terrified of him, and now that I think I know who he is, it doesn’t make me feel any better because I feared him long before I knew he belonged to Vile House. But if I have to put my life in someone’s hands and trust that they’ll complete my tasks, it’s him. Although...

“I’m doubting your ability to follow through now that I know who you are.”

“I agreed to it, didn’t I?” he asks, voice calm but jittery again. Like the words want to come out too fast.

I try looking at his eyes, and I quickly look away when I see all his monsters rattle their cages. “You’ll end all three names on my list?”

“You said gone. Since it’s *him* you’re asking about. I’ll make him gone until you say otherwise.” He reaches out to flip my arm over. The restraints burn at my skin, but there’s enough leeway to flip my wrist. A vertical scar stands out in the purple light, and his thumb brushes it. “Tell me why you made the deal, Remiel.”

“It’s none of your fucking business.”

“Mmm,” he agrees. “But as soon as I mark you as mine, everything about you will be my business, so you might as well tell me.” He presses on my scar, making it hurt. “Reeven Matterson,” he states the first name.

No point in hiding since I’m already laid bare before him. “He’s the man who leads the Matter Cult, and he’s been terrorizing my mom’s side of the family ever since she got us free of the cult. I want him gone to protect my family.”

“Gregory Malone.” The next name comes from his tongue with no acknowledgement of my reasoning.

“Has done everything within his power to turn me and my brother mad. He’s the reason my youngest brother killed himself, and he’s trying to speed up the timeline for me and Soren. I can’t let that happen.” And he was the man stalking me the night I ran to Vile House to strike this deal. He chased me here, so it’s only fair that I sic my new hound on him.

“Soren Sauder,” he says my brother’s name while his thumb continues to press on my scar. “Dead by a hand other than his own? To end the curse?” he guesses.

That’s what I wanted him to think, but I didn’t say dead. I said gone. I have a very strong feeling that I’m going to be next. I’m going to get pushed to my breaking point and end my life, and when that happens, I want Soren somewhere he can’t end his own. I want *him* to break the curse by being so well-contained and protected that he’ll never have the chance to kill himself. I want him gone, owned by someone else, so thoroughly controlled that he won’t be able to lift a blade or swallow a pill without someone breathing down his neck and stopping him. I might hate my brother, but I love him, too. I want him to live through this, even after I’m gone, to see the curse lifted from our family.

“Answer me,” Krypt demands.

“I want him owned,” I say. “Protected until I’m dead, even if he hates it. Because... because I want you to kill me so the curse breaks and Soren lives through it. When I’m gone, dead because of you instead of suicide, he’ll have a chance to live the rest of his life without the curse hanging over his head. He needs to be contained and watched until I’m dead.” I meet his eyes and all the monsters within them. “I want you to kill me to save my brother.”

Krypt’s hand tightens on my wrist, his fingertips pressing into my scar. My hand goes numb and a cry breaks through my pursed lips. “That’s not the bargain you struck. You only said gone. I’ll make him gone.”

“And kill me when he’s safe,” I add.

“No.”

“No?”

“No. You belong to me now, and I’m not letting a pointless death have you.”

I grit my teeth together and curse myself for not being more clear when I made my deal with this devil. “I have ways to make you change your mind. I don’t think it’ll be hard to entice you into killing me.” My smile is fake, but it feels sick and twisted... and good. “There’s no point in keeping the mask on. I already know who you are. Which is how I know you won’t kill Soren.”

“Careful, Remiel,” he says, fingertips trailing up my arm and stopping at the marker sketched onto my collarbone. “If you know who I am, you

also know that I've killed those I love before. My love is dangerous. My attention is worse."

"Take the mask off."

He tilts his head. "Blood first."

The tattoo gun in his hand buzzes, and he doesn't give me any time at all to brace for it. The needles prick into my clavicle, and I hiss out a pained breath.

"Once you know my identity and the identity of others in Vile House, you are banned from sharing it with anyone. Usually, it's punishable by death, but since you want death, I'll add my own stipulation." He dips the gun and brings it back to my skin. "I'll force you to kill yourself, and then I'll make sure Soren is next. I know *exactly* how to drive him mad. The Sauder curse will live on. All your young little cousins will be next."

My eyes drip tears of pain and defeat. "Fine. I'll keep your Vile secrets."

The tattoo gun keeps moving, burning. "You will stay with me from now on. Here or at my house, wherever the fuck I want you. You're mine, and I get full control of your life."

"That why you burned my house down like a psycho?"

"Agree."

"Fine. But you can't assault me anymore."

"I can," he declares. "And I will."

I gulp, but it turns into a hiss when the needles dig so deep they hit my bone. "Do all bargains come with ownership and sex?" I've never heard that before, but... what do I know about Vile secrets?

"No. But yours does." He glances at my eyes. "You can't interfere with Vile business, and you have no fucking say over what I do or don't do. When I want you with me on jobs, you'll be there. When I don't, you'll be under the care of my brothers or locked in my room. When you work, you'll keep your fucking hands off Cain Carson." He trembles, probably too many Cs in my best friend's name. "Actually, you'll keep your hands off everyone. If I hear you touch someone or they touch you, I'll cut parts of them off until you get the hint. Got it?"

Jesus. I'm too far gone now anyway. "Fine." Not like I touch many people anyway. "Wait. What if my mom wants to hug me or something?"

He dips the gun and tilts his head at me. "No touching unless I give permission."

“My god, you’re fucking crazy.” I squirm under the gun, but it only digs in deeper. “What else?”

“There is no timeline on our deal. Until I free you, you’re mine. Even after your conditions have been met and the three names on your list are taken care of. Mine. Agree.”

Until he kills me, yeah. “Fine.”

“My true name will never be revealed. You’ll keep it a secret until the day you die. If we’re in public together and I’m unmasked, you’ll call me by my birth name. If we’re in public together and I’m masked, you’ll call me Krypt. But that won’t happen. If I’m with you while I’m masked, you’ll also be masked. Got it?”

“Fine.”

“The same rules apply to anyone else’s identity you learn in Vile House. Trust me, if you reveal Vile House secrets, there are so many ways I can ruin you without killing you.”

I nod, not doubting that. Tears leak harder now, soaking my cheeks and dripping onto the tattoo he’s giving me. Blood drips down my chest, mixing with black ink.

“I might be crazy, Remiel, but good luck enticing me into killing you. I’m very patient,” he says. “Everything you know, fucking everything, is about to change. Are you ready?”

I don’t know what that means, but I nod regardless. I’m ready. Because I don’t plan to live through this. He *will* murder me, and when he does, the curse on my family will lift and Soren will carry on the family name in a new light. No more suicidal Sauder men.

He sets down the tattoo gun, washes my skin, and presses clear plastic to my new tattoo, taping it in place. Then he pulls a dagger from the band of his pants, slices the tips of two fingers open, and smears his blood across my face and lips. I don’t even cringe.

“Bargain struck?” his jittery voice asks.

“Bargain met,” I agree.

“Lick your lips,” he demands. When I do, his other hand smacks the underside of my chin, making me bite my tongue so hard it bleeds.

I don’t get time to wince. His fingers mix our blood, pushing it into my mouth and against my tastebuds. When he pulls them free and pushes them under his mask to suck the blood off, my hips move and the copper tang of *us* clouds my mind.

“Welcome to Vile House, Remiel Sauder.” He frees my hands and places them on the edge of his mask.

There’s no going back now. I rip it free.

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SHOW ME WHAT'S MINE

KRYPT

IT'S NOT my identity that shocks him because he already knows. It's the black eye and busted cheekbone that makes him gasp. It's my eyes and what lives within them. When my mask falls to my bedroom floor, Remiel's gaze doesn't drop with it. It stays on mine, maintaining eye contact despite how hard it is for most people to hold eye contact with me.

Oh... wow. His eye contact...

When the beasts within me surge to the pale silver of my irises, his throat rolls with a swallow and his fingertips touch my eyelids, forcing them closed.

I wait a single heartbeat, willing away my monsters, before opening them again. Remiel's breath hitches, and then he looks at my injuries. I didn't have them the last time I saw him in his music shop, but I got them shortly after. Minutes after exiting through the front door.

Because of Soren.

Because our worlds are so woven together that Remiel has no idea what kind of bargain he's struck with me. Everything he knows is about to change, and I'll be the conductor of his new life.

"Keegan," he whispers.

I lean back and stand up. "Not here. Here, I'm Krypt."

"How is this even possible? How can you live a double life and no one knows about it? Not even Soren or your brother?" He's rambling, but again, he does not know how deeply his world is about to change. "How do you do it? How do you keep such big secrets?"

"Stand up," I demand. "Show me what I own, Remiel. You aren't the hero here." I back away from him, admiring my name tattooed across his

collarbone. Menace drew the designs for me while Remiel was passed out and Cain was chained up, and it fucking bothered me to watch another man touch him. I picked which one I wanted to ink on him forever in the heat of the moment. If I had my way, I'd tattoo them all on him and cover every inch of his skin with my name.

I don't fully understand why I'm suddenly so drawn to him, but he looked into my eyes and didn't look away...

Remiel stands on shaky legs, but that's all he does. He stares at me until I lean against my dresser, waiting for him to show me all of his body. His eyes fall to the floor, but I won't stand for shyness. I'll expose him so thoroughly there won't be a single part of him hidden from me.

"Remiel," I warn, lighting a joint to calm my mind. "Now."

He tucks his fingers into the waistband of his boxer-briefs, but not to pull them down. He holds them up like the fabric is the only thing protecting him. He's masculine yet beautiful about it, and I love the way his body looks.

"I'm... I'm not gay. There shouldn't be anything sexual here."

Shouldn't isn't a word I live by. If I want something sexual, it'll be sexual. He doesn't get a say.

I just stare at him and smoke my joint. He's lucky I'm even smoking it. I cross one foot over the other and bask in the glow of my neon light, enjoying the way he fears me even more now that my identity is confirmed.

His hair is a dark blond that doesn't offend me like most blonds do. His baby blue eyes are too big for his face, but fuck me, they look nice while wide with fear. Glazed and glossy, they sweep my body and linger on my abs. My cock thickens inside my pants, and Remiel looks away, fingers still gripped in his boxers.

"Please, Kee-Krypt. You already took everything from me. My car, my house, my dignity, my fucking life. Don't make me do this, too."

"Took it from you?" I ask, trying to keep myself contained a bit longer. "Did you not bargain it away freely? You *gave* it to me, Remiel."

"Just Remi! No one calls me Remiel."

"I do. And if you aren't naked in the next ten seconds, you'll find out what else I can freely take from you."

His red boxers hit the floor, but his hands cover his junk. "I'm not gay," he repeats.

Up until the night in the cemetery, I didn't think I was either. I wasn't sexual at all. Had fucked a time or two just to see what all the fuss was about, but otherwise, I'm inexperienced and acting on instinct. And my instincts all want him. It's the reason I have a black eye and bruised cheekbone.

I finish the joint and drop the butt into an empty water glass on my dresser. Sighing, I tilt my head at Remiel. "What part of you do you think you can keep from me, hero? Your cock? Is that why you cover it?"

He shakes, trembling on the spot. I press my sliced fingers together just to feel my blood ooze.

"What happened to the guy who held my own blade to my throat and told me to run?" I push off the dresser and take a single step closer. "Show. Me."

"No."

I close my eyes and welcome the darkness that pulses through me. An adrenaline surge feeds my monsters and wakes up the sinister parts of my brain. For how many people have called me sick throughout my life, Remiel is about to get firsthand experience. My exhale comes out of my nose shakily, resembling the grip I have on my sanity. It's about to slip, and when it does, Remiel better have good survival instincts. He might wish to die eventually, but he's not ready yet. Not until he knows his brother is protected.

When I open my eyes and meet his, he chokes out a sound of fear and moves his hands to his sides. His soft cock hangs heavy between his legs, bigger than I imagined while flaccid. His hip bones are fucking beautiful, and all I want to do is dig my fingers into them from behind. Covered in marker, he looks harsher than he is, grungy and contaminated. It bothers me that Menace's marks are still on him, so I focus on the tattoo on his collarbone and admire the cut of his abs.

Licking my lips and getting a taste of his blood again, I swallow him down while walking a circle around him. No other tattoos mark his skin. A taut, tight ass and a muscular body taken care of. The only other marks on him are scars, and I plan to add a few more to his flesh. The red and purple of the bigger ones look perfect with his skin tone, but the white lines from former stitches look delicious enough to run my tongue over.

"What do you want with me?" he asks quietly.

Everything. To learn him. To figure out how he responds to fear and pain. To cut him off from everything and everyone in his life until he is solely mine and relies only on me. To warp his mind and force him to understand my sickness so I can understand myself—so I don't feel so alone in my sickness. To use him until he begs for me, and then to dangle him in front of death's door without ever letting him cross through. To teach him to take his own power and use it to his advantage.

"To remind you what it means to live before you die," I say, walking around to his front. When I look down, he tries to cover his dick again. His hands move, but fall back to his sides when I look at them. Because he's hardening now, cock filling with all the blood not going to his head.

Fear. It's his aphrodisiac. Interesting...

"Krypt, you fucking fuck!"

Remiel's eyes dart to the door at the sound of the voice. He bends to pick up his boxers, but I stop his hand and push him behind me just as the door bangs open. I've been waiting for this.

Remiel gasps, truly shocked, but I pull a gun from my pants and hold it against Soren's forehead.

"Don't do this, Ghost."

"My fucking brother!" he seethes. "I warned you not to, Krypt." Yeah, he told me to drop the bargain, but he's fuck if he thinks I'm gonna listen.

Soren has been my best friend since we were thirteen, but he became my brother when we were seventeen. When we pledged to Vile House together. When we got our new names—he became Ghost and I became Krypt—we made a vow to always protect each other. Remiel was never supposed to know, but now he's staring at a new version of his brother, afraid that he'll learn the terms of our bargain. Ghost demanded that I end this bargain, and I didn't listen, so here we are.

Wedge between the two of them, I realize how different they are despite their physical similarities. They definitely look related, both having the same blue eyes and tanned skin tone, but Remiel's hair is more golden-hued compared to Ghost's dirty blond. It's their energy that differs vastly; Remiel is all vulnerabilities and hidden darkness, but his brother lets his darkness take centre stage. Ghost does nothing to hinder his sinister personality, but Remiel hasn't learned to be comfortable in his yet.

"Soren!" Remiel gasps.

"Ghost," we both say, even though my gun is still between his eyes.

“One beating wasn’t enough,” Ghost says, his evil eyes not wavering from mine. “Fuck you for doing this, Krypt. Fuck you for all of it.” He wraps his hand around the barrel of the gun and presses it harder against his forehead. “We had a deal.”

“And now I have a new one,” I tell him. He knows what it means. For as long as I’ve known him, he’s tried to keep his brother alive. He pushed him away four years ago after their dad died, but it was a way to protect him. To give Remiel space while Ghost tried to figure out how to end their family curse.

“Fuck,” Ghost seethes, shoving away. The gun drops to my side, and Ghost peers around me. “Fuck you for making this bargain, Remi. You were never supposed to come here!”

But Remiel isn’t answering because he not only just found out that I’m a Vile Boy, but that his brother is, too. Remiel thought Soren was in The Misfits gang, but that’s just a cover. I warned him that everything he knew was about to change...

Ghost reaches around me to grab his brother, but I grab his wrist and warn him away. “Remi, look at me,” Soren demands. Remiel whimpers, but he must look at his brother, using my body as a shield to hide his nakedness. Funny how he swapped me from villain to protector so quickly. “He won’t tell me what you bargained, but I swear to fuck if you do anything to get yourself killed, I’ll end this fucking world. Got it?”

Remiel is quietly crying behind me. Up until this moment, Remiel figured Soren hated him and would use him to avoid the curse. I can feel his body shaking against my back, so I look at Ghost and warn him with a look. “Get out.”

“Fuck my brother and I’ll kill you, Krypt.” He backs out, grabbing the edge of the door. “Can’t fucking believe you.” He slams it shut and I lock it now that the confrontation is over and out of the way.

When I turn around to find Remiel staring at the floor, trying not to cry, I grab a fistful of his hair and force him to his knees. He cries harder, but his eyes meet mine when I jerk his head back. Such brilliant blue mixed in with all those tears.

“Truth hurt, hero?”

“Yes!” he yells at me. “Fuck you! Fuck all of you!”

“Feel left out?” I ask, my voice taunting. “Hurts finding out your whole life is a lie, doesn’t it? When those you love keep secrets from you and

always push you to the outside.”

Remiel’s eyes shift down my body, but he’s not seeing me. He’s mourning the truth he just lost. He’s reworking the puzzle pieces of his life to fit this new reality. He’s wondering if anything is as it seems and who else has been lying to him. While he breaks, I crouch in front of him, ready to grab all the jagged bits of him and rework them to my liking until he’s put together in a way that benefits me as much as it does him.

“What’re you gonna do now, hero? Break all the rules of our bargain and tell the town who we are?”

He wants to spit out the word ‘yes’ just to hurt me, but he purses his lips together, knowing that won’t benefit him. Remiel is smart, but he succumbs to stupidity and irrational behaviour just like the rest of us. Anger creates chaos, and when it’s all churned up with hurt and pain, the destructive path always looks most appealing. I understand that. Have taken that path more than I care to admit.

“How long?” he asks. “How long have you two been in Vile House? How long has my brother been lying to me? Who else in my life is a fucking traitor?” His questions grow louder the more brazen he gets. “Why’d you kill that girl? Why’d you rape me over her body? Why the fuck did you take my bargain, Krypt?” He shoves at me, and I love it so much that I force him to stand and push him onto my bed. “Why?!” He kicks at me.

He has a lot of information to process, but now isn’t the time.

“Where’s Cain?!” he screams, voice cracking.

I flip him onto his stomach, push his legs together, and sit on them. He fights it, but the struggle just makes my dick harder. His tight ass rests between my legs, and fucking hell, I’ve never wanted to fuck something harder. The way he bucks beneath me only heats my blood and draws the attention of my monsters. I don’t know where they come from or what they are, but I know they’re what people see and call me sick for. There’s something inside me that isn’t right, and I used to think it was a festering illness I needed to heal and purge, but I’ve become attached to it. I’m comfortable with what lives inside my head and taints my heart. We’ve learned to coexist.

But I still crave understanding. I still want a diagnosis.

“Please,” Remiel begs. “Just tell me where Cain is.”

Probably at Menace's mercy, but I don't say that. "I told you he was alive. I also told you not to ask about other men while you're naked."

"Then let me get dressed!" he shouts, but I push on the back of his head to drown his words in the blankets.

I have no idea what I plan to do with him. Out of some attachment to Ghost, I want to take it easy on him and give him the rest of the night to come to terms with everything he's just learned. But the other part of me wants to remind him that he belongs to me now, and choice is no longer an option for him.

That *he* chose this. *He* made the bargain and agreed to the terms. That *he* sold his life away with the hope of being fucking murdered, and instead of murdering him, I'm going to make him feel so tragically alive he'll start actually living.

"Krypt," he cries into the sheets. "Please."

I grind my cock against his bare ass, unsure what to do with him. Yeah, I assaulted him, but I also know very little about sex. All I know is that I want him.

"Please what?" My hair falls into my eyes when I lean over his back, running my nose against the knobs of his upper spine. He smells like smoke, reminding me how insane I went earlier. I burned his goddamn house down just to trap him with me.

My hips move, dancing on his body. Each rub of my cock against his ass dampens my pants with leaking precum. I fist my hand in his hair harder, pinning him down because I'm afraid he'll flee. I'm not in the mood to hunt anymore. I'm in the mood to fucking take. But I don't want him to look at me while I do it. I don't want him to witness my insecurities—my inexperience.

"Please, just let me process this alone. I need to be alone."

Like hell. I undo my pants and sit up, pulling my heavy dick free and slapping it against his ass. Menace's marker litters his back, and I hate it. I hate that he's covering more of Remiel than I am. So, I fist my cock and press the wet tip to the crack of his ass, burning with a sensation so strong I don't stand a chance of resisting it. He tries, squirming beneath me and muttering sobs into the blankets.

I want him on his stomach, his dick hidden from me. Because I don't know what I'll do if he's not hard. I don't know how to handle sexual rejection, and it will enrage me and scare me if I'm so into him when he

wants nothing to do with me. I already know he's not gay. He's told me. Asked me not to assault him. Begged for time alone.

But I've never been a good person, and my monsters are stronger than my morals.

I slide my cock through his ass crack, enraptured by the way it looks. Spreading him open with my free hand, I grind against him, slathering slick precum over his supple skin and into his crack. When he cries out, I press his face into the bed even harder, unwilling to understand if his cries are pleased or pained.

He's not fighting me anymore, but he's tense all over. The muscles in his back ripple with apprehension, and his ass wiggles beneath me. The material of my pants scrapes against his balls as I fuck his crack, keeping my pace slow but gripping him so hard he turns red. I like the way his thick thighs feel between my legs, shifting and writhing because he can't stay still and *take it*.

"Krypt." He pushes his head into my hand, forcing me to let him breathe. He turns his face to the side and tries to look at me, but I refuse to let him. I want him to fear me, not pity me. Not mock me. "At least add lube or something. It hurts."

I don't care if it hurts. Do I?

I don't think about it. I spit, letting it fall to his pink hole, spreading it up through his crease with the head of my cock to mingle with precum and turn him into a slippery mess. Letting go of his head, I pin his hips down and lean forward, fucking my cock against his ass harder.

Remiel's breathing changes. His breaths come faster and grow shorter, and I don't know what they mean, but I become frenzied. I spread him wide open and slide through his crack, pushing his cheeks together to fuck the tight space.

Tainted pleasure fills my body and entices my mind, and I spit again just so I can fuck it into his skin. It's been a long time since I even touched myself, and the last time I came was down his throat, but fuck me. I'm there. On the razor's edge of madness and pleasure, un-fucking-willing to pick a side. I want madness. I want pleasure. I want them both together.

Remiel hisses, maybe in pain, possibly in pleasure. Most likely in fear.

I need to brand him with something other than Menace's marker. I fall over him, fucking against him and sucking a mark to the side of his neck.

When my breath hits his skin, I realize I'm panting. Rasping. Going goddamn mad with the need to claim him.

My cock slides over his ass and my teeth sink into the flesh of his shoulder, and when he cries out in pain, I lose my fucking mind. I latch onto him with my teeth and come all over his ass and back, gliding through it because I can't stop. I won't stop.

My body trembles on top of his, and I breathe around his skin, biting down hard enough to draw a little blood.

"Krypt! Jesus," he complains, squirming.

I lick his blood and keep grinding. I don't know how to stop. The warmth of his body and the slickness of my cum is such a perfect feeling that I need more. I want to spread him open and fuck into his tight ass, taking and taking and taking until he has nothing left to give and my monsters are finally sated.

"Fuck," I groan, pressing my lips to his neck. Sitting upright, I admire the way I've coated him in cum.

Finally, something inside me settles. Menace's marks aren't the only ones covering him anymore.

The room glows purple and pulses to the sound of our breaths. No longer afraid of his eyes on me, I flip him over and peer down at him. His blue eyes are scared, but there's something else in them, too. Something that looks a lot like I feel. Sickly sated.

I lick my lips and look down. His cock is softening, but it's wet and shiny. When I look into his eyes again, he shakes his head and a tear leaks down his temple.

"Don't," he snaps at me. "Don't fucking say it."

He got off. He came. And he doesn't like it.

SORROWFUL SONGS & BREAKFAST

REMIEL

KRYPT ISN'T in bed with me, but the sound of my brother's gloomy violin is. It's coming from somewhere in the house, and I hate that it hurts my heart. Soren fucking sucks at expressing emotions, and really, he only feels a few because he's too selfish to feel much else. His range of emotion isn't vast, but the depth with which he feels them is endless.

He's angry and uncomfortable right now. I can tell by the deep tune of his music and the slow pace of his rhythm. I close my eyes and listen to the darkness of his early morning sorrow, my lip trembling as I hold back my emotions.

I'm angry, too. I want to add my dark cello to his violin and fill Vile House with devastation. Because the world is a fucked up place, and no matter what I do in life, I can't get ahead. I can't beat this curse. I can't lure a psycho into killing me to save my brother. I couldn't save my dad, and I couldn't save my other two brothers. I can't even keep Cain safe. I'm a failure at everything I do, and even when I try to help make something just a little brighter, I end up shadowing it with my deficiencies.

Krypt is right, I'm not the hero.

I can't even trust my brother, and now that I know he's been lying to me for years, I hate him all over again while loving him even harder. If I know him, and I think I do, at least who he is at his very core, then I understand he's here because of me. Because of our dead brothers. To save our family. Not for our benefit as much as his own; a narcissist at heart, he'd love to call himself our hero.

When Soren's tune changes to something even darker, I sit up to avoid my feelings. My ass and crotch are both sticky and crusty, coated in dried

cum that does nothing but make me feel ashamed. What the hell is wrong with me?

I orgasmed. While he assaulted me—again. I had no idea it was going to happen. I was scared... and then I was coming, and it scared me even more. I can't think about it without losing my mind, so I swing my legs over the side of Krypt's bed and pad to his closet, buck naked. I grab the first set of sweatpants and hoodie I find and carry them into the bathroom. Peeing, scrubbing myself as hard as I can at the sink because I don't know if I can use the shower, I throw the clothing on as protection and stand there, unsure what to do now.

Am I allowed to leave this room? Will I see other people, or am I confined to this space to keep their secrets intact? I want to find Cain and make sure he survived whoever that lunatic in the blue mask was.

I listen at the bedroom door, hearing only Soren's music. With my hand on the knob, I hesitate. I'm already overloaded with things to process. Do I have what it takes to go out there and learn more secrets?

The door smacks me in the chest and pushes me back, and I don't have time to pretend like I wasn't standing there. Krypt walks in, dressed in sweats and a black t-shirt. No mask. His black eye is turning green and yellow, and the bruise on his cheek isn't as harsh as it was under the purple glow of the neon light last night.

Krypt, I remind myself. Not Keegan. The Vile Boy who killed a girl for no known reason and threw a dagger at a Krampus last night. Krypt, who has sexually assaulted me twice and burned my house down.

Not Keegan, the weird teen who grew into a weirder adult.

He says nothing to me, but he takes in my outfit and seems to appreciate me in his clothing. Pushing past me, he walks straight into the bathroom, leaves the door open, and undresses. I don't know what to do, so I stand here and watch. His back tattoo is even more daunting in the daylight. The splashes of purple, vibrant and bright against the darkness of the black ink, consume my focus. His name shouts at me from the bottom of the tattoo, sitting between the dimples in his lower back, reminding me once again that this is Krypt, not Keegan.

His ass muscles flex when he drops his pants, and the heaviness of his cock and balls hangs between his legs when he bends down to pull his socks off. He looks back at me, and I try to look away, but I get stuck

staring at the chains rattling within his eyes. What happens if those monsters break free?

“Come,” he commands, stepping into the shower.

A shiver shakes me from head to foot, and outside the bedroom door, Soren’s music stops. Ghost. Not Soren. We’re in Vile House now, and I need to manage my expectations.

“Remiel.”

I walk into the steamy bathroom, fisting the material of his shirt in my hands, uncertain about how this level of fear is affecting me. His demand is obvious, but it still takes me monumental effort to undress. He’s seen me naked, tattooed my body, fucked my face, and come on my ass, but shedding the protective outfit in the daylight still makes me vulnerable. The only thing that puts me at ease is that he’ll be more pliant if I comply with his demands.

I undress, my fear worsening.

I step into the tile shower, noticing for the first time that the bathroom is more modern than the bedroom. The glass wall is fogged, but that’s probably a good thing. I don’t want to see myself in the mirror or the reflection of the glass.

I hover, but Krypt grabs my wrist and pulls me under the too-hot spray, tilting my head back to wet my hair. Wordlessly, he soaps my body and washes the marker from my skin, and when I’m red and the last of it has been cleared away, his eyes calm down and his jaw unclenches. He peels the wrapping off my new tattoo, gently rinsing the damaged skin with a washcloth and soap.

Then he looks at me. His dark hair barely grazes his shoulders, but it plasters to his forehead, framing his face nicely. The tone of his tanned skin and the dark brown of his hair make his eyes pop, and maybe that’s why they always look so intense. Maybe it’s not all monsters.

No... it’s mostly monsters... monsters I have no intention of meeting but am intrigued by anyway.

“I’m sorry,” he says quietly.

My eyes widen, but the shower water warms me comfortably. “For what?” Raping me? Tattooing me? Burning my house down? Killing the girl?

“That you had to find out about your brother like that.”

I snort and immediately regret it when his fingers tighten around my biceps. His nostrils flare. “Are you making fun of me?”

I clear my throat and try to bring back his calm mood. “No. It’s just that, out of everything, I find it odd that you’re apologizing for that. Specifically.”

“What else should I apologize for, Remiel? Everything else should have been expected when you made a deal with a devil. But your brother? That shocked you and wasn’t part of the bargain.”

Well, when he puts it that way, I guess he’s right. I severely underestimated what I thought giving my life to a Vile Boy meant. I figured he’d try to control me a bit, hover, keep a watch over me, and get me to do a few things against my will. I had not expected him to completely overtake my life to the point where I can’t even touch anyone, and no longer have a house, ID, vehicle, or any free will.

“How long have you two been... uh, here?” Never had a conversation in a shower, naked, with a mysterious but familiar man before.

He puts body wash on a sponge and my eyes follow it across his chest and down his abs. I swallow when he gets to his cock, looking up at his eyes instead. “We initiated when we were seventeen.”

“Seventeen?” I gasp. “So, you’ve been the purple mask for, what, eleven years?”

“Three years. Before that, I had to work my way up. Same with Ghost.”

“Ghost,” I repeat my brother’s new name. “Right. Why Ghost?”

“That’s his story to tell.” He spins to rinse off, but there are no bubbles on his back, so I take the sponge from him on autopilot. He tenses when I run it over his muscles, but relaxes into it a heartbeat later. Why am I doing this? Plying my captor to make him less abusive to me?

I’m such a fuck-up.

“Why do you hate the letter C?” I ask instead, ignoring my dick hardening.

“I don’t know. It just sets me off. I went through a lot of psych evaluations where I had to look at blobs and describe what I saw. A lot of them looked like the letter C.”

“Oh.” Strange.

“One of them looked like a C, but also like a pregnant belly. Nothing weirds me out more than pregnancy,” he says, hands braced on the wall while I wash his back. “Things itch at me sometimes.”

I'm smiling, and I don't know why. "Pregnancy kinda freaks me out, too."

He spins, and the water stream pushes his hair over his eyes. When he wipes it away, his biceps flex, showing me another tattoo. Keegan with a giant X through it, crossing it out. He notices me looking.

"Keegan died a long time ago," he says. "I feel more like myself as Krypt."

Maybe Remiel will die and I'll feel more like myself as the hero he calls me. I nod, rinsing the sponge clean. He puts shampoo on my palm and pushes me under the water again, so I wash my hair while he watches, forcing myself to get comfortable while I'm this raw and vulnerable.

"He's pissed at me. Told me to refuse your bargain. Doesn't want me anywhere near you."

"Well, considering what you've already done, I don't blame him."

Krypt's face is blank, but his jaw muscles twitch. "You think he's innocent? You think he hasn't done worse?"

I'm sure he has, but he hasn't done it *to me*. Krypt has. I'm selfish enough to care about what happens to me and not what happens to anyone else. Except Cain. And my sister.

"Rinse," he says.

I tip my head back, exposing my throat to Krypt while the water washes the shampoo away. Eucalyptus and aloe. The scent reminds me of my house that no longer stands. No point in mourning it now.

"Please don't burn my music shop down. It's... I can't live without it. It's the only limit I have."

His thumb and finger pinch my chin, making me lower my head. Water drips into my eyes, blurring my vision. His face is right in front of mine, eyes intense and lips together. "It's the only limit I'll respect."

I lick my lips and nod to accept that, despite how baffling it is. "Am I a prisoner here?" I ask. "Am I confined to this room?"

"Our deal is etched in your skin and sealed in blood. You're allowed to know the others now. They've all agreed to it. Except the one who leads us."

There's a leader? "You mean there are eleven of you?"

"There are ten who wear the masks. One who leads us, a small group of leadership, and about seventeen other members who live in this house when

they aren't in their own homes. You have to work your way to the top around here, and most never get there. But they're still Vile. Still family."

Oh, no wonder they hold initiation every year, then. I'm already learning so many Vile House secrets I refused to look into before my bargain.

"And what am I?" I ask.

He leans in until his lips brush against the corner of my mouth, water dripping between our faces. "Mine."

My stomach clenches.

I want to ask why Krypt took my bargain. Why did he willingly risk his one true friendship by betraying Soren to tether himself to me? None of it makes sense, and I'm too raw to hear the answer, so I don't ask.

After drying off and getting dressed in his clothes again, he leads me out of his bedroom.

Vile House is... exactly how I imagined it would be. Resembling an old live-in psychiatric ward or one of those houses that hosted conversion therapy back in the fifties, it's eerie and spacious. More ward than home; more gothic than modern. He takes me to the medical room, where he puts something on my tattoo and covers it in plastic again, and then we walk into a cafeteria-style kitchen.

It smells like breakfast, but is empty, apart from my brother. Soren—Ghost—sits on the top of a cafeteria table, a mug of coffee between his palms, watching the door we just came through. He's been waiting for us.

"Leave," he says to Krypt.

"No," Krypt says right back. He pushes me to sit on the bench seat, then goes to a table at the front to fill plates and get us coffee.

"Remi," Soren says. Ghost. "You won't survive this."

"I don't plan to."

He shakes his head at me and moves down to the bench beside me. "Please, Remi. Whatever the fuck you asked him to do, back out of it. I'm handling the curse."

"So am I," I tell him, not bothering to call him out on his selfish reasons for wanting to handle our family issue. "And I can't back out of it. It's sealed."

Soren's eyes sweep over every bit of my exposed skin, and when he finds nothing, he tugs on my sleeves.

“Don’t touch me,” I hiss at him, glancing at Krypt. “It’s right here.” I pull down the collar of Krypt’s shirt to show him the tattoo.

My brother looks disappointed in me. He shakes his head and sighs. “Let me guess, you want him to kill you? You thought you’d strike a deal with Vile House and find a way to end your life so it isn’t suicide?”

I widen my eyes and nod.

“He won’t do it,” Soren says. “But you’re going to wish he would.”

Krypt brings me a plate and a mug of coffee, sitting on my other side and glaring at my brother over my head. I take the coffee and drink it so fast my throat burns, but fuck this. They’re supposed to be best friends, and I’m already in enough of my own shit; I don’t need to be in the middle of theirs, too.

I’m still trying to find the mind space to process my two sexual assaults, the loss of my house, the dead girl, the ownership staked on me, and the fact that I got off while he pinned me down against my will.

“Any tea?” I ask.

“Tea!” my brother yells, and a minute later, someone brings me a pot of hot water and a few different tea bags. He’s younger than me, and I recognize him from the shop. I don’t remember his name, but he plays the oboe. Really well, if I remember correctly. He must be one of the lower-ranking ones Krypt mentioned.

“Thank you.”

He nods and disappears again.

“So, what now, Krypt? Gonna rape my brother a bit more? Rough him up until he’s battered and broken?”

“At least he won’t be dead,” Krypt deadpans, eating his pancakes.

There’s no point in defending my decision, so I pick up my fork to eat, unsure when I’ll be able to again, and let them talk around me. I don’t like the shame that engulfs me, knowing that my brother is aware of how weak and pathetic I am. His best friend sexually assaulted me, and here I sit, in his clothing and under his watchful eye.

“It’s none of your fucking business, Ghost. I have a bargain with him, not you. So fuck off about it and worry about your own shit.” Krypt means something else by ‘your own shit,’ and it makes my brother lean back, almost in reluctant submission.

“I’m working on it,” Soren—Ghost—says. Jesus, I really need to get used to the name change. “I need more time.”

Krypt nods. "Ask Facts."

"I will," Ghost says, and then he touches my arm. "Remi."

"Hands off." Krypt growls.

My brother's jaw clenches so hard it clicks, staring down his best friend while trying to get to the root of their issues. Me, I'm their issue, but I never intended to be. How was I supposed to know Soren's best friend was the one in the purple mask? Hell, at the time of the bargain, I had no idea my brother was standing in that room listening to me stutter.

Reluctantly, he removes his hand from my arm and glares at Krypt again. "Remi, shit is going down in Moros, okay? I can't explain what, but... just fucking be careful, okay? Don't go anywhere without one of us knowing. And try to stay away from Mom's."

"Why?"

"Because the Matter Cult isn't the only—" Soren cuts himself off, exchanging a silent conversation with Krypt over my head. "She's fine, but stay away for a bit, okay?"

Yeah, not fucking likely. I nod anyway. "Where's Cain?"

Ghost looks at Krypt. "Oh, shit. Menace get his hands on him finally?"

Krypt nods. "He's fine. I've told you that three times already."

"Well, I want to see him," I state, picking up my tea.

Krypt slams my tea back down. "What you want is no longer yours to desire. I decide what you fucking want from now on, Remiel."

Soren groans, standing. "This is so fucking weird. I hate it." He only hates it because it doesn't serve his own needs, but I figured he'd at least be pleased that the burden of me is off his shoulders. He stops behind Krypt, bent down with his mouth by his ear. "Rape my brother again, and I'll rape yours. Tit for tat, bud."

Krypt barely reacts. He scoffs and keeps eating. What fucking world do we live in where threatening to rape someone's brother happens over breakfast? In an old insane asylum... that I apparently live in now. Because my house is gone. Because a maniac burned it down.

I pull my tea towards me for warmth. I feel myself chilling in a way that isn't welcome.

MIDNIGHT DINER

KRYPT

I BLINDFOLDED Remiel and led him through the tunnels to leave the house. I didn't want him to know about the tunnels that connect to the asylum yet, mostly because I don't want him to know how to escape. I dropped him off at his music shop, where Cain was already waiting, and he hopped out of my truck without a look back. So I grabbed his wrist and stared at him until he remembered who he belonged to.

Moros is buzzing with something this morning. After Initiation Night, the town is more relaxed but more sinister, too. I like the vibe of it. There's no part of me that wants to leave Moros. Where else in the world could I be this version of myself and have it respected instead of imprisoned? Moros doesn't play by the same rules as anywhere else, and that's why I like it here. That's why it's home.

Sitting in Midnight Diner for lunch with my brother, I watch Reeven Matterson from across the restaurant. The first name on Remiel's hit list. He's a middle-aged man with a small cult following, leading a group of submissive, brainwashed idiots just to flex his control-freak muscles. He brings nothing to Moros other than despair, and the fact that he's going after people who have managed to free themselves from his cult pisses me off. Getting out of a cult is hard, and I don't want Remiel's mom's side of the family living in fear of this prick. Not because I like her, but because I dislike Matterson.

"He's a bit psycho," Riot, my brother, says, watching Matterson. "But he's not strong. He's good at brainwashing and control, but doesn't do his own dirty work."

“Yeah,” I agree. “He gets his followers to do it, which makes him an easy target because he’s gotten lazy.” I’m not worried about Reeven Matterson. He should be easy enough to make disappear, especially if I get the boys to help. Kyd’s wanted to tear this guy to bits for years. “It’s his followers I’m worried about.”

Riot nods. “They’ll need a new leader. They don’t know how to survive on their own anymore, so someone will have to take over. Any ideas?”

Kill them all comes to mind. “They believe in bloodlines, don’t they? The Matter Cult is all about continuing powerful bloodlines, right?”

Riot huffs. “Yeah, and he thinks his bloodline is the strongest, so he’s probably knocked up half the women in his cult. We could kill him. Throw his followers in with the Death For Life Cult. They can learn to worship their fearless leader’s ghost like they do.”

Fucking idiots. Cain has a girlfriend named Sadie, and her whole family, close and extended, sacrifice one another to their dead ancestors. I don’t presume to judge what people believe in, but some of it is so far-fetched that it makes my head spin. I won’t willingly sacrifice myself for anything, ever. I’m my own belief, and I don’t believe that the living or the dead will protect me. I’m hypocritical because I want Remiel to believe I’ll protect him, though.

“I’ll approach Abigail as a Vile mask and see what she says.” Abigail is Sadie’s grandmother, and she currently leads the Death for Life Cult.

“You fuck him yet?” Riot asks.

Here, in the Midnight Diner, we’re Killian and Keegan, two brothers out for lunch. We aren’t hiding, but we aren’t approachable either. We’re feared because of the mystery and mayhem surrounding the death of our parents. I repel people naturally, but Riot has perfected the art of drawing in whoever he wants near him.

“No.” I look at my brother, and he sees the shame in my eyes, so I keep talking. “Wouldn’t know how.”

“You’re not a virgin,” he says.

Close enough. I’ve had actual penetrative sex twice, and neither time was enjoyable. I’m afraid to fuck Remiel because it will twist his vision of me. Right now, he’s falling in line because he’s scared of me. But if he sees how insecure and inexperienced I actually am when it comes to sex, he’ll use it against me somehow.

Riot grins, setting down the crust of his club sandwich. “A lot of lube, stretch him open, and stick your dick in. Not much more to it than that.”

“Fuck you, Kill. What guy have you ever fucked?”

He laughs at me and signals for the server to close out our tab. “An asshole is the same no matter the gender,” he says. “Still want my help with G... Soren?”

The server brings the bill and my brother pays. “Can I get you guys anything else?” She avoids looking at me but eye-fucks my brother. No one ever holds eye contact with me for long.

“No, love. Thanks, though.” He smiles at her and she melts. My god. When I smile at people, they cringe. But Killian is on the sociopathic scale, according to his psych records, and even though he pretends not to be selfish, he is. Charming people and manipulating them to do whatever he wants them to do is his greatest gift. One I don’t have.

I take one more look at Reeven Matterson before following Riot out the door. We walk down Death Row, and I pause when we pass The Ambient Raven. Remiel is at the front counter talking to a customer, so I narrow my eyes to make sure no touching is involved. Riot lights a joint and passes it to me, reminding me to calm down in public.

“Well?” he asks. “Soren?”

“Maybe. Remiel wants him incapacitated so he can’t kill himself. Wants someone on him all the time. I don’t really trust you to be around him that much without killing him.”

Riot laughs again. It’s no secret they hate each other. I don’t know where the hate stems from, but they fight the most out of anyone in Vile House. Director puts up with it to a degree, but he often punishes them for the trouble they bring. None of us know what the punishment entails.

“If I kill him, it’ll end the Sauder curse and Remi can go free.”

I bristle at his words and stare at Remiel through the window. “Remiel will never be free.” Yes, free from the curse somehow, but never free from me. I worded the deal to make it sound like I might free him, but now that I have him, I know I never will. But I’m not at the point of sacrificing Soren for the sake of Remiel.

“Let’s go before Director rips us apart for being late.” I inhale half the joint in one breath, tearing my eyes from Remiel at work.



THERE'S a theatre room in Vile House, with a platform used as a stage and row seating bolted to the floor. Back in the day, it was used to teach the staff about new protocols and illnesses, to host staff meetings, and to do monthly briefings. Now we use it as a meeting room, and Director is at the front while the rest of us sprinkle throughout the seats—the ten of us closer to the front, and some of the lower ranks filling out the back. The initiates aren't welcome here yet, but if they pass their tests and do well in their training, they'll be allowed to sit in.

"You reveal yourself to Cain?" I ask Menace, cringing at the C name.

"Nope. Kept the mask on but gave him exactly what he wanted. Pain and pleasure," he whispers, rubbing his dick in fond remembrance. At least he kept him alive. "Fuck," he groans, rubbing himself harder.

I look away and shake my head, baffled by how easy sex is for everyone but me. Yet another thing that's wrong with me without me knowing why.

"Benton Wentworth," Director starts, standing at the podium. "He survived the night, but barely survived Kyd and Facts. They interrogated him all day, and we finally got some answers."

Facts is like an AI come to life. He knows everything, and because of how full his mind is, he's batshit crazy. The guy can barely form a coherent sentence without blurting out a bunch of information, and his IQ is so high he's never challenged enough, which makes him bored. Bored is deadly around here, but Facts also has a whole slew of warped realities because of his upbringing. Kyd, on the other hand, is a whole pot of crazy that comes with the biggest smiles and the most energy. A lot of unbearable colours, too.

"Hello," Facts says from his seat, barely containing everything he wants to blurt out. "Benton Wentworth is just the tip of the iceberg. Turns out he works with a whole group of megalomaniacs who want to take our town and turn it into something... else. One of them is Dr. Axel Graves."

My eyes widen at that, and curses fill the room.

"Yeah, that Axel Graves," Kyd says, standing up front with Director because he can't refuse the spotlight. "Born and bred in Moros, presumed dead for the past four years, and now back to haunt us with his evil little

brainwashing games.” He claps his hands in sinister glee. “Oh, god! He’s going to become my bestie with a mind like that!”

“Sit down, Kyd,” Director says. “Axel Graves is the one responsible for the weird behaviour in some of our residents. Including your mother, Ghost.”

We all look at him, but he keeps his face blank, waiting for the rest of the explanation.

“The group we’ve been studying are all chipped. We don’t know how Axel got his chips implanted, but according to Wentworth, Axel has been working out of a lab not far from here. He created the chips and is now using Moros citizens to test them on.”

“Mind control?” Seven asks.

Director nods while Kyd skips around the theatre to burn energy. “Mind control. Small things at first, but since you led us to your mom’s strange behaviour, we’ve been watching her,” Director says to Ghost.

Facts takes over again. “Hello. She’s somehow receiving subliminal messages. Maybe they’re coming straight through the chip, but they could be coming from an app on her phone or a demand sent to her through her phone. Maybe nothing like that, but I’ll find out. It’s what is making her do things her sane self wouldn’t do. Hurting Remi, burning her hand, stealing that baby from the hospital, things like that.”

I tense at the reminder of Remiel being hurt by his mother. A few months ago, she slashed his wrist with a kitchen knife when she was at his house for dinner. It’s the scar I ran my thumb over the other night, and I know Remiel is ashamed of it. He hasn’t made any suicide attempts, but he still bears the scars. Ghost glances at me, and I meet his eyes. We might not agree on my bargain with his brother, but together, we’ll do everything to keep him alive. He already warned him away from his mom, and I’ll be tracking him everywhere he fucking goes when he isn’t with me.

“And she’s not the only one.” Director projects his screen to the white wall behind him. Twelve other Moros residents fill the screen, each of them acting a little off compared to their normal. “We haven’t had the chance to scan them all yet, but at least four of them have been found with the same chip as Ghost’s mom. And we still don’t know how to remove the chips without killing the patient.”

Three other photos hit the white wall. All three of them have died within minutes of their tiny microchip being removed. Ghost got to choose

whether or not we tried to remove the chip from his mom, and for now, he decided not to. I don't know if he's afraid of losing her or if he's afraid of how it will affect his siblings, but it's his call.

"So, let's kill the conductor," Ransom says. "Kill Axel Graves and we kill the control he has on them."

Director nods, but shakes his head, too. "We can't find him."

"I'll fucking find him," Kyd declares, standing on a chair. "Look how fucking hard I am for this guy!" He pumps his crotch, humping the air. "God, I have a full-on raging boner for this mad scientist. He's mine. Dibs! Double dibs! All the dibs."

"Seven, I want you to lead a team. Put something together and get back to me, but I want his hideout found first and foremost. Kyd can second you."

"Yes!" Kyd fist-pumps the air. "Facts, you're with us!"

"Glitch," Seven claims him for his team. "Need your hacking." Glitch nods to accept that.

"Ghost, you continue to monitor your mom and infiltrate The Misfits. Something is up with them. Ransom, you and Monster are on the rest of the chipped, and Krypt and Riot, I want you two tracking every tourist who comes to town. I don't care if they're a reporter or a fucking sorority girl, I want to make sure they aren't being sent in by Axel. Menace," Director looks at him, a subtle grin on his face. "You know what to do."

Menace rubs his dick again. "Yes, sir."

"You need help?" Director asks him.

Menace has always preferred to work alone, but he looks at Glitch. "I'll need you once I get the chips out."

"I can do both," Glitch agrees. "Facts can help, too." Facts jitters out a nod.

Menace loves nothing more than causing pain and messing around with bodies, so he'll be the one extracting all the chips from the residents Ransom and Monster bring to him. Menace has an uncanny ability to open people wide and keep them coherent and alive for as long as possible. I once watched him root around in someone's brain while carrying on a conversation about fashion, of all things. He's the farthest thing from a brain surgeon, but he somehow pulls off such dexterous tasks.

When Director dismisses us, he pulls me aside. "Remi acting weird?" he asks.

“No. Why?”

His eyes meet mine. “She cut him. He went to a doctor for stitches. A doctor whose name someone has redacted from the file. I want to make sure there’s nothing inside him. It was his arm that was injured, but we don’t know if anything else was done to him while he was under that doctor’s care. Keep an eye on his behaviour, yeah?” He whispers so Ghost doesn’t hear, but my mind is already clouding. I’ll cut Remiel’s whole arm off before I let him become anyone else’s puppet. If it’s in his head, I’ll brainwash him harder than Axel Graves ever can.

“Want me to bring him for a scan?”

“Yeah, but keep him with you first. Keep it from Ghost for now. He’s already going mad trying to protect his brother, and we don’t need him falling prey to their curse.” Director sighs, wanting to touch me but knowing better than to try. “Our cover has to stay in place, Krypt. Moros is relying on us.”

And so is Remiel. It’s time we start knocking names off his list.

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INFECT ME

REMIEL

CAIN WON'T TELL me what happened to him on Initiation Night, but by the marks all over his body and the blush that rises to his cheeks, he had an alright time. He doesn't know who the person behind the blue mask is, and according to him, that made the night even better. He doesn't want to know. He's not even mad at me for putting him in that situation. He thinks me losing my house is punishment enough.

I lock the door of The Ambient Raven behind him, done for the day. But my cello stares at me from where it's displayed. It's been so long since I played it, and Soren's sorrowful song is still tainting my mind from this morning.

I sit down, bringing it between my legs, holding the bow, letting my body remember what it feels like to play. Pain and suffering, that's how it feels to hold my beloved instrument again. Agony because nothing will ever be the same since my dad and brothers passed away. Regret because being good at music did nothing beneficial for my life, for them, for my mother, who is fading away from the woman she was.

It hurts to hold the bow, but it hurts even more to drag it across the strings. The shop fills with a wretched sound. Something ripped straight from my heart to darken my space. My eyes close and the tips of my fingers hit the strings, sliding into position on the fingerboard. When I play the first deep note, a tear falls down my cheek, and when I play the second, I let it all out.

The loss of my family members. The lies from Soren. The assaults and the meaning of belonging to Krypt. The ashes of my house and the husk of

my car. The girl in the golden dress whose lungs rattled and calves twitched while I failed her. The Krampus who died on Initiation Night.

But mostly, I play for myself. For the days behind me and the clock ticking down the rest of my time on Earth. I play for the life I've lived and the one I still have yet to endure. I cry, mourning my prime and accepting the fate bestowed upon me. All of it and more leaks from my eyes and dances from my fingertips, letting loose into the strings of my cello to haunt the only place I have left that feels like home.

My eyes remain closed, and my fingers hurt from lack of playing, but when I transition into a new song, something dark and anguished, I cry harder when the piano joins me. I give myself a whole minute to pretend it's my dad, and then I look to my left, finding Krypt behind his purple mask, fingers moving slowly over the keys to add harmony to my sadness. Like my dad used to do. I play with him for long moments, releasing the rest of my sadness. And then I turn it into something louder. Faster. Deeper.

Because I'm fucking angry, and I need to let go of that, too.

My eyes find him, glaring at him while I play. Watching him match my tempo and create music that fits with mine, following my mood because he seems to read me like no one else can. Krypt doesn't fear my anger. He wants to build onto it, add fuel to my already burning fire. I'm a lit match, and Krypt will throw me onto any accelerant, encouraging me to burn the world around me like he burned my home.

It feels so good to play that it pisses me off. I throw my bow to the floor and tip my cello over, eyes on his mask. I don't know what I'm about to do, but I'm so fucking mad! I'm mad about everything and everyone, and it's all rushing at me here and now. I'm at the fulcrum point of my life, the one that either tips me over into insanity or keeps me here as a prisoner of my morbid future. I don't know which way I want to swing, but for now, I'll swing at him.

I pull my fist back to hit him, but he blocks my punch and shoves me back. Going at him again, I shove him so hard the piano bench tips over, and Krypt pulls me down with him, rolling me onto my back and straddling me like he did the other night. But this time, I can see him. He's not forcing my face into the mattress. He's pinning me down and daring me to keep going. To get up. To fight him off and succumb to the demons eating away at my soul.

“Take it off,” I snarl at him, fully aware that I’m enticing a madman. I’m too broken to care about the consequences. “Look at me. Let me see you. If you’re going to watch me break, I want to see your face while you witness my downfall.”

He pins my wrists to the floor above my head, wrapping his fingers around them to keep them secure. With his other hand, he pulls his hood down and takes off his mask, and when his eyes meet mine, I smile wickedly. For the first time, I think my internal monsters rival his, and I’m no longer afraid. I want him to let them out. I want to witness the destruction they cause, and I want to be the one who suffers from their madness.

Krypt sees everything about me. He sees my sanity slipping and my edges fraying. He leans over me, a chilling smile painting his face into something terrifyingly handsome. “You break so beautifully, hero,” he says, voice not as jittery as usual. “Does it hurt to shatter?”

I twist my wrists in his grip and buck my hips upward. “I’m not sane enough to hurt.” Because playing the cello again has unlocked my first suicidal thoughts. Because the shift in my life has rendered me dangerous. Because I feel so out of control that I don’t even care about what life and death mean anymore.

“Hmm,” he muses, looking me up and down, pressing his dick against mine and putting all his weight on my hips. “No pain?”

“None,” I lie, spit slicking my lips. “Gonna make it hurt, Krypt? Going to make me cry for you? Is that what you want? You wanna take everything from me and then give it all back so hard it fucking kills me?”

His tongue runs over his front teeth and his pale eyes dip to the pulse point in my neck. He tugs my shirt collar down, checking on the tattoo he gave me, grounding himself with the ink scabbing my skin. “I’ll take it all away until you have nothing, Remiel. And when you’re sad and broken and ready to give up, I’ll fucking force you to live and you’ll hate me for it.”

“Why?” I shout at him, hips bucking. “Fucking why?!”

“Because I fucking want to,” he snaps back. “Because you’re useless like this. You’re pathetic. Wasting away to nothing, trying to be a goddamn martyr, but failing miserably. You can’t save him, Remiel. You can’t save Soren, just like you couldn’t save your other brothers. Just like you couldn’t save your dad.”

I break my hands free and shove his chest, but he pins me down with his body. “Fuck. You!” I snap my head up, cracking my forehead against the bridge of his nose. Blood trickles down over his lips and drips onto my chin, but I’m too far gone to give a shit. My head spins and my vision sparkles. When Krypt wraps both hands around my throat and slams my head against the floor, I latch onto his wrists in encouragement. “Do it. Fucking choke the life out of me, Krypt. Kill me. Imagine how much easier your life will be once I’m gone. Fucking do it!”

He growls at me, blood leaking.

“Fucking do it!” I scream.

His lips crash to mine, and his hands tighten around my neck. Rust and copper fill my mouth, and I’m overwhelmed by a rush so strong my entire body surges with something deadly. I let go of his wrists and tangle my fingers in his shaggy, dark hair. Tugging at the wavy strands, but not to push him away. To bring him closer. Because when I die, I want to leave this world with the feel of him all over me. In my mouth and on my tastebuds, over every inch of my skin, and in my goddamn soul. I want him to infect me before he snuffs me out forever, and if these are my final six minutes, I’m going to have him for every one of them.

Because I’m fucking sick. Wicked.

My ragged breaths mix with his, creating a vortex neither of us can escape. Blood turns my face sticky, but I like it so much that I pull his hair and bring him even closer. He bites on my lip, drawing my blood to mingle with his. The combination is heady and dark and turns me feral.

I yank on his hair so hard his fingers loosen around my neck. I push against them, latching my lips onto the underside of his jaw and marking him as my own. If he gets to brand me, I want to brand him right back. Because I’m not leaving this world alone, and when I go, I’ll take every fucked-up part of him I can rip free from his body.

Krypt groans. The sound is strained and crazed, and all it does is make me suicidal. Because if I’m finally going to succumb to the family curse, I’m going to enjoy myself while I do it. Letting go of his hair, I force my hands between our torsos, ripping his pants open. His zipper breaks and the button pisses me off, but when they’re open enough, I force my hand down and grab his cock in a tight fist.

When he tilts his head to look at me, I see every one of his barely caged monsters watching me, rattling the bars of their enclosure, trying to escape

the confines of his eyes. Yes, I'm crazy enough to want the man who sexually assaulted me. Yes, I'm a fucking hypocrite because I told him I wasn't gay. I don't know what I am. Insane, probably. Because Krypt is the only one who sees everything within me and doesn't balk at the challenge of me. He doesn't fear me or my curse. He's stupid enough to think he can change it, and simply because he wants to try, even if it's out of some dysfunctional need to own me, I want to let him.

I'm done being cautious of everything. I'm done being afraid of myself.

"Oh, you're fucking broken," he tells me, that jittery edge back in his voice. "Mind finally snapped, did it, hero?"

"I'm no hero," I rasp at him, pulling him free from his pants. I roughly drag my palm up his shaft and squeeze the head hard enough to make him hold his breath. "So don't fucking treat me like one."

Krypt pulls away from me, but he grabs the front of my shirt and hauls me to my feet. I'm an inch shorter than him, so when he glares at me with blood under his nostrils and down over his lips and chin, I look up at him with eyes unafraid.

"Pick it up," he demands, nodding at the piano bench.

I bend to put it back to its rightful position, and then Krypt sits on it, hand still fisted in my shirt.

"Take your pants off. Now, Remiel."

I don't know why I want this so badly, but I do. I want the escape—the wrongness. I undo my pants and keep my eyes on his. "Going to fuck me?" I taunt.

His nostrils flare. "Show me what's mine," he says in the same tone he said it the night of initiation—dark, deranged, authoritative.

This time, I'm not covering my crotch. I grab my hard cock in my fist and stroke it slowly for him to watch. I kick my pants off with my shoes and don't feel ashamed of the bead of precum that drips from my tip. I'm crazy enough to be beyond aroused right now. Sick with it.

"Come here."

I step between his legs, my cock level with his upper chest. He looks up at me as he leans forward, tongue swiping the tip to get a hit of me. My breath shudders out of me and my abs all coil in need. Krypt swallows, the roll of his throat even sexier now that I've left a mark on his skin there.

Wordlessly, he grabs the back of my legs and lifts me onto his lap. My knees rest on the bench beside his thighs, and my ass sits on the material of

his black pants. Something sinister comes alive within me, straddling the devil like I have any right to be here. His cock juts against mine, warm and heavy and wet. I've never had anything in my ass before, and I've never craved it, but right now, I want him to hurt me. I want him to fuck me dry and make me bleed. I want to die on his dick and start my trip to damnation while he soars into euphoria.

I want to be afraid.

"Fuck me," I beg.

His eyes widen and his monsters thrash. He wraps his fingers around the side of my neck and uses his thumb to tilt my chin, keeping my face right in front of his. I'm grinding on his lap, trying to entice him into splitting me open, but he's not taking the bait. He looks dangerous... but unsure.

"Wrap your hand around us," he demands, calm but on edge, never looking away from my eyes.

I bring us both into my hand, rolling our cocks together and spreading slick precum all around us. I've never felt so empowered, and it's a strange sensation because I've never been so weak. I pump my fist, rubbing us together with spit until his breathing picks up and his eyes intensify even more.

Keegan has always been hard to hold eye contact with, but right now, as Krypt, I can't look away. I'm a prisoner to his gaze and a slave to his demands, and I've never wanted to be anywhere more than I want to be right here. Because I don't have to think when he does the thinking for me.

"When I fuck you," he starts, voice abrasive and raspy, "there will be no timeframe. No limits. No fucking windows where the world can see what's mine. Your body is meant for me and *only me*, Remiel."

"Fuck," I moan, not even sure why I suddenly love his unwarranted possession.

"And next time, when you beg me to fuck you, you better do it without the suicidal thoughts. Because I will fuck you within an inch of your life, but I'll always drag you back. You can't escape me. Not even death's cold clutches will rip you from my hold." He tightens his grip around my throat and my hips rock with the motion of my hand, rutting against his cock as ferociously as I can, crazed because of his words and insane because of his body. "You made a deal with a devil, hero, and now you live in my hell."

"Oh, fuck," I groan. My eyes don't flutter and my gaze never wavers. I watch him and his monsters as pressure fills my head and pleasure fills my

body. My cock hardens, throbbing cum to coat his dick in sick relief bred by fear, shame, and new desires. The orgasm is intense and slow, a buildup of pressure and the downfall of my restraint. I come all over him, staining his shirt, slicking his abs, and wetting his hard cock. “Krypt,” I moan.

When he violated my throat over that dead girl’s body, his heart didn’t even speed up when he came. This time, at the sound of his name in my pleasure-soaked voice, his breath hitches and his heart pounds hard beneath my hand. Those monsters in his eyes all surge at once, and I’m so terrified they’re going to break loose that another spurt of cum shoots from my dick to join his. His cock throbs in my fist, the head butted right up against mine. I want to look down, to watch him come, but he tips my head back and licks me from throat to lips before kissing me so hard I see stars and almost fall off his lap.

When the worst of it has faded and all that’s left are aftershocks of tainted bliss and swelling shame, he rips his lips from mine and grazes his teeth over my jaw. “You’ve done it now, Remiel.”

“Done what?” I’m breathless and boneless.

“Woken me up.”

I should be more scared of that than I am.

YOU TRUST TOO EASILY

REMIEL

WE'RE TRAPPED between two of my demons. Ahead of us, Reeven Matterson stands on a stone platform on the edge of the Moros cemetery, conducting a midnight mass for his brainwashed followers. We're supposed to be here for him, but behind us, slinking in the shadows of tombstones and crypts, Gregory Malone stalks me like he always does. This night was supposed to be about Matterson's planned disappearance, but we drew Malone's attention by accident. Or I did, because Krypt is concealed and Malone doesn't know he's with me.

For years, he's been stalking me. Trying to tip me over the edge and speed my path to suicide. He taunted my younger brother so hard and for so long that he hung himself just to get away from the creep. He's a sick bastard who thrives on controlling others, and for some reason, he's taken our family curse as a challenge. Soren thinks it has something to do with our mom and a shared history between her and Malone, but I don't know. He wants me so twisted up that the prospect of living becomes unbearable, and the other night, when he stalked me through the streets with my brother at his back, I almost submitted to it.

I ran to Vile House instead, knowing it was my last chance to protect myself from suicide and take matters into my own hands. To die by a hand that is not my own.

"Why was Soren with him?" I ask the darkness Krypt is crouching in. "The other night, he was with Gregory Malone when I came to Vile House, but all ten of you were there when I said my name. I don't get it."

"He's not called Ghost for nothing," Krypt says through his mask. "He has the ability to move from one place to the next without anyone noticing."

“Why was he with Malone, though?”

“Malone haunts you, and Ghost haunts him. Your brother wasn’t stalking you. He was protecting you.”

Did he herd me to Vile House?

I didn’t know my brother cared enough to notice Gregory Malone stalking me as often as he does. I honestly thought he was trying to kill me just to end this curse—Soren’s nature rarely puts anyone above himself unless he gets something out of it. Krypt told me everything I knew was about to change, and it has. I know nothing concrete and don’t know how to start dissecting it all.

Malone is watching me. He doesn’t know Krypt is protecting me, and he doesn’t know I’m aware of him being there. He’s tried many things over the years to get me to crack, and sometimes, just watching me like this is almost enough. I hate the way his eyes feel on me. They send prickles up my spine and make my stomach queasy. It’s a form of torture he’s conditioned me to react to. Years ago, when he first started following me, I started working out. I went from having a lean body with no endurance to a hardened body with muscles that won’t fail me. All because of him.

“What do I do?” I whisper.

Krypt’s eyes are on Matterson, but at my question, he shifts his gaze to me. “Matterson can wait for another night. Right now, you’re going to walk up to Gregory Malone and give him this.”

Discreetly, I take whatever he’s holding out to me. It’s a calling card, but it’s too dark for me to read what is written on the back. “I... I don’t want to confront him. He makes me... I can’t.”

“You can and you will. And when you give him that card, he’ll know you belong to Vile House. He already knows one of us is stalking him, and now he’ll sweat knowing you’re protected by another. He needs to know we took your bargain.”

“What colour is Ghost’s mask?”

“Give him the card, Remiel.”

“What if he tries something?”

“He won’t,” Krypt says. “He’s fascinated with your suicide, not your death. Walk the fuck over there and challenge him. I’m right here.”

I’m right here.

I’ve never had anyone at my back before, and it’s enough to make me lift my chin and straighten my spine. I grip the card and turn my back to

Krypt, facing Malone. Krypt calls me a hero, even though it's mocking, and it's time I start acting like the hero of my own life.

Stepping away from Krypt is harder than I thought it would be. The farther I get, the more my nerves intensify. Malone sees me coming, but instead of getting nervous, he gets a wicked glint in his eyes, and I just know he's going to fuck with me. Any opportunity to push me over the edge is fair game in his book, but he saw me go to Vile House, so he should be the one sweating now.

He's about fifteen years older than I am, and he must live a pathetic life if taunting Sauder men is where he gets his kicks. He's married to a woman who plays a harp, but I've never seen her step foot in my store. Probably because she knows her husband haunts me.

"Out a bit late tonight, aren't you, Remi?" he asks when I'm near him. "Never know what you'll find lurking in the night."

"I do know, actually." I close the distance between us, standing a foot in front of him and feeling more confident than I ever have in his presence. "It's you. It's always fucking you lurking in my night."

He laughs, and I hate the sound. "Wasn't sure where you'd be now that your house is burned to the ground. Someone else trying to push you over the edge?"

Yeah, but not in the same way he is. "What happened the other night? Didn't want to follow me into Vile House?"

His smile falters infinitesimally, and then it returns. "I respect your ability to get creative," he says. "Just makes the challenge more fun."

"My life being the challenge?"

"Your death," he corrects. "Any suicidal thoughts lately, Mr. Sauder?"

Plenty, but only if Krypt is the one doing the life ending. I smile at him, sweetness soaking my features. "Guess you'll find out." I hold out the card to him, and he steps back from it. "If you're brave enough to stalk me while I'm owned." I press the card to his hand and let go when his fingers wrap around it. His face pales, and I know Krypt has walked up behind me.

Gregory Malone's throat makes a strange sound, his eyes as wide as dinner plates as he tracks the masked demon at my back. He looks back and forth between something, but I'm not going to give this man my back to see what it is. Tonight, I'm the hero.

"Have a nice night, Greg."

He backs away slowly, the card tightly gripped in his hand. I don't know what it says, but he takes it and leaves, weaving through gravesites until he's back on the street and heading somewhere else. I should feel powerful, but I don't. I don't instill fear in that man. Only Krypt does, but I'll take it for now.

"What did it say?" I ask Krypt while I watch Gregory fade into the night. "The card."

"That his suffering will be everlasting if he so much as looks at you again."

I don't know if I believe that, but I nod and turn around. I startle when the purple mask isn't the only one looking back at me. Teal and white stand on either side of Krypt, and my throat dries.

Is one of them my brother? Who is the other?

"We'll be doing the haunting from now on, hero," Krypt says. "Gregory Malone won't know a moment of peace until the day he dies, and trust me, that's going to be a long time from now."

The one in the teal mask moves fast, throwing a black hood over my head. I panic, but Krypt's voice is in my ear. "We're taking you back to Vile House. Relax."

Relax? While my vision is cut off and my fate is in their hands? Not fucking likely. Krypt steers me out of the cemetery, and within a few minutes, I'm in a vehicle, sitting in what I assume is the back seat with his arms around me. The other two must be in the front because someone is driving, and hushed whispers fill the silence. After a bit of a drive and a long walk through somewhere damp and full of echoes, Krypt finally removes the hood from my head.

I blink at his bedroom, trying to get my bearings or figure out how we got here. Honestly, I'm just tired. My body is exhausted and my mental breakdown from earlier at the shop has riddled my mind with overthinking.

"Will I ever be allowed to know how we get here? I thought I wasn't a prisoner?"

"Yes," is all he says. "Bed," he adds a moment later, the smell of weed filling the room.

"Can I have some of that?" I ask, climbing onto his bed fully dressed.

Krypt sits next to me, his mask no longer on. Instead of offering me the joint he's smoking, he holds out a fresh one and puts it between my lips. It

might help my mind shut down and make sleep easier, so I lean forward and let him light it.

It's been a while since I smoked, but the taste is familiar against my tongue and the burn feels good in my lungs. I inhale a few times, listening to the paper crackle as it dwindles down.

Then Krypt says, "You trust too easily, Remiel."



MY BODY IS SWEATING, but my eyes can't see. When I come to, I don't come back the same as I was before. I'm lucid but unaware, slow to react but not understanding the threat, and scared without knowing why or what to do about it.

I'm suffocating against something soft, but hurting because of something hard. I try to blink away the blariness, but all I see is the dull glow of a screen that light-blinds me. The sound of moaning hits my ears, but it doesn't sound real. It's tinny and warped from a speaker, the volume turned down low.

I cough, and my lungs ache almost as hard as my head. "K-Krypt?"

The bed swallows me when something pushes on me from behind. Something or someone weighs me down, and I jolt when I feel fingers prodding at my ass. My naked ass.

The fear becomes much more vibrant now. "Krypt?" I try to look for him, but see nothing except the blurry screen that plays a porno. The men are indistinct because my eyes won't focus, but the words from the speakers hit my ears.

"Ah, stretch me open. Get me ready for that big cock."

Oh my god. I try to break free from whatever is pinning me down, but my arms don't move how I tell them to, and my legs are numb and heavy.

"You aren't supposed to be awake yet," Krypt's jittery, abrasive voice says.

"What... what are you doing?" I turn my head, but it's so heavy. It falls against the pillow no matter how hard I try to lift it. "What are you doing to me?"

I cry out when his fingers stretch me open. The sensation is so weird and unexpected that I attempt to wiggle free. Is he seriously just... fingering my ass? Why? Why drug me for this when I offered myself to him so willingly earlier?

My body jolts when he curls his fingers, hitting a spot inside me that sparks vibrantly. "Krypt!" I shout, my voice louder now. "Stop."

"You stop," he counters, adding another finger. "Go back to sleep, Remiel."

Go back to sleep? While he's, once again, sexually assaulting me? "No! Get off of me. This isn't part of our deal."

"I own you, hero. Your body comes with every aspect of our deal."

I lift my heavy head and tilt it until my neck hurts, looking at him down the bed. He's kneeling beside me, the iPad propped up against my hip as he watches the screen and... mimics their actions? What the hell is going on? Is he learning how to prep someone for sex?

I pinch my lips to hold in a hiss when he spears me open, but my face heats a second later when he brushes his fingers against something inside me again. I feel my dick twitch, refusing to think about it. Not again. Why does my body respond to this?

"Why do it like this, then?" I ask, the pillow dampening beneath my face. My eyes are leaking and I'm drooling, but I can't lift my hand to wipe it away. I'm all pins and needles. "Why drug me?"

"Because you aren't meant to see this part." He moves his fingers inside me and I jerk at the sensation.

"What part?" I shout, voice raw. "The part where you sexually assault me for the third time?" Anger tries to claw its way to my surface, but numbness and a lazy haze chase it away.

"You weren't supposed to know about this time."

"By what fucking logic does that make it okay?" I snap at him.

"Does it feel good?" he asks. "Does it hurt?" *Does he care?*

"It's..." I don't know what it is because I can't formulate a proper thought. Feeling is coming back in waves, brought on and intensified by the way his fingers pump inside me. My toes curl into the bed, yet no part of him seems to be enjoying this. It's monotonous and unpracticed, almost clinical. "It hurts!" I settle on that. "Stop doing this and explain to me what's happening."

“I’m prepping you,” he says, not stopping. “If you’d rather I fuck you without prep, I can do that, too.”

When I catch a glimpse of his face, it shocks me. Because Krypt is nervous. He wants me to tell him it feels good because he honestly doesn’t know. Is he inexperienced? Maybe he’s never fucked a guy before. I don’t know anything about his sex life or his sexual preferences because I’ve never gotten to know him that way. He’s... practicing.

I fucking hate that it softens me to him.

“If you’re going to fuck me at all, I’d rather you do it while I’m aware of it,” I say instead. “Don’t rape me. Let me choose.”

“You get no say.”

“Why? I begged you to fuck me earlier, and now you’re gonna do it like this? I don’t get you.”

“Stop trying. You never will.”

There’s something like self-loathing and sadness in his voice, and I don’t understand what it means. As my muscles come back online, I force my body to roll over, but I only make it halfway. On my side, his fingers slip out of my ass, and the way it clenches feels foreign and strange. Empty.

“Look at me,” I demand.

His eyes stay on the screen and his face remains blank. His hands settle on his thighs, the right hand’s fingers glistening with lube in the screen’s glow.

“Krypt.” When his eyes meet mine, his monsters are subdued. “I... were you afraid to do this while I was awake? Are you embarrassed or something?”

“Don’t look at me like that,” he snaps at me, the tone of his voice waking up his monsters.

“Like what?”

“Like you know!” he snarls. “Like you fucking know.”

“Know what?” I yell.

He climbs atop me and presses his palm to my throat. His eyes seek the tattoo he gave me, but it doesn’t calm him down this time. He’s shaking and violent, no longer serene in his secrecy. Whatever he thinks I know, he doesn’t like it. Krypt has a vulnerability, and the twisted part of me wants to find out what it is.

“How many men have you fucked, Remiel?” he asks, barely containing his anger.

“None! I told you I’m not gay.”

His hand relaxes slightly against my throat. My fingers wrap around his wrist, but they aren’t trying to pry him off. “Then why beg me to fuck you earlier?”

“Because you make me crazy,” I admit. “I’m fucking terrified all the goddamn time, Krypt. I don’t know what I’m doing or what I’ve gotten myself into, but if this is my fate—if *you* are my fate—then... then a sick part of me wants to revel in you.” Holy shit, did I just admit that?

His eyes narrow. “Sick.”

“Yes! *I’m fucking sick*. I’m sick for wanting you even though you’ve ruined me. I’m sick for thinking I can survive you even though I want you to kill me. I’m sick for enticing you when I should be doing everything you say because you own me. Something isn’t right with me, Krypt. Can’t you fucking see that? Can’t you tell how sick I am?”

“Don’t,” he snarls. “Don’t say sick.”

“Sick!” I scream, crazed now.

“Stop it!” His hand tightens again. The muffled sound of the iPad comes from somewhere beneath the blankets, but it does nothing to draw my attention away from every single one of his inner creatures, their claws wrapped around the bars of his eyes, rattling chains and champing at the bit to break loose. “You’re sick, Keegan,” he says in a voice that isn’t his. “Something is wrong with Keegan, doctor. He’s sick! There’s a sickness in you, boy. Sick. Sick. Sick.”

Fear claws up my throat and pools in my stomach. He’s not here. He’s trapped in the past, stuck in a memory, reliving the worst parts of his life from a time before he had any power. I’ve triggered him all the way back to his childhood. To a family that treated him like a monster.

He *is* a monster. But I’m one, too.

Because I want to meet his inner turmoil and whip it into something that submits to him. I care about him despite how deranged he is. I care, even though he’s hurt me and abused me, used me and shamed me. His dominance entices a sinister side of me that wants to fight—that wants to force him to *make* me submit. Against my will. Without my consent.

I’ve never had a say in anything, and apparently, I don’t want one with him either.

I reach up with slow hands, grabbing the sides of his face. His unfocused eyes meet mine, and I greet the monsters within, speaking to

them instead of him. “Fuck me.”

He trembles.

“Fuck me. Right now.”

He shakes.

“Take me. Fucking own me. Fuck me hard and match your sickness to mine.”

He snarls, choking me harder.

“Keegan.” I slap his face. “Fuck. Me.”

With a roar of absolute agony, he rips his pants off and grabs my hips, positioning himself between my legs. He’s half-snapped, trying to rein in a fraction of his control. But hesitation and vulnerability make him second-guess, and the porn he was watching makes sense. He drugged me and pulled up a ‘how-to’ video. He prepped my ass while I couldn’t watch him. He kept a secret from me out of embarrassment. The elusive, dangerous, violent, and dominant Krypt is shy.

“Are you scared?” I taunt madly.

His nostrils flare and his furious eyes never look away from my ass.

“Can’t do it? Can’t fuck me like I wanna be fucked?”

“Remiel,” he growls.

“What’s the fucking point? If I’m owned by you, and you’ll cut parts off anyone who touches me, then how the hell am I supposed to live the rest of my shitty life if you can’t even fuck me how—”

His thick, heavy cock impales me in a single thrust, forcing the air from my lungs and burning me alive with pain. He rips me open while tearing through the confines of his vulnerability, sheathing himself inside me to prove a point to himself. To me. My eyes water in pain, and whatever numbness dulled me from the drugs is gone now, replaced by the somaesthesia of his body wrecking mine.

“More,” I demand. “Scare me! Terrify me! Show me who the fuck you are!”

Lube squelches in my ass as he annihilates me, fucking into me so hard the feeling is almost numbing. His fingers dig into my hips, bruising and battering, but I don’t care. Because I’m sick, too, and I want him to know he isn’t alone. He practiced. He opened me up. He prepped me in secret because he’s ashamed of his inexperience. He’s triggered because of a word, and I want nothing to overpower him. Not his shame. Not a word. Not me. Krypt is a sick king, and it’s time he claims his title.

My hands fall to his shoulders, hanging on for dear life as he fucks me into the bed like a beast. I don't know what he's feeling, but he's caught in a frenzy of struggles. His sickness morphs with mine, and he doesn't know how to accept it. His body acts on instincts it never has before, and his mind hasn't caught up to his impulses.

When he looks at me, I laugh. Crazed and pathetic, but fucking joyous. Because I'm getting fucked in the ass for the first time by a man I don't even like, and everything hurts, but the hurt feels good because I'm so fucking afraid of it. I'm terrified and crazy. I'm wrong and right about it.

He launches off the bed, dragging me by my hair to come with him. My legs are uncoordinated as feeling returns, but he pushes me to the dresser beneath the glowing purple skull light, bending me over it and kicking my feet apart. When his dick impales me again, a dagger presses against my throat.

Fear lights me up from the inside out, and when I look in the mirror above the dresser, I see it in my eyes. It's brought me to life. In pain and suffering because of him, I've never felt more revived.

"Call me sick," he growls.

"You're fucking sick!"

He nicks my skin and draws blood. The bead of it trickles down the side of my neck and spreads over my collarbone where he tattooed me. I watch the droplet in the mirror, tracking its descent down my skin and relishing the way he coats me in deranged paint.

"Why? Why am I sick? Say it!" He presses the blade harder.

"Because you raped me over a dead girl's body."

He bites me.

"Because you burned my house to the ground."

He cuts me.

"Because you gave me no other choice but to want you! Because your sickness calls out to mine and makes me feel alive! Because whatever lives in your eyes is so fucking alluring to me that I'm even sicker than you are."

"Ahhh!" he snarls in my ear and drops the knife. He fucks me from behind, his skin slapping off mine and his cock battering my insides. I can't even tell if it feels good because the pain of it intensifies my insanity, turning me so dark I barely recognize light. Fisting a hand in my hair and pulling hard enough to crane my neck back, he runs his teeth over the side of my neck. "Call me sick," he says again.

Whoever called him sick in the past implied it as an insult, and I'm not going to do that. I push my ass back and buck him off, turning as he falls over his discarded shirt. He growls at me, but when he tries to get up, he stops himself. Because, once again, he's proving a point. I'm the one going to him. I'm the one giving in to everything he's thrust upon me. I'm the one being warped and shaped by his unforgiving hands, and I'm stalking towards him like I want more.

Because I do.

He stays on the floor, watching me from below with wild eyes and unruly hair. I don't know when I got my coordination back, but I've never felt more powerful. The tingles in my legs as they regain feeling create sparks of want within me, a necessary evil I'm eager and willing to consume. I stalk him, stepping on either side of his hips. His hands land on my calves and buckle my knees, forcing me to fall to his lap.

I grab his dick and position it at my entrance, eyes on his the whole time. Because while I'm afraid, I relish the fear he brings forth in me. "Whatever makes you sick is so fucking twisted that it heals me." I sink down on his cock, mixing pain with agonized bliss and confusion because I hate it and want it together. Krypt cries out in angry pleasure. "I need it," I tell him as he sits up to latch his mouth to my chest, sucking more marks into my skin and fucking me from the bottom. "I need your sickness more than I need anything. Fucking give it to me, Krypt."

He pulls me down and thrusts upward, shouting through his orgasm. Warmth spreads inside my broken hole, but it feels so good and so overwhelming that I slide against his abs, rubbing my cock all over him. When he bites my nipple and damn near breaks my hips with his hands, I bury my face in his hair and lose myself to his sickness, coating us both in cum.

Because at least it's on my terms. This *one* thing.

FOR BETTER OR FOR WORSE?

KRYPT

REMIEL IS DRUGGED AGAIN, but this time it's keeping him calm. The sun is barely up, but I hauled his broken and abused body through the tunnels, and when we got to the asylum, Director gave him something to keep him subdued. As his body and brain are being scanned and Director is watching the screens, Ghost glares at my back so hard that I finally turn around to glare right back at him.

"Something to say?"

"Take it outside," Director snaps at the two of us.

I push past Ghost and exit the room, walking down the empty hallway until he shoves me into the stairwell. We aren't masked, so right now, we're Keegan and Soren, and we have to be careful, but fuck him if he thinks I'm going to buckle under his glare.

"What'd I tell you if you raped my brother again?"

I need a joint. "I didn't rape him." *Only with my fingers.* "He asked for it." And fuck, it was marvellous. I couldn't tell if I was breaking or healing, had no idea what I was doing, but Remiel asked for sickness, and I fucking gave it to him.

"Remi?" he scoffs. "Remi asked to be fucked that hard? He asked for all those marks on his body? He asked to be sliced open by your blade?"

"Begged."

Ghost bristles, trembling so hard the railing he's leaning on rattles. "So help me fucking god, Keegan. If you—"

"You never know when to shut your mouth, do you?" My brother walks into the stairwell and butts his chest against Ghost's. "You think you have any say here?"

Ghost and Riot, currently Soren and Killian, square off, and whatever simmers between them isn't any of my business, nor do I give a shit. I leave them there and get back to Remiel, who is just being helped off the table. I try not to snarl at the nurse who touched him; she should be losing a finger by my rules. He's a bit wobbly, but it should wear off soon.

"You good?" I ask him. The words feel strange and come out too fast. Holding him up, I keep his gown closed. Like fuck anyone else in this place is going to see the ass that now belongs to me.

"What's this for?" he asks. "Did you break me last night?"

I sit him down on the examination table just as Director walks back into the room. Remiel doesn't know he's Director, though. "Hi, Remi. I'm Dr. Cooper."

"I know who you are. Lab scientist... doing scans?" Remiel asks, skeptical. "Why am I here?"

"Because your mom cut you open and we're making sure she didn't leave anything behind," I blurt out.

"What?" He gasps, looking at me before swinging his attention back to Director. "Leave what behind?"

"By now, I'm sure you've noticed that your mother is... acting a bit out of character."

"Uh, yeah. Sometimes. My brother told me to stay away from her."

Director nods, looking at me as if to ask how much I've told him. Which is nothing. I selfishly wanted his attention on me, not his mother. So, while Director gives him the *Cliffs Notes* version of what we think is happening with this microchip, I watch as Remiel shatters just a little more. He's alluring while broken, and I want to break him more.

His breakdown from last night was so different from this. Last night, he went psychotic. Dipped into the depraved parts of his psyche and revelled in the darkness. Today, he's a scared little lamb, wondering how he can be the hero of his mom's life. But I like that there's a selfish side to him, too. Because his first question is about himself.

"What do my scans show? Is there something inside me?"

"They look clear," Director says, but I notice something in his tone. He's lying, and I don't know what about, so I stare at the images of the scans, trying to make sense of something I don't understand. "We just wanted to make sure."

“How do *you* know all this?” Remiel asks Director, smarter than I thought he was. He’s putting the pieces together, wondering how Dr. Cooper relates to Vile House.

“I’ve been made aware because of my area of expertise,” he answers smoothly. Smoother than the lie he just told Remiel about his scans. I don’t see anything that stands out in the images, but I also don’t know what I’m looking for. “We’re trying to formulate a drug to counteract the chip. Or what we think is a chip.”

“Remi.” The door bangs open and Ghost looks in. “Let’s go. I need a minute with you.”

I shove Ghost out the door and leave Remiel to get dressed. Director follows us out with a warning. “You’re best friends. Act like it,” he reminds us before taking the tablet with Remiel’s scans and going back to work.

“The fuck is your problem, Soren? You know he’s mine.”

“He’s my brother!”

“And I’ll protect him the best way I know how. Lay off.”

He grabs the front of my jacket, getting in my face while nurses and staff members pretend to ignore us. This portion of the asylum isn’t busy and is mostly used for us, but it’s safer to use first names here while unmasked. “If I accept this, and that’s a massive ‘if,’ I won’t lay off. He’s still my brother, even if his life belongs to you, and I’m not giving up. I will find a way to keep him alive.”

“As will I.”

Ghost sighs. He’s egotistical enough to see it as a competition, like he can’t bear to be beaten if I find a way to protect Remiel before he can. “Just don’t keep him from me. I don’t know how much longer...”

“I have shit to do with Killian, anyway. I’ll come grab him from you later.” I break his hold on my jacket and grab his instead. “If you touch him or anything happens to him under your watch...”

Ghost rolls his eyes. “You fucked my brother, Kr...eegan. What’s that, like the third time in your life you’ve fucked? I have a right to be pissed.”

“Be pissed all you want. It’s not going to change anything.” I shove him away. “I’ll see you later, yeah?”

“Yeah.”

“Where’s Killian?”

He grins, and it’s fucking vile. “Bit locked up at the moment.” He walks inside the treatment room, and I leave before I can bite his head off for

being near Remiel.

I find my brother locked in a freezer in the morgue.



AFTER HOURS OF CHECKING TOURISTS, we have four of them bound and gagged on the floor of the old mining cave.

I also have Gregory Malone's pinky finger in my pocket because he touched Remiel's hand the other night in the cemetery. I warned him I'd cut parts off anyone who touched him, and that includes unintentional touches. Fuck Gregory Malone.

Monster circles the four captives, and Ransom watches Monster fondly. Riot stands at my side, and all four of us have our masks on.

"What'd they do?" Ransom asks.

Riot points at each one in turn. "That one can't remember why he's in Moros. That one says he's from here, but I have no idea who he is, and neither does Krypt. She claims to be looking for a doctor but doesn't remember his name, and she's... just batshit."

The batshit girl is the only one looking at us. The rest of them are cowering on the ground, looking confused and scared.

"We'll get them scanned and then have Glitch try to figure out what's up with their minds." Ransom looks at Monster, still pacing.

"If they're even chipped." Riot sighs. "The fuck is this chip thing? I thought that shit was only in sci-fi movies. This is Moros. We're stuck in the past, not advanced in science."

"Axel," Monster seethes. "It's him."

"Yeah, but what are these chips? Like actual microchips?" I ask, because I haven't seen one yet, and now I'm invested because Director lied about Remiel's scans.

"Facts and Glitch have been studying them after Menace gets them out. Director doesn't want anyone at the asylum to know about them yet, so for now, Menace is playing surgeon. They say they're like little bundles of wires that embed in the brain tissue." Ransom rips his eyes from Monster to look at us. "I get how Axel might be implanting randoms, but how'd he get Ghost's mom under his blade?"

“We don’t even know if it is surgical,” Riot says. “Glitch said something about nasal implants or something.”

The four of us aren’t the smart ones. We’re better at haunting, destroying, stalking, and killing. Torture and information extraction are more up our alley than trying to understand something scientific. Ransom is smart, but not in science, so he’s just as lost as we are. I’m bored with this conversation, and I’ve already been away from Remiel longer than I care to be. I promised to keep him safe, and I’m not doing that while standing in a mine.

“This is Glitch’s and Facts’ department,” I say. “Let’s just get these four to them, let Menace fuck around in their heads, and see what Director wants to do with them.”

Separately, we all make our way back to Vile House, getting the four tourists locked in the asylum’s cells. Director is going to scan them, and whatever he finds will dictate what happens next.

On my way up the stairs from the house’s cellar, I run into Ghost. “Why the fuck aren’t you with Remiel?”

“He’s in my room. Chill.”

I push past him, unhappy with that. He’s supposed to be in *my* room, not Ghost’s. “Wait, Krypt.” He touches my shoulder and pulls away just as fast. “I need you to be my best friend for a minute.”

“I’m always your best friend. It’s you acting like a jackass that’s fucking that all up.” I look at him.

“It’s you making a bargain with Remi that’s fucking it all up,” he snaps back before calming down. “I want Remi to stay here.”

“He is.”

“I mean all the time. I don’t want him going back to my mom’s place.”

“He won’t.”

“What about Selena?” Ghost asks. “She’s in the city all week for school but comes home on the weekends. She stays there.”

Selena isn’t my responsibility, but Ghost is my best friend, so I lean against the wall and block the stairs with him. “Well, Seven says she’s killing her initiation tests. Maybe she can stay here in one of the communal bunks. Want me to ask Director?”

Seven runs the initiates. He’s in charge of weeding out the weak ones and finding the strengths of the ones who have what it takes to be here. Pretty sure he gets off on torturing them and pushing them past all their

limits. Selena is doing well, and even though she's one of only three females who has made it this far, she's fitting in nicely. But if we invite her to stay in one of the communal rooms reserved for the lower-ranking members, she'll learn our identities, and that's not usually allowed until they're fully pledged. Not unless they were raised in this house from childhood, like Ransom was.

"He'll say no," Ghost says, rubbing the back of his head. His hair is darker than Remiel's but their blue eyes are the same shade, and over the years, the colour has calmed me. Even more so now. "She's not allowed here until she's a member, and I don't know... if she doesn't make the cut, I'd rather her not know I'm Vile."

"What do you want to do, then?"

"I'll stay at Mom's with her on weekends when she's there, but maybe you can bring Remi around a bit so we can watch out for both of them when we aren't doing Vile business?" he asks. "I mean, more often than not, she's here anyway, doing her tests, so..."

I don't want Remiel anywhere near his mother, but I understand Ghost's worry about his sister, too. It's the least suspicious thing we can do since we've been best friends for most of our teen and adult lives. Keegan and Soren used to hang out at the Sauder house all the time, so it won't look weird if we continue.

"Remiel is my priority," I tell him.

"Then help me make Selena mine."

"Selena isn't cursed like you two are," I remind him. "I'm going to keep Remiel alive so that it keeps you alive, and Selena is secondary to all that."

Ghost nods to accept that. "Alright. So we go together if it comes up?"

"Fine. Or she can stay at my place in town."

"That'll cause questions I'm not ready to answer yet."

I purse my lips, itching to get back to Remiel. "Okay, your mom's place if it comes up. How was he today?"

"He's freaked out about Mom and this chip thing, but... I dunno. He seems different. More determined or something." Ghost's eyes meet mine. "I'm not saying you're good for him, but maybe he's growing a bit of a backbone. Still pissed at you for raping him."

I'm still unsure if I'm meant to feel guilty about that.

"He wants to know why I'm in The Misfits if I'm a Vile Boy. He's got a lot of questions."

“And we have a lot of answers,” I say. “Let me know when you’re ready to tell him.” When he nods, I head up the stairs, but he calls me back.

“Krypt?”

I pause.

“Let me know when you’re dealing with Reeven Matterson. I want in on that one.”

I grin at the stairs and nod without looking back. “Look in the cells,” I tell him, nodding down at the basement I just came from. “Matterson and his cult are already here.”

“We doing it tonight?” he asks. He’s missed out on all the fun today. While he’s been staying with his brother, the Vile Boys who were free have been capturing the Matter Cult. They’re here, and I’m itching to get to them. But first, Remiel.

“Tonight. Get ready.”

Ghost has just as much of a reason to hate Matterson as Remiel does. Might be a nice brotherly bonding experience.

“I’ll fucking kill you for today, Ghost,” Riot says, coming down the stairs ahead of me. It gets me moving, and when I hear Ghost taunt him right back about whatever happened at the asylum, I walk faster.

I ignore everyone in the cafeteria, grabbing a plate full of food for Remiel. On my way to Ghost’s room, I pause in the hallway when I find Remiel sitting on the floor outside my locked door. He’s tuning a guitar, focused on the work, completely oblivious to being watched. It pleases something within me that he didn’t wait in his brother’s room. He’s mine, and he’s finally realizing it.

“Whose is that?” I ask, startling him.

He stands, looking at me like he’s relieved to see me. “I don’t know. Came with this.” He holds up a Vile calling card. An orange one. Seven’s. My anger ramps up. “And this.” He flips it over, and instead of a message written on the back, there’s a bunch of money taped there. He flips the money up, and written underneath it is Seven’s pretty handwriting.

Relax, Krypt. It’s just a job.

Remiel smiles at the look on my face, but he pockets the card and sighs. “Is that for me?” He nods at the plate.

I unlock my door and let him in, handing him the plate. He takes it, wincing as he sits at the desk in the corner.

“Tender,” he explains.

I turn warm. I want him tender twenty-four-seven, battered and bruised from my obsession. Marked as mine and aching with the remnants of my cock, never able to forget about me for long. Ghost was right when he said it was only the third time I've fucked someone, but being with Remiel wasn't like being with the first two. I'm engrossed now. And when I fixate on something, it's damn near impossible to pull me out of it.

"Eat," I tell him, walking to my dresser to light a joint. I need to calm my mind because it's been spinning ever since Director's tone of voice changed when he told Remiel about his scan results.

I don't know anything about this chip, or wires, or whatever the fuck they are, and up until Remiel became mine, I didn't really care. I mean, I want to protect Moros from Dr. Axel Graves and stop him from turning our people into his minions, but I've never given much thought to it beyond that. Now Remiel has been injured by his mother, and above that, he became my responsibility. His life is in my hands, and maybe I'm realizing that I want to do more with him than just own him.

I glance at him from the corner of my eye, wondering what he learned when he spent two years as a psychology student. Would he know what makes me sick? Would he be able to help me understand myself? Do I even have the right to ask after everything I've done to him? He's a morbid person, and I know he hasn't dropped his goal to entice me into killing him to end the family curse, so I don't know where we stand. All I know is that he's changing me.

For better or for worse?

"Are you bleeding?" he asks.

When I turn, my lungs full of smoke, he nods at my pant leg. The blood isn't visible on the black material, but it marks the dresser where I leaned. Gregory Malone's finger is still in my pocket.

"When Reeven Matterson dies, someone is going to have to take over his following. They aren't levelheaded enough to think for themselves right now." I reach into my pocket to make sure the finger is still there. "We're going to see if Abigail from Death For Life will take them in." It's a lie because the entire cult is already in the basement, but I want to know what Remiel thinks about it.

Remiel drops his fork and frowns at me. "They don't fucking deserve it. They deserve to flounder! Reeven Matterson has been killing my mom's

family for years, and they're the ones who do it!" He stands, trying to challenge me.

My blood rushes faster. "They're brainwashed idiots who do what their master tells them to do."

"So you think they need a new master?" he barks at me.

"Why not? At least Death For Life doesn't kill innocents. Just each other."

"Innocents," Remiel scoffs. "Are there innocents in Moros?"

"Are you innocent, Remiel?" I step closer to him, offering him the joint. He glares at it, having learned a lesson from the other night. "What makes you better than them? You watched a girl die in the woods, didn't you?"

"You killed her," he accuses.

"Did I?" I tilt my head.

He doesn't know the answer and can't prove it either way. "You throat fucked me over her body."

"Mm." I inhale weed and exhale evil. "I did."

He narrows his nice blue eyes at me. "Are you proud of that?"

"More confused by it than anything," I tell him, stamping out the joint. "Sexual reactions aren't really my thing."

"Oh," he says quietly, like this news has surprised him. He nearly looks flattered. "Could have fooled me."

"You're a bad influence on me." I put out my joint.

"How?" he asks, slightly hesitant about the answer.

I grab the front of his hoodie and pull him to my chest. Breathing in the scent of him to ground myself, I push him to his knees. He fights me, but not hard enough to make it believable.

"You make my cock hard." I move his hand to it, pinning it there. "You make me impulsive. You make me territorial. You distract me, Remiel."

His fingers flex around my shaft, but he refuses to acknowledge it. "I don't do anything but what you tell me to do, so it's your own fault."

"Are we pointing fingers now?" I ask. "Undo my pants."

"No."

"Who came to Vile House to strike a bargain?" I ask.

He undoes my pants.

"Who made a deal that involved giving their life away?"

He pulls down the zipper.

“Who accepted the terms of the deal without clarifying anything but the names on his list?”

He swallows, looking up at me.

“Who, Remiel?”

“Me,” he admits.

“So, where are the fingers pointed? You know the reputation of Vile House and the men who live in it, yet you came here willingly to strike a bargain. Now our bargain is struck, and you still want to act like it’s all my fault?” I nod at my pants. “Take ownership of your actions, hero.”

“I am taking ownership. I just didn’t expect... the rest.” He looks up at me, and fucking hell, my cock aches for him. “Bargains aren’t usually sexual. So I’ve heard.”

No, they aren’t. And they don’t always include full ownership, but I’m making my own rules, setting my own standards. “Did you not beg to be fucked the other night?” I run my fingers through his hair, gently for the first time. “Do you want to act insulted one minute and needy the next? I can play whatever game you need to play to justify it to yourself.”

“Why can’t I be both?” he asks, ripping open my pants. “Why can’t I hate you and want you? Why can’t I be disgusted by the things you’ve done and need you anyway? What are the rules here, Krypt?” He pulls me free from my pants.

“The rules are simple. You’re mine. Whatever other lies you have to tell to make that stick is fine with me.” I move my hand down to cup his chin while my dick bobs in front of his face. “So, what’ll it be? Am I forcing my way between your lips, or are you going to open them willingly?”

“Do you have a preference?” he taunts, all attitude. “Do you get a thrill out of forcing me?”

“I get a thrill out of *having* you. The method doesn’t matter.”

I almost smirk when he looks insulted. Does my hero want to be taken? Does he want me so ravenous for him I can’t contain myself? He must, because he purses his lips together and sits back on his heels, deciding for both of us.

I force my thumb between his lips and hook it over his bottom row of teeth. Pulling down until his jaw cracks and his teeth indent the pad of my thumb, I offer him a smile. A real one. One that usually makes people cringe. Remiel doesn’t cringe. He doesn’t look away either.

“Okay, hero. Have it your way.”

I push the head of my cock to his lips, and when he reacts by flinching, I force it all the way to the back of his throat. It's dry, so it hurts a bit, but he coughs around me and slobbers all over it. With my hand on the back of his head, I thrust my hips and take what's mine. What he so willingly wants to give me without admitting it to himself. The constriction of his throat and the scrape of his teeth accompanies the warmth of his mouth, and it feels so good I close my eyes. My inner monsters rattle my brain, wanting to see our sinister hero on his knees for us.

"You like to be taken," I state, but he doesn't have control of his tongue to answer. "And you want to be ashamed of it, right? You want to hate yourself for being raped and liking it."

He pulls back. "I didn't like it!"

"No?"

He hesitates. "Not the first time."

I watch him for a second, admiring the truth. He opens all on his own, granting me entrance to his mouth. I push in until he gags.

Outside my bedroom door, the sound of shrieking and screaming drifts up from the basement's cells. The soundtrack is almost as nice as Remiel's cello music, and when I look down at him again, fear clouds his eyes, somehow making them brighter. He comes alive while afraid, and it charms my darker parts, daring them to come forth and scare him even more.

I hit the light switch, bathing my bedroom in darkness. Remiel whimpers, trying to back off my dick, but I hold him there until he chokes around me. When he chokes so hard his body buckles forward, I let him off.

"What—who was that?"

"Open your mouth."

His glossy eyes reflect the purple glow of my neon sign, illuminating the spit dripping down his chin. I swipe my thumb through it and loosen my hold on my inner demons, granting them just a little freedom. Remiel notices, and his throat rolls with a heavy swallow. He opens his mouth, and his hand lands on the crotch of his pants, rubbing.

I circle his lips with the tip, mixing precum with his drool. He's beautiful down there, so broken, yet powerful. And he's a liar. Because he's not tempting me into murdering him. He's bowing before me because he fucking knows I own him. Remiel was born and bred in Moros, but until I saw his ID the night of our bargain, I didn't know he was a legal citizen. There's a need inside me that wants to wipe him from the face of the earth

and turn him into a phantom soul only I control. I want him to be my secret, my saviour, and my downfall. Because I've always been sick, but Remiel makes me sicker.

“Lick.”

Remiel moans, but it sounds conflicted. His tongue swipes the tip of my cock, making me tremble. “You barely even reacted the first time. What’s different now?” His lips run down the length of me, and when he licks from base to tip, I inhale deeply to tame myself.

“You are,” I tell him.

“Krypt, I—”

The sound of a siren echoes through Vile House, and if I thought I stood a chance of taming myself before, I definitely don’t now. My eyes meet his, and something malevolent fills me.

I smile at him.

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WE HUNT

REMIEL

A SIREN WAILS through Vile House, and just as I glimpse Krypt's deranged eyes, the power cuts off and darkness hides them from me. The red glow of an emergency light dims the space a moment later, and I tremble at the unknown.

"What's happening?" I try to stand, but Krypt grabs my hand and wraps it around his cock. "What's going on?"

Hoots and hollers come from deeper in the house, and a few human howls send chills up my spine. Things bang and doors slam, and Krypt grows impossibly harder in my hand. I try to ask again, but he grabs the back of my head and forces his cock down my throat until I'm suffocating while he comes. He doesn't pull out until fear and a lack of oxygen make my eyes flutter, a second away from passing out.

I suck in air, gasping and gagging. "Krypt! What's happening?"

"I brought you a surprise, Remiel," he says, his voice once again jittery. "It's time to make good on the first name on your list."

Reeven Matterson. The leader of the Matter Cult. I gulp. "What do you mean?"

"No one enters Vile House unless they're here to make a deal, and if they don't, they never leave." He grips my face in his hand. "And I just lured your cult leader straight to us."

I'm too scared to look into his eyes, illuminated red from the emergency lights. "What do we do now?"

He laughs, and it's the first time I've ever heard the sound. It's deep, prickly, and unhinged. "We hunt."

Krypt does up his pants and throws off his shirt. His naked torso and Vile House tattoo make him demonic, but the blades he holds make him deranged. He puts on his purple mask, and no part of me wants to leave this bedroom with him. I'm a coward, because I'd rather hide in the closet than face the first name on my list.

"I don't hunt, Krypt. Jesus! What is happening?"

"Put this on." He puts it on for me, strapping a black mask to my face. When I look in the mirror, the stitched face of it basks in the red light, and when he pulls my hood up, my temperament changes. I become less afraid. Darker-minded. Gleefully contemptible. "No one in Vile House will touch you, but that doesn't mean you're safe, Remiel. Never leave my side."

Oh my god.

Krypt throws his bedroom door open, and different sounds rush at us. Chasing footsteps and wicked laughter. Banging doors and cries for mercy. Who else is here? Who else are they hunting? Who is my enemy tonight?

He takes my wrist and tugs me down the hall and stairs, leading me to a living room area I've never seen before. The dinner he fed me almost comes back up when I see nine more Vile Boys waiting in their masks. Others in black masks stand behind them, but more are already hunting the prey in the house, preventing them from leaving.

The blue mask guy with Krypt the night of my house fire laughs. The white-masked one barely prevents himself from pursuing. The teal mask moves from side to side without making a single sound. The pink one is brimming with energy, and the yellow one matches his vibe.

Tonight, the Vile Boys are sick and twisted, ready to be let loose inside their own house to complete my bargain. I asked for this. I made a deal for this. Which makes me their devil tonight. All ten of them are shirtless, and they turn around for me to look, to identify them. Granting me permission, I see their matching back tattoos. Their colours. Their names.

Seven. Orange. I'm fixing his guitar.

Monster. Yellow and agitated.

Riot, the one in white from the other night.

Menace, the one in blue. The one who took Cain...

Facts. Burnt copper. Twitching.

Ransom. The stoic one in red.

Kyd, the energetic one in pink.

Glitch, who is literally glitching with the need to chase something, his neon green mask tilting from side to side.

My brother. Ghost. The teal face of his mask warped into a disgusting smile.

And Krypt. My monster, who contains his own monsters. Tonight, he will willingly let his sickness shine, and I hate that a rush of adrenaline lights up inside me, excited to see the ten in their prime for the first time.

“Reeven Matterson!” Kyd shouts, following the name with a cackle so intense I shiver on the spot. “Where are youuuu?”

“Let me hunt, Krypt!” Monster demands. “Let me go! Set me loose!”

Ransom laughs behind his red mask, eyes on Monster.

“Hero?” Krypt asks, keeping my name to himself for now. The ten know who I am to him, but maybe the black masks don’t. “Bargain struck?”

A thrill pulses in time with my heart, quickening its tempo and rendering me unafraid. “Bargain met.”

The ten holler, jumping on the spot before stalking through the house, set free on my first target. My brother comes up behind me, joining Krypt at my back.

“Welcome to chaos, brother,” he says, then presses something against my palm. A knife. I don’t know how to use it, but I wrap my fingers around it.

And for the first time since I struck my deal with Krypt, the two of them act like the best friends they are. United in their minds and excited about something so ugly.

“I compromised,” Krypt whispers in my ear, his body lurking over mine. “You didn’t think they deserved to join another cult, so I brought them to Vile House. If we catch them, we’ll decide their fate.”

Matterson’s followers. He must have brought them here before we even had the conversation in his bedroom. That’s who has been screaming this whole time. The entire Matter Cult is here, and I have the power to wipe them out entirely. I’m thirsty for it.

I’m so fucking thirsty it terrifies me.

I press back against his bare chest, rubbing my ass on his still-hard cock. “Teach me how to hunt.”

He moans against my neck, the sound growly and pleased.



VILE HOUSE HAS TURNED into a madhouse.

With Krypt at my back and a knife in my hand, we stalk through the halls and act like gods. I've never felt powerful before, and without my Vile Boy behind me, I'm still not, but that doesn't stop me from revelling in the audacity of this night.

The Matter Cult is here, and their terror is addicting. I understand why Gregory Malone haunts me now. Tonight, I get to be the death omen.

With screams and pleas for mercy echoing throughout the house, Krypt leads me through a series of connected patient rooms. The other nine are stalking the Matter Cult, but I have my sights set on Reeven Matterson himself. The man who trapped my family in his cult and has been punishing them ever since they broke free. The man who made me sacrifice my blood to him on my seventeenth birthday. The man who does nothing but scare and dictate his constituents and force them to do all his dirty work.

I'm out for his head.

"Bloodthirsty looks good on you, hero." Krypt has already maimed three people. He didn't even hesitate, just like when he threw that dagger at the Krampus. He slashed hard enough to draw blood, and snapped bones to create musical screams. But he hasn't killed. Not yet. He says that will happen in the basement. "Listen," he demands, lips by my temple and his bloody chest at my back. "What do you hear?"

I go completely still against him, tuning out the sound of my blood rushing to listen to the sounds of the house. Someone is running in the hallway to my right. Someone else is yelling about fairness from the upper floor. A few people are crying, sobbing quietly. A woman whispers about seeing an exit back that way. Thrashing bodies are being dragged down the basement stairs. Psychos are hunting. My morals are quiet, not telling me whether the entire cult deserves to live or die.

Krypt's heart beats against my chest. Loud but unhurried.

A chair scrapes up ahead.

"There," I whisper, feeling Krypt nod against the side of my head. "Matterson."

“Fingers tight. Breath steady. Eyes open, Remiel.” He fixes my grip on the knife’s hilt. “Stalk him.”

I want to ask what to do with him once I catch him, but I bite my tongue. I don’t even know if I’m capable of that yet. On hushed feet, I step forward, following the almost silent sounds of Matterson sneaking through the house. I know it’s him because we’ve been following him for a while now, corralling him exactly where Krypt wants him to go, keeping him away from exits and ensuring he gets lost in the maze of Vile House. We’ve been scaring him, letting him think he can get away before yanking that hope out from under him time and time again.

On my own two feet with the knife in my hand, I walk through rows of chairs in the darkness, breathing through the mouth hole in my new mask. It’s a throwback to the night Matterson chased my family home and stalked us through my mom’s house. I was twenty-three then, but I’m a different Remiel Sauder now. Darker. Dirtier. Under the watchful eye of a chilling man in a purple mask.

Matterson uses the darkness of the theatre room to climb onto a small stage, slinking behind the podium at the head of the room. I watch the area, waiting to see if he’s going to appear on the other side of it. When he doesn’t, Krypt touches my shoulder. A quiet command.

He goes left, and I go right, approaching the podium from opposite sides to trap our prey. My heart pumps hard and my eyes narrow, focusing on his hiding place. When a blue glow appears from inside the platform’s concave back, Krypt’s mask looks at me again. We both stop.

Whispered and frantic, Matterson talks into his phone. “Get to the room with the stage! Get me the hell out of here, Jones.”

Calling his cult to his rescue won’t work. Not tonight. Especially when Krypt snatches the phone from his hand and puts it on speaker. Matterson screams, but the voice coming through the phone quiets him.

“Matterson? Help us! We’re in the basement, and they’re keeping us here. The fuck are you doing?!”

Reeven Matterson is nothing but a coward who relies solely on his following. He won’t save them, and they’re stupid for wishing for it.

“Krypt,” one of the Vile Boys says through the speakerphone. “Have fun.”

I’m grinning behind my mask, amped on adrenaline. This is the first time I’ve known what it feels like to be stronger, deadlier, more sinister

than a cult leader, and I don't hate it as much as I thought I would.

"What's going on here?" he asks, sparing me a quick look before focusing on Krypt. Krypt has the Vile mask, and I don't, but that doesn't make me less of a threat. I want to teach him that lesson. "Why are we here? What is going on?"

He sounds like me from a few hours ago.

I look at the purple-masked man who has done nothing but ruin my life. Krypt is twisted beyond recognition, daunting and harsh, but right now, he's awaiting my order, like I hold the chains to whatever lives in his eyes. I nod at him, still grinning, and Krypt grabs Matterson from beneath the podium.

He screams, and I shiver in fondness for it. Oh my god, I'm sicker than I thought I was. When Krypt has him contained, a knife to his throat, he pushes him onto his knees and makes Matterson face me. I stand above him, just because I can, looking down at the man who stalked and murdered my mom's side of the family. As I look at his tears, the tremble of his hands, and the pure panic in his eyes, I breathe it all in and allow myself this moment to feel as vile as the rest of the ten.

I sink down to eye level with Matterson, and with a final look at Krypt for permission, I lift my mask.

"Sauder," Matterson gasps. "You! What is the purpose of this? You think you have what it takes to control me?" He thrashes in Krypt's hold, but it doesn't appear to be a challenge for my master.

"I think I have what it takes to *kill* you," I tell him instead. It wasn't a part of the deal I made with Krypt, but now that this disgusting cult leader is right in front of me, I want it to be. I want to take a life. I want to play the role of judge, jury, and executioner. I want to dole out justice and inflict the same damage upon him as he's put on my family.

Virtue In Lives Exchanged... it's the Vile House motto, and I want to play by its rules.

He laughs at my declaration, but Krypt shuts him up. "Look at him," he snarls. "See his face. Look into the eyes of the man who will end your life."

Matterson looks at me, seeing for the first time how crazed I've become. I let him see it all. I turn as destructive as I was the night I goaded Krypt into fucking me. When he shakes harder and the ground beneath him turns wet, I smile at him.

"Oh god," he cries, his eyes shifting to something behind me.

I turn, finding my brother at my back. I never even heard his footsteps. His teal mask stares at Matterson, but his hand lands on my shoulder in support. Krypt tenses at the touch, but he allows me to have my moment. Crouching beside me, Ghost removes his mask, and Matterson stares in shock at the last two Sauder sons.

“You’re a Vile...” Matterson mutters. “Both of you?” He tries to look at Krypt, but he doesn’t allow it.

“Have you met my brother?” Ghost asks, his voice amused and entertained.

Krypt lifts his mask and looks at me, and I know exactly what he’s thinking. Matterson is in his final six minutes, and Krypt has a question from before. So, I ask it this time.

“What are you thinking about, Reeven? In your moment of death?”

Krypt’s sick grin greets me, and I fucking love it.

“Is it regret? Is there a highlight reel of your life playing through your memories?” I lift the knife I’ve been holding and press it under his jaw, Krypt helping to keep him still. “What do you regret?”

“Nothing!” Matterson shouts. “Fucking nothing!”

I tilt my head at him and get a thrill out of using Krypt’s words again. “Pique my interest and I might let you live till sunrise.” Fuck, I’m gross. I’m gross to make a joke in a moment like this, especially when it refers to moments before Krypt assaulted me for the first time. Something is seriously wrong with me, but I’m too bloodthirsty to change at the moment.

“Six minutes,” Krypt says. “Just a drop in the time span of his life. Isn’t that right, Remiel?”

“I fucking hate that you two have murder jokes.” Ghost laughs hard. Harder than I’ve heard him laugh in a long time. It echoes through the theatre room and makes Matterson tremble. Ghost stands, giving me permission to lead this show. He steps up to Krypt’s side, forcing Matterson to focus on me and only me.

“What do you regret, Reeven Matterson? Your six minutes are ticking down.” I smile at him.

“Not killing you when I had the chance,” he spits at me.

“Remiel,” Krypt warns, coming to the end of his leash. “I can’t listen to him talk to you like that.”

I move the knife down to Matterson’s chest, trying to find a fleshy place between his ribs. “Right here?” I ask as Matterson thrashes in his hold.

Krypt's fingers land on mine, steering the tip of my weapon to the right place before he angles my hand. "Hard and upward," Krypt says. "Leave it in so he doesn't die right away."

"No!" Matterson begs. "I'll leave Moros. You can have my following. I don't care about any of them. You can take them, and I'll leave and never come back."

"It's too late for that," I snap at him. "You fucked with my family for too long. My turn to fuck with you." I push the knife, and it's harder than I thought it would be. I bring the heel of my other hand to the butt of the hilt, using it to help me push harder.

Matterson cries, screaming into the theatre room. I push harder, and Krypt keeps him from thrashing too much. Ghost's hands land on Matterson's shoulders, holding him steady as I murder him.

I'm murdering someone. Right now.

"More, hero."

"Then leave it in," Ghost adds.

I take a deep breath. This is monumental and will change me to my very core, but I've come too far to turn back now. The sickness is in me, and it's festering away in the centre of my chest, filtering through my bloodstream and turning me vile.

With a final shove, I stare into Matterson's eyes. They aren't like Ophelia's because he's not close enough to death yet. The blade is keeping most of his blood inside, but the stickiness of his wound reaches my hand, and I lift my fingers to look at it. Crimson, made brighter because of the glowing red emergency lights, drips down my fingers and weaves into the creases of my skin. I'm numb to it, but buzzing with something.

"It's regrets, isn't it?" I ask Matterson. "That's what I thought about when Krypt almost killed me."

Ghost glares at his best friend.

"I thought about my brothers, my dad, and all the people you took from my mom. Are you thinking about your kids, Reeven? Are you thinking about your wives? How many of them have you failed? Are you thinking about how much better off they'll be without you?" I hit the knife in his chest, driving it a little deeper. "Reeven Matterson, founder of the pathetic Matter Cult. You're fucking nothing! You wanna know why?" I stand, shivering with need. Need for what? I don't know. "Because I fucking made you nothing."

“Fuck,” Krypt groans.

Ghost hauls Matterson to his feet, and then black masks are there to help carry the dying man to the basement. “You good?” Ghost asks, getting right in my face. I nod, looking past him to latch onto Krypt’s gaze. “You’re good,” Ghost says with a laugh. “Don’t take too long.”

With that, everyone leaves me alone with Krypt on the stage of a theatre room in an old asylum house. Unmasked and bloody, frenzied and broken, cracked in half but healing.

“Look at me,” Krypt demands, grabbing my chin and forcing my eyes to his. “Oh, fuck, Remiel.” He growls low in his throat. “This is what it feels like to *not* be the hero. This is death and energy. This is wickedness and goodness morphed into one fucked up feeling. Feel it,” he commands. “Fucking feel it.”

I am feeling it. I’m humming with it. Vibrating and ready to explode. It’s overwhelming and powerful, and no part of me wants to let it go. It’s a high I’ll never top and a sensation I’ll never replicate. It’s what makes a serial killer a serial killer, because nothing—fucking nothing—can top this euphoric haze of pure power.

“Are you powerful?” Krypt asks, voice jittery.

“Yes.”

“Are you deadly?”

“Yes.”

“Are you the hero?”

“My hero. My own hero.”

He hums under his breath, sinking into this feeling with me. He builds it, makes it stronger, taunts it and teases it until I’m damn near ready to explode with it.

Then he takes it all away.

“I’m the antihero,” he snarls at me. “And you’re still mine. Fucking feel this, Remiel.” He drops his hand to squeeze my throat.

“What?” I bark at him. “Feel what?”

Like a bad omen, he whispers, “Fear.”

The energy of everything changes, and dread suffocates me. My cock is unbearably hard.

FEELINGS I CAN'T NAME

KRYPT

REMIEL'S LIP trembles and his eyes water as his blood-high sinks into the pits of despair. Yes, he killed a man, and I'm proud of him for slaying his demons, but he will never be more powerful than me. Because I won't let him be. Because he doesn't want to be. I took the power role right from the beginning, and he's gotten comfortable under my control. He feels important there, and I don't think Remiel has ever felt important before.

My hero doesn't want to be the almighty. He wants *me* to be his deity. He wants to be scared.

I pull my mask back down and tilt my head at him, waiting for him to challenge me. He won't, but the option is there if he wants to try.

"What's wrong with you?" he asks, shaking for a whole new reason.

"I'm a killer who hasn't killed. A hunter who let his prey get away. A madman with a fucking need that hasn't been met." I trail a knife from the hollow in his throat down his sternum.

"Wh-what need?"

I love the way Remiel looks in fear. I wish the lights were brighter so I could see the sheen of sweat above his brow and the way his hands rub together. But under the red-washed emergency lights, I see it in his eyes. I feel it in the way his body shivers and his heart rate accelerates. I taste it in the way his energy changes, and I know it by the way his pants tighten. Because I've learned a few things about my hero.

Fear turns him on.

"Blood, Remiel. I fucking need it." I dig the tip into his chest, loving that it goes in deeper when he breathes harder. To breathe is an instinctive reflex that harms more than it prepares him for what's to come, and I love

that he turns stupid for me. His survival instincts are warped. Maybe he trusts that I won't harm him, but he's going to find out how wrong he is about that.

I won't *kill* him.

But I'll hurt him. His blood, like all of him, belongs to me, and I crave it all over my body, against my tongue, and dripping down his skin.

He smartens up. Finally, he smacks my hand away and sends the knife flying. Turning his back to me is his first mistake, but running is his second. He should know by now that running only feeds my beasts and entices me more than anything. I smile behind my mask, giving him a head start, and when he looks over his shoulder to see if I'm following, I throw a dagger straight at him. He ducks, and it wobbles to a halt in the wooden doorframe.

"You're fucking crazy!"

"Run, hero!" I shout at him, sinking into the sickness my mother hated me for. "Fucking run!"

He runs, and my animal instincts engage.

Remiel is predictable. There are only two places he'll go. The front door, or my bedroom. I'm not going to let him go to either, because I might be a hunter, but I'm done toying with my prey tonight.

I stalk after him, easily keeping him in my sights. He isn't as familiar with Vile House, and the darkness makes it a maze he's eager to get caught in.

Fear has him clumsy. He trips over the rug in the living room, crawling across the wooden floors to get to the stairs. He makes the mistake of looking back, and when he finds me only steps behind him, he whimpers. But it doesn't sound all that panicked. He's trying to entice me because he's as dark as I am.

He grabs the rung of the railing, trying to swing himself to his feet and climb. As soon as he makes it up to the third step, I howl at his back and latch onto his ankle.

"Krypt!" he screams, scared for real now.

I yank him down the stairs, his head clunking off the risers and his hands grasping at the railing. He kicks at me, but I'm more coordinated than he is.

"Didn't try very hard, hero." I tug him down and rip his shoes off, tossing them aimlessly.

“Stop! This is my night! Don’t ruin it.” His nails scratch my forearms, and the burn of it is fiery.

“Your night?” I rip his pants down next, finding him hard behind his red boxer-briefs, his thighs thick and tinted with blood. “You gave me the names, and I get to end them. Make them gone. Isn’t that what we agreed on?”

Remiel makes a last-ditch effort to get away from me, but I slam him down and pin him there with my knee on his chest.

“Krypt,” he cries. “Please.”

“Please, what, Remiel? Please let me go? Please don’t fuck me on the stairs? Please don’t hurt me?” I tilt my head and watch him whimper. “Please scare me more?”

Anger stamps into his features, and he growls at me. “Fuck you. I don’t want to be scared.”

“No?” I move my knee down until it’s pressing painfully against his hard cock. “When are you going to own up to things? You love finger-pointing, don’t you?” I grind my knee harder, and when he cries out in pain, I keep going. “Admit you’re scared.”

“No.”

“Admit it.”

“No!”

“If you don’t admit it, I’m going to flip you over, tear the rest of your clothes off, and slice my knife across your lower back until the blood drips down your ass to lube your hole. Then I’ll fuck it inside you until your cum does the admitting for you.” I press my knee down and bring my small dagger to the corner of his eye. “What’ll it be?”

My defiant little hero purses his lips together, glaring at me.

“Honesty in the form of silence. I hear you, Remiel.” I grab his waist and slide my knee to his hip to flip him over, but he stops me.

“You don’t have all the power here, asshole.” He forces himself against my chest, sitting until I feel the prick of a knife against my stomach. “You wanna fuck me bloody, you’ll do it while you look at me.”

Eye contact. He craves it, and it changes something inside me. No one, apart from Ghost and my brother, can hold my eyes, yet Remiel *craves* it. Maybe because of defiance, or maybe because he likes to remind himself that I’m not sane while I assault him, but either way, he needs my eyes as much as I need his blood.

I rip his boxers open, tearing them to shreds. The movement makes his knife slice through my skin, blood dripping warmly. He keeps his eyes on mine but lowers the blade to touch my mask. He rips it off, but we're concealed in the dark enough to keep me comfortable. I back up to get my pants and boots off while Remiel takes his shirt off, eyes still on mine. Completely naked together for the first time, I hold up a packet of lube from my pocket and ask the silent question.

"Surprised you even want to make it feel better. Thought you wanted to fuck me with blood."

"Do you want that?" I challenge.

He rips the lube from my fingers and tears it open with his teeth. The action reminds me of condoms, but we're way past that. We were way past that the night I licked his blood from his throat over Ophelia Hargrove's body.

I fist my dick in my hand while Remiel fingers his own ass, watching my expression and gripping the knife in the other hand. The atmosphere has changed, and he's almost unafraid. The fear has mostly faded, but I'm about to scare him in a different way. I'm going to test him. Because there's an insecure part of me that wants to know if he actually cares about me. About my life. Or is he only here to entice me into killing him as part of our bargain?

I lean forward and take his hand, forcing his fist to grip the handle until the blade is pressed to my throat. "Don't move it, Remiel." I grab his hips and pull him down a step, and when the head of my cock presses against his lubed ass, I look him straight in the eye as I ease inside him. My forward motion makes the blade slice into my neck.

Remiel breathes harder, pleasure mixing with worry, and fuck... the way his ass feels around my cock defies all concepts I previously had about sex. I push in harder, opening him for me, taking what's mine, but appreciating it differently this time. The blade cuts when I groan.

"Krypt," he warns, trying to move the weapon.

"I told you not to fucking move it."

He swallows, pressing it against my neck again. Lighter this time. He winces when I fuck into him, but I can't tell if it's because his ass hurts or he's afraid of the knife against my throat. I want him to admit he cares. That he doesn't want me dead, even after everything I've done to him. I want my neck to bleed and jar him into a decision about what I mean to him.

Because Remiel Sauder has become everything to me. My property. My obsession. My fixation. My dream.

I've never dreamed before.

His tight ass sucks me in and his eyes never leave mine. My internal monsters thrash, but I think I see his rise to the surface to meet mine. I push inside him slowly, feeling every inch gained. Taking my time. Getting lost in the frenzy of *him* rather than the frenzy of sex.

This is ownership with a test. Will he slit my throat in passion and end this bargain we have now that he's stronger, more capable, and the first name on his list has been taken care of? Or will he pull back, drop the knife, and prove that he cares about me even though I'm the thing that ruined his already tainted life?

I glance down, watching my cock disappear inside him. It does something to me. Reactions to situations have always fascinated me, and right now, my own reaction is tempting me far more than ever before. Because I'm inside him, watching the way two bodies become one, enthralled by the idea that we're connected so deeply. But when I lift my gaze and look into his eyes, it's the way he looks back that renders me conflicted.

"Don't," he says, rushed and begging. "Don't make me do this." His hand trembles, making the knife against my throat shake.

"Do what?" I grab his hips and pull him closer until he's one step above me and I'm thrusting into him from the bottom stair. The blade digs in harder, drawing a pained groan from my throat.

I can feel blood trickling down my skin, coating my chest and turning sticky in the air. His breath fans across my wound, but his eyes never leave mine, not even when I push into him so hard his body thumps back and the stairs dig into his spine.

"This..." His fingers drum on the handle, so I cover them with mine to keep his hand steady. "This isn't our dynamic."

"How not? Haven't you wanted this?" I pull back and sink forward, burying my dick in the only body that has ever felt good.

Remiel gets panicked. Maybe angry. His nostrils flare and his free hand swipes through the blood on my upper chest. "This! *You* make *me* bleed, not the other way around. You hurt me. I don't hurt you!"

"But you want to."

"No," he whispers, eyes turning glassy.

I lift my head and press on his hand, baring my throat to him and the weapon. “Don’t you want payback? I burned your fucking house down, Remiel.”

He cries out.

“I raped you!”

“Krypt,” he begs, free hand rubbing my blood onto his cock.

“I drugged you and stalked you! I keep you here as my fucking prisoner, Remiel. Make me pay for it!” I snarl at him. “Do it!”

“I can’t!” he screams, tears leaking down the side of his face.

“Because you’re a coward?”

“Because I want you! I’m... I’m a willing prisoner, okay? I fucking want you!” He rips his hand free and throws the knife somewhere into the living room.

I’m so jarred by his admission that I refuse to accept it. “No. You need me,” I correct.

“No,” he says, shaking his head. He sits up and pushes me back. Flipping our positions so I’m sitting upright on the step, Remiel climbs onto my lap and wraps his fingers around the back of my neck, thumbs under my chin. “I don’t need you.”

I watch him intently, looking for lies and meaning. I don’t know what he’s getting at, and the whole thrill of the night is shifting into something vulnerable and horrific. This is supposed to be about blood and the rush of death. Yes, I wanted him to throw the knife and show he cares, but now he’s saying things that don’t mesh with my idea of the connection we share. I want him scared! Honest with actions, not words!

I’m his monster. The one who will complete his bargain. His tormentor and his rapist. He relies on me to keep him safe and end the lives he wants ended. Nothing more.

“I don’t need you,” he repeats. “I can survive without you. At least until the curse takes me. But I can do it. I can live on my own.”

I swallow, too afraid to say anything.

“But I pick you,” he says, tilting my chin and looking straight into my eyes. “I told you I’m sick. I fucking told you.” He lifts onto his knees and wiggles until my cock lines up with his ass. “I pick you as mine. I pick you to turn me into something I’ve never been before. I choose you to show me a way of life I’ve never lived. I don’t need you, Krypt. I fucking *want* you.” He slides down my cock, and even though I’m mentally panicking, I’m

coming, too. Suddenly and without warning. Feeling it too deeply without reacting to it. My cock throbs inside him while my chest pulses from what he said. It's not pleasure soaking me. It's pain. I can't tell if it's good or not.

The pit of my stomach coils tightly, churning and burning into something volatile and dense. My eyes surge with the need to free my demons, wondering if they've always simply been vulnerabilities in the form of tears, and the breath in my lungs refuses to leave. I don't know what the feeling is. It's a craving I can't name and a sensation that doesn't make sense.

I want to fucking kill him for being so stupid.

I want to kiss him without hurting him.

I want to lock him in the basement as punishment for what he said.

I want to wrap my arms around him and touch him tenderly.

I want to throw him from my life so he can never change it.

I want to hold on to him so tightly he can never leave.

He wants me. The real me. Keegan from town and Krypt from Vile House.

I don't like being wanted. I love it. I hate it. It's too much and not near enough. It's all my diagnoses coming back to war with one another because none of them can settle on the way we feel about this. He's an idiot! *He's fucking mine.*

"I want you," he repeats.

"Don't. Stop wanting me."

"I can't."

He can't. He can't. He can't. I'm going to kill him with my want, and he has no idea how dangerous my love can be. My love is warped. It doesn't feel the same as it does to others. It's alarming and scary and dangerous. It's a complete fall into obsession and the obliteration of everything else. If Remiel becomes the focus of my love, it will annihilate him. Wipe him out. Strip him bare and turn him into a husk of his former self. He'll die.

I tilt my head at him, hurting everywhere but nowhere in particular. "You're tricking me. Trying to entice me into killing you."

He squints at me. "How is telling you I want you a trick?"

I latch onto his hips, scrutinizing everything about him. The way he breathes and moves. The way he looks at me. The way his lips pop open and his pupils dilate. "I told you my love is dangerous. You're using that to make me kill you. No." I push him away, barely caring when he crashes to

the floor and falls down the last few steps. “No, I won’t let you.” My cum seeps from his ass, but I’m too stuck in my head to appreciate it.

“You won’t let me want you?!” He stands, naked and angry, inner thighs glistening.

“I won’t let you want me! I won’t kill you, Remiel!” I turn my back on him and rush upstairs. I’m supposed to be in the basement, but fuck everything and everyone. I’m overstimulated and incapable of processing my thoughts. Because, for once, they’re mingled with feelings I can’t fathom. Feelings I’ve never felt before. Feelings I don’t understand.

Feelings I can’t name.

This was supposed to be about fear. Now I’m the one who’s terrified.

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SPACE & FRIENDS

REMIEL

WHAT THE FUCK is going on?

I watch Krypt's back tattoo disappear up the stairs, blending into the dark hallway until he's gone from sight. I admitted something to him that hurt to say, and this is how he's going to treat me? He's going to mask me, teach me to hunt, cross a name off my list, and then scare me into sick sex... and then leave when I admit I don't want to hurt him?

Well, fuck him.

I grab the railing and take a step to follow him, but someone latches onto my wrist and pulls me back.

"Better give him a minute." A jacket is thrown over my shoulders, and when I turn around, I see Killian. Wait. Not Killian. Riot is what his tattoo says, because we're in Vile House. Krypt's brother. Holy shit... he's Vile, too?

I pull the jacket on, thankful that it covers my dick and the cum leaking down my legs. Jesus. What is happening to me? I'm naked in the middle of a dark house where people are dying in the basement and masked men are doing the killing, and all I can think about is getting Krypt back?

"No. I'm not giving him a fucking minute. He's an asshole who doesn't—"

"Know how to feel feelings?" Riot supplies with a charming smile. "Exactly." He bends down to hand me my pants, and I tug them on just because I feel so stupid. "He was testing you. With the knife. He wanted you to admit you cared about him."

"Well, I did, didn't I?"

Riot nods. "Yeah. Thing about Krypt is, he wants something, but he never expects to get it, and once he does, he has no fucking idea how to handle it. You just rocked his very foundation, Remi. My brother doesn't know the difference between hungry and horny, so you think he's going to understand the difference between captivity and you willingly being here? Up until now, he was safe using your bargain as an excuse. He doesn't mind being your jailer because you asked to be a prisoner. You just told him you're more like his guest, and that's gonna take him a minute."

"Why?" I ask, looking up the stairs, barely holding myself back from rushing up there. "Why doesn't he know the difference? What's... does he have a diagnosis?"

"He's got about thirty," Riot says. "And half of them cross out the other half. No one understands Krypt, not even himself, so it scares him that you want to try."

I never said that. Maybe I implied it. When I told him his monsters are alluring and his sickness makes me sicker, I meant that I wanted to understand him because I want to learn to understand myself.

"I should go up there. Check on him."

Riot laughs. "Trust me, he'll be down in a minute." That gives me hope, but he shakes his head. "Not for you. Not yet. When Krypt gets overwhelmed, he turns to violence. There are currently twenty people dying in the basement, and the others are holding off to give him the chance to kill off his crazy."

"By killing the Matter Cult?"

"Yeah. So, if you don't want to see it, you should go."

Do I want to see it? Do they deserve to die or should they be let free to make their own choices? I know the right answer, but I'm a changed man, so I ignore it.

"Go where? He never lets me leave. I don't even have a house anymore."

"I'll take him," Menace says, coming up from the basement. His blue mask is on the top of his head, and now that I see his face, it makes sense why he wanted a night with Cain. He shares an understanding look with Riot. How do they know so much? Were they standing there in the dark, listening and watching us on the stairs?

"Where?"

“Cain’s. Come on, Rem. He’ll be fine. You deserve a night with your friend.”

It’s almost midnight, but Cain is a night owl, and maybe I need to get out of Vile House for a bit. It’s tainting me.

I’m letting it. Willingly.



AFTER A WARNING from Menace not to reveal his identity to Cain, he drops me off at the front door of my best friend’s house.

“Place isn’t gonna burn down now that you’re here or anything, right?” Cain chirps, handing me a beer.

Honestly, I don’t even know. Maybe, but I don’t say that. Krypt is probably deep in his murder haze right about now, but I don’t know what he’ll be like once he emerges from it. Will he be pissed I’m at Cain’s, or will Riot and Menace keep him contained?

“Do I wanna know what all this is?” Cain asks, motioning to me. “Are you hurt?”

Yeah, I’m covered in blood. Reeven Matterson’s blood is all over my right hand, and Krypt’s blood is everywhere else. “It’s... it’s not my blood. I’m fine.”

“You’re not fine, Rem. Talk to me. Vent, or whatever.”

Cain is someone whose looks don’t match his personality. He’s harsh, covered in tattoos and piercings, and comes across as dark and unapproachable. But he’s soft and sweet, cares deeply about those he loves, and isn’t ashamed of who he is at all. He blushes a lot while looking angry about it, but he’s also not afraid to ask the blunt questions. We became friends because of our love for music, and over the years, he’s one of the few people who doesn’t look at me like I’m a ticking time bomb for suicide. He’s the only person I feel safe venting to.

“I made a bargain with Vile House,” I admit, drinking half my beer in one pull.

“What?!” He smacks the kitchen table we’re sitting at. “That’s what the calling card was under your sink?”

I nod, looking at the label on my bottle. “Yep.”

“What bargain? With who? Fucking why, Remi? Jesus. I spent one night with that freak in the blue mask, and I... what the fuck?”

The freak in the blue mask... and I can't even tell Cain who he is. Or that he's caught his interest. “The purple one, as you saw on the card. His name is Krypt. With a K.”

“A K?” he asks. “Nevermind. That doesn't even matter. Why the hell did you make a bargain with him?”

“Because I felt like I didn't have any other choice!” I vent. “My life is dwindling down to the end, Cain. I can feel it. I'm losing myself, and sooner or later, I'm gonna kill myself just to make it stop. There's shit I need to do before that happens. To protect my family and... to keep Soren alive.”

“Don't talk like that,” he snips at me. “There's no such thing as a suicide curse. Sometimes I think it just gets in all your heads. Like you're all so consumed by it that you think you're going to succumb to it just because everyone before you has. Be different.”

“You think it's that easy? You think I want to die? I don't. I don't have shit to live for anymore, especially since my house burned down, but I don't wanna hurt my brother. I fucking know what it feels like to lose a brother, and I don't want to put Soren through that again. No matter how much I hate him sometimes, he doesn't deserve that.” Which is so hypocritical of me since I asked Krypt to kill me, but if Soren can live the rest of his life without the curse hanging over his head, it'll be worth the pain of losing his last brother. The sacrifice will be worth it.

“No one does,” Cain agrees. “And this is just Moros fucking with your head. Nowhere else in the world believes in a stupid suicide curse. Moros just makes dark things seem appealing.”

“Appealing?”

“Believable,” he amends. “What got so bad that you had to go to Vile House?”

I finish my beer, and by the time the bottle hits the table, Cain puts down two more. Fine. I'm scared of what happened tonight. I killed a man and then chased Krypt away by admitting I wanted him, so yeah, I'm gonna get drunk with my best friend and blurt everything except their identities.

“I killed Reeven Matterson tonight.”

Cain's eyes widen, but his words stay silent. I watch him process that. I mean, death and murder aren't really uncommon here. Yet another thing

Moros makes believable, but I've never killed anyone. Cain knows that.

"And his whole cult is in the basement of Vile House right now. Probably being murdered or tortured or toyed with. Because I put Reeven Matterson's name on my bargain list, and Vile House is following through." Which means I just revealed a murder to an outsider, and Krypt is probably going to maim me for it.

"Wow." Cain leans back in his chair, shaking his head and almost laughing. "Honestly, I didn't think you had it in ya. Why the Matter Cult? Because of what they're doing to your mom's side?"

I nod. "I'm just sick of everything being so life or death here. Like, yeah, cults are a normal thing, and it's hard to get out of them, but we did. Mom got us out. And now she's suffering for it." *And microchipped and brainwashed and acting weird.* "I just want that to stop. The Matter Cult doesn't belong in Moros like the rest of them do, you know? The rest get along, and they work together to protect Moros. The Matter Cult ruins Moros and kills our people."

"Can't say I disagree. Death For Life Cult isn't much better, but at least the ones they kill agree to it. Stupidly," Cain says, leaning forward with his tattooed elbows on the table. "How'd it feel? To kill him."

"Well, he wasn't dead when they took him away, but there was a knife in his heart, so..." A sick grin almost graces my face, but I wipe it away. "It scared me. I got caught up in a power haze, and I don't know if I wanna feel that again."

Silence settles in as we both think about that. I know what it feels like now, and I know Cain is trying to imagine it. "Who else is on your list?"

"Gregory Malone."

He clinks his bottle to mine. "Fuck, I almost... that power haze sounds kind of fun, and I almost wish you didn't go to Vile House. You should have come to me instead. We could handle Gregory Malone," he says, laughing. "He's just a fucking creep."

"Yeah, a creep who keeps evading me. I need Krypt to end him so he stops stalking me and Soren."

"Krypt, eh? What's he like?"

"He burned my house down..."

Cain laughs, the beer taking effect. "Yeah. Guess that answers that. Have you met the rest of them? Do you know who they are under those masks?"

Krypt said that if I ever told anyone, he'd force me to kill myself. "You know I can't tell you that."

He leans in more, almost conspiratorially. "Do you know the one in the blue mask?"

"I can't tell you, Cain. I'm sorry, but you should definitely stay away from him. All of them. They're..." I don't want to say sick since Krypt doesn't enjoy the word, but they're something like it. "Unstable."

"They're Vile Boys." Cain laughs. "Of course they're unstable." There's a sense of curiosity in his eyes, and it's going to get him killed. "What happened after you killed Matterson? Why did you get dropped off here?"

Because I triggered a madman's feelings, and he doesn't know how to process them. Because I'm gross and vile and feel something for the man who made me his prisoner and then forced me to like it. Because life is finally exciting, and now that I have a taste of the more sinister side, I'm finding a home there. With him. I don't need him, just like I told him, but I want him. Because my days are numbered, and the ones with him are the first ones I'm truly enjoying. Which is pathetic.

I've been in more pain, suffered more, hurt emotionally harder, and been the most terrified of my life since meeting Krypt, yet the feeling of *life* is so intense it makes me feel truly alive for the first time in my pitiful existence.

Maybe—like a massive maybe—I feel stronger. Strong enough to beat the Sauder curse. Maybe I don't have to die...

"He needed space to... maim and murder off all his energy." I finish my beer and set the empty bottle with five others. Not wanting to talk about it anymore, I get up to grab another for each of us. "You ever going to tell me what happened on Initiation Night?"

"You ever going to tell me what happens when you stay with him every night?" he fires back.

I sit down and slide him another beer. "Better get drunk for this."

"Why?" He's grinning now, his septum piercing reflecting the light from the candle on the table.

"Did you fuck the one in the blue mask?" I ask instead.

"I'm... I have a girlfriend."

"Yeah, and I claimed I wasn't gay."

Cain barks out a laugh. "Are you?"

"Well, I'm fucking something. He forced me... and now..."

“You like it.” His grin turns wicked. “I cheated on Sadie,” he admits his own truth. “Not like I had much say in it, but...”

I laugh into my bottle, feeling crazed. Two best friends, drinking beer in the middle of the night, talking about our sexual assaults like they weren’t assaults. No wonder we live in Moros. We’re as twisted as this town is.

Did Moros mold us into these people, or would we still be this version of us if we were born somewhere else? I guess we’ll never know.

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AM I IMPORTANT TO YOU?

KRYPT

“LINE UP!” Director shouts, forcing us into rank.

The ten of us stand in a line, and it tugs on my already frayed nerves to be at the very end. I glare at Monster before he even opens his mouth to say something about it.

“A fucking cult?!” Director yells at us. “A whole goddamn cult? How the hell do you think we’re going to cover this?”

Director approved Reeven Matterson’s death, but not the death of the entire cult. I didn’t mean to kill them all. I mostly wanted to scare them, take out a few of the more brainwashed ones, and set the rest free with wounds and new outlooks. That’s why we left our masks on. But after Remiel... well, I lost myself in a manic episode, and when I came to, I found the eyes of all my brothers the same as mine. We all dipped into the same depravity last night.

Even Facts, who lifts his jittery hand. “Hello. I have an idea for that.” He pulls a tablet from inside his jacket and hands it to Director.

“A mass suicide?” Director asks. “No one is going to believe that when they worshipped his bloodline.”

“Hello,” Facts repeats. “I wrote a suicide note. It claims that the bloodline has been tainted, and none of them could bear it, so they chose to eradicate it altogether. If you’re wondering how to explain away the state of the... uh, bodies, well, we can use these microchips to our advantage. We can implant them, and when the police and forensics study the bodies, they’ll conclude that they were all chipped and mad. It will also aid in our search to find Axel Graves.”

Kyd sighs dreamily at Axel’s name.

“So, let me get this straight,” Director starts. “You want me to, once again, use your fuck-up as a win? You want me to forgive this major indiscretion, pretend the whole thing never happened, and reward you by getting the police involved in Axel’s lab to make your job easier?”

“Hello.”

“No!” Director cuts Facts off. Facts isn’t always as volatile as the rest of us, but cutting him off while he’s speaking is his biggest trigger. Glitch wraps a hand around Facts’ wrist, holding him steady while he shakes so hard his teeth chatter and his nails dig into his palms, making them bleed. “You will clean this up. You will help the remaining family members of the Matter Cult plan their funerals, and you will offer them the full support of Vile House. They. Weren’t. The. Job! Reeven was the job, and you fucks lost your minds!”

I lost my mind a long time ago. Not my fault he’s just figuring it out now.

“And you.” Director steps in front of Ransom. “I expected more from you.”

“Why?” Ransom asks, chin high. “Because I’m more responsible? Because I’m at the head of the line? Because you put me in a different category than the rest of them?” He steps forward, challenging Director, and it’s the first time I’ve ever seen him so defiant towards our leader. “I’m here for a fucking reason, Director. You made me like this. You made me one of the ten. Did you forget why?” Ransom radiates such authority that the rest of us get agitated.

But when Director grabs the front of Ransom’s jacket, Monster turns feral. He snarls right next to me, bouncing on the spot and watching Director with such threat in his eyes that I put a hand on his shoulder to steady him. He shrugs me off because he hates being touched more than I do.

“Calm, Monster. Ransom can handle his shit,” I whisper, touching him again anyway.

Monster snarls again, eyes on Director. “Don’t fucking—”

“Monster,” Ransom says smoothly. When their eyes meet, Monster physically relaxes under my hand.

I pull him back in line just as Director nods towards the end. The nine of us are fucking shocked! Ransom has never been at the end. Never. But he

keeps his chin up and grins at Director as he walks to the end, putting Seven in the highest ranking spot and me second to the end.

“You’re all cleaning up this mess. I saw the basement footage, and you’re all to fucking blame.” Director paces, pinching the bridge of his nose. “And, Krypt?”

I swing my eyes to him, bored and eager to go see Remiel.

“As punishment, I have a job for you. You aren’t going to like it.” His eyes almost look sympathetic. “Time to put that mind of yours to use.”

Great.

CURRENT RANK

1. Seven
2. Ghost
3. Menace
4. Riot
5. Facts
6. Glitch
7. Kyd
8. Monster
9. Krypt
10. Ransom



THE AMBIENT RAVEN is open for business, and Cain and Remiel are both at the front desk. If I go in there and act possessive of Remiel, Cain will know who I am and what it means. But if I don’t go in there and act possessive of Remiel, I’ll burn his fucking shop down and break the one limit I told him I’d respect.

Ghost offered to come with me to give me an excuse for being here, but I turned him down. I need time alone with Remiel. After everything last

night. After the job I've just been given by Director. This might be my last chance to...

He might not need me, but I need him.

The bell chimes when I walk through the front door, drawing their attention. Sad classical music filters through the shop, but it has nothing on the sadness mingling within the darkness of my soul.

Remiel looks at me, alarmed and relieved. My heart thumps out a hard beat, confused by his reaction.

"K-Keegan," he says, acting the part and hiding my identity.

But when I look at Cain, I give myself away. "Leave."

Cain's eyes widen in understanding and Remiel's face drops.

"Remi?" Cain asks.

"I'm fine. Just go."

Cain grabs his coffee and walks toward me and the front door, but before he can walk by, I stop him with a look. "Just so we're clear, *I'm* the one who protects him. Not you."

Cain's the daredevil type, so he levels me with what he thinks is a threatening look and opens his stupid mouth. "And just so *you're* clear, he's my best friend and you won't take him from me."

"You sure?" I ask, flicking a Zippo open. "Be easy for me to make you disappear."

"Keegan!" Remiel warns.

But Cain is smiling. I don't know what it means. "You ever going to properly introduce me to your friend in the blue mask?" he asks, proving that he now knows who I am.

"From what I hear, you've already been properly introduced." I tilt my head at the door. "Go. Now."

Cain rolls his fucking eyes at me, and the only thing staying my hand is the pleading look on Remiel's face. When he leaves, I lock the door behind him and stand here, unsure how to proceed. I've never been good at talking, so I don't really want to do that, but Remiel looks expectant. He has so many questions about last night, and I don't really have answers, but he... he cares about me. For fuck knows what reason he cares, and maybe that makes him deserving of some sort of explanation.

"Are... are you okay?" he asks me.

Really? That's his first question. Clearly, I'm okay. I'm standing here, alive and fine, but maybe he means something else. My head isn't okay. My

heart isn't okay. Because I found out I have one and that it knows how to feel shit. Hard. I don't like it, and I resent Remiel for waking it up.

If anything, I'm mourning the loss of the sex last night. It was supposed to be about fear and power, but he ruined it by doing exactly what I wanted him to do but never thought he would actually do. I came because of a rush of emotion, not a power dynamic that put me above him. It's all fucked up and warped, and I don't know how to level it out.

But being near him now, it's not sex I'm craving. It's him. His attention and his anger. I don't deserve more than that, but I want it anyway. I want him to understand me and become as sick as I am, to understand that maybe we're matched because we're both so broken. His brokenness led him to me, and my brokenness helped empower him. We're matched in pain, but both undeserving of each other.

I don't deserve his understanding.

He doesn't deserve to suffer my monsters.

He's better than I am, and I've never cared about something like that before, but...

"Are you hungry?" he asks when I don't answer. "I haven't eaten all day. I could... um, take you for dinner?" He rubs his palms together and avoids looking at me.

Dinner? I don't date. I don't want to date. I want to skip the dating phase and go straight to ownership and possession. He's either mine or he's dead. There is no in-between.

"Krypt?" He slowly walks up to me. When his hand lifts to touch me, I look at it, and he pulls it away.

I grab his wrist and dig my fingers into the scar there, reminding me how important it is to stop Axel Graves. "Don't treat me like a boyfriend, Remiel."

He frowns at me. "You got me breakfast at Vile House and then brought me dinner another night. Why can't I do the same?" He rips his wrist free and pulls the front of his shirt down to show me my name there. "You already fucking branded me and made me yours, so... let me be yours. Let me play pretend." There's a new edge to him, something mad and darker than I like, and it has me alert. Many men in the Sauder family have gone mad, and that's inevitably what led them to suicide, so I have a new eye on Remiel. He's a risk right now. To himself. Because this mania is new; it has shifted into something destructive rather than productive.

I don't agree or nod or give any affirmation, but I don't disagree either, so Remiel opens the door and holds it for me. I step through it and wait on the sidewalk while he locks up. Death Row is busy with evening foot traffic and closing shops. It's already getting dark since it's autumn, and the power lines are all weighed down by blackbirds and crows that appear as shadows in the fading light. The air is thick and misty, cool but not windy, and I feel comfortable in the blanket of fog that lines Death Row.

When he puts his keys in his pocket, I watch him instead of everyone else on the street. No one talks to me as Keegan anyway, so it's easy enough to ignore them, but it makes my teeth hurt when people greet Remiel. My blood burns hotter with every person who looks at us together with questions in their eyes. He's Remiel Sauder, the poor son of a family of suicidal men who owns their favourite shop and knows them all by the music they play. I'm Keegan Hallows, the crazed son who killed his parents and can't hold eye contact.

We walk down Death Row together. Remiel leads, but I'm at his back like a stuck shadow, unwilling to let him get far from me. He doesn't seem bothered by any of it. Not me at his back or the people who look at us.

He walks past the Midnight Diner and pulls open the door to Cauldron, a soup and sandwich place. Its dark brick interior and black and woodsy furnishings appease my hatred for bright things, but it isn't busy, and that settles me a little more. I slide into the booth opposite him, unsure how to feel about any of this. I've never shared a meal with someone other than the ten at Vile House or Ghost and my brother at a restaurant. My parents didn't even invite me to family meals growing up, instead forcing me to eat in my room with Killian, who eventually refused everything I wasn't allowed in some show of solidarity.

The deep and slow violin comes from a musician playing in a dark corner, but she's far enough away that I'm not agitated.

Remiel looks as nervous as I am, but I think our nerves are for different things. His blue eyes are big but sketchy, unsure if he should look at me or not, and his palms have not stopped rubbing together. The outfit he's wearing must be new, because the creases and lines from the rack are still on the crisp fabric. A pair of dark jeans that look perfect on his lean legs and a charcoal grey button-up sweater that is too preppy for him but looks nice anyway. Around his shop, he wears Crocs, mostly with socks, so they're still on his feet, bumping mine under the table.

He pushes his hand through his dark blond hair, taking a deep breath. "Do you know what you want?"

I look at him instead of the menu before dropping my eyes to it. When the server comes, she looks at him and not me, and I don't like her eyes on what's mine. He orders, and I just say 'same' to force her away faster.

"What's wrong?" Remiel asks, voice low. "Are you okay after... uh, everything?"

"His whole cult is dead."

He nods to acknowledge that but doesn't focus on it. Which is weird because this is part of the bargain he made with me, and now he doesn't care? What's wrong with him right now? "But what about you?"

"What about me?"

"Krypt," he groans.

"Keegan."

Remiel looks around to make sure no one heard that, and then he does the weirdest fucking thing. He reaches under the table and takes my hand, holding it right there on my leg. The fuck? I stare at him, too afraid to look away and miss the reasoning for this weird act of affection. I like it, but it pisses me off. Does he think I'm weak and in need of comforting?

"Keegan," he says, fingers moving through mine. "Why'd you walk away from me last night?"

"Why do you care?" I tilt my head.

"Because I want to make sure you're okay."

"I'm fucking fine. Jesus." I almost pull my hand away, but fuck... I can't. To touch him is as grounding as it is infuriating. "You aren't my hero, Remiel. Stop acting like it."

"I don't get you." He's the one to remove his hand, and I almost flip the table when he does. "You act like you own me. You won't let anyone touch me or look at me. But I can't be the same for you?"

"You're not being possessive. You're being soft, and I don't... respond to soft."

But maybe I want to. Maybe I can. Maybe I want Remiel to touch my hand again, and maybe I want to touch him back.

A bowl of soup and half a sandwich are placed in front of each of us, glasses of water set in the middle of the small table. The server leaves just as quickly. I don't pay attention to what kind of soup it is, but I eat it just to shut myself up. Hungry or horny? Or something else?

“Fine,” Remiel snips, picking up his spoon. “We won’t talk about it. We won’t even acknowledge it. We won’t comment on the fact that I said I wanted you, and for whatever reason, you couldn’t handle that.” He looks at the slices on my neck, the ones that started our game of confessions. “And we won’t even think about the knife you made me hold to your throat *while you fucked me*.” He almost shouts the last four words.

The restaurant goes silent, and my fury builds. I never look away from Remiel’s eyes, and he never looks away from mine. He’s drawn to my monsters, and right now, he’s rattling their chains so hard they’re bound to break loose.

“Careful, Remiel. Downtown Moros isn’t where you want me breaking free.”

Finally, a spark of something other than worry and pity lights up his blue eyes. It’s defiance and his craving for a challenge. “You keep threatening that, but I’ve never seen you crack. Starting to think it’s all talk.”

Did I do this to him? Did I manipulate and control him so well that I turned him injurious? I’ve accidentally controlled people before and turned them into something they aren’t, which was how I got the sociopathic diagnosis, but my brother does that better, and Remiel is smarter than that. Why does he willingly goad an insane man?

“I’ve never cracked?”

“Not that I’ve seen.”

“Is this another attempt to get me to kill you, Remiel?” I ask.

“No.”

“Then what the fuck do you mean? What I’ve already done to you isn’t cracking?”

“No,” he scoffs. “That’s just you.”

Just me. “Think back. Think of everything I’ve done to you. Think hard, Remiel, and don’t remember it all with rosy sex glasses. I’ll wait, and when you’re done, you can let me know where your goddamn morals are. Because I don’t get it anymore.”

I’ve locked him in a bargain that will never free him. I’ve forced him to watch a girl die, and then scared him so hard he pissed himself. I raped him over her body. I burned his home and his vehicle. I stole his identification. I made him homeless and trapped him with me. I drugged him multiple times. I sexually assaulted him again. I tattooed him against his will. I

forced him to show his body to me and ignored his sexuality. I hunted him through the streets of Moros on Initiation Night. I've secluded him and kept him from his family and friends. I turned him into a killer. A murderer. Then ditched him when he needed me because he's developed some sort of attachment to me.

An attachment I refuse to believe is anything other than Stockholm syndrome.

I finish the soup without tasting it and push away the sandwich. Remiel is still eating, thinking, recalling our short history and trying to decide what he thinks of it.

"Eat that," he tells me, nodding at the sandwich.

I raise my brows.

"Eat it. I know you don't eat enough."

I pick it up and rip a bite from the sandwich, shoving his in front of him as a demand for him to eat, too.

"It was the night you tattooed me," he says, taking a small bite. "The night you showed me who you are. I started meshing *that* you with *this* you."

That makes no sense, so I keep chewing.

"Keegan has been in my life since I was young. I've always been scared of you. I never really knew why, other than you being super intense. But now that I know you... fit somewhere, it puts me at ease or something. Keegan became Krypt," he whispers, "and it..."

I wait.

"It suits you. Moros needs you."

"But you don't." I didn't mean to say that, and I look away as soon as I do.

"No, I don't," he agrees. "But we're not acknowledging that I want you, so I'll move on." He takes another bite and chews slowly. "The reason I like that you became someone else and found where you fit is because it makes sense to me. I've never fit. And then I made a stupid and completely suicidal bargain with you, and you treated me like absolute shit."

Where's he going with this?

"And brought me to fucking life. You taught me to fight back. To bring forth my darker parts. To let them out because you can handle them. You scare the shit out of me, Keegan, but you make me feel more alive than I've

ever been before. So, yeah, my morals are all messed up, but I still have them.”

“Just not when it comes to yourself. You’ll let me do anything to you, and that’s not fucking sane, Remiel.”

“Then I’m not sane.” There’s that crazed, almost manic edge to his eyes again, and I don’t like seeing it there. I want him sick and twisted, not internally dark and able to self-harm.

I lean forward, peering into his eyes, trying to decide if he has inner monsters, too. “What’s it gonna look like to you when I finally snap? After everything I’ve done, what’s cracking mean to you?”

Something entirely too dire passes through his gaze, making alarms go off inside me. “Am I important to you?” he asks.

I clench my jaw, distracted by something I should be noticing but am not.

He’s disappointed with my lack of answer, so he sighs. “I don’t know what it looks like when you snap, but here’s what it looks like when I do.” His smile is tepid but monstrous. “Guess we’ll find out what’s stronger. You or my curse.” He lifts his hand, holds up a single pill, and swallows it.

FAILURE

KRYPT

EVERYONE HAS a moment in their life that changes them. That warps the trajectory of their path and sends them down a road they never meant to walk on.

This is mine.

Because Remiel is my path, and now he's trying to force me down a different one. I won't fucking let him. Because I missed the signs. For how raptly I pay attention to him, I confused his trip to damnation with his trip to a finite ending, and it all circles back to me. I left him last night, and now he's leaving me tonight.

I'm good in a crisis, but... this is Remiel, and I'm choking on panic. Fear's sharp claws drag through my insides, scorching me internally while I externally take in the scene.

I know what he swallowed. I even know where it came from. Because there's only one man smart enough in Moros to make a pill for suicide, and he's the only man I know to call for help.

"Krypt?" Director answers the phone while my hands shake. "Where are you? You're supposed to be getting ready for this job at—"

My voice jitters, my words coming out too fast. "How do I stop a suicide pill from working?" I stare at Remiel from across the table, refusing to turn into him from the night of Ophelia's death. I won't experience this second-hand like he did. I will turn back the fucking clock and stop the world from moving forward until Remiel is off death's doorstep and back under my possessive control. He's scared. I can tell he is, but he's also unhinged and doesn't regret it. "And how much time do I have?"

"You take it?"

“No. Answer me.”

“Not long. When was it taken?”

“A minute ago.”

“Get him to the asylum. Now. Where are you?”

“Cauldron.”

“Sending someone.”

I hang up and grab Remiel’s arm, hauling him from the table. When the server tries to tell me I haven’t paid, I fucking snarl at her and keep moving. He’s off-balance and fading fast, the pill zapping his energy and slowing his heart already. I can’t fade. I can’t spiral. I can’t fail him.

The Ambient Raven is too far up the street, and I don’t have time to walk him there to get my vehicle. Remiel’s legs start giving out, so I hold him up with one hand and pull a gun from the back of my pants with the other, pointing it at a pedestrian getting out of his car.

“Keys. Now.”

She locks up in fear, but another vehicle screeches to a halt on Death Row. “Get him in! Now!” Glitch yells, and Facts hops out of the passenger seat to open the back door for me.

I haul him into my arms, carrying Remiel, and climb in the back with him, his body already weakening. When Facts climbs in the back with me, I snap at him.

“Fuck off.”

“Open his mouth.” He opens a small vial. “Hurry!”

I prop Remiel’s head on my lap and force his mouth open, letting Facts pour black sludge down his throat. Remiel chokes, coughing some of it back out, so Facts slaps a hand over his mouth until he swallows. We’re speeding down Death Row towards the asylum when Remiel groans and chokes up more black liquid.

“He’s going to throw up,” Facts says. “White pill should stand out if his vomit is black.” Does he carry charcoal around on him in case something like this happens?

He does throw up, and the charcoal makes it foamy, but I don’t see a white pill. I don’t see it! And I’m panicking. I’ve never panicked a day in my life, but I don’t know how to stop this. I don’t know how to beat this curse and keep Remiel in my world. *I don’t know. I don’t know. I don’t know.*

I have a fear now. It’s losing Remiel Sauder.

“Fuck you, Remiel! Fuck you for being the worst hero!” I smack his face and he throws up all over my lap. “Fuck you!”

I try to hold him still to stop his shaking, but I blink when Facts touches me. I’m the one shaking, and I’ve never felt more helpless. Because Remiel is still now. His body isn’t moving, and he’s not throwing up. His eyes are rolled back, his eyelids open, and I shake harder.

“Remiel!” I scream in his face.

Because his six minutes were cut in half by that pill, but it’s me who is experiencing a highlight reel of all my regrets.

I should have paid more attention to him. I should have seen this coming when he acted differently today. I should have taken that mad sheen in his eyes more seriously, and I should have let my brother and Ghost help me. I should have treated him better, showed him how strong he is, proved to him he’s important to me so he never had to ask. I should have answered all his questions instead of goading him about what it means for me to snap.

Because this is it. I’ve snapped. If Remiel leaves this world without me, I will follow him all the way to the pits of Hell and stalk him there until he knows what punishment really is.

Because I got attached. I don’t know what love is, but I know what obsession is, and Remiel is the focus of my life. I’ve never had an obsession quite like him, and the loss of it feels too much. It’s impossible. It’s wrong. There’s no longer a Krypt if there isn’t a hero.

For how trained and experienced I am in emergent situations, my body is not reacting like it was taught to. I can’t catch a full breath, the shaking is unbearable, and the pressure filling every cell of my body is going to suffocate me in fear and loss.

I have something worth losing. I barely got to fucking grip it in my fist because fate took it away from me, and to mourn is to die. I’m dying with him.

“Remiel,” I beg. “Look at me! Focus on something. Don’t you fucking die.”

“One minute,” Glitch shouts from the front. “Facts?”

They talk, but I don’t hear them. Because Remiel’s chest is going nuts, his heart beats both too fast and too slow, depending on the second. He jerks, spasming violently, and I break completely.

“Remiel.” I hold him still and try to force him back to my world. “Don’t you fucking leave me here! Wake the fuck up!” I smack him, trying to jar

him back to my side of the white light.

My vision blurs. Wet and glassy.

“Epinephrine!” I shout. “Someone give me an EpiPen!”

No. No. No. No.

How fucking dare he test me like this?! How fucking dare he show me that I’m not as strong as his family curse? How fucking dare he try to leave me when our bargain is not yet met and my monsters were just starting to warm to him?

I haven’t freed you, Remiel!

Am I important to you?

I should have said yes. I should have admitted it. I should have told him that he’s everything to me, even though I don’t know what it means. I’ve never regretted anything, but I regret this. I regret my bargain and my obsession. Because it fucking hurts!

Pain lances through me from everywhere. Ten million stabs just in my heart and a trillion more everywhere else. My vision blurs and my head pounds, and I’m begging. I’m begging him to stay, but I’m begging the devil not to take him.

“He’s mine!” I roar, my voice different. Jittery but dead. My fingers dig so hard into his skin, but he doesn’t react. There’s no pain left. He’s not feeling anything because he’s gone...

“No!” I smack him. “Remiel!”

The SUV jolts to a stop, and my heart stops with it. Someone tries to rip him from my arms, but I’m snarling at everything and everyone. And then a needle pricks my neck and Remiel is taken from my clutches.

“Here.”

I’m dizzy, but I see needles and instruments and IV lines being hooked up to my broken, dead hero. I see something go down his throat. I see his body jerk. I see pads and stretchers and wires and bodies.

It’s all a mad blur. A nightmare come to life. I never thought my biggest fear would be the death of a person because I’ve never given a shit about life and death and the people in it. But I do now. I do because Remiel is mine, and I’ve never had anything worth protecting. I failed him, just like he knew I would.

I’m clutching at air, stumbling to get to him, angry at the world for tainting him so wholly. For making me such a failure. I’m dizzy with

wishes and overwhelmed with grief that I haven't given permission to consume me yet. Not yet. Not yet.

Don't fail him. "Remiel."

Don't take him from me.

Don't. Don't. Don't. Please, give him back. "Remiel."

"Krypt." Ransom is right in front of my face, gripping my head. "Trust me. Got it? Fucking trust me. I promise you."

Then everything goes black. I die with Remiel.



WHEN I WAKE UP, I'm more furious than I've ever been. More terrified than I've ever been. More panicked and more broken.

And chained.

"Remi! Someone get me the fuck outta here! Where's my brother!"

I blink away the haze and see Ghost chained next to me. We're in the cells of Vile House, chained to the fucking wall like a pair of possessed men.

I bolt upright, almost passing out again at the suddenness of it. "Remiel?" I ask him, voice distorted. "Where the fuck is he?"

"You fucking bastard!" Ghost snarls, spitting at me. He's close enough that he turns his rage on me, the chain around his wrists loose enough to be manipulated.

I don't fight it when he wraps it around my neck and pulls it taut from behind. Because I'm ready to die. I'm done here. Ready to move on to a new world with Remiel. Because there's no point in being here anymore. Not in Vile House, not in Moros, and not in this world. Without my purpose, I'm a shell, only filled with unkempt guilt and unbearable grief that makes me angrier than I've ever been.

Kill me, Ghost. Kill me, Soren. It'll be a favour.

Electricity crackles in the air, and then we're both tense and spasming on the stone floor of the cell. Not even electrical chains can jar me back to life. When the shock stops and the tremors fade, I stay there and stare at the ceiling, feeling nothing but death.

Not even numbness. No, I'm too guilty to feel numb. I don't deserve numb. I deserve pain and suffering, emotional turmoil, and unrelenting shame. Because I failed him, and now Soren has to suffer the loss of another brother and prepare for his death next. Because I'm stupid. I made a deal with a Sauder man and thought myself stronger than his curse.

How fucking dumb have I been? I'm not strong. I'm pathetic. Fucking useless. Good for nothing but harm and death, and that's exactly what I did to Remiel. I killed him when I told him I wouldn't.

I became obsessed with him quicker than I realized. I ruined him so thoroughly that I've ruined myself.

Ghost is crying next to me. I've never seen him cry before. Not even when his dad and brothers died, but he's doing it now, and it sinks me further into shame. I don't know if I'm capable of crying, but to know I've made him weep for the loss of yet another brother is enough to gloss my eyes with something wet.

His hand jerks, landing on mine, and he doesn't move it. He keeps it there, his palm on the top of my hand, and continues to hyperventilate next to me. I spread my fingers so his fall through them, and he doesn't fight it.

I killed his brother.

I killed his last remaining brother.

I killed the person he was trying to save.

I killed his last hope of beating the curse.

I killed his pride by proving to him that he's not strong enough to end the curse either.

I've never been sorry before, but I am now.

"Both of you," someone shouts, banging against the bars of the cell. "Look."

Neither of us lift our heads. I don't think I can. I can't even move because I don't want to move. I'll fade away right here and fight my way through Purgatory to get to wherever Remiel ends up.

"Suit yourself."

Beeping, rushing, frantic voices and medical orders come from a speaker, but Ghost and I both jolt into a sitting position when Remiel's cry of anguish joins the sounds. Seven stands outside the cell with a tablet aimed at us, showing Remiel being revived. Ransom is there, doing something to Remiel, and Director is handing him vials and syringes, and there are lines and wires everywhere.

Then Remiel coughs again. My cracked heart cracks even more, creating a fissure so wide the two halves will never go back together again. I don't know if it's relief I feel or something stronger, but the guilt is still rampant.

Seven clicks out of the video and opens another one. Remiel, on a hospital bed in the asylum, hooked up to a heart monitor that shows his is still beating.

“He made it. Thanks to Ransom.”

Ghost cries out in relief.

But that numbness I said I wasn't worthy of has enveloped me in an unwanted hug.

Because Remiel is alive, and I can never see him again. If I do, I'll kill him for trying to leave me. With the loss of grief, fury takes over.

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NOT EVEN DEATH, REMIEL

REMIEL

I ALWAYS THOUGHT that when I went mad, it'd be this obvious trip to insanity, like I'd recognize when it was happening. I've been bracing for it all my life, so it's not like I didn't see it coming. I just didn't see it coming *like that*.

It wasn't a slow build or an iconic downfall. It was fast and jarring, there in an instant, and poisoning my mind faster than I could apply the antidote. It was like a wasp sting. It hurt so fucking badly when it happened, and I was aware it had happened, and then... the burn spread. The sting of it was so harsh that I never stood a chance of fighting it off. Healing it. I turned black and couldn't find any light.

I wonder if that's what it was like for my brothers. My dad.

My youngest brother struggled for so long, trying to avoid the curse but not strong enough to withstand it. Gregory Malone pushed him over the edge. He differed from me, but still snapped in a second.

Our middle brother seemed fine one day but not the next. He flipped on a dime, but his death didn't come until weeks later. Because we watched him. We protected him. We knew, and we tried our hardest. In the end, it wasn't enough.

My dad was happy. He reached middle age and defied the odds of so many Sauder men before him. I think he was hopeful. He felt defiant and powerful that he'd beaten those odds, and because of that pride, he didn't notice when it snuck up on him and ripped it all away.

But me? I had business to accomplish, and my business was not yet done when the curse infiltrated my mind and turned me suicidal.

I killed Reeven Matterson, but that's not why.

I fell for my rapist, but that's not why.

After my beers with Cain, I laid awake in his spare bed and couldn't turn my mind off. Because everything came at me all at once.

My mom is chipped and brainwashed. My brothers are dead. My dad is gone. My uncles and cousins are dwindling by the year. My life has no purpose. I made a stupid bargain with Vile House because, like my dad, I thought I could stop it. I thought I could entice a killer into murdering me. And that's what set me off. Krypt won't murder me.

And I no longer want him to.

Because my newfound hope for life became more important to me than ending the Sauder curse, and that makes me selfish like I've never been selfish before. I fooled myself into thinking I could enjoy him until death eventually claimed me, but I've been lying to myself for days now.

I'm not just enjoying him. I'm dragging him down with me. I'm choosing him over saving my family.

The flipped switch of my priorities overwhelmed me.

I left Cain's house before dawn, slinking through the streets of Moros until I found what I was looking for. A nurse. A guy who is a respectable professional at the asylum but deals prescription medication in the dead of night. I went to him for something to numb me, knock me out, turn me off for a few days.

And it was there, in the back of my head, the knowledge that I shouldn't trust a nurse who steals medications from insane asylum patients and medical cabinets. *I knew*. I knew there was a very high chance that what he gave me wasn't what he claimed it was. That's why I waited. I didn't take the pill. I cried on a bench on Death Row with the crows as my allies, and then I went to work to snap myself out of it.

All the while, that white pill that *apparently* promised numbness was in my pocket, taunting me with a deep sleep uninterrupted by overthinking thoughts. A reprieve from the madness swirling uncontrollably inside me.

I was born doomed. My aunt told me that when my mom birthed me and saw that I was a boy, her face fell. Mom knew. She knew having a boy was a death sentence, so from the very beginning, she treated me as one. She loved me in increments. Instead of letting me capture her heart, she protected it from the eventual heartbreak she'd feel. I don't blame her. If that many Sauder boys died early, I'd do the same thing if I found out I had a boy.

Actually, I'd never have kids. I'd end the Sauder bloodline altogether.

But because of my gender, my parents never made me important. My teachers knew I'd kill myself at some point, so they never put much stock in my education or advancement. I mean, what's the point when it's all leading nowhere, right? I don't blame them either.

I've never had a meaningful relationship, have only one true friend who doesn't believe in curses, and have a strained relationship with my remaining brother. A good but distant relationship with my sister.

Until Krypt. Who made me his world. For deranged reasons, sure, but it was the first time I'd ever been important. And I think that's why I want him. Because I'm Remiel Sauder, unimportant and destined to die, and apparently, I'll take attention in any form I can get it.

And Krypt's attention is all-consuming.

I hate how weak it makes me that the first chink in my well-maintained armour was him walking away from me on the stairs. The first kiss of poison stung my brain when his back tattoo disappeared upstairs.

The poison spread when I talked to Cain and admitted that my entire foundation had changed because of a man who turned his back on me.

The bright spot in all of it was what Riot said to me. About how Krypt doesn't know how to feel feelings, so he'd need a minute to process. But while I gave him that minute to process, I also processed.

I'm a sick man with an attention issue.

I developed a level of codependency with a killer who treated me like his property.

I put my life in his hands, and he protected it against my will.

I went from being Remiel on a mission to protect my family to Remiel selfishly obsessed with my own needs. And when Krypt showed up at the shop, I got stupidly hopeful again.

Krypt has a trigger word.

I have one now, too.

Important.

Am I important to you?

He couldn't even answer, and in the blink of an eye, that spreading poison dripped into every fissure of my brain and spread through my bloodstream.

I swallowed the pill because if I'm not important, there's no point anymore. That's what my poisoned mind told me.

I just wanted to scare him. Force him to tell me how he feels about me.

I felt weird less than a minute later, knowing that nurse fucked me over. I had no idea what I actually took, but the honest fear in Krypt's eyes made me regret swallowing it. Because right there at that table, with his phone pressed to his ear and the words 'suicide pill' coming from his mouth, I *knew* I was important to him.

I regretted it. He was right. It is regrets that go through our minds in our moment of death, and right then, I regretted nothing more than scaring him.

I told him that wasn't our dynamic, and I meant it. He's supposed to scare me. I'm not supposed to scare him.

"Hi, bestie."

I turn my head in slow motion, the room taking a second too long to shift focus with my eyes. Next to my hospital bed, a young guy with ice-chip eyes full of absolute craziness stares at me. I don't think he knows he's smiling, but it's there on his face, making him eerily friendly.

My throat burns and my voice is weak when I ask, "Bestie?" I cough, and this guy holds up a cup with a straw to my lips. He sits right on my bed, hip digging into mine, not understanding personal space or indifference. We don't even know each other.

"Yeah," he says happily. "I knew it from the moment you came to our house. We're meant to be besties, and I've waited so long to tell you. Literally forever."

I take a sip when he forces the straw through my lips. "Do I know you?"

He points to his hair, tinted bubblegum pink, like that should mean something to me. When his hand waves around in front of his face, his smile stretches impossibly wider. He bends down, nose literally touching mine, and whispers, "Pink mask. Kyd Kopitar! Nice to officially make your acquaintance, bestie."

I try to pull back, but he leans in with me. "Oh. Uh, hi." Kyd. The energetic one.

Kyd sets the water down and forces me to move over so he can lie next to me. He crosses his ankles, sighs at the ceiling, and puts his arm behind his head. "So, I've always wondered. What's death like?"

I attempted to kill myself, and this is not how I thought my wake-up would go. The entire length of his body is pressed against mine, and he's humming something under his breath. His energy is optimistic and happy,

and even though I don't deserve it, I want it. He feels nice to be around while my mind is so dark.

"Did I die?" I ask.

"Yep. For like three whole minutes. Maybe four. I stopped counting the seconds out loud when Ransom told me to shut up. He's rude like that, but I love him. He's my other bestie."

I bet everyone is his bestie. "I don't know," I answer him. "I think I got trapped in some place that told me how stupid I was. Like it shoved my regrets at me and nothing more." I cough again, and Kyd's hand lands on my chest to rub gentle circles. I... weird.

Kyd nods his head on my pillow like that makes sense to him. "I figured."

"Did you?"

"Well, this one time, I tried to drown myself in Gamble Lake just to see if I could see Hell, and when my breath stopped and my brain died, all I could think about was how I regretted not getting my dick tattooed. I'd always wanted to, but I'd never done it because I couldn't come up with the most awesomest design. So that ran through my head, and I think it's what brought me back to life. It tracks."

He's ridiculous. I don't even... "Did you do it?"

"Get my dick tattooed?"

"Yeah."

He sits up. "Wanna see?" He puts his fingers into the waistband of his bright yellow pants.

"Uh, maybe later."

"Right. Right." He offers me another megawatt smile before lying down again. "What'd you regret? No dick tattoo?"

I laugh despite the direness of my situation. "No dick tattoo."

"I know a guy," he says. "I'll hook ya up."

"Thanks." When I cough again, his hand comes back to my chest, relaxing me enough to admit the truth. "I regret almost succumbing to my family curse, but mostly, I regret how much it'd hurt my brother and how bad I scared Krypt."

Kyd snorts and laughs way harder than someone should after a suicide attempt. "Yeah, those losers are currently locked in the basement because they went fucking feral."

"What?"

“Lil baby Ghosty and Krypty. We had to lock them up in order to save you. They were just getting in the way and being irrational because of their love for you.”

Love.

I shake my head, unwilling to believe that.

“What’s it like to be loved?” Kyd asks.

For whatever reason, that’s my tipping point. My eyes well with tears and my chest cracks open, the poison of the past two days spilling out of me and rendering me weak and broken. He doesn’t say anything as I cry, but he moves to his side and cuddles me like... like we’re actually besties.

I let him because I need it.

Dr. Cooper comes to check on me, asking about where I got that pill. I keep my mouth closed about it until my brother storms into my hospital room, demanding to know who gave it to me and why the fuck I did it. Kyd stays by my side the whole time, flashing his teeth at my brother like he’d rip out his throat for upsetting me. Guess I really do have a new bestie.

I told him the name of the nurse who gave me the pill and explained that I went for something else. Soren left as Ghost, eyes shrouded in the promise of death. Cain came by, bringing me something to eat from the Midnight Diner, crying with me and promising me that I’m stronger than my family curse. He was mad at me for not going to him and made me promise to always go to him. I don’t think it was empty.

I talked to a psychiatrist. About suicide and my mental state. I got a therapist. I got placed on a seventy-two-hour watch. I’ve tried it all before, the therapy and the help, but maybe this time will work.

Krypt never came.

Dr. Cooper sits at the side of my bed. He kicked Kyd out, and now I’m propped up on pillows, unsure what to make of this man or why a pharmaceutical scientist has such an interest in my case.

“They call me Director,” he says, draping his lab coat over the back of his chair.

“Who does?”

“The Vile Boys.”

“Oh.” I frown, unsure what that means. “You’re... what?”

“Vile House has been in my family for generations. My grandfather and my dad were both Director during their lives, and now it’s mine. I own and

run Vile House, Remi. Since you're now with one of my boys, it's time you learn who we are."

Literally nothing is what I think it is. My whole life is a fib. Moros is a mystery.

"My great-grandad used to work at the old asylum here. He was a psychologist, and he helped make Vile House what it is today."

"Which is what, exactly?" I ask.

"A family secret, I suppose. Just another dark society in the history of Moros," he says with a sigh. "But I like to think we do good. Good for Moros and the residents of Moros."

"Virtue in lives exchanged," I whisper.

He offers me a small smile. "My boys might be a bit unconventional, but they understand what virtue is. It's their mind frames and genetic makeup that give them the ability to create goodness with vile acts. It's not perfect, but I think Moros is better for it. Do you?"

I'd never really thought about it before. But Krypt and the rest of the Vile Boys helped me end a cult that did nothing but harm, so maybe I see his point. They got a sick thrill out of it, but the town will prosper without the Matter Cult. Vile House has always been a silent partner, a place to go for help, even if it's feared.

"I think I do."

He smiles again. "Remi, I created that pill you were given."

"Why?" I gasp.

"It's supposed to be for medically assisted death that isn't sanctioned by the hospital. Or, in the case of Vile House, it's a safeguard. If the ten are ever taken, they always have it as an option. But listen to me, Remi. None of them ever, in the history of Vile House, even before my specific pill, have taken it. They're stronger than that. But... I worried about Krypt over the past few days."

My throat clogs. "Is he okay?"

"He's very much not okay, but he will be." Director sighs. "He's a complicated person. I've been working with his doctors for years, and none of them have ever come up with a perfect diagnosis for him. Krypt sees that as a fault because he wants to understand himself, and since his bargain with you, he's... I think he feels seen and understood for the first time."

"By me?"

He nods. “Yes, but that also scares him. He’s hidden himself so well that drawing out all his parts takes time. Krypt has two settings when it comes to feelings. Absolute numbness, or complete overwhelm. You overwhelmed him, and when he gets overwhelmed, he’s not a pretty person to be around.”

“He doesn’t want to be around me anyway. He hasn’t...”

“Would you believe that’s for your own good?” he asks. Director stands, and the sympathetic smile on his face breaks me even more. “He asked me to give you this.” He sets an envelope on the bedside table. “Vile House is at your back, Remi. Now and always. You struck a bargain, and we will always see that through. Rest up.” With another smile, he leaves me alone in my room.

I’m terrified to open the envelope. Terrified that it will be a goodbye.

It takes me an hour of pure anxiety to even touch the envelope, and an hour more to open it. When I see the purple calling card, I cry so hard I soak my gown and stain the front of the card.

Please don’t break me, I pray before flipping the card over.

Not even death, Remiel.

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PLAY, REMIEL

REMIEL

WHEN I FINALLY DRESS IN Kyd's too-bright clothing, I stand at the door of my hospital room and peer into the hall. It's dark, not a populated area of the asylum, and to be honest, it creeps me out. It's movie-stereotypical. It reminds me of the asylum season of *American Horror Story*. If I had to guess, the weather outside would be stormy and ominous. Tumultuous, like my heartbeat.

I like horror shows, books, and movies, and I grew up in Moros, so it's not like my life doesn't resemble one, but it's never felt more real than right now. Not even the night I ran during initiation or hunted a cult through Vile House.

I step into the hallway and peer into the darkness. I swear something is looking back at me. Squinting, I try to make out the shapes and the sounds, as if squinting helps my hearing, too. The light above me flickers fluorescent, but ten feet down, the shadows eat the shapes.

I blink, unfocusing my eyes. I see it. Something silver and pulsing. Thrashing. Monsters trying to rattle their chains and break free from their confinement. He's here. He came. Because...

Not even death, Remiel.

Not even death can take me from him.

The calling card is in my pocket because I'm sentimental about it. It might not be verbal proof that I'm important to him, but the sentiment is implied within his four words.

"Do you hate me?" I ask the hallway, my voice timid.

"Worse."

I swallow, fiddling with the card in my pocket. As much as I wanted to see him over the past few days, a part of me thought it would be tender. That he'd look at me with something deeper than ownership in his eyes. That he'd want to make sure I'm okay.

But now that I'm facing him, even though I can't see him, fear is the reaction that feels right. Krypt scares me. I'm comfortable being afraid of him. I crave it, even. He told me that if I fell prey to the family curse, he'd end my bloodline. Technically, I died for three minutes, so I broke my bargain with him. I worried him. I scared him. I chased him away by wanting him. I got soft with him when he doesn't respond to soft.

And I have no idea how he's going to react to any of it. He's had three days to process it, but Director implied he stayed away for my own good. My own good mustn't be the priority anymore.

"What's worse than hate?" I ask, sweating.

"Indifference," he says.

Oh. My face falls and my heart sinks. He's right. At least hatred is a strong emotion. Indifference means nothing, and if he feels nothing for me... my breath comes out shaky, and I stare at the refraction of the flickering light on the laminated tiles. They're chipped, the stone floor peeking through every crack.

"Why didn't you just let me die then? Is that really how you feel?" I ask the floor.

"No," he says, the word so finite it jars me and makes my stomach flutter. "Whose hero were you trying to be, Remiel?"

I'm the farthest thing from a hero. I can't even call myself a martyr, because if I'd died, Soren would be next, and the Sauder curse would live on to wipe out every male in my family.

"I'm no hero."

"Finally, you listen to me," he says, and I can't see him, but I *feel* him take a step closer to me—many steps. I guess my sixth sense didn't die during those three minutes. "How fucking dare you, Remiel."

I startle when his voice comes from behind me, his breath on my neck. I shriek so loud it echoes down the hall, but before I can turn around, his arm wraps around my neck from behind and his palm presses to my throat. When his fingers wrap around the sides, I come back to life for real. His threatening touch is still a touch, and I've missed his hands on me.

“I told you that you were mine.” His voice is more abrasive than normal, shaky and uneven. “I told you not even death could take you from me. I fucking told you what would happen if you gave in to the family curse.”

I shake against him, my back to his chest. My body is weak from spending days in bed, but my mind comes back online like he’s woken it from the dead. With the permission of his nearness and the timbre of his voice, my brain wires all cross and spark back to life.

“Why’d you do it?” he asks, tightening his hand on my throat. “Are you seriously that fucking pathetic? That you need my attention so badly that you’ll kill yourself if you don’t get it?”

Anger flares to life and joins my fear. “Fuck you.”

“No. Fuck *you*, Remiel.” He chokes me. My hands latch onto his wrists, but my prying does nothing. Krypt’s lips land on the side of my neck, tasting me hesitantly. “Am I important to you?” he asks in my voice. “Am I important to you? Am I important to you?”

“Krypt,” I choke.

“Guess we’ll find out who’s stronger. Me or you, Remiel.” He presses a soft kiss to the side of my neck, and then he shoves me so hard my face smacks off the wall on the opposite side of the hallway.

Blood fills my mouth and nose, dripping over my lips. My ears ring and my head spins, eyes not yet sure if they can focus. I grab at my face, turning to find him, but what I find isn’t Krypt. It’s only the sickness within him.

His monsters have finally snapped free from their chains.

This. This is what it means for him to crack.

“Good luck,” he says in a voice so wicked my bones rattle. Then he laughs, and fear like I have never known skitters through me with such ardour that I know I don’t stand a chance of surviving him.

I have better odds of surviving the asylum.

So, I run. I run, and this time, I don’t fucking look back.

I don’t know these hallways and can’t navigate their maze in the dark. Fear makes me fast, but terror clouds my judgement, that cognitive distortion is back to make me stupid. I’m sick of running from him. I’m sick of being hunted by him. I want to stop, face him, lift my chin and own up to what my body wants from him.

But I’m not suicidal anymore, and I know I won’t survive the monsters that have broken free from the confinement he so carefully kept them in.

My Crocs are worn and slippery, barely any traction left, and the outfit Kyd brought me puts me at a complete disadvantage. I'm bright yellow and hot pink, and not even the dim hallways conceal me. So I stop aiming for the light. I run down darkened corridors, ignoring the eyes I feel peering at me from the windows in the doors. I don't know what back alley part of the asylum we're in, but I know I won't like what I find behind those doors.

Krypt's monsters aren't the only ones surrounding me.

"Pretttyyyyyyy."

I shriek and sprint past the voice, grabbing the wall to vault around a corner. I come face to face with a woman in a hospital gown. Her stringy hair conceals her face, but her milky eyes glow at me, and her toothless smile rivals Kyd's.

"Friend," she says.

I almost piss myself again. I keep running, my legs already tiring and my lungs protesting every breath. At my back, Krypt stalks with casual grace. A horse still abiding by the reins but champing at the bit to break free from the lead line. The woman behind me hisses, shrieking in fear, which means Krypt is closer than I think.

A green glow lights the passage ahead. I turn in the opposite direction, avoiding the light in order to find somewhere to hide. I'll never make it out of here, and I can't outrun him, but maybe I can hide. Maybe I can crawl into myself, hold my breath, and wait him out. He'll get bored eventually.

Right?

I find an arched entrance and slow my pace as I walk through it. The stone walls have changed, becoming older and more damaged. Along the walls, metal rings are bolted into the stone, chains and manacles hanging from them. A waiting area? A prisoner area? What the fuck is this place? I reach out to touch a chain, snapping my hand back just as fast. If I rattle them, I'll rattle Krypt.

The longer I walk, the more chains there are. At least nothing is tethered to them anymore. The manacles are free from necks and wrists, but their history scares me.

The narrow passage ends at a wooden door, iron bars acting as a window. I glance behind me, totally trapped now, stuck in a passageway with no comforting exit. He's somewhere at my back, but this door doesn't promise refuge. It's a trap, and I've led myself into it.

The sensation of spider legs skitters over my goosebumped skin. The stone surrounding me chills the damp air, but the darkness beyond the door is colder. A chilled sweat sticks my shirt to my lower back, and no matter how many times I swallow, the lump in my throat never goes down. I wrap my fingers around the bars, hesitantly leaning forward to peer through the slats in the door.

Absolute blackness.

I look over my shoulder towards the corridor.

Absolute darkness. I'm trapped in a living nightmare.

The only light comes from me. Because the fucking shirt I'm wearing has a glow-in-the-dark unicorn on it, and I built its charge by standing under the fluorescent lights for so long. I try to rip the hoodie off to turn it inside out, but as soon as I pull my arm through the sleeve, I go still. Footsteps. Coming closer. Coming from everywhere. At my back and beyond the door.

Oh, fuck. *Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!*

A terrified whimper makes the lump in my throat worse, and I can't fucking breathe! Panic chokes me, and I don't know where to run. I'm trapped among manacles, a dark hall, and a door that promises something worse. And I'm glowing, drawing it all to me.

"Krypt!" I scream, losing my mind. "Please!"

Please, what? Please help me? Please save me from whatever else is stalking me? Please end me now because I can't stand the thought of walking through that door?

I scorn myself for screaming, drawing attention to my position, but I can't help it. Fear has me irrational, and no matter how hard I try to steady my breathing and calm myself down, sobs of terror escape from between my lips. I cover my mouth with my hand, pressing my back to the door. I slide down it, trying not to cry, trying to get my bearings, trying to fucking think of a way out of this.

Because fear is the feeling that felt right when Krypt was my focal point, but now that I don't know where he is, I don't like it. I don't want it. I can't handle it.

I'm a prisoner to it because I put myself in a position to be afraid of *everything* when all I want is to be afraid of *him*. Only him.

I pull my knees to my chest and bury my face in my hands, completely giving up. I'm ashamed of how pathetic I am. Trapped in a madhouse with insane patients and a demon haunting me, I lose myself to fright so hard

that I can't even rationalize the dread eating at my nerves. It's all-consuming, making me shake and shiver, bawling into my hands because this is it. This is the madness. The *true* madness. The one that every male in my family surrenders to.

Back in my hospital room, I recognized that taking the pill was wrong. I felt a spark of hope when Krypt sent the calling card to tell me that not even death will take me from him. Where'd that hope go? I'm right back to spiralling because...

I took a suicide pill and survived, but I won't survive this.

I'm about to succumb to the Sauder curse.

I belong here, in this dark, abandoned ward of the asylum. This is exactly where I'm meant to be, but I'm fresh meat and haven't yet learned how to live among the others. I'm crippled by the panic of it. Of them.

I cry so hard my head pounds and my body uncontrollably heaves. Those regrets are racing through my mind again, clouded by terror and stomped on by failure. I didn't want to become another statistic, but here I am, lost in an asylum, losing fragments of myself and no longer fighting to live. I don't know what's going to kill me first, the monsters hunting me or the promise of reprieve if I take my life into my own hands. I've given up. Again. For real this time.

Looking up, I find a long length of chain hanging from the wall next to me. I could loop it through the iron bars in the door, wrap it around my neck, choke myself to near death and then let it take me wholly. Maybe I'd get to listen to the rattle of my lungs and be fascinated by it like I was with Ophelia. Maybe my calves will twitch and my eyes will bulge, and when Krypt finds me, he'll stand there and count down my final six minutes.

My life isn't mine anymore, anyway. I have nothing to live for, and I'll never be important to anyone. Krypt might possess me, but he doesn't actually care about me, so what's the fucking point? My brother has Vile House, and my sister... she has my brother. They'll be better off without me, and so will this world.

It's time. Time to go.

Crying harder as realization dawns that this is my finite ending, I reach for the chain. There's no game of chance this time, not like with the pill. I know exactly what I'm doing now.

But I don't get the chance. The door at my back opens, and I scream bloody murder as I'm yanked through. Consumed by darkness. By fear. By

fate.



TIME PASSES and I'm aware, but I'm so lost in my own internal safe place that I don't feel what's happening to me. I've retreated, trusting my mind more than my reality, and that's the most horrific thing. Because my mind isn't sane and it promises me no safety.

My eyes are open, my head tipped back on the hard back of a wooden chair. In the cathedral-like ceiling of yet another chamber, the moonlight filters through a grate, letting in the cold autumn air along with it. I see it. I don't know what it means. I don't feel it.

Until I'm jolted back to life by a shock so intense my jaw clenches and my muscles spasm. Electric currents turn me rigid and jumpy, and the pain of it is so strong I hiss through my locked jaw.

"Play."

My body sags when the current turns off. My jaw unlocks and the taste of blood fills my mouth. My thick and numb tongue is bleeding, but I don't have the energy to swallow the blood. It drips down my chin along with my drool, and I struggle just to breathe.

"Play, Remiel."

I cough, barely able to lift my head. I sag in the chair, but when my legs twitch, something is between them. Closing one eye to look, I find a cello there, propped against me to keep it upright. It's not just any cello, it's mine. The one I keep on display in my shop and only play when I'm melancholy and afraid.

Groaning, I force myself to sit straighter, still scared but less so because I know Krypt is the one demanding my music. I look around the dark chamber, noticing I'm the only thing spotlighted by the moon. The corners are dark, and Krypt lurks within one.

My fingers twitch around the length of a bow, and despite how infrequently I play anymore, it's second nature. The instrument between my legs is comforting because I've spent so much of my life playing it, using it to speak instead of saying words, letting it convey everything inside me, bringing it to the outside.

Moments ago, or maybe hours, I almost killed myself again. Now, I'll play. Because it's the only thing I know how to do.

I sit straighter, gaining movement and energy as the buzz of the shock wears off. My crotch is wet, but I barely pay it any mind, too far gone to worry about dignity. I don't know what to say or how to speak to Krypt, so I'll let my music do the talking.

I clear my throat, grip the bow, and hold it to the strings. My left hand comes to the fingerboard, positioning the cello how I like it. Familiar. Comfortable. Safe. I don't know what he wants me to play or why he even wants me to play at all, but my fingers naturally find the strings they want to start on, and my bow brings them to life.

I play.

Through the sound of my music, I tell Krypt how sorry I am. I let him feel my sorrow and despair. I bring to life the depth of my darkness and the absolution of my doom. I show him how helpless and afraid I am, and how cynical I feel towards everyone, but mostly myself. I cry when my fear comes through the notes, blending into the harmony that signifies my pain. Because pain is at the very root of everything.

It fucking hurts. It hurts to be a nobody. It hurts to own a music shop that feeds a town's needs, but to have none of my own needs met by the town. It hurts to be a Sauder. It hurts to have lost, to have feared love, to have lived half a life on the outskirts of sensation. It hurts to know I've wasted my limited time here, never getting close to anyone or experiencing anything great. It hurts to amount to nothing. And it hurts to know that when I'm gone, the accumulation of everything I was will narrow down to the words 'friend, brother, son' on yet another headstone in a long line of them.

I play harder.

I express sorrow and shame. Malice and anger. Terror and foreboding. I play it all for Krypt because he's the only person listening. I play for so long that my fingertips bleed and my shoulder burns from moving the bow. My tears have turned dry and my heartbeat has settled into something as melancholic as my mood. The lump in my throat eases, making my voice want to join my music. But I don't let it. I don't trust the lyrics.

When the emotions are purged from my soul, my bow falls away to hang at my side, the tip resting on the stone floor. The shaft of moonlight has moved, highlighting me from a new direction and marking time passed.

My fingers slide down the fingerboard, shrieking soft notes before blanketing me in silence. Because there's nothing left to say.

I sit and breathe. Just breathe. Not seeing. Not feeling. Not rationalizing. But living. Alive. For now.

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I FEEL

KRYPT

REMIEL STARES at where I'm standing, but he doesn't see me. Even if I wasn't concealed by shadows, his eyes would not register me. He's purging himself of his demons, half dead with the effort of it. Now, it's my turn to scare him back to life. Living for real this time.

I step from the shadows and approach him, removing the cello and the bow from his fingers. He doesn't move or acknowledge me, but when I crouch in front of him, his eyes meet mine. I've never seen them so empty.

"Life hurts, hero," I tell him, absolutely hating him in Kyd's clothing. "Going to live it or give it up?"

He stares, blank-faced and void.

I grab his wrist and haul him to his feet, and he lets me steer him to the edge of the cavernous room. The asylum has many old stories, and this chamber is one of them. Tiered, circular seating lines the circumference, but it's dark and unseen for now. I push his back to a gate, and when he still doesn't respond, I tether him to it with a set of shackles. His wrists bound to it beside his head. He still doesn't react.

But when I strap a metal collar around his neck and latch it to the bars of the gate, his eyes shoot up to meet mine.

"What're you doing?" he asks, voice timid and pathetic.

I hold up a knife, letting it glint in the moonlight so he knows it's coming. "It's in your bloodline, right? The curse?" I cut open the hoodie, slicing through that disgusting glowing unicorn. I rip it open and cut it off his arms, watching his skin pebble with goosebumps. All his abs flex, coated in sweat and grime that darkens his skin and makes it glisten.

"Only the men," he answers, watching me with indifference.

The shirt falls to the floor in tatters, and my name on his collarbone sates me slightly. Remiel swallows against the rigid collar, watching my eyes while I undo his pants and force them down his legs.

“And you are a man. A Sauder man.” I grip his soft cock for the first time, liking the weight and warmth of it. His breath shudders and his chest heaves, but he says nothing. “A Sauder man with the Sauder curse.”

“Yes,” he whispers.

“Want to surrender to it, Remiel? Or do you want to fight it?”

The metal manacles rattle against the gate, and Remiel looks at me with false hope in his eyes. “It can’t be fought. It’s... like you said. It’s in my blood.”

I press the tip of my blade to the hollow of his throat, just below the collar. “This room used to be a viewing room. When the asylum was new and they were experimenting with medical procedures, they’d bring insane patients here, believing that their sicknesses were possessions. Schizophrenics were possessed by demons, so doctors brought in exorcists to purge them.”

His blue eyes meet mine, glossy with tears that won’t fall. “I didn’t take you for a history buff.”

It almost makes me want to laugh that he’s so delirious. He’s naked, chained, and has a dagger pressed to his skin, but my interest in history is more pressing.

I hum to agree with him. “But those who were truly mad were considered tainted. Their blood was poisoned. Guess what they did to them, Remiel?”

He wets his lips and sucks his teeth. “Bled them.”

“Bled them,” I repeat, moving the dagger down his sternum. When I pass his navel and shuck it up to the base of his cock, he looks straight at the monsters in my eyes and hardens against the blade.

“Are you going to bleed me of my bloodline? Drain me until I’m no longer a Sauder?”

I grip his jaw and press the knife tip against the base of his cock. “You *are* no longer a Sauder. That happened the night you became mine.” I squeeze his cheeks and pop his lips open, letting my spit drop into his mouth. “You already contain so much of my DNA, and ownership is nine-tenths of the law, so by that standard, you’re fucking mine, Remiel. I took

your identity the first night you walked through the front door of Vile House, and you haven't been a Sauder since."

He swallows, wetting his lips again. "Then why am I still cursed?"

I slide my hand up his face and weave my fingers into his dirty hair. It's limp and greasy, darker than usual, but still silky and thick. I give it a tug, tipping his head back until the metal digs into his Adam's apple.

"Because of me," I admit to him. "I drove you mad, didn't I? When I wouldn't tell you how I felt. When I didn't answer your question. When I forced you through the maze of a long-forgotten ward of this asylum. It's all me."

"On purpose?" he asks, panting harder. Dick harder.

I release his hair and pet his cheek. "Not on purpose," I admit to another fault. "But this, right here, what we do tonight, will very much be on purpose. And when you walk out of here, alive and mine, your blood will be purified and you'll give your life to me for real. Your whole life, and so fucking help me, Remiel, if you try to end it early again, you will not like who I turn into."

"Krypt," he whispers, but I don't know what it means. It's a plea and a promise, tainted by a lie and wrapped in fear. "It's not all you. It's me. I'm the broken one."

I push the other side of the gate open, stepping through it until I'm at Remiel's back. Admiring him from behind, I can't help but grope his ass through the bars, smacking him red and strengthening my claim over him. When we leave here, he'll be marked so thoroughly by me he won't even know who the fuck he is anymore. He'll be able to build a new identity under my possessive watch.

Because I need him to *want* to live.

I grab the cart with my supplies, pushing it back to the front of the gate. While Remiel panics, looking at everything on the cart, I dip through the gate and fill the space with ignorant screeches as I drag a metal fire pit across the stone surface. Hot coals and glowing embers already smoulder within it, and I add a few pieces of wood to bring the fire back to life. It warms the space and casts a flickering orange light to see by. It licks in Remiel's blue irises. I've been planning this for three days, and now I'm ready to purify him as much as I tarnish him.

He's scared. Of the fire and the instruments I shove into the coals. Of the tattoo machine and the pot of black ink. Of the swath of fabric, neatly

holding blades ranging from surgical precision to serrated hunting knives.

His dick flags a little, losing interest as anticipation wins out. “What are you going to—” He presses his lips together. He doesn’t want to know what I’m going to do to him. Instead, he meets my eyes and says, “Fix me.”

I offer him a real smile. “You’re already fixed, Remiel. Now you just need the reminder.” I jostle the handles sticking out of the fire, making sure each tool is properly heated. I’ll let them sit a bit, starting with a different tool. “Look at me.”

He rips his eyes from the fire and looks at me.

“You *are* important to me.”

A tear falls down his cheek.

“Being important to me is not an easy thing to be. It’s going to hurt. It’s going to hurt so much more than it feels good.”

He nods, swallowing and crying. His breath puffs out his nostrils in harsh pants.

I pick up the tattoo gun and dip it in ink. Art isn’t my forte, but calligraphy and letters are. I’ve practiced with the tattoo gun, but Remiel’s skin is the only living thing I’ve inked. I trust myself enough not to need a stencil tonight, because every mark I make on his body is meant to be harsh. Every single scar he gets from this night will remind him who the fuck he belongs to and what the fuck he has to live for.

Me. Him. Us. Whatever the combination of us creates. A sick bargain that’s become a way of life.

“I don’t need your permission, Remiel. But do you give it to me?” I hold the tattoo gun and motion to the cart with every tool on it. I’m asking, and that has to count as growth because I’ve never asked for permission before.

“Will it hurt?”

“Very much.”

“I...” He meets my eyes. “I trust you.”

“You shouldn’t.”

I push the metal collar up to his chin and tip his head back until it hurts. He winces, but the first prick of the needles against his throat shuts him up, only drawing forth hisses. He bites back questions about what I’m tattooing, and I’m so focused on the work that I barely notice his cock hardening against my thigh right away. I smile to myself.

“That pill went down this throat,” I explain, dipping the gun. “This part of your body is forever tainted. Every time I look at the way you swallow or the bob of your throat, I’ll shatter. Because it broke me, Remiel.”

“I’m s-sorry,” he cries.

“Shh.” I keep him still until the word is done. Single letters from the top of his throat to the hollow at the bottom. Dark and black and bold, uneven and unmatched.

I set the machine down and pick up a blade from the middle of the cloth. It isn’t surgical, so it’ll leave a rough scar, but I want it to. Beneath the bottom letter of his new throat tattoo, I dig the tip of the knife in.

“It travelled down here.” I slice Xs into his skin, small and straight down his sternum. “Down your esophagus and into your stomach, and I’ll never forget the look in your eyes as it travelled through you. Because I saw it.”

“Saw what?” he asks, voice pained. He’s sweating a bit now, too.

“You knew. Ghost told me you thought it was a sedative, but I saw it in your eyes, Remiel. You knew it wasn’t.”

He sobs softly, his memories hurting more than my carving. “I didn’t know for sure, but I knew there was a chance.”

When I reach the bottom of his ribcage, my column of Xs complete, I move the blade down to the area beneath his navel. I look at his face, so anguished, and then I slice from hip to hip. “They pumped it out of your stomach and had to give you medications to counteract the ones shutting you down.”

He twitches and screams in pain but never takes his eyes off mine. I kneel in front of him and watch the wound leak blood down his pubic bone and over the base of his cock. It passes his dick, and a few drips leak down his balls and thighs.

I press on the cut and lean forward to lick the blood off his cock. I haven’t tasted his cum yet, but the rust of his blood and the hardness of him against my tongue make me thicken in my pants.

“I’ll bleed every last drop of your blood until you believe the curse is gone. I’ll drink it all, consume it, and take the curse for myself.” His cock bobs in front of my face, twitching on its own and leaking clear fluid from the tip. I lick that too, letting it light a fire inside me. I bury my face against his groin and drink him in, licking and sucking until my face is covered in his blood.

When I look up at him, he's flushed and sweaty, but terrified and turned on, too. I suck his dick into my mouth, spreading precum and blood along his shaft. The feeling of a dick in my mouth is new, but to consume him is my nature. I might be in charge of him, but I want to worship him.

"Krypt," he groans.

I stand again, setting the knife down. The cut isn't deep, it's just a bleeder, so I'll leave it open for now. The ones on his sternum are leaking a little but mostly drying. The collar around his neck bothers me. I don't want it rubbing against my letters there, so I unclasp it and drop it to the floor. His head hangs forward as he pants shallowly.

"This next one is going to hurt, hero. Bite down on this." I hold up a strap of leather, but Remiel doesn't bite it. "Remiel."

He looks at my eyes. My lips. My eyes. My lips.

"Ask for it," I dare him.

Sweat drips down his temples, and his tongue runs over his bottom lip. "Please."

"Please, what?"

He leans forward, making the manacles rattle. "Please... please kiss me."

To kiss is to consume. It's a claim. A chance to steal oxygen and mingle exhales. The only times I've pressed my lips to his have been to devour brutally. He's already brutal tonight, so I lean in slowly, teasing my lips against his. I close my eyes and feel his tongue sweep out, dampening his lips in preparation for mine.

Without seeing him, I feel everything about him. The slight tremble running through him. The sweat on his skin. The thump of his heart under my palm. The shallow pants that leave his lips and the restraint as he prevents them from turning harsher. I'm a twenty-eight-year-old man, and Remiel Sauder is the first person I've kissed.

I bump my nose to his, letting out my own shaky exhale. When he whimpers quietly, his body begging and his dick hard against my own, I part my lips and lean into him. The kiss starts open-mouthed, slow and hesitant. I barely move my lips, but Remiel moves his, making mine follow. He does it again, opening and closing slowly, kissing me with no tongue but every emotion ranging from lust to fear to shame and pain.

I feel it throughout my body. The kiss travels, tingling my temples and filling my blood with a slow-burning flame. It hardens my cock but softens

my heart, slowing time and defying my instincts.

I groan, but it's not a savage sound. It's relief and longing, surprise and mercy. From a kiss with no tongue. A kiss with impact. A kiss that scares me and tastes like blood. Because I *feel* it everywhere. *I feel*.

"I trust you, Krypt," Remiel whispers against my mouth.

I want to remind him he shouldn't, but I can't. I've made myself everything to him, ensured it, even, and his trust means more to me than I'll ever be capable of conveying. "This is going to hurt, hero."

"I know."

He doesn't know. He might mean everything with me is going to hurt, or he might mean the end of this kiss is going to hurt. Either way, he's right. I press my mouth to his one more time, savouring the taste of his docile need, and then I pull back. Tonight will be brutal; tomorrow, we'll attempt something softer.

"Are you ready, Remiel?"

"Yes." He looks at me with wet eyes, dazed from gentle intimacy.

I unclasp the hook of his right arm, sliding it along the bars until his arm is outstretched beside him. Hooking it back, I run my fingers over the scar left by his mother. The suicide mark he bears but did not draw. I'm going to cover it.

"Pills and hanging," I list the two ways his brother and father killed themselves, looking at his neck. "Your throat and your neck are now mine. Wrists are next." His other brother cut himself and bled out right on the plot he was meant to be buried in.

"What? You're... covering all the ways I could kill myself?"

I step over to the fire, moving the handle of a poker around. "Bite this." I hold up the leather again.

He shakes his head, but he does it. His eyes widen in extreme fear when I pull the tool from the fire. It's large and glowing red. Without giving him a chance to protest, I line it up with the inner length of his forearm, spanning from wrist to halfway to his elbow, meet his eyes, and press the hot metal against his skin.

Remiel cries out, muscles flexing, veins bulging, and hand fisting. His eyes leak tears as he squeezes them closed, and drool drips down his chin and around the leather. The brand hisses against his flesh, the smell of burnt skin ripe in the air. When I pull it away, the first few layers of his skin come with it, and I throw it back into the fire.

Remiel's eyes won't focus, the pain too intense.

"Look at me, Remiel."

He's hyperventilating through his nose, barely able to keep his head up. He looks at me, lashes wet and stuck together, his jaw locked.

"I enjoy the way you hurt, hero. Do you like pain?"

He shakes his head weakly before it slumps forward. I remove the leather from his mouth and lift his chin for him. "It's not pain," he rasps. "It's fear."

"I know what turns you on," I tell him. "Pain does nothing?"

He shakes his head again, and I notice his cock has once again softened. "Pain feels negative. Fear feels like..."

"Living," I finish. "One more time. Open your mouth."

He begs me not to, but I shove the leather between his teeth, and he clamps down all on his own. He's crying harder now, and when I pull his other arm taut, pressing the second brand there and pulling it away, he hyperventilates so hard he passes out. His head hangs, chin resting against the Xs on his chest, his slobber dripping into the fresh wounds. I toss the brand aside and make sure the last one is nice and hot.

I wish I really could bleed him. Maybe it'd be enough to make him believe the curse was gone, but I don't trust whatever dark magic I possess to bring him back to life, and losing him isn't an option for me anymore. Instead, I'll have to bleed him in increments, cut him whenever he gets close to poisoning himself, and burn the rest of the curse from him. His wrists will be in so much pain, and over the next few days, they'll blister and peel. When they heal, they'll leave a raised scar with my name, and if he ever thinks about cutting his wrists, he'll have to slice right through my brand. I hope it's enough to make him hesitate, to pause long enough to think. To stop. To remember the life he's learning to live.

"Remiel," I say, tapping his cheeks. "Remiel."

He jolts, his eyes wide with pain and his forehead coated in sweat. The leather falls from his mouth, and he groans in agony.

"You're almost done, hero. One more burn."

"No," he begs. "No more burning. No. Please."

"One more burn," I repeat. My hand rests on his chest, pressing my warmth into his heart. I look at his wet, scared eyes and tell him something personal. "You called yourself sick, and until you said it, I'd considered the word... an insult. But if you're sick, Remiel, if whatever pumps through

your heart and coats your brain is a sickness, it's a fucking blessing. Not an insult." I pick up the leather strap and hold it in front of his mouth. "I want you, too, Remiel. I pick you, too."

He chokes out a weak sob, still drooling.

"And I want your sickness to meet mine, and whenever we get too tainted and Moros can't handle us anymore, I want to die sick with you."

When his lips part on another cry, I shove the leather between his teeth, grab the last brand, and press it to the skin of his left pec.

SICK

Remiel taught me to relish the word instead of fear it.

He screams through the gag and drops almost to his knees, hanging by his wrists. While the tool is still hot and coated in his burning skin, I free his weak arm, press the handle to his palm, and pull off my shirt. "Right here, Remiel." I point to my heart.

Even though he's crazy and delusional, or maybe because of it, his fingers wrap around the handle and his eyes meet mine. He can barely hold it up, but he stands, forcing himself to his feet. The leather falls from between his teeth. He breathes hard, and his eyes focus on my chest.

"Sick," he whispers.

I help him press the brand to my skin, and the pain of it connects our damned souls for all of eternity.

PLAYING REAPER

REMIEL

I WADED THROUGH LIFE NUMB, thinking it was living. I got comfortable being distant, protected myself and those around me by being indifferent, and quit everything I tried because there was no point. I was going to die by my own hand eventually, so I never put forth much effort. I quit school. Didn't make more than one friend. Kept space between me and my family. Focused on music and the shop because they were the only guarantees before I died.

Krypt has brought me back to life by making me hurt. Numbness isn't living; being battered and bruised is. It's a feeling, and in my new mind, it means I'm fighting. There isn't a part of my body that doesn't ache. Muscles I didn't know I had protest my every movement. My eyes burn from crying, and my throat is coated in fiery ice from screaming, raw and ravaged.

But I bleed from everywhere else. My wrists are coated in a healing balm and wrapped in gauze, the same as my chest. The brands still burn, but the cream helps. The slice on my lower stomach now holds stitches, and sometime after I passed out, Krypt must have cut me more because I have stitches near the femoral arteries in my thighs, next to the pulse point under my jawbone, and on my forehead where my hairline sits. Just little lines that tug at my skin. He's marking all the areas of my body that could shut me off, giving me a chance to second-guess my actions before I do something dire.

It's sick and twisted... but I think it might help. If I ever get suicidal thoughts, I'll have to go through his marks to accomplish the task, and as disgusting as that makes me, it gives me a level of comfort and relief I've

never experienced before. A layer of protection in the form of unwanted scars.

But it's the word trailing down my throat that shocks me most. Because it's personal. For him. The S starts under my chin and the R ends at the hollow of my throat. The word 'shatter' in bold, mismatched letters, the R accidentally marked over with a sliced X.

This part of your body is forever tainted. Every time I look at the way you swallow or the bob of your throat, I'll shatter. Because it broke me, Remiel.

He's admitting that he cares about me enough to shatter at my death, and seeing it now, reflected in the mirror of his bathroom in Vile House, a new wave of tears leak down my cheeks. I'm important to him. It doesn't matter that it's ownership and possession. Apparently, I don't need more than that. I just need someone to fucking care. Someone who isn't my brother, suffering from the same curse. Someone who isn't my sister, who is trying to save me. Someone who sees the parts of me I keep hidden and lures them to my surface, enjoying them instead of fearing them.

Until Krypt claimed my bargain, I'd never been seen before.

It's heavy and terrifying, but it's welcome anyway. It's proof that I have a role, a purpose, and a life worth living. We're twisted together in such an unhealthy way, but I think it's saving our lives. My life, anyway.

Even my teeth hurt when I brush them, crying into the sink because I'm emotional without understanding why. My gums are tender and my jaw aches with the rest of my body.

"Remiel," Krypt's abrasive voice isn't jittery today. I turn to look at him standing in the doorway, his face a mask without wearing one. Even though I'm only wearing boxers, he never looks away from my eyes, and right now, I don't fear the monsters in his.

"My mom called this morning," I tell him. "She's acting weird again. She told me some doctor is waiting to meet me." Which confused me because my mom doesn't know I spent a few days in the asylum.

Krypt's brows pinch. "What doctor?"

"Dr. Grave... Grey, maybe," I say, looking at the burn on his chest. It matches mine. We really are both sick.

Recognition of the name crosses his face before he wipes it away. "Come. I need to check your wounds."

He's showered, my blood no longer coating his face. I don't know how long it's been since he chained me to that gate. Maybe it's the next day, or maybe many days have passed. I'm unsure, but I know he hasn't left my side. I slept for a very long time.

I sit on his bed while he puts new salves and wrappings on all my wounds. But it feels strange to call them wounds when they did so much healing. "You don't have to watch me if you have things to do," I tell him.

"You're the only thing I have to do right now," he says, focused on his task. "And we have the next name on your list to deal with."

Gregory Malone. My creepy stalker who wants to push me to an early grave and ignite my family curse. I almost beat him to it. "What are we doing with him?"

"We're going to the funerals today," he says, soft fingers coating my wrists in ointment. "For the Matter Cult members. Malone will be there."

If I had the energy, I'd snort at the fact that Krypt is going to the funerals of all the people he killed. My perception of the world has changed since walking through the front door of Vile House. Moros has always been dark, but it's darkly humorous now, and I don't care what that says about me.

"And since you announced to everyone at Cauldron that I fucked you," he pauses, eyes meeting mine, "we're going together. As a..."

He's afraid of the word. "As a...?"

He wraps my wrist in new gauze. "Get dressed, Remiel."

"I don't own funeral attire. You burned it in my house."

He nods at a black bag hanging from the door of his closet. "Wear that. Eat this." He picks up a bowl of fruit and yogurt from the bedside table. "Find shoes that fit in my closet." He pauses, a sneaky expression on his face. "There are *a couple* of options." He leaves his bedroom.

A couple.

Is that what we are? Not a very healthy one.



COMPARED TO OTHER CULTS, the Matter Cult was small. But twenty-one funerals at once does not seem small. The Moros Cemetery is

packed full, but I'm getting the impression that most of the townsfolk are here to say 'good riddance' rather than to mourn.

Gregory Malone is here, watching me from the back of the crowd, but Krypt isn't watching him as closely as I thought. He's not Krypt today. He's Keegan Hallows. We're Keegan and Remiel, the new gossip couple in Moros. Soren is on my other side, but the two of them are acting weird. Because they're watching my mom instead of Gregory Malone.

She's here, dressed in the same black cloak as the rest of us—it's a Moros funeral tradition. A bit on the nose, but what in Moros isn't? Selena, my sister, is standing with her, but something has changed about my sister, too. She's more confident, standing straighter, looking at the townsfolk like she knows their secrets. My mom is beside her, watching everyone but the cult being buried, but her eyes are strange and her movements are twitchy.

"What's wrong with her?" I ask my brother.

Soren hasn't seen my new Krypt-inflicted body modifications, and I hope he doesn't until they heal. He's been moody today, fighting with Krypt's brother about something, but as soon as we got to the cemetery, they separated and put it to the side. He leans towards me but never takes his eyes off Mom.

"Don't go near her," he says.

"Why? The brain control thing?"

"Yes." He glares at me. "Keep your voice down."

Ever since Krypt told him I mentioned Dr. Graves, they've both been stuck to my side.

"Who is he? Dr. Graves?" Because I know they both recognize the name.

Soren glares again, but Krypt tightens his hold on my wrist, fingers pressing into my new burns. I wince and shut my mouth. Apparently, this isn't the place to talk about it.

I still don't know all the identities of the Vile Boys, but some of them are here. Killian, who is Riot, stands with Mason, the tattoo artist Cain goes to, and the blue mask of Vile House. I don't know much about Mason, but his eyes are so alert that it makes me wonder... how long has he been Menace, a Vile Boy? And why? What drives someone to join such a society? He's staring at Cain, who is with the Death For Life Cult, holding Sadie's hand.

Kyd isn't here, and when I asked Krypt about it, he said Kyd is actually a patient at the asylum, so he's not often allowed out without being masked.

As I look around the crowd and notice the locals, I take them in under a new light. Anyone could belong to Vile House, and until I learned about Keegan, Killian, and Soren, I never truly considered the people I knew could be Vile. Now the options are endless. I should feel naïve about everything. Instead, I feel like I've been let in on a Moros secret. This town is fucking deranged, but... I think I love it here. Somehow, I finally feel like I belong.

Black cloaks and a massive crowd, seeing off a cult that did this town harm. Crows and ravens cawing throughout the cemetery. The line of Sauder headstones and the forest I watched Ophelia die in. There's something sinister about Moros. It breeds dark people, but it also creates a community of tainted loyalty. We might be twisted, but we're twisted *together*, and if Moros is good at one thing, it's protecting our town from outside influences. We need to change, but we don't want to, and I smile in enjoyment of our defiance.

As Reeven Matterson's wife starts to play the oboe while the caskets are lowered, violins and other string instruments join her. Soren places a hand on my chest. I wince, eyes watering at the pressure on my wounds, but I don't pull away.

Krypt pushes him away and pulls my back against his chest. "Don't."

Soren shakes his head and rolls his eyes. "Fucking pathetic. I'm going to talk to Mom. Don't leave his side."

"Don't tell me how to protect him."

"Fucking pathetic," Soren repeats. He backs away, drawing the hood of his cloak up over his dark blond hair, his lithe, leanly muscled body slipping through the crowd seamlessly. He shares a look with our sister and then speaks to Mom.

She doesn't even register his nearness. "Something is getting worse with her, right?"

"Yes." Krypt's voice is by my ear.

"Who is that doctor?"

In a deep timbre, Krypt whispers, "Do you remember the name Axel Graves?"

oh. *That* doctor? "He was a young doctor, wasn't he? He died a few years ago."

“Not dead,” is all Krypt says, cutting off the conversation. He draws up my hood, covering my head, and keeps me in front of him. I close my eyes and listen to the harp music that has joined, feeling every area Krypt’s body touches mine. He doesn’t react when I lean against the brand on his chest, but his hands dip into the open slits in my cloak.

Tugging on my hips, he pulls me back until the hard outline of his cock presses against my ass. My eyes open and my cheeks heat. Everyone is watching the oboe and the harp and the women mournfully playing them, but I’ve never felt more exposed. With Krypt behind me, the feel of his dick against my ass, and his body so obviously connected to mine, my eyes dart around to see if anyone has noticed.

Soren has, but he sighs and looks away.

I’ve never come out as anything other than Remiel Sauder. I’m sure the town considers me heterosexual, but I’ve never had a girlfriend either. Then I went and shouted about Krypt fucking me while in a restaurant, and this is Moros, so gossip travels fast.

Everyone knows. Everyone will know. They’ll know I’m being fucked by Keegan Hallows, but they have no idea he’s the man behind the purple mask. For some reason, I get a thrill out of being deceptive and sneaky. My body heats more, the flush spreading from my cheeks down my neck and chest, making my brands burn hotter.

Krypt digs his fingers into my hips again, bruising and controlling. I suddenly wish I wasn’t wearing a cloak, but I’m also desperate for the blanketing cover of it.

“Hmm,” he hums next to my hood, fingers slinking forward to brush the hard outline of my cock. The material of my pants brushes against the cuts he left on my thighs, making them sting. “Does it make you feel powerful that you ordered all these deaths, Remiel? That you played reaper?”

My lungs pinch. I haven’t considered that. Here I am, mocking him for attending the funeral of all the people he killed, yet I’m the one who ordered the kill. Krypt is just my hitman. I watch the townsfolk greedily glare at the caskets, but then I see family members and kids who have lost their parents to a savage crime. They think it was a mass suicide, but my conscience knows it was me. Reeven Matterson’s wife plays sombre music with the others, but her eyes are dry and her expression is blank. The family members weren’t lured to Vile House for the slaughter, and now that I’m

seeing their reaction to all this death, I know they're relieved more than they're sad.

Maybe I do feel powerful for freeing his wife from his pernicious influence. I lean back against Krypt, and his hands slide to my middle, cupping my cock in his palms. "Would it make me horrible if I said yes?"

He hums confirmation, squeezing my dick. "Horrible. Isn't everything here horrible?"

While he rubs and works me up to a temperature that radiates blue flames, I look around again.

Mist and fog hang in the air, but it does nothing to cloud the corruption of Moros. It adds to our appeal. There are gangs and societies, murderers and stalkers, adrenaline junkies and thrill seekers. There are those who believe in removing the veil between here and the afterlife, and there are others who create unsolved crimes just to watch the reporters come to investigate. We're warped and twisted, and yeah, maybe horrible, but not to each other. With the Matter Cult gone, Moros is even more aligned, and that doesn't feel so horrible.

"Not all of it." My eyes shift to Gregory Malone, only to find him already watching me. Maybe Krypt's vile influence is getting to me, but I grin at him, and I know it's a disgusting expression. But he deserves it. "I want to do more horrible things."

"Like what?" he asks, hands inside the slits in my cloak, undoing my pants and forcing his way inside. My cloak covers me, but if anyone cared to look, they'd know what was going on. Thankfully, Gregory can only see my head through the crowd. "Like get off on the fact that we killed these people?"

My hips buck forward, my cock sliding through both his fists. He twists them down my shaft and rests his chin on my shoulder. "Yes."

"Want me to fuck you for real over their corpses this time? No throat assault, but an actual fuck, Remiel."

I imagine it. My palms pressed flat to the wooden coffin, fingertips digging in while Krypt plows into me from behind.

"I could make you cum on Reeven Matterson's casket," he whispers. His voice is gaining that jittery edge again, making me aware that he's trying hard to hold back. "Would you like that?"

"Fuck," I hiss when he pinches the tip of my cock hard enough to hurt. "Gregory Malone," I whisper.

Krypt stops his hands and butts his nose up to the side of my hood. “What have I told you about speaking another man’s name, Remiel?”

Not to do it while naked. But I’m not naked. I turn my face and meet his eyes with one of mine, the other blocked by the hood. “When we kill him. I want to...” Shyness takes over at what I’m about to suggest.

Crows caw, and the harp music changes to something everyone else sings along to. I know the lyrics and have sung them at my brothers’ and father’s funerals, but right now, I’m too busy panting and sweating, trying not to moan when Krypt’s hands move again.

“Say it,” he dares.

I turn my head forward to avoid looking at him. “I want you to rape me over his body.” I hate myself. I hate that I want it. I hate that I used the word rape instead of sex. I hate what it implies and what I’ve turned into.

I’m so messed up. By my family curse. By my upbringing. By Moros. But mostly, by what Krypt has awoken in me. Unfortunately, that thing he’s awoken is my will to live, so I’m either stuck suppressing it forever, or I can fucking own it and not be ashamed. Because Krypt says I’m important to him, and I know he means my sinister bits, too.

Precum coats my dick, his hands spreading it down to the base of my length. My balls are heavy and my asshole twitches, craving the fullness of him barrelling inside me. My knees shake, and my hands latch onto his forearms with the fabric of the cloak between us. Tingles spread in my gut and around my lower back, causing my breath to shudder. Waiting. Anticipating. Nervous about what he’ll say.

“When we kill him, I’ll bend you over his coffin and fuck you so hard you won’t be able to stop crying.”

My teeth chatter and my eyes roll.

“And when my cock is buried deep inside you, and your whole body is shaking in restraint and need, I’ll push you forward and make you come all over his *closed* casket because not even his dead eyes are allowed to see you in pleasure.”

Oh my god.

A lady walks up beside us. I register her but can’t look. I try to angle away to prevent her from seeing what is about to happen.

“And since I’m way too possessive to let him take your cum to Hell with him, I’ll fucking burn his casket, body and all, and fuck you again until he’s nothing but ashes in the wind.”

I choke back a moan and fall back against his chest. My cock thrusts through his fists, and a surge of dark adrenaline pulses hard in my temples. I coat the inside of my pants and boxers in cum, breathing way too hard and only staying upright because he forces me to.

The orgasm consumes me, muffles my hearing, splotches my vision, and makes my head light. Krypt doesn't stop. When oversensitivity makes his touch almost hurt, I dig my fingers into his arm and try to stop him. But I'm no match for him. He jerks me hard, the movement so obvious to the woman next to us that she scoffs and walks away. Pain builds with pleasure, mingling together until I bite into the fabric of my cloak and come again. I cry out loud enough that a bunch of people look our way, so Krypt turns me around and buries my face in his neck.

I'm still shaking when he reaches between us and opens both of our cloaks, his cum-coated hand sinking into his pants. He pulls his dick free, jacking it frantically. I can't see it, but I feel the head of his cock press against the base of mine, and with a hitch of breath and a stilled fist, he adds his cum to my boxers and coats me in his mess.

I don't expect it, but he bites back a groan at the same time his free hand grips my chin and pulls my face to his. He crashes his mouth to mine in an all-consuming kiss that kills me and brings me back to life simultaneously. It's all saliva and warm breath, and fuck, I can't get enough of it. It's the first time he's kissed me with something like absolute desperation, and if he doesn't stop, I'll start to expect it. The slow kiss at the asylum was everything, but this one is *everything else*.

"You will wear our cum for the rest of the day, Remiel," he says against my mouth. "And tomorrow night, when we get Gregory Malone, you'll do so with my cum in your ass."

"Yes," I whisper for no reason. "Krypt."

He tucks us away, making the wetness of my pants more palpable against my skin. With a quick look, he spins me around and makes me walk through the funeral procession to watch all the caskets get lowered.

LOVE IS OBSESSION

KRYPT

I DON'T ENJOY BEING HERE while Remiel is waiting in my bed.

Does it make me a bad person that I tied him naked to my bedposts and then ordered his sister to guard my door as part of her initiation tasks? She doesn't know her naked and hard brother lies beyond, delusional with the need to be ravaged, but I like the symbolism of it. Selena needs to learn her place. Her loyalty lies with Vile House, not her family, and if she wants to make it through initiation, she'll learn that pretty fucking quickly.

Director casts his tablet screen to the white wall of the theatre room. He's standing right where Remiel drove a blade into Reeven Matterson's heart, and the memory of it has my dick so hard Menace notices. He grins but doesn't comment.

"It worked," Director says, looking right at me. "We tapped into your chip."

Remiel doesn't know what's coming, and I don't plan on telling him. He's only just starting to get better from his suicide attempt, and when he wakes up tomorrow morning to find me gone, he's going to need to learn to live without me for a bit.

Hopefully not forever.

While he was healing during his seventy-two-hour hold at the asylum, I was calming down by setting up my tools and working a job for Director—Axel Graves.

After Ghost and I hung the nurse who dealt Remiel a suicide pill, we cut off his hands and strung them around his neck. His cock went next, shoved down his throat. He died slowly, choking on his own flesh, and then we hung him outside Misfit Hall, The Misfits home base, to pin it on them.

From there, we walked to Ghost's mom's house and stayed there until we got information. She muttered a lot about Dr. Graves, and eventually, she said something about a trailer, pop-up style clinic for depression and mental health treatments. It moves around, peddling therapy appointments for those struggling mentally, and once we figured out where it was, I went in.

And got chipped.

Dr. Axel Fucking Graves hypnotized me, implanted a chip up my nose with a tiny wire device, brought me out of the hypnosis, and sent me on my way. My mind is a vault, so the hypnotism didn't work, but I played along until I got the chip. Glitch has been studying it when I'm not with Remiel, and it turns out the chip is simply a tracking device. And now Director has a link to my whereabouts, so it's time for me to complete the next phase of this job.

But if Axel Graves knows anything concrete about the layout of Moros, which, according to Director, he does, he'll mark my tracking dot inside the asylum and Vile House. I played my part well enough, and he believes I'm unaware of the chip.

The only problem is that when the chip is pulled out by force, it releases an electrical shock that pulses through the brain and kills it. So, Glitch better fucking find a way to get this thing out of me, or I'll drag Remiel to an early death with me.

"Feeling anything from it?" Director asks me.

I shake my head.

"Here's what we know. Graves is offering a service, hypnotizing the people who seek it out, and implanting the tracking chip. It gives him a tie to where they are at all times, which means he can track them and access them easily. From what we can ascertain, it appears he's tracking them, catching them while they're alone, and *then* implementing some sort of brainwashing. The chip isn't doing the brainwashing. It's Graves doing it."

Kyd smiles so big it's goddamn blinding. "He's so fucking smart. He's doing it in increments. Chip, find, subtle brainwashing, release, repeat."

We all glare at him for finding this attractive, but really, who are we to judge?

"It's the *why* we don't know yet," Director says. "That's where you come in, Krypt."

"Send me!" Kyd shoots to his feet with his arm raised. "Puh-lease! Send me in, coach. I can *do* this." He does a high kick like a cheerleader for who

fucking knows what reason.

He *can* do it, but because of his fondness for Axel Graves, Director won't send him. He's too warped, and even though I'm also warped, I got my name for a reason, and Director is going to exploit it.

Glitch tugs on the back of Kyd's bright purple hoodie and yanks him to his seat. "Down, boy. You'll get your shot."

"Tomorrow is the plan. We just need Graves to take the bait. You know where to be to appear secluded and approachable, Krypt."

I nod, already knowing the plan.

While Director explains the rest of it and assigns roles to the others, I let my thoughts drift to Remiel's bargain. Matterson and his cult are dealt with. Gregory Malone will be dealt with tonight. I just have to figure out if Remiel has changed his mind about his brother, the third name on his list. Does he still want him captured and consumed by someone so he can't get enough wiggle room to turn suicidal?

Ghost hasn't made any attempts on his life, but I've noticed things about him over the past few months. He's irrational and ballsy, which isn't new, but he used to do it for the thrill. Now he does it because he likes tempting death, and sometimes, the glaze in his eyes makes me think *he* is the one tempted by death. He's got a job to do with The Misfits, but he's even getting brazen about that.

My brother must track my thoughts because he looks over at me and nods. If Remiel still wants Soren contained, I've already made an agreement with Riot to do it. It'll be dangerous, but I don't trust anyone as much as I trust my brother when it comes to this. And who knows how long I'll be under Axel Graves' control. If I even make it out alive...

"There have been at least twelve more reports of strange behaviour in residents," Director goes on. "Monster and Ransom are tracking them, but we still need our man on the inside so we can track your whereabouts and find his lab." His eyes come back to me. "You ready?"

Not until I say my goodbyes to Remiel and finish his bargain. This is the worst possible time for me to go on a job that could end my life, and as much as I don't want to do it, I have to. Because I belong to Vile House. They're my family, my life, and my motivation, and I've let them down before. I won't let them down again. I have to trust that my new marks on Remiel's body are going to be enough to make him hesitate if things get dire.

“Tomorrow.”

“Go.” Director nods at the door. “I’ll see you in the morning.”

The rest stay to work out the details, and I light a joint on my way out back. I need to be calm when I face Remiel. He can’t know that anything other than Gregory Malone’s end is coming.

I step outside, the patio wet and misty. I don’t usually get nervous about jobs, but I’m nervous now. Because I have something to lose. A person to give up. If I don’t free him from our bargain, and it turns out I don’t survive this, he’ll never be free of his curse. I’ve never known possession and obsession like I do with Remiel, so the thought of freeing him doesn’t sit well, but what else am I supposed to do? Ghost will take over his bargain if I don’t make it back. He’ll watch out for him... so long as he doesn’t fall prey to the family curse.

The weed tells my mind to calm, and when I’m blanketed in something that feels settled, I head to my room to find Selena Sauder still standing there. She nods and walks away, but I call her back.

“If I don’t make it back from this job...”

“What job?”

I can’t tell her. She’s not at that security level yet. “I need you to watch out for them.”

“Who?”

“Your brothers. Both of them.”

Confusion lines her face, but relief sags her shoulders. “I am. I do.” She steps closer to me, eyeing my door. “Which is how I know you’ve ruined him.”

My fists clench, and the blanket of calm evaporates.

“Remi isn’t meant for all this.”

“Then you don’t know him.”

Selena nods to agree with that. “No one knows him. Not Cain, not even himself. I think...” she pauses, gritting her teeth, “I think you forced him to get to know himself, and as much as it ruined who he was, it strengthened him.”

“I don’t need the speech. Just watch over him when I’m gone.” I grab the doorknob.

“He won’t survive without you,” she tells me, making me stop. “You made him dependent on you.” When I look back at her, she doesn’t look angry. “So fucking come back,” she finishes and walks away.

So fucking come back.

I know she's unhappy about her brother's best friend suddenly owning her other brother, but fuck her. She sees that Remiel is gaining strength, and I don't need her blessing. But she's right. I did make him dependent on me, and he's going to have to survive me being gone. If anything happens to him while I'm away...

I squeeze the doorknob harder. No point in dwelling on the guilt I'll wither under. I enter my room, but Remiel isn't tied to my bed anymore. Did she free him, or did he get out on his own? If she so much as touched him... sister or not, she's losing a finger. He's sitting at the little desk in the corner of my room, fixing Seven's guitar. Restrung it and tuning it as he goes. I'll never understand how he can recognize notes from each instrument. The piano is the only one I know and understand, and that's because it sat alone in the corner of my bedroom growing up, becoming my only companion.

He looks showered and clean, and a glance into the bathroom shows me the drips sliding down the glass doors. A part of me likes that he's made himself comfortable here, but a predatory part of me, which is stronger, doesn't like that he defied my bounds, either by breaking free or being set free. I also won't appreciate it if he's re-bandaged his own wounds. Those are my marks to cater to.

When I close the door, he looks at me.

It washes away my frustration and softens me to his needs. He's sore, suffering from healing wounds, and I had the fucking audacity to tether him in an uncomfortable position. He didn't even complain about it, but I see the fatigue in his eyes and the discomfort in his body.

I walk to my bed, forcing myself not to crowd him. His eyes track my movement, and his shoulders sag when I sit down. "How is it coming?" I nod at the guitar.

He looks at it like he forgot he was working on it. "Um, good. Almost done, just tuning it." He fiddles with the tuning keys and then sets it on the floor to lean against the desk. "What's... is everything okay?" His brow creases in concern.

"Why are you asking?"

"You're... over there."

I almost grin.

I lie back against the headboard and close my eyes, more tired than I thought. "Then come be over here with me." I kick my boots off and listen to them thunk to the floor. I pat the bed beside me. "Let me look at your wrists, Remiel."

Silently, he sits cross-legged beside me, holding his bandaged wrists out. The t-shirt is mine, and I like that he's wearing it, but I like it even more that it shows off his arms. Toned with defined muscle and skilled at playing cello. Veiny and pronounced, but covered by white gauze. I peel it off, unwrapping it slowly so it doesn't rip his healing skin away. They'll need to air out for a few hours.

"I thought you don't do gentle," he says, watching my nimble fingers.

"I said I don't respond to soft," I correct him. "Doesn't mean I can't be soft."

"Can you?" he asks, a hint of a smile on his face.

I look down at his arm, my smile also trying to appear. Not sure why. "First time for everything."

Glistening blisters that barely leak, mottled red flesh in the shape of my name, and peeling skin make up the underside of his arms. I'm not sorry. I know it hurts because the one on my chest hurts like a bitch, but they're safeguards. Watchdogs. A line of defence that will make him hesitate, even for a few seconds. I can save him with a few extra seconds. I won't let him attempt it again, but if he gets the idea in his head, I feel better knowing my marks will cause even the slightest hint of second-guessing.

The burns are still oozing a little clear liquid, but the cream I've been putting on them is working wonders. "Do you need anything for the pain?"

"Like a pill?"

I look up at him. "Don't joke."

His eyes fall for a second. "Do you..."

"Do I what, Remiel?"

"Do you really give a shit about me, or is it all about ownership and possession?"

"Do you expect more from me?"

He sighs, buying time to plan an answer. "I don't know. Can you feel more than that?"

"Are you asking if I'm a psychopath?"

His lips pinch, but he owns it. "Yes."

I grin and start unwrapping his other wrist. "I've gotten the diagnosis in the past, but no. I'm not. I can feel a full range of emotions. I just confuse them and can't properly label them all the time."

"Give me an example," he says.

"I'm frustrated because you aren't where I left you, so I'm mad, I guess. But I don't know if I'm mad at you or at myself for putting you there while you were so sore. And since I don't know, there's a gnawing feeling inside me that's probably something like regret or the need to apologize, but instead, it just makes me feel hungry. Or horny. Agitated." I look at him again. "Which is actually another source of frustration because, until you walked into Vile House, I didn't really get horny."

"So, it sounds like you can label the feelings and the reasons, they just all blend together into a circular pattern. That's not uncommon."

"No?"

He shakes his head. "Give me another example."

I get the gauze off his wrists and let both of them rest on his knees, palms up. "Do you expect me to love you?" I ask instead.

He squints at me, blue eyes curious. "Why would you ask that?"

"Because we're attached now, aren't we? We're... us. A kouple... with a K. Wherever the fuck the future goes, we're going together. Most people call that a relationship, and relationships come with love."

"You forced us together," he amends.

"You walked in here."

"What's love to you?" Remiel asks.

"I don't know." I shrug. "Obsession."

"Tell me what else you're obsessed with. Any other people?"

"No."

"A thing? A place? A hobby?" he asks.

"Not really." I look around my room. "I feel safe in here, but I'm not obsessed with it. I guess I'm kind of attached to the others, but not obsessed with them. I fixate on things, but eventually, those drop off and become nothing again."

"Is that my path? You're fixated on me now, but it'll drop off?"

"You don't feel like a fixation," I tell him. "You feel like an obsession. But I can't tell what that means. Is love an obsession, or am I too volatile for that?"

Remiel tosses the used gauze to the end of the bed and reaches out to touch me. He hesitates, hand outstretched, eyes on mine for permission. I take his fingers and look at them in my hand. Admiring. Understanding. Feeling.

"I don't think your love will ever be romantic," he tells me. "Romance doesn't do what you did to me. But it's not all one-sided. I did terrible things, too, and they aren't romantic. I think your love is more like consumption. It's fierce and territorial and irrational. Maybe that's not love. Maybe it's just possession."

"Is there a difference?"

He swallows and lets me play with his fingers. "Are we talking about me and you here?"

"Yes."

"Okay, well, do you want to own me and take away my free will?"

"For a while," I admit. "Until you start making better choices."

He laughs, and my eyes snap to his face because... because that's the first real laugh he's given me. *God, it's better than his cello.* "That's fair. I bargained my life away, so that's our foundation."

"But?"

"But," he says. "I kind of hope we... if there is a we, I hope it becomes more of a partnership. It doesn't have to be equal. You give what I need and I give what you need, even if it's unhealthy. Love, to me, is caring enough about someone to know what they need and wanting to give it to them. It doesn't have to be romance and kindness and compassion. It can be rough and unhinged and aggressive if that's the language we speak it in." He looks up at me. "I barely know you, Krypt. I don't know what you need because you've spent this whole time bringing me back to life. So I can't love you, and you can't love me because our relationship hasn't been about each other. It's been about a curse. It's been a deal. It's been about fear."

I don't like that. "So far," I say, and I've never felt more vulnerable than from those two words.

"So far," he echoes with a small smile. "I don't expect anything," he answers my original question. "I just know that I want you. I know you don't want to acknowledge that, but I do. I don't want to hurt all the time." He holds up his wrists. "But I get why you did this. It healed some fear inside me, and I think... I think you gave me what I needed because you care about my life."

“About owning it,” I insist.

His fingers twitch in mine. “This is the first real conversation we’ve had. One without threats and dares and challenges.”

“So?”

“Why now?” he asks, more astute than I gave him credit for.

Because I’m being soft, like I told him. I hadn’t planned to be, but I saw him sore and cared about it. Because I know what’s coming tomorrow, and maybe I craved something sentimental to take with me on this job. Because tonight is going to be dark, and maybe I want a moment of light with him.

Because my concept of love is obsession, and it’s morphing into something that comes with feelings and regrets. I don’t want to go to Axel Graves and live out my final six minutes regretting not speaking to Remiel like he’s a real person instead of an object of my possession. I want him to feel important and hopeful so that, if I’m gone for too long, he won’t kill himself because of it. He’ll be hoping for my return.

But *feeling* isn’t my strong suit. It confuses me, and confusion makes me unstable. It overwhelms me, and when I get overwhelmed, I need an outlet. I’m trying not to make Remiel my outlet.

“What of your bargain?” I ask instead. “Has it changed at all?”

“No. I still want to end Gregory Malone.”

“You know that’s not the name I’m asking about, Remiel.”

He sighs. When he shifts his body, wincing at some of his wounds, to lean against the headboard beside me, I go still. Two men, in bed together, not fucking or sleeping. Not bleeding or crying. It’s new for me, and it feels so good that I close my eyes again to appreciate it.

“I’m not naked, so I’m going to say his name,” Remiel warns me. “Cain thinks that the curse on my family isn’t real. That it just gets in our heads, and Moros makes it believable. We succumb to it just because the knowledge of it is there, putting pressure on us from our very first breath.”

I hate to say it, but I agree with his tattooed friend. It’s a mental state, and the Sauder men allow themselves to get swept up in it. Suicide is real, but a curse that dooms a bloodline seems more like brainwashing.

“Maybe he’s right,” Remiel goes on. “Maybe it is all about pressure and the stories we’ve been told. Maybe all that is mixed in with mental health issues and a hereditary inclination to be dark-minded. Maybe the curse is nothing more than a placebo effect. We’re told we’re going to kill ourselves, so we do. It makes me wonder what would happen if we were

never told about our family history. If the story changed. If our upbringing was different.”

“If you lived somewhere other than Moros,” I add.

“Yeah,” he agrees. His hand drops between our bodies, and his fingers brush mine. Before I can react to it, his knee bends, resting against my thigh. “But it doesn’t change the fact that every Sauder man has died by suicide.”

“You have the same genetic makeup as your sister, and she’s not at risk. Neither are your aunts or female cousins.”

“Maybe it’s like heart disease or gout. More common in men.” He huffs a small laugh. “I don’t know what it is, Krypt, but I’m still scared of it. For me. For Soren. It’s real to us.”

Which brings us around to my original question. “So, what do you want to do with him? Because your plan to entice me into killing you failed, so you need to rethink what your goal is here.”

He takes a long time to think about it. All the while, I fixate my attention on where his leg touches mine. A simple touch. Comfortable. I’m not a man who enjoys being touched in such a way. My hands cause harm and my body is a weapon, but with Remiel’s leg against mine, I don’t feel so dangerous. I feel at ease. So much so that the monsters inside me slumber.

“He’s always been dangerous, but it’s getting bolder. Have you noticed?” he asks.

“Yes.”

“Then I still want him... uh, owned? Watched? Under the influence of someone else.”

“Okay,” I agree.

“Okay?” he asks, knee moving. I reach down and hook my hand under his leg, bringing it back to rest on mine. “Do you have someone in mind?”

“Ghost is a Vile Boy, so he’ll be on jobs a lot. Since you want him watched all the time, and we can’t bring outsiders into Vile business, it’ll have to be another Vile. I’ve already made a deal with one of them to be his shadow.”

“Who?”

“Do you really wanna know?”

He pauses, then says, “Yes.”

“You won’t like it.”

“Tell me anyway.”

“Riot.”

Remiel groans. “I don’t trust that. Your brother hates my brother, and it’s obvious to everyone. I don’t trust him to keep Soren alive.”

“He will.”

“Why?”

“Because I asked him to.” I turn on my side, the burn on my chest cracking with the motion. Remiel looks at me, and I look at him, and whatever else he wants to say falls away into the abyss. This feels like getting my affairs in order, prepping for a future I’m not returning to. I don’t like it, and Remiel can tell. Before he can ask, I cut off his chance. “Ready to end Gregory Malone?”

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SICKER TOGETHER

KRYPT

GREGORY MALONE IS A RARE BREED. He has no specific skills, isn't particularly powerful, and doesn't instill fear in the residents of Moros. Mostly, he's just a creepy guy who slinks through the streets and people ignore him because he's not overly worth noticing. Being known as the creepy guy in Moros says something since we're all a bit creepy, but Malone takes it to a new level.

The one area he excels... evasion. Since getting my calling card in the cemetery that night, he's been even more elusive. He's good at going unnoticed, skirting capture, and avoiding the wrong places at the wrong times.

He won't escape me tonight.

Sitting in the passenger seat of my SUV, Remiel rubs his palms together, eyes alert as he watches the street. "About what you said at the funeral..."

"Which part?" My eyes stay locked on the Neon Demon nightclub. There are only two exits to the building. We're at the front, and Ghost and Menace are at the back.

"Uh, about the ra... sex over his dead body."

"What about it?" My dick twitches.

"Did you mean it?"

I meant it. He was the one who asked for it. But it won't be tonight. Because I made Remiel a promise before that. I guaranteed that Gregory Malone wouldn't know a moment of peace until he died a long time from now. "We aren't killing him tonight."

"Oh."

I look at him quickly, not wanting to take my eyes off the door too long. “Disappointed?”

“He deserves to die,” Remiel says, watching his rubbing palms.

“Does he?”

“Yes!”

“Hmm.” I get comfortable and watch the door. “I think he deserves worse. He’s stalked you, taunted you, made you scared enough to come to Vile House, pushed your brother over the edge, and made it his personal life’s mission to keep the Sauder curse alive. Death is too easy for him. Too finite.”

Remiel says nothing, but the air around him darkens. There’s a saying in Moros about death being a blessing because there is always something worse, and now the gears of his mind are grinding, considering all the things that could be worse. I already have a plan for Gregory Malone, and Director approved it because he needs a lab rat. The Vile Boys approved it because they like having a punching bag. Remiel is going to approve it because he’s sinister and not as innocent as he pretends to be. He wants Malone to suffer, and I’ve become someone who enjoys granting his wishes.

My phone vibrates on the centre console. Pressing the speaker button, I say nothing.

“He’s taking too long,” Ghost says. “I say we go in there.”

“Give the Neon Demon a few demons to celebrate,” Menace adds.

I look at Remiel. I have a mask for him, but if we do this publicly, the town will know that Vile House has Malone. It’s a risk because someone could nark on us, which won’t do anything but cause unnecessary headaches, but this is Moros... the town is loyal to Vile House. We protect them, worship them as much as they worship us, and create a consequence in a part of the world that needs one. No one is going to miss Gregory Malone, not even his wife, so I trust that they’ll spread gossip to one another but not to outside authorities.

“Want to go in?” I ask Remiel.

Staring at the door, his palms stop rubbing and he nods.

“Masks on,” I tell Ghost and Menace.

Ghost whoops and I can imagine Menace’s predatory smile. The Vile Boys do love a hunt. I hang up and grab the masks from between my legs.

“You wear this, don’t leave my side, and don’t speak. No one needs to hear your voice. The club owner will leave the music on, and the flashing lights and dark space will provide cover, but you still aren’t to engage with anyone. Not even Malone. When we get him, then you can have your shot at him. Understand?”

“What if someone attacks us?”

“They won’t.”

“How do you know?”

“Because I’ve been Vile for many years, Remiel. Moros gives us room to work.”

He takes the black mask. “Yeah, but there are a lot of outsiders in that club. They don’t all know about Vile House.”

“When has a Moros resident ever let an outsider dictate what they do? If anyone steps in, the locals will shield us. Put it on and keep your mouth shut.” Before he can, I do something impulsive. I grab the back of his neck, press my forehead to the stitches in his, and breathe him in. “I only just got you back, Remiel. Don’t tempt my control again so soon. Obey.”

“I will,” he promises.

Even more impulsively, I press my lips to his and inhale the soft gasp that leaves him. I savour him. Slowly. Too quickly. Then I pull away and don my mask.

Guns aren’t my favourite weapon, but one is holstered inside my jacket. In my hands, I have twin blades, longer than throwing knives, but short enough to be intimate. I give Remiel a matching one and push him ahead of me through the front door of Neon Demon. He’s at my chest, but the bouncer looks past him at me, granting us access with a deviant grin and a nod of respect, fisting his hand over his heart. The music turns up.

The club is crowded, the dance floor full, and the tables occupied. Across the sea of writhing bodies, I spot Ghost and Menace in their masks. They flank the outskirts of the dance floor, whereas I part it like the sea with Remiel at my chest. Locals notice us and manoeuvre into a position that keeps them safe while the out-of-towners look on with piqued interest but not a fucking clue.

Gregory Malone isn’t the dancing type. He’s the lookie-loo type. Which means he’ll either be at the bar, watching from eye level, or up above, gazing over the mezzanine. I keep one hand on Remiel as we walk, letting my eyes scan the balcony for Malone’s face.

“There,” Remiel says, breaking my fucking rule not to speak. He points at the bar where Malone is standing with his back to us, ordering a drink with no idea he’s finally the one being haunted.

“Silence,” I whisper in Remiel’s ear.

I tilt my head toward the bar, and Ghost and Menace head that way. The music thumps in my chest, and the strobe lights pulse with its beat, the combination both illuminating us and hiding our trajectory.

The bartender, a woman with a scar slashed through her face and a head of wild red hair, notices us. She pours herself a shot, gives a warped smile, and steps back to let us work.

“Hey!” Malone slaps the bar. “Are you going to hand me that?” He points at the drink she made him, sitting on the other side of the counter out of reach.

“Oh, hun,” she shouts at him. “You won’t get the chance to drink it.”

“What?”

We surround him like four dark illusions, shadowing him. Ghost and I face his back while Menace faces the crowd to protect our backs. Remiel is shaking in front of me, but I think his jitters are from adrenaline instead of fear.

The bartender picks up Malone’s glass, raises it in toast, and then takes a long drink. When her eyes look beyond him, he finally gets the hint that something is wrong. For how often he stalks, he sure isn’t familiar with being on the opposite side of the deal.

He spins, coming face to face with a teal and a purple Vile mask and Remiel’s black one. Fear lights up his eyes, and his face pales. Remiel shakes harder. Malone is a survivor. He’s an escape artist. He’s a fucking cockroach. But there’s no escaping this. He glances around, eyes darting to find an exit route that won’t end in his capture, but when his shoulders droop and he looks at us again, he realizes he’s trapped.

“Figured it’d catch up with me eventually,” he says, barely heard over the music.

He succumbs too easily. But that’s what makes it fun. Subtly, I holster my knives and draw throwing daggers from within my jacket. He’s going to run as soon as he gets the chance, and it’s been a while—since the Krampus—since I had moving target practice.

We step back as a unit, giving him space to walk. He falls into the middle of our group, Menace at the front and Ghost and me flanking his

back and sides. Remiel stays at my chest, not needing to be told what to do. I see Ghost's fingers move, dipping into his pockets to pull free throwing daggers.

Menace walks us through the crowd, a straight line to the exit. Locals dip their heads and keep dancing, their eyes on the outsiders, ready to step in if needed. The ones unfamiliar with Moros and Vile House watch with fascination, but so far, no hero complexes.

I dip my head when we get to the middle of the dance floor, mask brushing the side of Remiel's head. "He's going to run. Stay right where you are, hero."

Ghost and I drop back, giving Malone a bit of breathing room. That's when he takes his shot. He cuts to the right, trying to disappear into the crowd. Locals shove dancers aside, granting us an unobstructed view of Malone's fleeing body. Ghost looks at me, his eyes flashing through his mask, and together, we both throw a dagger.

Mine lands in Malone's left shoulder blade. Ghost's embeds in his right. Malone drops to the floor, but he scrambles, trying to get back to his feet. Menace throws the third knife, a bigger, longer one that buries itself in Malone's ass cheek. He goes back down.

Without any more fanfare, we haul him to his feet, touch our fists to our hearts to thank our locals, and haul him out the front door.

"His house?" Menace asks, tying his wrists in a knot only a bondage expert would know.

"Yep."

Gregory Malone ends up in the trunk of my SUV, bound, gagged, and bleeding.

Remiel reaches for his mask, but I stop his hand. "Leave it on. We're being watched."

"That was... that was... fuck! I can't believe we got him!"

I grab his wrist and haul him to my chest. "What part of 'keep your fucking mouth shut' didn't you understand? We're in public, hero. People know your voice."

He shrinks, nodding. I open the passenger door for him and tilt my head at it. When Ghost pulls their vehicle around, I follow them down Death Row.

"Whose house?" Remiel asks now that we're in private.

"Gregory Malone's."

“Why?”

“Because his wife gets a say.”

“Why?”

So many questions. “Because she’s a Moros resident, and we don’t disrespect our own.” I glance at him. “Why’re you shaking?” I ask Remiel.

“I don’t know. Shock, maybe. Adrenaline. It’s... the man trying to get me to kill myself is finally...” He sighs, pressing his hands flat to his thighs to stop rubbing them together. “It’s heavy. In a good way.”

“Cock hard, Remiel?”

His hands shift upward to check. “A little,” he admits. “Is yours?”

“Mhm.” I turn the corner and follow Ghost’s tail lights. “But not because of that. Because of you. Because you’re shaking.”

“You like when I shake?”

“I like when you react.”

“Is that why you... over Ophelia’s body? Because you liked how I reacted?” he asks, brave now.

I nod behind my mask.

“Explain it.”

“When I first saw you notice her, I thought you’d freak out. But you didn’t. You just stood there, and it intrigued me. It excited me when you paid more attention to her wheezing breaths than the fact she was dying. I don’t know, it... fascinated me, so I tried to see if I could jar you out of it.”

“You did,” he admits.

“And you pissed yourself.”

He groans.

“Which was hot. Reactions to fear are... fuck, Remiel. I’ve never loved someone’s fear as much as I love yours.”

“Love,” he whispers. “Obsession.”

I ignore that.

“I lost my mind and... yeah, you know what happened after that. I know you hated it.” That’s about as close to an apology as I’m going to get. I don’t think I’m sorry, but I understand that maybe I should be.

“So, it’s not a pissing kink? It’s a fear kink?” he asks.

“You can piss yourself anytime and I’ll get hard over it,” I say, grinning behind my mask. “But mostly, I just enjoy the way you get scared. It brings you to life. It feeds a need I never knew I had.” I turn onto Malone’s street while he cries in the back. “You’re the one with the fear kink, Remiel.”

“No, I’m—” His palms rub again. “Yeah, I guess I am. I never knew. Until you.”

Backing into the Malone’s driveway, I admit, “I never knew a lot of things until you either.” I tug on his mask to make sure it stays on, and then get out and walk to the back. I open the hatch and wait for Remiel.

“Are we taking him out?” he asks.

“No,” Ghost answers, standing next to his brother. “He stays there.”

“You love this shit, don’t you?” Remiel asks Ghost. “That you can walk into a club wearing a mask that earns you respect and walk out with a man’s life in your hands.”

Ghost has a sinister mind and a need to be superior to everyone else, so I know he’s smiling behind his mask. “Fucking right, I do. But that respect was earned, not demanded. Don’t mistake the two, Remi.”

Menace walks down the porch steps with Gregory Malone’s wife. She knows, but she’s not crying. She wraps her housecoat around her, holding it tight, and keeps her chin up as she approaches us. She nods in respect, and we part to let her see her husband.

Malone gets himself into a sitting position, two daggers still sticking out of him, but the one in his ass is gone. He’s bleeding all over, but it’s his eyes bleeding lies that are the worst. He wants to promise his wife all sorts of things, but she doesn’t look willing to listen.

“What’ll you do with him?” she asks us while Gregory pleads for her mercy.

“He’s going to disappear,” Menace says, voice modulated. “Forever. Do you want access to him? We can grant you that.”

“You’re keeping him alive?” she asks.

“Yes. For now.” I hand her his wallet and keys. “Do you want a say in when he dies?”

Her eyes scan our masks, taking extra long on Remiel’s. Our masks have voice modulators, but his doesn’t, so he better keep his mouth shut. “If you wait until he turns fifty-five and actually give me a body, I can collect his pension.” She shows us his ID. “That’s in two years.”

Wow, he’s older than I thought he was. He looks young for his age, and Remiel must not believe it because he reaches out to take the ID from her. “You realize you’re agreeing to two years of his torture, right?” he asks her.

Ghost shakes his head, Menace looks at me, and I squeeze his defiant fucking ass for speaking again.

But Marnie Malone is attentive and discreet. “He tortured you for way longer,” she says to Remiel. “Tortured me even longer than that. I don’t need his pension, just thought it’d be a perk to come out of all this... madness. I don’t want a say.”

“Two years and a body,” I state. “Hero?”

Remiel nods. “Two years and a body. You’ll get his pension.”

Marnie nods, tossing his wallet into the trunk with him. “You don’t even deserve a goodbye. This is on you, husband.” She slams the door, and Malone barely gets his legs inside before it comes down. “You don’t need to warn me about discretion,” she says to us. “Guilt kept me away, but I’d love to drop off my harp.”

Remiel tenses, but he gives her a nod. Obviously, she knows who he is, so naturally, I will come back to threaten her if she so much as breathes his name. But truthfully, she looks relieved, like an era is ending and she can finally live without her husband’s stench surrounding her. Why she never did anything about him isn’t my business. A person trapped in a dangerous marriage isn’t my place to judge. She’s free now.

We don’t drive to Vile House. We head to the asylum, and Remiel gets nervous the closer we get.

“Why here?” he asks. “Don’t put me back in there...”

“You wanted to know how we come and go from Vile House. This is my act of trust, Remiel.”

“What? I don’t get it. What’s the asylum have to do with Vile House, other than Dr. Cooper working here?”

“Get ready for a long, dark walk underground. Moros is multilayered, and the tunnels are how we get around.” I pull into the lot closest to the ward Remiel was kept in. I won’t make him go back to that chamber room, but someday, I’d love for him to face it and get comfortable in its history.

“Tunnels,” he whispers to himself, thinking it all over. “But Vile House is in the middle of town.”

“Long and dark walk, like I said. First, we’re dropping Malone off in his new cell. He’s gonna be a patient here. In the ward I chased you through.”

Menace and Ghost get the back of the SUV open, and once Malone is out, I pull into a parking spot. One of the initiates will clean the back and put the vehicle somewhere to sit for a while, so I leave the keys under the visor.

“What is it? The ward?” he asks. When we walk inside and head through hallways to get to the secluded, locked-up ward, I pull our masks off.

“It’s our ward. If we ever get hurt, we come here. It’s fully functional, but only in a few areas. The rest of it is like a prison, housing people who have been put in here over the years. Just like we’re putting Malone here. Director has a use for some of them, but mostly, we’re just completing bargains and... getting a kick out of it.”

Remiel scoffs. “Your own personal playpen of pathetic little beasts to hunt.” I smile at that, and Remiel notices. “You look nice when you smile.”

“Jesus, Remi,” Ghost scoffs at him. “He fucking raped you, and now you’re gonna tell him he looks nice. You need your head checked.”

I look nice when I smile? Most people cringe when I smile. I’ve never been called nice before.

“My head’s never been fine, but neither is yours, so fuck off,” Remiel barks back at his brother.

Menace is having way too much fun dragging Malone by the ropes he tied. Menace is into restraints and bondage, pain play, and finding limits, but he’s not going to give Malone a chance to voice his limits. Whatever happens to Gregory Malone from here on out, Vile House members who need an outlet will do it. He’s ours now, thanks to my hero.

“Want first crack at him, Rem?” Ghost asks as we stand in the doorway to Malone’s new room.

But Remiel is looking down the hall, recognizing the doors he ran through and the path back to the hospital room he stayed in for seventy-two hours. Director’s team were the doctors who visited him there, and the therapist he’ll be seeing is a woman who belongs to Vile House. We call her Psych, and nothing else.

“Come on, hero. Let me show you.” I take his hand instead of his wrist, and I tell myself it’s because his wrists are wounded. “We’ll be back,” I tell Ghost and Menace.

The room he stayed in is dark, so I flick on the light to let him get a better look at it now that he’s... levelheaded. It looks like any hospital room, up to date and modern, but Remiel isn’t noticing the equipment. He’s remembering his short trip to death, the suffering he survived, and what happened when I eventually came to him afterwards.

“Kyd,” he says softly. “Came and spent a lot of time here with me.”

I grit my teeth and drop his hand as he roams the room. Love Kyd, but I beat his ass when I saw the footage of him cuddling up to *my* Remiel. I haven't even cuddled Remiel, but shit, it looked nice, and I'm envious of it.

Remiel looks at me from in front of the monitors that shouted his pulse. "He said you and my brother got locked up."

I don't want to talk about that time. I'd never been more scared. More defeated. "What're we doing in here? Don't you want your shot at Malone?"

"No. His fate is sealed, and that's all I care about. Gone, just like I said." He sits on the edge of the patient bed. "I want to know what happened to get you locked up."

"Why?"

"Krypt."

"Talking isn't my forte, hero. Stop trying." I turn to face the hallway, ready to leave him here on his own if he wants to risk running through these halls again.

"Krypt, please."

Please. Please. Please. The word has never penetrated me before, but it does now. Because Remiel isn't begging for torture to stop. He's not pleading for his life, his sanity, or his safety. He's asking me a question and hoping that I'll *please* answer it.

Fuck. Only for him.

"I lost my shit, like I told you the night I put that word on your throat. I shattered, Remiel."

"But why?"

I spin to see what's hiding in his eyes. Is this another signal I'm missing? Does he need me to tell him he's important again? Is his life at risk if I don't?

"I'm just asking," he says, sighing and giving up. "Nothing more. Let's just go."

I look at the floor instead of him. "I told you that love feels like obsession to me, and then in the next breath, I told you I'm obsessed with you. I admitted I shattered when you tried to fucking die on me because it goddamn broke me, Remiel. I put my marks everywhere on your body so you hopefully never do it again, which means that I give a shit about you. I got locked up in a cell while you were dying because I thought you were dead, and since I no longer had you, I no longer had any fucking reason to

keep going. I spent the whole time being electrocuted and broken because... because I *broke you*. What else do you want from me? Jesus.”

Remiel laughs, and my blood turns to lava.

“I’m not mocking you,” he assures me. He stands, approaching me. Slowly, so that I know he’s going to touch me, he lifts his hand and places it right on my chest. My heart. The burn that matches his. “You know what regrets went through my mind when I was in my moment of death?”

“Your brother.”

He nods. “And you. I’m sick for wanting you, but you’re sick for taking me. We’re sick, Krypt.”

I look into his eyes. The blue pulses, bringing the monsters within mine to the surface while his demons wake up. We are sick. Sick individuals who are sicker together.

“And?” I ask, liking the heat of his hand on my chest.

His grin is shy but sinister. “I like it.” He leans in, lips brushing my jaw. “Might even say I’m fucking obsessed with it.”

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CONFLICTED FREEDOM

REMIEL

I CAN'T BE CERTAIN, but I think Krypt is conflicted.

His over-the-top possessiveness doesn't know how to mesh with his newly discovered acceptance of feelings, and he can't decide if he's fucking me like he owns me or fucking me like he respects me.

His natural inclination is to force me, but his conscience is nagging at him because I'm wounded. He can't grab my wrists or tether them to anything. He can't dig his fingers into my skin without opening my stitches. He can't force my face to the mattress without risking my forehead sutures. He can't wrap his hands around the healing tattoo on my throat. He can't even spread my thighs without opening the slices there. He's stuck, unsure where to put his hands and what to do with my body when he isn't controlling it. Previously, he wouldn't care. But now...

He gets frustrated. He pushes on my shoulder, forcing me away. His cock pops free from my ass, and I brace myself against his bed, turning to face him.

"Look what I've done to you!" he screams at me, losing his cool for the first time. Well, not for the first time. I've seen him snap, but this time, he's losing it on himself. "I can't even... fuck!"

I know better than to touch him right now. He's more volatile than the storm building outside, flashing lightning through the single, uncovered window.

"I've fucking ruined you! Look at your body, Remiel!"

I've seen it. I don't need to look. It's scarred and marred, healing and disgusting. I look like a stitched-together version of *Frankenstein's* monster,

and Krypt is my *Frankenstein*. I didn't ask to be cut open, but I don't resent him for doing it.

Krypt's chest heaves, his eyes full of something other than his monsters. Shame. Worry. Fear, maybe. The burn on his chest is red and harsh, panting SICK with each harsh breath. But sickness hurts when it heals as much as it hinders, and that's what he's experiencing right now. A new outlook. The result of his behaviour. The consequence.

My mutilated body. He's seeing it for the first time through a set of eyes not shrouded by demons.

But so am I. I'm looking at my skin and seeing his protection. I'm looking at his worry and seeing how important I am to him. Nothing about us is healthy or even moral, but sometimes, two wrongs *do* make a right, and together, we're something close to warped perfection.

Turns out, I do need him.

He needs me.

Nothing else really matters. Because Reeven Matterson is dead. Gregory Malone is trapped in the asylum for at least two years, not haunting me. My brother will be guarded to keep him alive.

And I'm Remiel Sauder, Krypt's pathetic hero who is going to make it to twenty-seven.

I hold up my wrists, showing him his brand there. "Pain becomes protection." I trail my fingers over the Xs on my sternum. "Xs cancel out my mistake. To shatter shows you care, but it shows me I'm important enough to break you." I bare my throat to him. "Scars serve as a reminder, a safety net, a promise that I'll think next time I do something so suicidal." I let him look at every set of stitches on my body. "And this." I pat the word SICK on my chest while looking at the one over his heart. "This connects us, and I don't want it severed." Finally, my hands move to his name, the first tattoo he gave me on my collarbone. The significance of our bargain. "Bargain struck, Krypt?"

A new bargain. One where we move forward in life together, no matter where it goes. I don't kill myself, and he doesn't lose himself.

His silver eyes meet mine and his dark hair hangs over his face, the back pieces brushing the tops of his shoulders. I don't want him to regret what he's done to me. Regret is for our moment of death, and if I get my way, that won't be for a long time. He wars with himself, trying to align his hopes with his morals and his fears with his failures. But it's too late for all

that because he *made* me his the night I walked into Vile House, and I *became* his when I taunted him into fucking me. We're already weaved together, warped and twisted so all our parts meet, and I don't want him to free me.

Shifting his eyes over my body one more time, he looks past the scars to see me. I'm not privy to his thoughts on any of it, but the creatures within him surge back to the surface, showing me they accept me. Will Krypt?

Naked, hard, and daunting, he closes the distance between us. With nothing more than his knuckles under my chin, he tilts my head and says, "Bargain met, Remiel." He inhales, lips against mine without kissing. "You're going to regret this."

I spin him and push his back to the bed. Crawling on top of him, I straddle his legs and look down at his harshly handsome face. "I take back what I said." I put his hands on my thighs, tempting him to touch me without hesitation. My inner thigh stitches tug, cracking open a little.

"Which part?"

I line his lubed cock up with my ass, sinking down slowly. Fuck, the way he fills me is unlike anything I've ever felt before. All that numbness inside me gets pushed out when he pushes in, and the feeling is torturously comfortable. Bending, pressing my lips to his, I whisper, "Guess I am gay after all."

"No," he growls, fingers digging into my nape. "You're mine."

About fucking time he came back around. I grin against his mouth. "Prove it."

His hips lift, and his cock hits deep enough to steal my breath. I plant my palms beside his head, bracing myself while my wrists burn. I dip my head to peer between our bodies, watching his cock drive into me. It's surreal, honestly. This man. Me. Sex that mingles cravings with fear and pain, started with rape, and somehow awoke a part of me that'd been slumbering under my blanket of indifference. I know these desires are wrong, but fuck, they feel right.

"Look at me," Krypt rasps, his voice back to being abrasive and jittery.

I snap my gaze to his, lost in the swirling silver and chains that rattle within. Our bodies rock together, knowing what to do even though this is new for both of us, but our eyes never disconnect.

"How can you do it?" he asks.

"Do what?"

“Hold my eyes.”

I never could before. As Keegan growing up, I couldn't look into his eyes without shying away. I misunderstood him and saw his monsters instead of the chains they rattled. I saw his intensity and didn't know how to handle it. But since meeting him as Krypt, something changed in the way I perceive him.

He's still intense. He still has monsters. I still don't fully understand him. So maybe I'm what changed. I turned dire, and the lenses that direness forced me to look through saw things differently. Instead of his insanity intimidating me, it intrigued me, like Ophelia's moment of death. I stare because I see the beauty in his confliction, the pain in his misunderstanding, and the struggle he lives by not understanding himself. Krypt is as much of a mystery as Vile House is, but now I can see him.

“Because mine are finally open,” I tell him.

Krypt trembles for a moment, as if that declaration has forced feelings upon him he isn't ready to feel. I wondered why he wasn't obsessed with me all my life if he's this obsessed with me now, but I think I have my answer. I never looked at him like this before. He never felt seen by me. He didn't care about me because I didn't care about him. Once seen, eye contact comfortable, he latched onto one of the only people brave enough to look into his eyes. Me.

He closes his eyes, breathes deeply, and when they open again, every single one of his inner beasts blink back at me.

Oh, there he is.

He flips us, slamming me onto my back hard enough to rattle my teeth. His cock slips free, but he hikes up my legs and slams back in, drawing a ragged moan straight from the depths of my soul.

“Finally,” I groan, digging my fingers into his forearms. “I'm not the hero.”

Krypt grabs my wrists and pins them beside my head, no longer caring about my burns. “You're fucking nothing, Remiel.” He slams into me, but his movements take on a rocking motion that doesn't match the complete obliteration he has planned. He wants me to be nothing, yet he always gives me that inch... a tiny fraction of a chance to take the power back and become *something*. It might be minuscule and ass-backwards, but he's the only one who has ever given me a hazardous shot.

I rip my wrists free, feeling my skin peel against his hold. I don't care, because this is more important. Weaving my fingers into his shaggy, dark hair, I hold firm and force him to look at me. My legs wrap around his hips, stretching my stitches, burning brilliantly.

"I'm not nothing," I seethe at him, letting some warped version of love and admiration filter into my voice. I speak better with a cello, but the notes of my vocalization will be enough—Krypt knows my music. I snug up my legs until his cock is as deep as it will go inside me, my blue eyes on his thrashing silvers. "I'm whatever you turned me into. You woke up all my hidden parts, and this is what you get. I'm yours, Krypt. Keegan. I'm fucking yours."

His eyes pulse and his body stills. The room takes a breath. The purple neon light flickers. My heartbeat drowns my hearing and his thumps hard in his chest.

Please, accept me.

Please, want me.

Please, show me I'm important to you.

His nostrils flare and he reaches up, taking one of my hands from his hair. A fragment of fear splinters through me, but when he puts my palm over the word burned into his chest, it leaves me. His hand lands on my chest. Our sicknesses joined.

"Would you still be mine if I freed you?" he asks.

I don't think he wants the answer. He slams his mouth to mine, gyrates his hips, and turns off my brain by coating it in pleasure. Sick pleasure. Exhausting, draining, extended pleasure that turns into too much but is never enough.

I bleed through my bandages and sweat out my family curse. I hold on to him hard enough that he won't forget to drag me into his future, and I cry out in bliss with every orgasm he forces on me throughout the night.

I sob because I'm happy and scared about it.

I laugh because I'm crazy and pleased about it.

I love because I'm sick and twisted about it.

Broken yet whole, I settle under the blankets of his bed with him at my back. He hasn't cuddled me before, but for some reason, this time is different. His predatory grip on me is physically softer than usual, but more emotionally desperate. I can tell he's thinking hard about something, but the pull of sleep is too great for me to resist.

I wish I had resisted, looked at him one more time, admired everything about him. Because when I wake to the sun already up, it spotlights a calling card.

A torso, ribs, a spine, a pelvic bone. Purple splashes.

I flip it. And touch my throat as I shatter. *Would you still be mine if I freed you?* he had asked...

I free you, Remiel.

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A NEW ENEMY

KRYPT

I DON'T LIKE that Director knows I'm hurting. I especially don't like that he can guess what's hurting me.

Life was better when I felt nothing and had no attachments. Remiel has made me weak and vulnerable by tainting my decisions and warping my motivations. He infected me with feelings and tamed the monsters in my eyes, and a part of me wants to hate him for it, but a bigger part respects him for being capable of it. I've craved being seen, so much so that I ached for a diagnosis when none fit me.

Remiel diagnosed me. By holding my eyes.

"You're coming back," Director states, handing me a jacket with knives and daggers hidden in the liner. Axel Graves will find them, but any chance is better than none. "You know that, right?"

If I make it back, I'm going to force him to answer a question I've been too chickenshit to ask. What did he see on Remiel's brain scan?

I put on the jacket and avoid answering. I've had the tracker in my brain for a week, so if Axel Graves is the one watching my dot on a map, he'll know exactly where I've been. He's from Moros originally, so he knows where and what Vile House is. There's a very real chance whoever meets me today will be there to kill me. But even if I make it through that and am taken back to the lab to start the brainwashing procedure, he's not just going to let me come back to Moros like he did with Remiel's mom. I'm a risk. She's not, so our paths will be different. My only task is leading Vile House to Axel's lab. Whatever else I have to endure while I'm there is on me.

I've never really feared dying. I figured it'd come at me fast and furious, and when my light blinked out, that'd be the end for me. Even if I

was captured, I'd endure it until my hope died, and then I'd take the suicide pill we all keep on us. Either way, I planned to die with no regrets.

But once again, fucking Remiel has fucked with my plans.

Because I don't want to die.

Would you still be mine if I freed you?

I free you, Remiel.

I'm desperate to know the answer. I'm terrified to know the answer. I might never get the chance to find out.

"Once we ping your location, we're coming for you, Krypt." Director looks at me.

He can't hold eye contact as long as Remiel can, but he's better than most people. "You'll make sure Remiel..."

"Vile House has him. Always. And once you get back, you'll have him. He's protected, Krypt. What else?"

"No. No *what else* bullshit," Ghost says, walking into the tunnel. "Like fuck you're getting your affairs in order. You'll be back by tomorrow." His face is a stoic mask, but determination lines his eyes. "I'm coming with you."

Ghost is going to fucking hate me for what I do to him next. But I'll let it be a surprise for my brother to deliver. Remiel can handle the fallout from that.

"You're on rescue team one, idiot," Director tells Ghost. "You need to be here, on standby, to go in when we get the signal." Because no one moves as silently as Ghost. Ghost gears up to fight the order, but Director cuts him off. "Open your mouth and you'll join Ransom at the end of the rank line. I need you here. Krypt needs you here. Remi needs you here."

I shove a handgun into the holster inside the jacket. Ghost grabs my shoulders, touching me when he knows I don't like to be touched. Right in my face, he looks into my eyes with almost as much comfort as his brother.

"Remember that time you went through an interrogation for six days and nights, under bright lights and loud music, tortured and taunted, tricked and fucked with?" He slaps my cheeks. "You fucking made it. This is gonna be child's play."

I zip my jacket. "You trying to say you're worried about me?"

Ghost grins. "You feel guilty about raping my brother yet?"

My eyes flash to Director, but he shakes his head and ignores us. "I'm still considering it."

Ghost laughs like the asshole he is. “How’d you leave it with him? He knows where you’ll be?”

I look down.

“Krypt, you fucking bastard. You walk out without a word?”

“I set him free. Our bargain is met.” Once Riot deals with the last name on Remiel’s list. I already had my goodbye chat with my brother. “He’s better off—”

“No, he isn’t. You fucked him up and made him yours, despite how many times I told you not to. You’re coming back to him.” He stares at me, hatred and respect mixing in his eyes. “I’m gonna kill you for this.”

“Can it wait until after?” Director butts in. “We’re on a time limit.”

“See you tomorrow, yeah?” Ghost asks, trying to make me promise.

“We’ll see.” I let him pull me into a side hug tap thing, and then I turn my back on him and follow Director through the tunnels. “Watch out for Remiel.”

“I always do.”

That’s all I need to know to die today.



AXEL GRAVES IS THREE THINGS. Smart, conniving, and fucking crazy.

He knows exactly who I am, where I came from, and what I’m doing here. I knew it from the moment he stepped out of the vehicle. He’s not walking into a trap. He’s a man who set this trap and sees me as his prey.

But I’m no one’s prey. I’m the fucking hunter.

When I showed up to where the mobile trailer was, all I found was a note taped to the door. *The quarry*, it said, so here I am, at the quarry. Not thinking about Remiel.

“Which one are you?” he asks, sauntering his business shoes and pleated pants in my direction without ever coming close enough. “Red?” His hair is so black it’s iridescent and silky like raven wings, but his eyes... well, one eye. The other is partially closed, but doesn’t appear injured. His eyelid flutters sometimes when he moves his line of sight. “Pink?”

Oh, he’ll rue the day he meets Kyd in his pink.

“What’re we doing here? I’m not in the mood for a swim.” I look at the tinted windows of his SUV, wondering who else is in there or if he had the balls to come alone.

“A little show and tell,” Axel says with a pretty smirk. “I like to brag.”

“I’m not a good audience.”

“Hmm.” He leans against the hood of the vehicle, slipping his hands into the pockets of his suit jacket. “I suppose not. You’re likely to throw one of the three,” he pauses, “sorry, four daggers in your jacket at me. Perhaps use the pistol? Or if things really come to blows, you’ll reach for your ankle knives.”

There are five in my jacket, but I respect his attention to detail. “Probably.”

“I’m a lover, not a fighter... Riot?” He lifts a brow.

“Know my weapons, but not my name?”

“I know what’s in front of me, not behind my back.”

“Krypt,” I tell him, not giving a shit if he knows it. “Get on with the show and tell.”

“Krypt.” He nods, looking at the quarry. Water has filled it over the years, turning it into a dirty swimming hole. “I’ve heard about you. What you went through.”

“Went through?”

“For initiation. Your tests.”

“How?”

He keeps his gaze on the water. “Did Director tell you who I am? I mean, obviously you know my reputation if you’re here to infiltrate my lab, but did he get detailed with it?”

I’m not someone who is easily tricked, mostly because I don’t have the patience to listen. But I can’t walk away right now. This is my job, given to me on behalf of Vile House to protect Moros. There are few things I care about in this world, but Moros is one of them.

“Is this the *tell* part of your show and tell?”

“It is,” he says, laughing nicely. “Have you met the one they call Medic?”

I nod. Medic is the man who acts as our doctor, surgeon, and general practitioner. He patches us up if we get wounded and gives us referrals for our mental health.

“He’s Director’s brother, you know. My birth father, but he didn’t raise me. A Vile House secret.” Axel looks at me. I’m surprised, especially because Director didn’t warn me, but I don’t show it. “It was your testing that... caused a rift between us. As you know, mental coercion and brainwashing, really anything to do with mind control, are my... *crème de la crème*, if you will. The way you withstood that mental torture was...” He moans, kissing his fingertips.

“So, you’ve known my name and who I am this whole time? Why the game?”

“I knew who you were then. You didn’t have your name yet. Krypt. It fits.” He smiles.

“With a K.”

“Mm. Even better. I want to show you something, Krypt. What my methods can do. Then I want to explore them with you. Your mind is a vault, and I haven’t found a subject yet that can resist my coercion. I need to study its weak points on someone who stands a chance at fighting it. Would you work with me?”

“With you? You’re working with Benton Wentworth, trying to take over Moros.” My fingers twitch, wanting to grab the handle of a knife just to feel the grip of it.

Axel waves that off. “His billions are paying for my experiments, yes, but Moros is what I’m trying to protect.”

“From?”

“Outside. Ah, here they are.”

I straighten, finding a group of ten people walking towards us. One of them is Remiel’s mom. They all look normal, but their expressions are expectant, as if they’re waiting to learn why they’re here. Axel’s minions, who came when he called.

“These ten are to the point I can utter a single word or address on the phone, and they come running. I’ve trained them with sound signals.”

“Why her?” I nod at Mrs. Sauder.

“Because she’s a horrible person. That Sauder curse.” He clicks his tongue. “Her husband was living longer than she thought he would, so...”

No. *What?* “How do you know this?”

“That’s not the right question, Krypt. The right question would be ‘why am I doing this?’ don’t you think?” His one eye looks at me as his ten controlled minds come to a stop ahead of us. “These are test subjects. But

imagine the power Moros could have if we had a group of ten powerful people under our control. Because the world is coming for Moros, my friend, and we're not ready to defend our home."

"Who's coming for Moros?" Because we thought it was him and his team of billionaires. People have been trying to overtake Moros for years, but their money doesn't get them far against our town. But if the right person or group took a shot, well, we're only so strong. I don't even know if I believe a word out of his mouth yet.

Axel pulls a folded piece of paper from his jacket pocket but doesn't hand it to me. "Moros is a town full of myths, cults, sinister people, and darkness. Over the decades, it's earned a reputation, hasn't it? Government organizations leave it alone, the FBI and CIA don't come here, and we draw the kind of attention that gets stupid people killed or missing but repels street-smart people. Who do you think would benefit from owning an untouchable town and the people in it?"

"Just fucking tell me. I'm not the dramatic build-up type."

He sets the folded paper on the hood and steps away from it, walking to his group of controlled people. When he's far enough away, I grab it. It's an encrypted message I can't fully understand, but a few things stand out.

A date. Almost a year from now.

Every M, O, R, and S is capitalized.

It takes me a very long time because I'm not the puzzle-solving type, but the seemingly insignificant lowercase letters at the bottom... they aren't in order. But if you reorganize them, they spell...

"Ah, so you're aware of them." Axel gracefully spins to face me.

Reaper Corp, that's what the letters spell. The organization that breeds its own killers, specialists, and geniuses. The group who took over a city down south and turned it into their own personal kingdom. If they want Moros...

I crumple the paper. "How do I know you didn't just print this off?"

Axel smiles at me, but he clicks something between his fingers. "I'll prove it to you." As one, his group of ten come at me. But it's not them I'm worried about.

Something in my mind changes, and when they grab me, I don't fight it. Because the clicking sound told me not to.

DON'T BE NAÏVE

REMIEL

I FREE YOU, *Remiel*.

I free you, Remiel.

I free you, Remiel.

I don't want to be fucking free!

I want to be owned. Alive under his protection and under his skin because our sicknesses seek one another. Why the hell did he free me? Our bargain isn't met! There's still one name on my list, and now that Krypt has cut me loose, I'm feeling closer to the family curse than ever.

Vile House was empty when I searched it this morning, everyone having already forgotten about me since Krypt left. Left... just gone. Without a word or any sort of hint at when he'll be back. It's been four days, and no one will talk to me. Not even my brother.

I have no home. No friend but Cain. No fucking clue what is going on or why he freed me. Where is he? Is he safe? Did I do something to push him away?

Of course I did. I'm the pathetic idiot who fell for his rapist. I should have known from the beginning he'd never see me as anything more than an object to own. He treated me like shit, took me against my will, drugged me, and violated me. Krypt has made his intentions clear from the beginning. I'm a piece of property and nothing more. It's my own fault for deluding myself into thinking it could be something more.

He fled at the first sign of love. Feelings he's learned to handle, but love?! What was I thinking? I can't love him, yet I do. He can't love me, and he doesn't. I thought I'd be okay with that so long as he kept me as his. I could live my life as his voodoo doll because his attention is the best thing

I've ever experienced. I relied on it, got comfortable under his gaze, and stupidly expected I'd have it for the rest of my life.

I never expected him to free me and disappear.

The Matter Cult is dead, and Gregory Malone is locked away, so I pace the length of the Sauder graves in solitude. No eyes on me, no stalkers at my back. I'm losing my mind to abandonment, but it's worry making my heart skip beats. Selfish worry, because I don't know what to do now that I've lost him. But worry for him, too.

I saw it in his eyes, something like love, or as close to it as he can get. I heard it in the way he asked me if I'd still pick him if he set me free. I saw it in the way his usually flowing calligraphy stuttered on his final calling card, freeing me against my will. In such a cowardly fucking way. A calling card?! Not even a face-to-face rejection? My god, he's an asshole, and I miss him an unhealthy amount.

"Hi, hun."

I'm too dead to be startled, but I blink at my mom as she walks over Dad's grave like she doesn't even see it. The fog is thick in the cemetery today, but she drags more along with her, shrouding her in something ominous. The bags under her eyes aren't new, but they're deeper now, darker purple. When I look into her eyes, they differ so greatly from Krypt's thrashing monsters and rattling chains. Hers are empty, void of thoughts and vacant of emotion. Nothing expressive or emotive comes through when I look at her, and I wonder when she became such a shell.

"What's wrong?" she asks, scrunching her face into something like concern.

I look closer. When I woke up in her house and had breakfast with her and my siblings, she was acting strange, but she wasn't empty. She was still our mother, and she wanted a family meal together after all the time that had passed without one. I didn't know about the microchip then, but it was inside her, doing something to her. She cut me months before that morning and held a knife to me again that day. What happened between then and now to change her so drastically?

"Thinking of joining them?" Mom asks, nodding at my brothers' graves, still standing on my father's.

I take a subconscious step back. She's never outright asked me about suicide before. "Do you want me to?"

She laughs. It's a sad, forced sound. "No, hun. But I think you should see the doctor."

"What doctor?"

"Dr. Graves. He can fix you. He has what you want." She tucks her hair behind her ear and smiles down at Dad's headstone. "I heard you fell in love with Keegan."

Has what you want and Keegan in the same breath...

"What does he have that I want?"

"Dr. Graves found all sorts of things in his head. He's got many secrets, but you were his best-kept one." She smiles at me like we're having a happy conversation instead of a dire one. "He calls you a hero."

My body chills and my spine tingles. Dr. Graves has Krypt, and somehow, my mom knows about it. I don't know if it's intentional or if he's in danger, but the warning signals within me, the ones gifted to me by Moros itself, are all blaring alarm bells.

"Dr. Graves is with Keegan?" I ask her.

She brushes dirt and dead leaves off the headstones, humming and nodding. "Oh, yes. It's been a while since you were all at home. Would you like to come for dinner?"

The fuck is wrong with her? "Actually, can you take me to this doctor? Can you introduce me to Dr. Graves?"

Maybe I'm back to being suicidal. Suicidal with a purpose this time.

"Yes. After dinner." She extends her hand to me, and it takes more mental preparedness than ever before to take it. "We'll get your sister and brothers to come as well." She snorts, covering her mouth. "Brother, excuse me."

I don't want my brother there. If Soren comes, he'll talk me out of going to Dr. Graves. Free or not, I'm still Krypt's fucking hero.



SOREN DIDN'T SHOW up for dinner. Probably because he's still not talking to me ever since Krypt left me. But Selena is here, and she knows something about Mom. Because she's strategically placed herself between

us, and I notice because this is the first time my sister has been protective in this way.

She's studying psychology to protect me, but she's never been a physical barrier between me and our mom. What does she know, and how does she know it? Did Soren tell her about the chip?

Mom's grip on her fork is white-knuckled, and the two of us are watching her warily. "I think I'll redo your bedrooms now that none of you stay here."

"I do," Selena says.

"Do you?" Mom asks. "You're never here anymore."

I study my sister. She comes home every weekend, so where is she staying? Did she get a partner? Is she in a relationship? "Where do you stay?" I ask her.

"Here, mostly," Selena says. "Rem, you wanna help me clean up?"

No. I need to remind Mom she's taking me to see Dr. Graves. I shake my head, but Selena nudges me under the table and grabs my sore wrist to make me stand. When I wince, she drops it, but still pushes me into the kitchen.

"What're you doing here?" Selena hisses at me once we're behind the wall of the kitchen. "You can't be here, Rem."

I tilt my head at her like Krypt tilts his head at me. "Why not?"

"Because..." She presses her lips together before sighing. "Soren told me about the chip."

She's lying. "What else did he tell you?"

"Look," she snaps at me. "It's not like it's a secret that you're dating Kr-Keegan. It's going around Moros like wildfire."

"Who?" I grab her wrist this time. "What'd you almost call him?"

"Keegan."

"You know." I squeeze her wrist. "You know about him... them. How, Selena?"

"I don't know shit," she says, pulling her wrist free. "You need to leave."

"And go where? I have no fucking house, Selena!"

"Because he burnt it down to keep you!" she whisper-shouts, shocking herself. "Fuck."

I shake my head at her. Yet another person in my life feeding me lies. "You're all the fucking same. Lie to Remi because he can't handle it,

right?" I turn my back.

"You *can* handle it!" She grabs my shoulder and spins me to face her. "It's just forbidden to talk about."

"So... you're one of them, too?"

She shakes her head. "I wasn't joking when I said I was going to initiate this year. I did. I'm... nobody. Only an initiate. Which means I know about you and him, but I don't know anything else. I didn't learn it until after you did. I didn't know who he was when he had you on Initiation Night, okay? I didn't know it was Keegan." She sighs. "But trust me, Remi. You have to leave Mom alone. Krypt is... out there, trying to protect you."

"Me?" Fat fucking chance. He freed me and left me to rot.

"He told me to watch out for you while he was gone, so that's what I'm doing. Please leave. You can stay at Keegan's house. Or Vile House. It's your home now, too."

My sister belongs to Vile House. She initiated. My brother is a Vile Boy. My... maybe-boyfriend is a Vile Boy. My mom is chipped and controlled. Krypt is missing. I have no home and no life other than him.

"I can't leave. She's going to take me to Dr. Graves. He has Krypt."

Selena's other hand lands on my shoulder. "Krypt is there willingly."

My eyes water. "No. He'll... they'll brainwash him."

Selena shakes her head at me, but she's pushed aside a moment later. Soren takes her place, coming out of nowhere. He lifts my chin, looks me straight in the eye, and makes me a promise. "They'll try, but he didn't get his name for nothing, Remi. I promise you, we're getting him back."

Selena's eyes widen. "What the fucking fuck?! You're Vile, too?!" Selena gasps. "I thought you were in The Misfits?" Guess she doesn't know everything then. Soren ignores her.

"He won't be the same." Tears fall down my cheeks.

"He's a fucking master of mental control, Remi."

No, he's not. He gets overwhelmed by emotions. He can't talk about anything. He doesn't know how to express himself with anything but violence. He's not a master of control.

Soren grins, probably knowing what I'm thinking. "Okay, let me rephrase. He's a master at mental fortitude. Nothing gets in or out if he doesn't want it to. Trust him, Remi."

I look into my brother's blue eyes and break just a little. "He freed me."

Soren scoffs. "So you'd pick him willingly. Don't be naïve, Remi. You'll never escape him, whether you want to or not. He did this to make you choose him. But even if you don't pick him, you're still his, so relax, okay?"

"Where is he?" I ask, trying not to think about that because it's making me too hopeful that Soren is right. That Krypt still wants me to be his.

"Right where he's supposed to be. Come on. We're going to Vile House." He looks at Selena. "All of us. Initiate." He grins at her.

She grins back. "What about Mom?"

"Leave her," Soren says with indifference. "We'll deal with her later."

When we walk out, Mom is sitting at the table like she's awaiting her next order. I don't think she realizes when we leave. If she's this badly mind-controlled, what's going to happen to Krypt?

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THIS IS A HUMAN BRAIN

KRYPT

THERE'S a memory trying to creep its way in. A time when my mother, Gia, looked at me like I wasn't even human. Her blond hair, so different from mine and Killian's, curtained her eyes, but I could read her lips.

He's sick, Owen. We need to... end him before he kills us or hurts Killian.

My dad, Owen, looked at me then. His lips said something about me never hurting Killian, but there was agreement in his eyes. My parents were going to kill me. For being sick.

Do you see him?! Look, Owen! See! See him for what he is! Open your eyes and see!

C. C. C. C.

I hate the letter. I hate blonds.

The memory is real, but it doesn't shift into what actually happened. I was fourteen at the time, and that very night, I killed my own parents. Killian helped. It was the first time I really gave in to my sickness, let out my monsters, and ruined a set of lives that wanted to end me for being born this way. I stabbed my mother in the throat and watched her die while Killian gave our father fourteen stab wounds to his abdomen. One for every year he treated me like a monster.

But that part never comes.

In this version of the memory, Gia smiles at me and says, "Don't worry, darling. We'll get you the help you need. We love you."

My brain stutters. Memories and realities aren't meshing... but fuck, I want them to. I want it to be real. I want just one look from the woman who

birthed me to be full of love and understanding. Compassion and acceptance.

“She loves you, Keegan,” someone says. “Come here.”

I get up and walk over to the voice.

“She misses you. Kneel.”

I kneel.

“She wants to talk to you. Stand up.”

I stand.

“She doesn’t think you’re sick. Kneel.”

Sick. Sick. Sick.

A burn on my chest and a man who sees me. A mouthy, suicidal idiot who bargained his life away and became mine. In sickness, we found our health. Clarity comes in flashes, this reality blending with the one playing out in my head. Gia loves me. Remiel holds eye contact with me. My parents are alive and supportive. Remiel wants me, but he doesn’t need me. He chooses me. Picks me.

Like Gia never did.

I blink away the false past and cough out a sob that has no place in my life. My body becomes mine again, and the walls in my mind fortify, solidifying into something impenetrable once more. Jesus, that was close.

My dry throat tickles and my eyes burn like I haven’t blinked in days. The soft green walls and the trickling water fountain come back. Brown leather couches and a cool mug of tea remind me where I am.

“What was it?” Axel asks from his leather chair. “The mention of your mother? What snapped you out of it?”

I place a hand on the couch, shaky and embarrassed about it. This is the closest he’s come to controlling me, and I loathe the way it feels. Like I failed. Like I’m undeserving of my name. But mostly, I’m conflicted. Because I have a trigger word. It used to set me off on a homicidal path, but right now, it saved my life.

I walk to the window, pressing my forehead to the glass. But it isn’t glass. It’s a mural, painted on the wall of this underground room, the likeness of sunlight so well faked I can almost feel it. Sweat slips down my neck, my hands shake, and I squeeze my eyes closed to ground myself with images of Remiel.

“I’m not your enemy, Krypt.”

“No?” My voice cuts my throat, raspy and abrasive. “How long have I been here against my will?”

Because the tracker didn’t work. He tricked me. Told me a story about Reaper Corp, made me believe we were fighting the same enemy, and then brought me here after he removed the tracker. Where here is, I don’t know, and now Director can’t locate me. I’ve been in a state of severe concentration for... days. Weeks? Trying to withstand his hypnosis and brainwashing methods.

“Eleven days,” he tells me casually. “Please, tell me what snapped you out of it.”

Rage wants to build inside me, but I don’t have the energy to let it become anything productive. I squeeze my eyes, breathe through my nose, and then face him. His one eye is alert and focused, trying to decipher what triggered me out of his control, but the other is closed and relaxed. Sometimes his eyelid flutters, but when it doesn’t, it means he’s calm. In control of himself.

“Where are we?”

“My lab.” His smile is so pretty. Too pretty. Perfection on an imperfect man. Deceiving.

“Which is where?”

“I took your tracker out for a reason, Krypt. I need time to work before your band of brethren come for you. I need to prove to them we can work together.” He taps a digital pencil on his tablet. “Trigger?”

“So go to your fucking father! He’s Vile! Leave me the fuck out of it.”

Axel clicks his tongue and taps the pencil. “But your mind is what I need. That was the closest I’ve come to controlling you, and I need to know why it failed so I can implement it into my methods.”

“You can’t implement it,” I tell him. “Because you’ll never know everyone’s trigger word.” I fist my hands.

Axel’s gaze drops to my covered chest. Right where the word is tattooed over my heart. He smiles coyly, then makes a note of something on his tablet. My trigger word. Setting everything down, he stands, straightening his pristine suit. Why he wears it in an underground bunker is beyond me, but he seems to prize appearances.

“Have a look at this.” He clicks a button and a white screen comes to life. It’s a medical image I can’t read. A scan of some sort. “And trust that

my motivations for doing this are purely for science, but also... my act of good faith.”

I’m too tired for this shit. Axel Graves fucking loves to show and tell, and I’m sick of listening to it. I sit down on the leather couch, my body sagging in exhaustion.

“This is a human brain. And this is a mapping video showing real-time blood flow to certain areas of the brain.”

“I’m not a fucking doctor. I don’t know what this shit means, so fuck off.”

“I have a point. I promise.” He uses a goddamn laser pointer, of all things, to highlight a section of the brain. “This is the limbic amygdala and the frontal cortex. And since you’re not a fucking doctor and I won’t fuck off, I’ll just say that this particular activity map shows less connectivity between these two parts.”

“Don’t care.”

“Now, mind you, there haven’t been a lot of studies done because the criteria are hard to meet, but listen to this. In a normal person, the connectivity between these two parts differs significantly from this one. It’s not regulating circuitry correctly, if that makes sense.”

“It doesn’t, and I still don’t care.”

“Ah, but you will.”

“Why? Is it my brain?”

Axel’s pretty smile comes back. “Basically, when these two sections aren’t functioning as well as they should be, the patient would have a much more difficult time regulating emotions. Actually, it can cause quite extreme emotional pain.”

I stare at the screen, unseeing.

“As in, the kind of emotional pain and lack of emotional regulation that could, perhaps, lead to suicide.”

My eyes flick to him. My body gets hot. Exhaustion tries to win, but alertness takes over.

“A suicide curse might not be real, Krypt, but brain matter doesn’t lie.”

I stand, grabbing the edge of the couch to stay upright. I haven’t uttered a single word about Remiel, but he knows.

“I had his mother slice him so I could stitch it up and... have him for a bit. I know you assume I put a chip in his brain, but I didn’t, as these scans prove. I wanted to study his brain, like I’ve studied many of the Sauder

males' brains. As you see, Remiel, much like his brothers and many of his relatives, has noticeably less functionality in this part of his brain. The curse isn't real, but the genetic makeup is."

Is that why Director looked at his brain scan and lied about it? Does he know? How would Director know from a still image when this one sparks and moves?

"The good news," Axel goes on, "is that we can improve some of his regulatory responses with medication. There's no cure for this since it isn't technically anything diagnosable, but we can aid him in how he manages extreme emotions. This is my act of good faith. I am not your enemy," he repeats.

I am Krypt, the Vile Boy. I don't know how to react to situations with anything other than rage or violence. I don't know how to be relieved without thinking he has an ulterior motive. Is this something I can protect Remiel from, or is Axel going to use the one man I need as motivation to get me to do what he needs me to do?

I'm broken. Caught somewhere between wanting to give up and never wanting to stop fighting. The problem is that I don't understand what I'm fighting against. There is no clear enemy. Axel says he's not my enemy, and he's showing me something to help Remiel, yet I'm locked in his bunker, undergoing manipulative brainwashing. He's using me to perfect his methods, but do I have a right to be pissed off about that when I did the same thing to Remiel?

I used him. Took him as my own, made him rely on me, and then left him. Axel Graves is not inherently different from me; we just have different needs and interests. But we still go about getting what we want the same way.

"I found these in your pocket," he says, holding up a small stack of my calling cards. "I'd like you to write out two of them. One to Remiel Sauder to let him know you're okay. He's been suffering and trying to find you. And the other to Director. I think it's time we all come to an... arrangement."

He's been trying to find you.

Does that mean he's still mine even though I set him free?

I can't stop looking at the brain map. "What medication?" I don't take the calling cards. There's a small part of me that respects him for not

writing the messages himself. He has the cards. He could have sent one to Remiel and Director on his own.

“We can experiment safely. Director is better at pharmaceuticals. Mostly, medications for bipolar disorder, anxiety, and depression will be our starting point. Perhaps even some antipsychotics. Rest assured, it will be done safely and with Remiel’s consent.”

“Remi,” I correct him. I’m the only one who gets to use his full name.

Axel smiles at me, and I’m struck once again by how pretty it is. Pretty, but entirely unappealing. “Might you help me bridge this gap between my organization and yours?”

Axel Graves and Vile House.

“To protect Moros?”

“To protect Moros.”

I don’t trust him one fucking bit, but this is my chance to get a message to Remiel. I take the cards.

CUT HERE

REMIEL

I'VE ALWAYS WANTED to be important, but I've never wanted the spotlight. With the Vile members standing spread out among the circular tiered seating, I stand in the middle of the chamber and remember.

I remember waking up after fearing for my life in the corridors of the asylum, staring at the moon through the grate in the ceiling. Playing my cello in this very spot with shame soaking my soul and devastation suffocating my mind. I remember the gate he tethered me to and the pain he inflicted with knives, hot brands, and a tattoo gun.

I remember *him*.

I remember him telling me I *am* important, that he shattered, that he can't watch the roll of my throat when I swallow.

I look up, seeing all the coloured masks except teal. Ghost really can move without being noticed, and wherever he is, I hope he's looking out for Krypt. The rest of the Vile Boys are watching me, ready to have my back and look out for my well-being. Because I'm one of them now. I might not be masked like the ten are, but I belong to Vile House through something that feels like family. Whether Krypt takes me back or not.

"Bestie."

I look up at the whisper to my left. Kyd's pink mask stares at me, hanging over the wobbly railing to get as close as he can.

"Can you put in a good word with the doc for me? I think he's gonna be mine someday, and I wanna start out strong."

I smile at his craziness even though every other part of me is riddled with nerves. I nod. And then Director walks in wearing a black mask with a

golden face. He touches my shoulder in support when the gate I was chained to swings open and a group of people walk in.

I don't care who they are. My eyes search for Krypt, and my fingers touch the calling card that showed up yesterday.

Remind me who I am.

I don't know what it means, but my mind has run through three thousand possible meanings since it showed up at Vile House two days ago.

My mom is part of the group walking into the chamber. I stiffen at the sight of her, but honestly, I'm so far past caring that I shift my eyes to the other faces, looking for one. I recognize a few from Moros, some familiar to me, some not. But one is missing.

I don't see *him*.

As one, the group of people come to a stop in a line. Side by side, they stare ahead without really seeing. Or maybe they do see but they've been commanded not to react? I have no idea, but my mom is as blank-faced as the rest of them. She doesn't see, acknowledge, or try to help me. I'm standing right in front of her, and she doesn't fucking care.

Should I be helping her?

"Hello, Vile House." A tall man in a light grey suit walks through the gate. His smile is pleasant, his stubble is perfectly trimmed, and one of his eyes flutters shut. "Pleasure to finally meet you."

No one says anything, and when I look around, I notice all the Vile Boys have turned still. Kyd is bouncing a bit, but the rest are stoic, calm, and braced for whatever comes next.

"Where is he?" I shout, unable to keep my mouth shut. "This was supposed to be a meeting in good faith."

"Rest assured, Remi Sauder. He's here." Axel smiles at me, and despite how friendly it looks, it doesn't settle me. "First, a little show and tell." He clicks something in his hand, and then all hell breaks loose.

A gunshot echoes through the chamber, and Director grunts behind me. Before I get a chance to look at him, the group of ten fan out and more gunfire busts my ears. Axel Graves keeps his smile through it all.

Who the fuck shot the gun?

“Remi.” Director grabs my shoulder to steer me to the edge of the room. “Go. You’re not trained. We can handle—” Another bullet rips through his bicep, his blood spattering my face.

I catch him as he stumbles, hooking his arm over my shoulder and ducking for cover. The Vile Boys are spread out, picking off Axel’s group of zombies. My heart pounds and my eyes search, wondering if I’m going to find my mom’s dead body or Krypt as the one who killed her.

“I have to find him,” I tell Director, setting him to lean against the stone wall. “He’s controlled. Axel has control of his mind.”

“He’d want you to get out of here,” Director says, looking for his team. “Kyd!”

I turn in time to see Kyd launch himself over the railing. He lands with more grace than I thought him capable, his feet light. He unsheathes a dagger and whips it at Axel Graves.

But Axel is fast. He steps to the side, avoids Kyd’s grab, and gets Kyd spun around. Kyd’s back is pulled to Axel’s chest, and a sharp blade rests against Kyd’s throat.

“So fucking hot,” Kyd groans, which is when I notice he’s already embedded a dagger in Axel’s thigh, with another held to his femoral artery. “Hey, soulmate. Seems we’re at an impasse, but I’m cool to stay just like this for a bit.” He wiggles his ass back, grinding on Axel.

Axel is still fucking smiling. He looks right at me when he says, “Kill Remiel Sauder.” That thing in his hand clicks again.

Relief churns with fear when I see him. My Krypt.

Unmasked, hollow, and deadly, he prowls towards me with no chains on his monsters. They’re all set free, creating havoc in his mind and violence in his heart. He’s the most unhinged version of himself, and he’s never looked more terrifying.

I shake on the spot, caught between wanting to go to him and wanting to run away. I’ve done that already. I ran from him in this very asylum, thinking I stood a better chance of surviving it than him. I won’t make that mistake again.

Curved knives spin in his grip, and his vibrant silver eyes stay locked on me. Dressed in darkness and shrouded in his natural shadows, he takes his time getting to me. When Facts tries to intercept, he’s thrown to the side. When Seven hauls him back, he gets a slice to the cheek.

When Riot steps in front of him, Krypt growls.

“Think, you dumb bastard. Think! For your fucking self!” Riot snarls at him. “You won’t hurt Remi.”

But he will because he can’t think. He might have gotten his name for having a mind like a vault, but Axel Graves figured him out. Found a way in. Penetrated his walls and freed his demons so that rational thought means nothing and memories are warped into something that feels like numbness.

“Krypt.” Riot tries again, stepping back with every forward step his brother takes. When Krypt doesn’t slow, my heart sinks. When he looks at me like he doesn’t know me, my heart stops. When he stops twirling the knives and raises one to kill me, my heart dies. “Run, Remi!”

Remind me who I am.

I backpedal, being pulled by Ransom and Glitch. Krypt snarls at them for touching me. But I keep going.

“Get in front of me,” I tell them, an idea forming. “I need space to take my shirt off.”

“What? Why? Run, Remi!” Ransom pushes me behind him, and Glitch tries to shove me towards the exit.

A knife fight breaks out, metal clangs together, and shouting ensues. Guns clatter to the stone floor, firing bullets in wayward directions. I keep my eyes on the danger and undo my jacket, needing to get through to him.

Remind me who I am.

Krypt cuts Monster, which makes Ransom go insane. He attacks Krypt at the same time my brother drops from the platform above, landing right on Krypt’s shoulders. I rip my shirt open and toss it aside.

“Krypt! Stop!”

“Fucking stop him!”

“He’s my brother, Krypt! Don’t fucking do this! Keegan, please.”

The problem with fighting your brethren is that you don’t fight to kill. Krypt powers through them all because they’re hesitating, trying to keep him alive. He snaps and snarls and gives no fucks about how many of them he cuts and injures.

With a deep breath and a panicked mind, I shout, “Let him through!”

“Remi!”

“No!”

“Let him fucking through!”

Krypt breaks through all on his own, and I’m right here, within stabbing distance. His order is to kill me, and he plans to follow through. He’s lost

one knife somewhere in the fight, but he lifts the other. He grabs me by the back of my neck, draws me forward, and gets ready to stab.

“Cut here!” I raise my wrists. “If you’re gonna kill me, you’ll have to go through your brand on my skin. Fucking cut me here, Krypt.”

Ghost gasps, seeing the full extent of my scarred body for the first time, but it works. Slightly. Krypt hesitates, almost like he glitches. His orders are strong, the pull of them fierce, but something in what he sees on my body jolts him enough to create hesitation. Everyone else crowds in at his back, ready to haul him off me if he tries again.

“Well?” I shove my wrist right in front of him. “You gonna do it? You gonna kill me? Do it. Cut here.”

It’s barely noticeable, but his hand shakes and his eyes pulse. He stares at his name on my wrist, unblinking. His eyes leak as confusion mounts. His mind is a mess, and he doesn’t know what to listen to. Axel’s order, or the physical reminder of who he is and who I am right in front of him.

I watch him, ready to die here if he chooses to end me. It’ll break my family curse, anyway, *so fucking have at it, Krypt. You’re the only person I’ve ever loved, and it’d be a blessing to die by your hand.*

“Remi,” Ghost warns me, seeing the decision on my face. “Don’t.”

Remind me who I am.

Krypt’s watering eyes shift, taking in every tattoo, burn, and scar he’s left on my skin. When he gets to my chest, I put my hand there and look him straight in the eyes as I remind him who he is.

“We’re sicker together, remember?” My voice shivers, stuttering and betraying the absolute fear within me. It might be a blessing to die by Krypt’s hand, but now that he’s back in front of me, I’m choosing to be his, even though I’m free. I don’t want to die before I make him mine again. I tap the word burned into my skin. “We’re sicker together, Krypt.”

He blinks for the first time, and the whole chamber holds its breath. The Vile Boys are poised and ready to strike, Axel and Kyd watch with rapt interest, and Director clutches his arm and side, waiting to see what his trained soldier is going to do. I don’t know the state of the ten zombies, and maybe I don’t want to. All I care about at this moment is Krypt and whatever inner battles he’s fighting.

A sound comes out of him, something between a choke and a grunt. His hand still grips the hilt of the knife, but his knuckles are white and his wrist is shaking. His eyes stare at his name tattooed on my collarbone.

“Mine,” he says, barely audible.

“Even though you freed me, I’ll always be yours.” I lower my hands to my sides and let him make this decision. Can he fight Axel’s control, or will he kill me to follow orders? It’s up to him now.

His back straightens and his fingers dent the back of my neck, digging in so hard that pain shoots into my skull. He blinks again, keeping his eyes closed. His nostrils flare. The Vile Boys step forward...

I’ve never anticipated a moment so much in my life. Not when I took a suicide pill, and not when I almost gave up outside the door to this very chamber.

Open your eyes and see me, Krypt. Look at me as yours and remember all the ways we fester together to create something poetically eternal. See my sickness and let it match yours, and when we’re combined as one, love me as an obsession.

His eyes open. The silver sparkles at me, and beneath the surface, his monsters are back to rattling their chains. “Remiel,” he says, voice jittery and normal. “Fuck. Fuck. Remiel.” He doesn’t loosen his hand on my neck, but he pulls me tighter, dropping the knife.

I sag with assuagement and break wide open. My heart spills onto the floor and his possessive hands come around me, not to hug, but to contain.

“I’m... so...”

Sorry.

He’s never apologized to me for anything other than when I found out about Soren being a Vile member. I don’t know if I’m allowed to hug him, so I lean against him, press my cheek to the side of his head, and let it all out. All of it. The pain, the worry, the fear, and the fucking relief that he’s here, standing in front of me, breathing and alive.

“Ah! Amazing! It worked!” Axel excitedly shouts, still holding a blade to Kyd’s throat while Kyd stays cozy by trying to snuggle against his front. “Remarkable, Remi. This is the first time I’ve had absolute control of him, and I had to drug him to get it. Even through the brainwashing, the mind control, and the drug, you still broke him out of it. Absolutely remarkable.”

Nothing feels remarkable. I’m fucking angry! He’s had Krypt for two weeks, and I’ve realized how dependent I am on him. It’s pathetic, but Krypt is the driving force in my life, and I’ve never worried like I did while he was gone. As adrenaline fades, feelings flood back.

“Don’t,” Krypt whispers next to my ear. “Remiel.” He pushes me back so he can look at me. He takes his time studying everything about me, from my eyes and how tired they are to the healing my wounds have done. “Are you...”

I nod, expecting him to ask if I’m okay.

“Mine. Are you mine?”

My eyes brim with tears, and I feel stupid about it. Fuck. He’s seen and put me into so many humiliating positions that this should be nothing. But it’s not nothing. It’s the start of what we will become. It’s freedom and the choice to remain a prisoner. It’s a life meshed and a mind warped. It’s pain and comfort, depravity and sin, hopes and newfound desires. It’s nightmares that feel comfortable and curses that feel powerless.

“Remiel, are you mine?”

I grab the sides of his face, swiping my thumbs over his cheeks. He bristles at my touch but doesn’t move away. “I was yours the night I walked into Vile House. Free or not, I’m fucking yours.”

Krypt wraps his hand around my throat and squeezes hard. “Big fucking mistake, Remiel,” he says, but he looks relieved about it.

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WHO AM I NOW?

KRYPT

I ALMOST KILLED HIM, and I'm thankful for it.

He originally came to me intending to make me murder him. Everything he's done since then has fucked with my mind, making me wonder if it's real or if it's a trick to break me until I blackout and kill him just like he wants me to.

Now I know for sure.

Because he stopped me. He doesn't want me to kill him anymore, which means his intentions have changed and I can finally trust him. But having my trust, my attention, and being the object of my obsession won't be easy for him, and I have no plans of backing down from who I am. Remiel will either thrive or flounder under my interest, and it's up to him to decide. I'll control everything else.

He's worried about me. I can tell by the way he glances at me when he doesn't think I'm looking and the way his hand won't leave me. Even though he's subtle about it, it's always touching me, grazing my arm, butting up against my leg, or resting on my knee.

If I'm being honest, I need it.

Because I'm drained. Mentally and physically. I've been fighting with my mind for days, trying to keep Axel out. He denied me sleep to see if my mind would become pliable. He starved me until I was delusional. He mutated my memories into something else, made me believe lies, and tricked me into thinking Remiel had died. I almost snapped then, but some tether, whether it was a bone-deep knowing or a tickle of fate, told me he was still here, in my world.

Axel Graves is giving his show-and-tell report to Vile House. We're in the theatre room, tensions are high, and no one knows who to trust. He's proving to them that Reaper Corp is after Moros, and I can tell Director believes it. Somehow, Vile House is going to work with Axel Graves, and I fucking hate it because I want to kill that fancy prick. Wipe that pretty smile right off his dead face, and let Remiel witness the moment life blinks out of his eyes.

I haven't said a word since the meeting started. I haven't answered a single question about what happened to me, where the lab is, or if I'm okay. Because I don't know. I fucking failed. Axel turned off my tracker at the quarry and then poisoned me, and I've never felt more humiliated. I don't want to talk about it.

"I am formally requesting your permission to move my lab and studies to the South Ward of the asylum," Axel says.

Kyd sighs dreamily, and it pisses me off so much that I grab Remiel's wrist and dig my fingers into my name. It's healed considerably while I've been gone, and I don't fucking appreciate that. I'm the one who's supposed to heal him. Not time.

Shouting breaks out, all the boys fighting for control. Benton Wentworth and his billions of dollars are mentioned, Axel's source of funding, his birth father, Medic, and the threat of Reaper Corp. The asylum belongs to Vile House and Director's family, but it also belongs to Moros, and we're fiercely protective of it. Guess we'll just have to see if Moros is really what Axel wants to save, or if this is all just one elaborate con set to ruin us and our town.

"Go," Director says to me when I close my eyes to tune it all out. My head isn't right, which means I don't feel safe. "Rest."

I grab Remiel and drag him out of the theatre room.

But I don't take him to my room. I can't go in, knowing he suffered in there while I was gone. He asks me three times where we're going, and after my third silent answer, he shuts up. He shuts up through the tunnels, doesn't comment when I push him into the passenger seat of my SUV, and stays quiet as we drive down Death Row.

I stop in front of his shop, parking without a word. I breathe through my nose and try to stabilize. I'm not even sure what is eating me alive.

Panic. Fear. Exhaustion. An overwhelming sense of *everything* because Remiel fucking chose me. He wants me. He decided to be mine even

though I freed him. There's a small part of me that wonders if he only succumbed to it because he knew I wouldn't let him go anyway, but that minuscule chance that he really does want to belong to me is astounding. So much so that I'm struggling to manage it.

"Get your cello."

"Why?"

I grip the steering wheel, and he doesn't say more. When he gets out, closing the door behind him, I open my eyes to the nightly sights of Moros' downtown. Pedestrians walk, robed figures slink, and teens run between buildings and alleys. It's normal. Comfortable. Calm. The thick mist is natural, the cawing crows are familiar, and the shop signs are companionable. Everything is the same as when I left it, minus the Matter Cult and Gregory Malone.

So, why does it feel so different?

Is it because I'm insignificant? Moros doesn't need me. They need Vile House, but nothing and no one relied on me while I was trapped in Axel's bunker. I wasn't needed, missed, or required. Vile House can survive without me, like they have for decades before I came. I'm a blink in time of Moros history, a masked member of the ten. Do I deserve my mask?

Who would I be without it?

Did I do anything good while locked away? Did I give Axel the answers he was looking for? Will the newfound knowledge help him mind-control Reaper Corp to save our town?

Did Remiel even miss me? Did he look for me? Did he break apart into beautiful fragments, or did he hold himself together in my absence? Perhaps, like Moros, I'm a blip of time in his life, too.

I've never second-guessed like this before. Not since I was a child and my parents feared me for reasons unknown. Killing them was my awakening, and since that night, I've been confident and lethal, despite wishing for a diagnosis. Now I'm unsure about everything, and I don't know the root of it.

Remiel. But why? Why does his opinion matter? What importance does he play in the foundation of who I am? What difference does he make in *my* life when *I'm* the one who controls his?

What do I seek from him?

He looks into my eyes like he understands me, and that's not something I've experienced before. I think I crave it. Need more of it. Because Remiel

is the only person who ever saw my monsters and coaxed them into loving him. I don't think I'm capable of love, but whatever monsters live inside me are, and they picked Remiel, making me want to obsess over him forever to understand why. Why do they love him? Why do they change the way I think about life and its meaning?

What fucking control does Remiel Sauder have over me?

He puts his cello in the back and gets back in, buckling his belt. I pull onto the street without a word, unsure where I'm going. I drive past my house, the one I killed my parents in. Killian technically still lives there too, but we hardly stay there if we can help it. We should sell it, but it feels tattooed on our souls, unwilling to let us go, so we keep it and maintain it and stand in it when the urge strikes. I drive past Remiel's childhood home, remembering what Axel told me about his mom.

His dad was taking too long to die, so she...

Do I tell him?

She survived the night and probably got ordered to go back home. Remiel looks at the windows, craning his neck to see if he can spot her. Her vehicle is in the driveway, but no movement shows inside. I drive past, knowing he wants to ask. He doesn't.

I drive past the cemetery I throat-fucked him in, the streets I hunted him through, and the husk of his former house. He doesn't look at that one. On the single road that leaves Moros, I speed up until I come to the dirt path that leads to the hiking trails and mining tunnels.

Kyd brings people here to scream. I need Remiel to play his music.

Remiel hesitates at the mouth of the tunnel. Nerves work their way through him because he doesn't know why I've brought him here. To the residents of Moros, these mining tunnels are nicknamed The Mad House, because whatever you experience inside turns you into a different person if you make it out. It's a house of mirrors, a maze, a death trap, and a fun house all in one, and the only distinguishing factor is fear and solitude. It's hard to be alone in the dark with your own thoughts.

"Is this it?" he asks, his voice aimed at the tunnel's entrance. "You decided to kill me without being brainwashed?"

No... because I want life and him in it.

"Walk, Remiel." I shove him forward.

With his cello case slung over my shoulder, I follow him. I have a flashlight, but I don't click it on. Remiel can move as slowly as he wants, so

long as he keeps moving. This is his walk through The Mad House, and if he makes it out alive, I'll know he has what it takes to survive me.

Who is he now?

Who am I now?

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THE MAD HOUSE

REMIEL

I'VE NEVER BEEN a reflective person because I didn't put a lot of faith in my lifespan. Suicide was my ticket out, and I got comfortable in the reassurance of that.

When my second brother died, and I saw how it wrecked Soren and Selena, Vile House became my ticket to *redemption*. I still knew I'd die from the bargain I made, but I wanted to do something good with my death: end the Sauder curse.

I failed. Gave up, like I do with everything else. Became selfish enough to want to live through it because I fell for the devil who took my bargain. I went from wanting to entice him into killing me to being determined to live just to get the chance to know him, and now nothing is right, but everything is finally clear.

I love Krypt, the Vile Boy. I love Keegan Hallows, the teen who murdered his family. I love him in a way that isn't sane, comes with shame, and hurts so harshly it entices me into continuing just to survive the pain. But mostly, he scared me into a life I didn't know I dreamt about. A life of extraordinary highs and ravaging lows. A life with him at the helm, conducting the progression of who I am and how I live. Because he made me realize that I have no idea who I am or what I'm doing, and I'm someone who likes to be told. I've never known a more suitable dictator.

I want to live now. But only if he's there, ruling me from above and challenging me to prosper. Only if I get to look into his eyes and see what thrashes within, drawing them out to help him understand himself. I want his sickness to infect me like poison, spreading throughout my bloodstream to taint me with his darkness. And in return, I want to give him the antidote

to a mind that plagues him. A mind that doesn't understand who he is or why his parents didn't love him. Krypt is a man with layers, but he doesn't delve into his deep ones because he's never wanted to before. He's a surface-level villain with an antihero core.

Feelings scare him much like he scares me. I come alive while afraid. But how will he react to fear?

The mining tunnels under the mountain have always been a source of fables around Moros. People go in and they never come out. Screams can be heard on calm nights when the fog isn't too thick, drifting all the way down to Moros' main street. The locals take pause, respecting the scream of a person either finding themselves or haunting themselves, knowing what it feels like to be challenged by Moros.

Countless unsolved crimes and missing persons' cases lead to these tunnels, these mountains, and they remain unsolved because Trigger Mountain has power, granted and given by Moros.

The Mad House, these dark passageways are called. I've already started my trip into madness, so I'm about to see how far down the rabbit hole I can go. Trigger Mountain might find my trigger yet.

Drips echo all around me, not making their whereabouts known. The echoes cause confusion and morph everything into an ominous sound that slithers down my spine and sparks all my survival instincts to life. *There it is, my will to live.*

My shoes turn damp and my skin becomes sensitive, the fine hairs on my arms standing straight to taste the air that shrouds us. I don't know if Krypt is far behind or way ahead of me, and for once, I don't want to know. This differs from being chased through the corridors of the asylum. That place was full of physical threats, but the only threat in here is me. My instincts, my mind, and my strength.

It's time I face myself.

I keep my hand on the stone wall of the tunnel, feeling my way through the darkness. Where I'm going, I don't know, but I trust that my body will get me there or Krypt will herd me there. I walk on uneven ground, feel movement beneath my hands, and hear things that may or may not actually be there.

A voice.

A memory.

A moment.

The happiness my dad experienced on the very day he swallowed so many pills they killed him. *How did that happen?*

My brother, who struggled for so long and eventually hung himself when Gregory Malone got to him. *How did that happen?*

My brother, who was fine one day and not the next, cut his wrists and bled out on his own gravesite. *How did that happen?*

What will my ending be? What will my method be? *What will I regret in my final six minutes?*

It's not fear that overcomes me, it's sadness. Sadness for lives unlived and lost. Missing time and a scrapbook that finishes early, too many blank pages at the end. It's grief for so much carnage, and pain because loss hurts deeper than anything. It's a sad determination that wants me to end this curse to protect Soren because, other than Krypt, he's the person I care most about. Hate and love mingle between me and Soren, but even our hatred is founded in a sense of love, and we both share that with Selena.

I have a family. A brother, a sister, a best friend, a Krypt. Things to fight for and a reason to exist. I'm important and wanted.

With the end of the tunnel and a corner upon me, the mood changes. Sadness turns to fear when my name hisses through the hollow pits, meeting my ears at different times in differing tones. My temples prickle and my throat goes dry, knowing this stretch will test my durability. It's beckoning my sanity and wanting to strip it away, but I'm stronger now because Krypt strengthened me. He taught me to live in fear, and now I'm partly comfortable here.

I free you, Remiel.

Freedom means death, and I'm not ready to die. My mangled flesh and scarred body have to mean something. The pain of it can't be for nothing, and if life and death are ahead of me, offering themselves as pretty options in a '*this or that*' game, I pick life. I pick me. I pick Krypt and all the beautiful ways he'll scare me. I pick selfish needs over protecting my family from the curse. Because I'm selfish now.

I've never been a strong person, but I want to fight. No matter how much it terrifies me. No matter how strong the pull of suicide tugs at me. Fear makes me crazy, so I smile at the darkness and peer through the shadows to see what they want to show me.

Shapes and movement. Ghosts and demons. Regrets from the past and regrets not yet lived. They're all there, taunting me forward, trying to trap

me in my madness. Because I *am* fucking mad. No sane person does what I've done and feels how I feel, and I no longer care about right or wrong because those choices aren't mine to make. They're his. He gets to decide what happens to me and how it happens, and the only choice I get in the matter is how I react to it.

"Krypt!" I shout, listening to the warped version of my voice bounce back at me. "I fucking choose you! Free or not, you're mine!" I laugh, crazed and pathetic, defiant about it. "Is this what you want? You want me to hope that you'll pick me back? You'll trick me into falling for you, and then you'll kill me like I've wanted all along?" *So poetic.*

I failed Ophelia in her time of death, and now Krypt will fail me in mine.

But a surge of strength rises within me, and I shake the thought away. Krypt won't kill me. He'll keep me.

I laugh harder. It's a weird sensation, tickling my throat and making my head ache. I can't remember the last time I laughed freely, and with nothing but phantoms to hear me, I do it now. I laugh so hard the reverberation of it creates sinister music in surround sound. I laugh hard enough to cry, and when heaving sobs of riotous glee make me cough, I buckle forward and hack at the ground. I cough so forcefully that I fall to my knees, but I'm comfortable here. So comfortable, I sprawl out on my stomach and press my cheek to a cool puddle.

Everything settles. Silence. It's a moment in time that carries weight because it's the pivotal point of no return. It's a choice I didn't know I had.

The *Mad Hatter* said, '*We're all mad here.*'

Einstein said, '*Insanity is doing the same thing over and over and over and expecting different results.*'

Alan Watts said, '*In madness lies sanity.*'

William Shakespeare said in *Hamlet*, '*Though this be madness, yet there is a method in't.*'

Madness is of the mind. To experience true sanity, I must free myself from my mind. A full break. Shut it off and live without it.

Laughter feels so far away now.

The Mad House of Trigger Mountain breathes around me. Cool, damp air pants across my nape and lifts the hem of my shirt. It drips tears on my head and whispers promises of protection if I just stay here a little longer. It

holds my hands from below, and I dig my fingers into its embrace, comforted by the way it cradles me.

I close my eyes and listen to it live. There's history here, stories of love and loss, a decadent mingling of never and forever. It's convincing. Trigger Mountain loves in a way that makes me want to stay. I could be here, living in the darkness with an abundance of nothing and a mind snapped free. It's easy. Because *'we're all mad here.'*

“Remiel.”

...but life is so much more terrifying, and finally, I'm picking me. I smile again.

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HAUNTING & LOVELY

KRYPT

“I CHOSE to die from my life to willingly live in a nightmare,” Remiel mutters. “Irony.”

He’s right, in a sense. He is going to die from his life, but I’ll be the nightmare he lives in. Not this mountain or these tunnels. Remiel is fucking mine, and our nightmare starts now.

Because he chose to find his way out of the tunnels. He picked himself. He picked me and a life we’ll live together. He discovered his way to this open cavern on his own, stumbled in with a crazed smile on his handsome face, and I didn’t hate the way it looked. It’s gone now, but I can tell it isn’t far away. He’s half gone, slipping into insanity because he’s learning to be comfortable there.

“Sit.”

“Aren’t I free?” he challenges me, taking wobbly steps because The Mad House is getting to him.

“Define freedom.” I tug on his shirt and push him to sit on the edge of a rock.

“Hell,” he says, staring at the cave instead of me.

It’s open and wide, has a high ceiling despite how deep within the mountain it is, and a fissure in the roof lets a little moonlight in. Ah, me and Remiel, reflecting under the moonlight yet again.

“Whose hell? Yours or mine?”

“Mine,” he answers, watching me now that I’m taking his cello out of the case. “Your hell locked me out when you set me free with a fucking calling card. Coward.”

It was cowardly, but I growl at him anyway. “You think you deserve more than a calling card? You’re the only person I’ve ever sent one to.”

He looks at my eyes, but his are mostly blank. “Liar. You gave one to Gregory Malone.”

I grin, remembering that. “On your behalf.”

“You never told me what it said.” I did. I told him that it said Malone’s suffering would be everlasting if he so much as looked at Remiel again, and I’ll deliver upon that. “And yeah, I do think I deserve more than a calling card if you’re going to break up with me.”

“Break up?” I lift his cello out of the case. “You think this is a relationship?”

“Not a romantic one,” he scoffs.

“Then don’t expect romantic things from me. I claimed you with a calling card, so what’s more poetic than a calling card declaring your freedom?” I put the cello between his legs, and Remiel holds it on instinct.

“This,” Remiel says, motioning at the cavern. “This feels like true freedom.”

“How so?”

“Freedom from living,” he says. “Because it’s come to that, hasn’t it? You’re too much of a coward to admit how you feel, so you’ll end my life to avoid it. At least I’ll die playing nice music.”

I’m so fucking tired, but to see him spark up some sass just because he wants me to admit I’m not going to kill him has my cock hard. “Better get playing that nice music then, hero.” I hand him the bow.

He doesn’t ask questions or put up a fight, he simply starts playing quietly, letting the harmony find itself. I step back to watch him. Whatever he wants to tell me, it’ll come out in his music, and I know how to hear it now. But while he plays, he’s going to listen to me.

“You’re a hypocrite. You know that?” I ask.

He looks up, fingers and bow still moving. “I know. But how?”

“You claim I’m too cowardly to tell you how I feel, but it was you who said you don’t need me.”

“But that I want you,” he corrects.

“Mm.” I hum, undoing my jacket. “Yet I told you I shattered. I told you that my love is an obsession, and I’m obsessed with you. I told you that you are important to me, and I marked the proof of that into your skin.”

His music deepens, and his eyes shine wet and blue.

“I asked if you would be mine even if you were free, and then I freed you.”

“With a calling card.”

I smirk and shrug out of my jacket. “If anyone is a coward, Remiel, it’s you.”

“Why?”

“Because you still choose death over me.” I pull my t-shirt off, and Remiel’s eyes drop to the burn on my chest. “You almost embraced it. The night you took that pill. Last night, when you confronted me under Axel’s control. And today, just now, when you lay down inside a mountain to give up.”

“Not give up,” he states, transforming his music into something new and dismal. “Accept. It’s fate.”

“Is it?” I undo my pants.

“My fate. A fate I am trusting you to overpower.” Remiel smiles at my hands and keeps playing. “Only you would be powerful enough to challenge fate, Krypt. Are you going to?”

It’s his way of admitting he wants to live and that he wants me to control him. It’s perfect. “I *am* fate. Your fate.”

“Yet you freed me.”

I kick my boots off. “And you choose me anyway.”

“I did,” he agrees.

“But when I almost killed you, that’s what really sealed our fate.” I push my pants over my ass and hips. “Because you stopped me.”

He looks away from the bulge in my boxer-briefs to study my eyes. It clicks with him, and he plays a little softer when he figures it out. “Ah, so now you trust me? Now that you know I’m not tricking you into killing me.”

I step out of my pants, barely feeling the chilled air against my heated skin. “Two weeks ago, Axel Graves hypnotized me. Honestly, I think I let him because I wanted to know what was hiding in my mind.”

Remiel stiffens, not liking that someone took control of me. We still haven’t talked about my time away, and if I get my way, we won’t until I’ve slept. “What was hiding?”

“You, I think. He videotaped the session, and your name was the only one that ever came out. What do you live for, Krypt? *Remiel*. What do you

dream of, Krypt? *Remiel*. What do you fear most, Krypt? *Remiel*. What would you die for, Krypt? *Remiel*.”

Remiel’s fingers slip on the fingerboard, but he corrects them as his eyes soften. “What do you want, Krypt?” he carries on the line of questioning.

Him. Not much else.

“He dug deeper, trying to get me to admit any other desire. He found all sorts of personality traits and learned a lot about how I’d react to a situation, but he never got another name.” I run my fingers through my hair and look into his eyes. “Just you, Remiel. Because it hasn’t been long, but obsession works fast. Love is obsession, and obsession is the point of my life. To own and possess my obsession, to do what you said that night on my bed. *Love is caring enough about someone to know what they need and wanting to give it to them*.” I wet my lips. “I know what you need, and I want to give it to you. Even if you hate me for it.”

“Krypt.”

“Yes,” I agree. “Krypt and Remiel. That’s our fate.” I turn my back to him and let him look. Because not all my time at Axel’s bunker was horrible. I found out what means the most to me, and it’s not Remiel. It’s *me and Remiel*. Krypt and Remiel. And I marked my body for him.

My Vile House tattoo has always been a source of pride, but my gifted name under the skeleton’s jaw was the source of my true accomplishment. I became Krypt and finally felt like myself. Now, Remiel’s name sits with mine because he is not only my source of pride, but my source of liberation. He is love. He is obsession. He is mine, and I am his, and not even death, fate, or a fucking suicide curse will tear us apart.

Remiel is life. *Krypt and Remiel* is the only future I want.

His cello clatters to the stone floor, and his bow follows. I don’t look, but I sense his approach. Hesitantly, his fingertips touch my skin. The tattoo is still healing, but I come to life under his touch. It spurs a buried need and morphs into something dangerous, but the rightness of it is so apparent that I close my eyes to appreciate the choice. Remiel Sauder walked into Vile House and became the driving force of *me*.

“I’m... you... this is... Krypt?” Tears choke his voice and turn it squeaky.

I turn, grabbing his outstretched hand. “My love is dangerous, Remiel.” I tilt his chin and watch him cry. “I warned you.”

“I want it anyway,” he says, crying harder. “I want it *and* I need it. I need you.”

No, he doesn’t, but I’m selfish enough to appreciate that he thinks he does. I sure as shit need him, but I’ll never tell him that. There is so much yet to come. A dangerous life with Reaper Corp trying to take over, truths to tell him about his mom and his brain, and lessons to teach him about life and what it means to live it with me. They’ll all come in time.

Tonight, I want to fucking possess him.

Remiel notices the shift in my eyes, and his head shakes. “No,” he says, begging. “Don’t tell me to run. I don’t want to be chased. I’m done running from you through dark tunnels.”

I’ve learned that Remiel loves fear. At first, I thought it was that stalking feeling that came with the way I hunted him. It’s not that. Remiel’s fears are mostly of himself, the unknown, and loss. Remiel fears being invisible. But he also fears unpredictability, and tonight, I’m going to be unpredictable.

“No more running,” I tell him. I grab both of his hands and bring them to cradle my head. He spreads his fingers through my hair and looks me straight in the eyes.

“I missed you.”

I needed the time away from him to learn how much I wanted him. “You aren’t free anymore, hero.”

His hands shake in my hair.

“I will never free you again. Are you sure you want to make this decision?”

He wets his lips. “Do I have a choice?”

“The illusion of one.”

He smiles. “I don’t want to be free from you. But... would you have...”

“Yes.” I drop my hands to his pants and start undoing them. “Even as Keegan, you intrigued me. That’s your question, right? Would I want you even if you hadn’t made a bargain with me?”

He nods, not paying attention to his pants. I let them drop to pool around his ankles, and he kicks them off without noticing.

“You interested me growing up, but I never learned to obsess over you until you looked straight into my eyes and didn’t back away.” I let him look now, loving that he wants to. “But I never would have gotten the chance to own you if you hadn’t made a bargain.”

“Well, at least Gregory Malone did one thing right. He chased me to Vile House that night.”

I pinch his hip and glare at him. “What’d—”

“Yeah, yeah. No speaking other names while I’m half naked.”

My puppy is already so well-trained. I’ve used a punishment method so far, but right now, I’m going to try the reward system. I sink to my knees in front of him, eyes on his. I don’t know how to feel about it yet. His lips part in awe or shock, and his fingers tighten in my hair. I’ve never serviced him before. Briefly that night he was chained to the gate, but nothing more than that. I want to. I’m nervous to.

Remiel’s cock thickens in front of my face, and my mouth waters for the taste of it. The hitch of his breath makes everything sexier, but the blue of his eyes captures me. He’s not a man who is familiar with being pleased. He’s the one who works on demand, fixes their instruments and orders them parts. He’s the body I’ve used and abused and the mouth I’ve raped. My fingers have touched him only while drugged or scared, and the look of gratitude that mingles with nervousness is everything to me. Because he deserves it.

He chose me. And that warrants a reward.

I grab his hip with one hand and his cock with the other. Sliding it down the length of him, his foreskin pulls back to reveal a shiny tip, flushed red and weeping for me. I lean in to lick it, drawing a gasp from him. The touch of his hot flesh against my tongue ignites my blood and deepens my darkness, but nerves are still more powerful.

I’ve never done this before.

He’s going to know.

I should have fucking drugged him again.

“Krypt,” he says, fingers softening in my hair. “Look at me.”

I can’t. My face burns, and embarrassment turns me sour. I hate being mocked. I hate feeling embarrassed.

“Look at me.”

I look up, unfamiliar with being beneath someone. Not since my parents were alive. But Remiel isn’t looking down on me as if I’m nothing more than an unwanted soul. He wants every part of me, my damage, my control, my sickness, and my inexperience.

“Open.”

“Don’t fucking make demands of me, Remiel.”

“Open,” he whispers.

My lips open, and I fucking hate it. His hips shift forward, and my hand digs in to hold him back, but not before the head of his cock presses against my parted lips. He gyrates, sliding the slick tip around the outside of my mouth, coating my lips in precum until my tongue naturally wants to lick it away. I lick my lips and his dick in the process, and then I do it again because he tastes like cravings. Hot embarrassment turns to heated need.

“Open,” he whispers.

I watch him and open. Remiel slides his cock along my tongue, but not too far. He pulls out and then does it again until I’m leaning forward on my own, taking him a little further each time. When his cock hits the back of my tongue, I gag, and a moment of bemused regret consumes me.

I never gave him the grace he’s giving me the night I abused his throat over a dead girl’s body. I should be sorry about it.

I’m not.

When I’m taking most of his cock and his shaft is slick with spit, he holds my hair tighter and uses it to rock into my mouth at a faster pace.

“You were practicing, weren’t you?” he asks, voice raspier. “That night you drugged me.”

Fuck him. I bite down and he yelps. A laugh follows.

“Jesus. Why are you so sensitive about it? Who cares if you’d never been with a guy before and needed to practice?”

Fuck him again. I spit his dick out and turn him around. Forcefully, I bend him over until his hands brace on the rock. I can’t fucking bear for him to look at me right now. “Can’t keep your fucking mouth shut while I’m trying to be good to you, Remiel?” I spread his ass cheeks and shove my face between them.

“Ah, fuck,” he groans.

I lick at his rim and shove my tongue into his hole, desperate to open him up and claim him. His ass rocks back in time with my tongue, and his balls hang heavy between his legs. My tongue roams, feeling every part of him, the way his ass flutters, twitching to be filled. Sliding my tongue inside him, I feel my own cock pulse, loving the way it feels to consume him in a new way. Remiel moans like the men in the videos I studied, so I do it again. And again. But I need to see his flesh and all my marks on it. Standing, I rip his sweater and t-shirt over his head and toss it to the ground, admiring the way his spine straightens when I grab hold of him again.

“I care,” I answer his question, shoving my fingers into his mouth so he can’t speak. “Because it wasn’t just sex with a guy. It was sex in general.”

He mumbles around my fingers, but I shove them in hard enough to make him gag and splutter so he can’t talk back. When they’re nice and slick, I pull them free and bend him forward again. I press them to his hole, easing one inside.

“You were a virgin?”

I slam my hand over his mouth. “Stop asking questions, Remiel.” I spit on his ass and watch it roll down to my fingers. Pushing it inside of him, I ease him open and debate how many honest answers I want to give him. “No. I wasn’t a virgin. But you were the first—”

“First what?” he asks, pulling my hand away from his mouth. “Don’t hide from me, Krypt. You’ve literally seen me piss myself and cry with your cock down my throat.”

I spit on his hole again, adding a third finger. Is three too many? The videos showed three, but my cock is thicker than three. “You were the third time I’d had sex. Ever. I didn’t enjoy the first two times. No more questions.”

Remiel, brave tonight, forces me back so he can turn around. My hand slips free, and his eyes meet mine. So do all his scars and tattoos.

Sick. Shatter. Krypt.

Fuck, he’s stunning.

“The third time?”

Don’t fucking look at me! “What’d I just say about questions?” I snarl at him, wrapping my fingers around his throat and pushing him down onto his back. He cries at the impact and winces at the rough stone digging into his back, but he never looks away from me. “I hated sex. Never wanted to have it. Until you. Fucking happy?”

“Yes,” he rasps. “Only me. Never anyone else!” he shouts.

“Possessive?”

“Yes,” he seethes. “I don’t care if you fucking finger me while I’m drugged or rape me because you can’t help yourself, so long as it’s me.”

Pathetic. I love it. I spread his knees with my hips, and Remiel pulls them back on his own. “So desperate, Remiel.”

“So what? You made me this way!” he screams, his voice echoing through the cavernous space. “You turned me into this vile, pathetic man

who craves deprivation and wants to be abused. What the fuck is wrong with me? What did you do to me?"

"Exactly what I wanted." I spit on my hand and rub it into my cock. His glistening hole isn't wet enough, so I spit there, too, wishing there was lube. Craving his blood even more. "Remember how you loved to point fingers at me, Remiel? You blamed me for everything, and sure, I'll take it, but look at you now. Who's the sick one?"

"I am."

"That's right, hero. You're fucking sinister."

"Yes." He sucks on his fingers and slides them into his ass. "I'm so sinister that I want you to fuck me so hard I can't breathe. I want to hurt. I want to shatter like I made you shatter."

"Thought you didn't like pain?"

"Maybe I crave the pain you cause me," he snips at me.

I rip his hand away. "This is my ass. You don't get to finger fuck it."

"Then hurry up and fuck it."

"Put your hands behind your head." I nudge my cock to his hole. "Now."

He links his fingers and puts them behind his head, his dirty-blond hair getting messy from them. His cheeks redden and his eyes blaze, but his cock has never been harder.

"You've already ruined me," he says.

"Finger-pointing again?" I push in a few inches, and tingles of pleasure tickle my balls.

"At myself. I wanted to be ruined. I let you."

"Let me?" I laugh, and fucking hell, it's a crazed sound. "You fucking *let me* ruin you? You think you had that much control?"

"I did."

I slam into him, and he loses his breath. The dryness stings a bit, so I pull out and spit again. I fuck into him hard a few times, still laughing. Unsure why. It's a combination of exhaustion and suffering from the past two weeks, relief that Remiel is here with me again, and goddamn joy that he's admitting how dark and dirty he's become. I did that. We did that. We fucked the concept of right and wrong and turned it into something immoral that works for us. I'm narcissistic enough to take all the credit, because if it weren't for me being an irrational heathen, Remiel would have shied away and withered under the impending doom of his suicide.

“Where’s your control now, hero?” I squeeze his thighs. “You just lay there like a helpless little doll.”

“Yeah, and get exactly what I want while doing it.” His smile is devious and cruel. It makes me feel comfortable. I understand deviance and cruelty, and Remiel is finally speaking my language. “Did you listen to my music?” he asks. “The music I just played for you.” His arms flex with restraint, my name on his wrists on full display.

I dip my eyes and follow the track that the suicide pill took from his mouth, down his throat, and into his stomach. *Shatter. X marks the path. A slice to free it from his body.* “It was a horror lullaby.” I tug him closer, the rock scraping against his back. “You wanted me to know that you’re soft and scared.”

“It was romance,” he corrects. “My interpretation of it. Haunting and lovely.”

I look at his face, his lips wet and his eyes glossy. “Lovely?”

Remiel nods. He removes one of his hands from behind his head and touches mine. I startle, going still inside him, but he takes my fingers from his bruised hips and wraps them around his cock. Slowly, he moves my hand up and down his length. “It’s lovely the way you haunt me. Every part of my life is dictated by you now. When you’re gone, I feel you stalking me. When you’re near, I’m attracted to your monsters. When I sleep, you haunt my dreams. And when you’re inside me like this, vulnerable but dangerous about it, it shows me exactly who you are. Because I demanded rough enough to hurt, yet you’re being gentle with me while adding roughness to your words. You’re a fucking riddle, Krypt. I love trying to figure you out.”

“Stop trying.” Because I don’t know why I’m being gentle. I crave it, something different. Something that separates him from the violent way I interact with everyone else. I want to war with him over everything, but I want him to fight me back hard enough to challenge me. I want him to submit by choice rather than demand, and I want him to fear and love me simultaneously. What does love feel like?

“Never,” Remiel says.

I bend over him, slamming my mouth to his just to shut him up and taste all the words I don’t want him to speak aloud. I rock into him and fumble my coordination with my hand on his dick, but I don’t stop, and Remiel doesn’t care that I’m clumsy.

Pressure builds and turns into pleasure. It's been a long time since I came, and I refuse to be embarrassed about my reaction to him. It should be a compliment, so I press my forehead to his, thrust into him slow and deep, and listen to the way he gasps every time my thumb swipes his slit.

"I love you," he whispers.

"Stop."

"I love you."

I groan, barely holding it together. "Shut up."

"Ahhhh, Krypt," he moans, breath fanning my mouth. "I fucking love you."

"Remiel," I snarl.

The confession hits a crescendo, and heat radiates from the centre of my chest. I stop breathing, consumed by bliss and scared of his love, filling his ass with the proof of my pleasure. Remiel's hands come back to where they started, weaving through my hair to tug my face to his. He whispers his love against my lips and then kisses me as his cock throbs in my hand and coats me in his mess. My ass muscles clench and a breath whooshes out of me, and on that breath, I say, "I'm obsessed with you."

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GIVE ME FEAR

REMIEL

I'M OBSESSED WITH YOU.

He loves me. In whatever way makes sense to him, he loves me, and I'm so struck by his admission that I don't notice our bodies have gone from rigid to relaxed, cum slicked between us, and Krypt's usually volatile energy is calm.

In a move so unfamiliar to him, he pulls back to look at me... almost sweetly. His eyes on mine—his beasts gentle and slumbering while my heart thrashes. Because... because something feels different.

Yes, I want him to love me. I want him to be obsessed with me. I want tender moments and savage ones. But this moment, the one that's become the epicentre of our forward trajectory, the declarations and the words with meanings that mark the progression from before he loved me to after he loved me... it doesn't feel right to have him so timid.

"Why are you... you said you don't respond to soft." I tilt my head at him, confused by his reaction. Because if Krypt is going to love me and obsess over me, I want him to do it as himself. Not as a version of himself he thinks he needs to be to appease me. "Why are you being soft?"

He squints at me, a beast or two waking up within him. "You just survived The Mad House, played me your music, endured a fuck, and told me you..." he swallows the end of the sentence. "I don't want to hurt you right now, Remiel."

I'm pathetic because it hurts me that he doesn't want to. "Then don't, but you still have to be yourself! I've never felt this... comfortable and at ease around you."

"You want me to hurt you?" His voice is mocking. "No."

My eyes widen and my anger flares. He's telling me no? After everything he's done to me and every instance he's refused to listen to my no? Fuck that. Fuck him. I push myself to sit on the edge of the rock, and when he backs away, I grab a fistful of his shaggy hair and tug so hard a few more beasts brew.

"You don't get to say no to me." I glare at him with a hardened expression I've never had before. A power I've never felt before.

"Don't I?" he mocks, still thinking I'm beneath him. "What the fuck is it you're actually asking for here? Pain?"

"No."

"Pleasure?"

"Maybe."

He nods at my abs, still slick with cum from minutes ago. "Tell me what you want, Remiel." He leans forward instead of away, close enough that the silver of his eyes swirls turbulently. "Fucking tell me."

"Scare me."

His nostrils flare.

"Fear. I want fear." My chest heaves and my heart hammers, the admission monumental because it's the first time I've asked for it. "Don't obsess over me as someone other than yourself. You scare me, Krypt. Keegan. You scare me, and I fucking like it when you scare me, so stop treating me—"

I scream when he hauls me to my feet, the brands on my wrist burning under his tight grip. Krypt doesn't care. He said he didn't want to hurt me, but he has no problem following through when his foundation is being questioned.

He drags me across the cave, pulling me deeper and deeper into a dark spot with a low ceiling, my sock feet scraping across the stone floor and my skin turning red under his grip. I scream the whole time, begging him to stop, to let me go, to tell me what he's doing! But he doesn't, and I love that he doesn't. Because something about the way he makes me terrified is invigorating, and this is exactly what I asked for.

Throwing me onto my stomach, Krypt pins me down with his knee. The real fear begins. Because I'm looking down. Down. Down. Down. Into a black abyss with no bottom and no end, and for all I know, it could go straight to the pits of Hell. The upper half of my body hangs over a cliff's

edge. A cliff, in the middle of a deep cave, proving that depth has no bounds.

“Look,” Krypt growls at me, his voice back to jittering. “Look and see your fucking future if you piss me off again. You don’t want to know how many people have pissed me off and ended up down there.” He pushes on the back of my head so hard my body slides and I scream into the abyss, listening to my terror echo back at me from the vastness below. “Happy?” he asks.

“Yes,” I whimper. “Because this is you! The real you. Keegan and Krypt together.”

He laughs, and the way it reverberates off the cave’s walls is debilitating and grossly harmonious. “This is you, Remiel! You! You’re the one who craves the fear. You’re the one who sinks under a love confession but comes alive as soon as your life hangs in the balance. Can I love you now? Can I love you while you’re terrified of me?”

Yes. Yes. Yes. Because something is terribly wrong with me. I’m no longer suicidal and tempting death, but I still crave the danger and the lashing of anxiety that reminds me I’m alive. Terror wakes me up. Fright brings me to life. When every hair on my body is erect, I spark and snap, thriving because it’s such a blatant reminder of who I am, what I have to live for, and how much stronger I am now.

Before Krypt, fear rendered me useless. Gregory Malone stalked me through the streets of Moros and turned me into a scared little boy. The constant worry of suicide filled me with so much dread that I hid for half my life. I forgot to live it because I was so scared of it ending.

But since Krypt, I relish the sensation of being so afraid because it doesn’t make me weak anymore. It strengthens me because I can cope. It turns me on because there’s still a part of me that gets a rise out of the simplicity of an accident. One little shove and I’d fall to my death. One wrong move and I’d be lost to the abyss down below. To sit on the precipice of life and death is an aphrodisiac so strong my cock hardens again, digging into the stone and gravel beneath me.

I’m addicted to fear, but I’m a junkie for the way Krypt delivers it.

I laugh. Because I’m crazy. “Love me, Krypt.”

“Jesus,” he groans, pulling me back a little and flipping me onto my back. Only my head hangs over the ledge, and when he looks down at me, my stomach flutters. Because I see his obsession that means love, but I also

see something new. The mingling of sick and silly in the way he's smiling at me. I've never seen him playful before, and to be honest, I didn't know he had it in him. "What scares you more, hero, me, or that fall?" He nods to the ledge.

Relaxing my neck muscles, I let my head fall back. It hangs in the dark air, and I close my eyes to see if the sensation of falling heightens. I feel the sturdy ledge under my back, the deadly fall beneath my head, and the strong grip Krypt has on my arms.

"You," I answer.

He slides me over the edge a bit more and I sweat all over. Sitting on my shins, he relaxes his hold on my arms until I'm bending backwards, hanging with my whole upper body over the open space. I breathe harder, my eyes opening to see the path to death.

"Still me?" he asks. He lets go of my wrists altogether, and I cry out in fear, scrambling to latch onto him again. He laughs. Fuck, I love it when he laughs. "Backwards, Remiel. So, you're scared of me, but hold on to me for safety? Which is it? Am I your danger or your safety net?"

"Both." My abs and the mostly healed slice on my stomach burn when I pull myself up by them, sitting right on the tipping point with my back to the blackness. "You're my sanity and my insanity."

He hums at that. "You know what I think?" he asks, pulling me up a little more. "I think you'd be three times more afraid if I wasn't here. Everything is more terrifying when you're alone."

I panic. "Don't leave me."

He backs away, and when I try to scramble after him, he kicks out, planting his foot on my chest. My bony ass is unsteady, sitting right on the edge. "Sit there. Alone. Don't fucking move. I'll be right back." He lowers his foot. "If you aren't here when I get back, I'll jump down there to follow you."

Then he walks away. Leaves me here. Sitting on the lip of the underworld. If I lean back, I'll fall straight down its throat and end up in Hell's belly. Now that he's gone and not taking my attention, I hear things I hadn't heard before. They're the same sounds I heard in The Mad House. Whispers and secrets. Drips and echoes.

They turn me cold and set off my goosebumps. Phantom, imaginary fingers brush up my spine, tickling me, teasing me, trying to entice me to

tip back and surrender to the fall. It's honestly tempting, but... my will to live is so much stronger now.

I'm fortified here in this new life of mine. I smile at the taunt of death but turn my back on the promise of it. It's within reach if I ever need it, but it's not the thing I turn to anymore. Krypt is. That makes me smile. In the middle of a black cave, all alone, with a lethal fall at my back, my naked, dirty, cum-slicked body sitting on jagged stones, and a maniac somewhere nearby, I smile because I'm happy.

Happiness isn't an emotion I'm too familiar with, and the way it warms my core but flutters my stomach is comfortable. Wanted. It makes me want to laugh during dangerous games with Krypt, then end up in bed together and have a night that depends on his mood—gentle and close together when he's calm; painful and sinister when he's not.

"Still in this world, hero?"

I startle when his voice doesn't come from one clear direction. It travels up my spine, but whispers against my lips, too. "Yes." My teeth chatter.

Bright light blinds me, coming closer. I shield my eyes, trying to squint past the beam to see my monster. "You need to learn to make the danger fun," he tells me, his voice not as jittery as usual. "You're allowed to be scared and happy. Terrorized and laughing."

"Am I?" I ask, still squinting. "Since when do you know so much about fear?"

"I cause it for a living, Remiel." He bends down in front of me. "You know what I like about you?" He lowers the light, shining it on my wet cock.

"What?"

"That you see one threat. The one behind you." He nods at the drop.

"And the one in front of me." I nod at him.

"What about that one?" The flashlight's beam goes up, and when my eyes follow it, I gasp. "You forget to assess your surroundings, hero. Same as the night Ophelia died. You were so focused on her, you didn't even know I was watching you."

Above me, a large and very heavy stalactite hangs from the roof of the cave. The mineral formation has formed from water dripping from the ceiling, and this particular one is so long that it's less than a foot above my head. And it doesn't look stable. He's right. Despite having that sixth sense, I don't always pay attention to my surroundings. I would never have

noticed the one above me if he hadn't pointed it out, and now that he has, I realize I'm surrounded.

A deadly fall at my back.

A madman at my front.

A crushing death above me.

Trigger Mountain all around me, ready to swallow my soul.

I look at Krypt, meeting his eyes in the flashlight's glow. My heart is thumping like crazy, but instead of wanting to move out from under the danger, I grin at him.

"There you are," he says, voice scratchy and playful. "Fun and fear. That's what you need. Not everything needs to be so dire, Remiel." He pushes on my chest and pulls my body back until only my head hangs over the edge again. Positioning the flashlight to point at the stalactite, I stare up at it, wondering if it'll kill me while Krypt watches.

"I don't think I want to die anymore," I admit. "Not even by your hand or by accident. I'm selfish because I'm no longer trying to end the family curse."

Krypt's hands slide up my bare legs, passing over my stirring cock to caress my stomach and chest. "When you asked me to kill you to end your curse, I almost killed your uncle to end it."

Jesus. I didn't even think of that. "What stopped you?"

"I didn't want our bargain to end," he admits. "I didn't want to free you." He pinches my nipples, making me hiss. "And now that you're mine, even after I freed you, you're mine forever."

"Not if I fall over this cliff when that thing falls on me."

"Remiel," Krypt says, voice serious. "I'll move this goddamn mountain to stop it from killing you."

Oh my fucking... "Krypt," I moan when he blows dust off my cock, using his hand to remove the rest. He takes me into his mouth, and my head hangs over the precipice, eyes staring upward. Krypt doesn't really know how to suck a dick, but neither do I, so it doesn't matter. I'll keep it to myself, but I love that he has an insecurity about sex. He's more inexperienced than I am and doesn't like to draw attention to that, but I love it.

Because I'm just as possessive as he is.

Grabbing my knees, he bends them up towards my chest, making my body slide closer to the abyss. "Krypt!"

He laughs around my cock, pulling my knees back down. I want to make him laugh every day. "Don't shout too loud."

I won't. Because the echo of my voice is enough to bring this whole place down. I want to be buried with him someday, but not today.

"Fear is my thing. What's yours?"

"Power." His tongue licks my slit, making me writhe.

Obviously. "What else?"

"Dominance. Possession. You."

The fear I'm feeling mingles with pride. I'm the one who brought his sexuality to life...

Because I'm terrified to say it, I do. "I love you."

Krypt growls, and then he stands. He yanks me to my feet, my head narrowly missing the stalactite. With one hand latched around my wrist, he shoves against my chest with the other.

My stomach drops, my lungs seize, and every part of my body tingles with jarring fear as I start to fall over the edge.

"Kry—" My teeth rattle together when I'm jolted to an abrupt halt. The soles of my feet dig into the ledge, and the only thing keeping me from falling over is Krypt's vice-tight grip on my wrist. "No. No, no, no, no. I don't like this! Bring me back."

"I will," he says, his cock thickening in the ray of light. "As soon as you come."

I shake my head, trying to swallow the terror stuck in my throat. "I can't! I can't come like this."

"Then we'll be here a while," he says, looking at my arm, uselessly stretched out for balance. "Jerk yourself off, Remiel. Let me watch how fear lights you up." He smiles at me, and fuck, my cock throbs with need.

Shaking, terrified, and teeth chattering, I grab my cock in a tight fist, keeping my eyes on Krypt the whole time. When he uses his free hand to rub himself, I look down to watch. I move my hand up and down my length, not even ashamed that I'm this hard.

It doesn't matter that there's danger all around me because, once again, Krypt is in control of my life. He lets go, I fall. He pulls me back, I live. Whatever way this goes, we go together, because I'm dragging him with me if he tries to let me go. I grin at him.

Fear and fun. He's right.

Pleasure builds, mingling with darkness and delight. My body sweats while Krypt watches, and when I'm close, he laughs again. Then he lets go of my wrist.

"Krypt!"

He latches onto me, tugging me back up, and that's when my body loses its mind and I come, pumping my cock in an unrelenting grip.

"Holy fuck! I'm so sick. You're sick!" I babble.

"We're sick." He hauls me up, my cock still pulsing cum against his hip. "Now get on your knees and open your mouth."

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EPILOGUE

REMIEL

MY BROTHER ISN'T IMPRESSED. He's a goddamn hypocrite because he wants me to take the pills, but he refuses to let the doctor brain map his head.

Connectivity issues and reduced blood flow... is that really the cause of the Sauder curse? Why didn't my mom ever take me to get these tests? It was all failed therapy and warnings about what to watch out for.

"Told you," Cain says. "Suicide curses don't exist. It's chemistry and anatomy and genetics and all that shit."

"What do you know about chemistry and anatomy and genetics and all that shit?" Soren asks him, scoffing. "Remi, take the damn pills. Any line of defence is good, right?"

"Okay, then why won't you do it?"

Soren turns into Ghost before my eyes, and I get my answer. He doesn't want to change. He's still dark-minded and happy with the diagnosis he already has. He has an unrivalled sense of self that makes him the biggest asshole I've ever known, but there's something good about him, too. I don't hate him like I used to.

"I gotta get back," he says, handing me the bag with three pill bottles inside. "Take those, or Kr-Keegan will lose his shit." He glances at Cain, but Cain already knows who Krypt is. "See you later, yeah?"

Soren is a danger to himself. After all this time and the suicide curse almost taking me, he's still taunting death because it intrigues him. And since he's unwilling to see the doctor to know if his brain is the same as mine, I'm keeping my bargain with Krypt. And my brother is going to hate me for it.

“Yeah,” I say, glancing at the door. “At Mom’s?”

Soren stiffens, not liking our mom anymore. I’m not exactly sure what changed, whether it’s her mind control or something else, but ever since Krypt got back from Axel’s bunker, Soren has wanted to murder our mom. “Yeah. Selena will be there.”

“Okay.” I’m about to stall to keep him here longer when the front door of The Ambient Raven opens.

Two brothers walk in. Keegan and Killian Hallows. Keegan looks hot as hell and more dangerous than anything, but Killian has an easy, demonic smile on his face.

I’m sorry, Soren. But it has come to this.

“The fuck you doing here?” Soren snaps at Killian, getting right in his face. No idea what their spat is about, but Krypt says I can trust his brother, and unfortunately, I trust Krypt.

“You never know when to shut your mouth,” Killian says to Soren.

Then Killian acts. My brother is on the floor, fighting back, but Killian gets his hands behind his back, cuffs him, and shoves a rag to his face.

“The fuck!” Soren shouts through the rag. “Remi, the fuck is this?” He tries to look at me while fighting against Killian’s knee pinning him down. “What’d... you... do?” His voice slows.

“Bargain struck, Remiel?” Krypt asks.

“Bargain met,” I agree, grinning at him. “Sorry, Soren. You should have agreed to see the doctor.”

My brother fades out, Cain has no idea what’s going on, and Killian hauls Soren to his feet. He’s still conscious but not very coherent.

“Promise?” I ask Killian.

His smile is still demonic when he nods. “Trust me, Rem. He won’t do anything without me knowing.” I don’t know if I believe that since my brother can move around like a ghost, but I nod. He pushes Soren out the door, and then they’re gone. Swallowed up by Death Row foot traffic that doesn’t even blink at the sight of a drugged and restrained guy.

“What the fuck was that?” Cain asks when the door closes.

“The fate he picked,” I say, looking at him. “Want me to close up the shop?”

“Uh, no, it’s okay,” Cain says. “I’m gonna clean up and kill some time. I’ve got a tattoo appointment at seven.”

With Mason. Menace. The blue-masked Vile Boy Cain fucked but doesn't know. I feel like such a shitty friend for not telling him, but I'm certainly not going to while Krypt is standing here. I'll tell him later, tomorrow, after his appointment. And he should probably tell his girlfriend...

"Enjoy." I smirk at him.

"Remiel," Krypt calls out a warning for me to hurry. He's fucking bossy and impatient, but my god, it sends a thrill through me.

I tuck the medications into my jacket, grab my keys and phone, and follow Krypt out the front door. My brother is gone, under Riot's control now, and Cain is... well, Cain is in for a rude awakening when he realizes the tattoo artist who gives him ink and an orgasm every few months is the same man who chased him through the streets and fucked him hard on Initiation Night.

Krypt pulls me past Cauldron, not wanting to spend any time where I almost died, but he slows his steps again once we're past. It's Devil's Night, and like most holidays, Moros does it in style. For me, Devil's Night had always been about resisting the pull of an early death. There's something in the air this time of year, and a night that literally worships the depravity of our town, pulls pranks and turns the streets into a maze of Purgatory... well, I almost fell prey. This year, I have a hellhound nipping at my heels to keep me on the path that leads to life.

I brush his hand with mine, testing to see if he'll let me hold it. He pulls away, but it makes me grin a second later when he grabs my wrist instead.

"Where are we going?"

"Home."

Home. Vile House with Krypt. A warmth resonates all around me.



"WHAT'RE YOU DOING?" Krypt asks, snatching the bottle of body wash from me.

I squint my eyes at him. "You said home. This is home now, isn't it?"

"Yes."

"Okay, so I'm putting my body wash in the shower."

He throws it in the trash can.

“Krypt! What the fuck?”

His long fingers wrap around my throat, and my back hits the tile wall of the shower. The floor is wet, so my socks soak through, but my eyes shoot to his. For whatever reason, his monsters are all right there, at the surface, rattling their cages with sinister glee. “You think you get to smell like anything other than me, Remiel?” His hand tightens, his palm pressing against the word tattooed on my throat. “You are mine. You smell like me. You wear me. You belong to me.”

My god. “It’s just body—”

“No.” He spins me around, pressing my face to the tile wall. I gasp when the cold water turns on, drenching me and my clothing in ice. “See this bottle, Remiel? This is the bottle you can use. See this body, Remiel?” He runs his hand down my back and over my ass. “I wash it. Not you.”

His hips press against me, and my cock, hard and infuriatingly eager, hits the tiles. I groan, hating how much I love being completely consumed by him. He’s insane, unhinged in his possessive ideologies, completely batshit with the need to take my rights away, but then again, I kind of gave them up willingly, didn’t I?

“Krypt,” I groan. “Our bargain is over. We talked about being partners, didn’t we? I can touch my own body. Wash it.”

He rips my pants down to below my ass as the water warms. “I wash it. I own it. I hurt it. I heal it.” His fingers press against my taint. “I fuck it.” He pushes one finger inside me, making my eyes flutter. “Our bargain might be over, but a new one has started.”

“What one?” I push back on his hand, my fingers gripping the slippery wall.

“Our sick bargain, Remiel. The one that will take us into forever and teach us to be sick and sinister together.”

Fitting, I suppose, that this whole thing started with a bargain and ends with one, too. I don’t regret any of it. “Do I get to use my own toothbrush?” I ask, goading him.

“No.”

“Going to hold my cock for me while I pee?”

He adds a second finger. “I’ll terrify you until you piss yourself anytime, hero.”

I grin against the wall. God, I'm vile. "What're the terms of our new bargain?"

"Learned your lesson, did you?" He adds a third finger.

Yes, I did. I made a bargain without boundaries before, but I won't make that mistake again. This time, when I give up my rights and my life, I'm going to do it willingly and with a clear head.

"Own me," I say, setting the first term. "But love me, too."

He snarls behind me, but I can't see his face to know what his monsters are doing.

"Fuck me and force me and abuse me," I set the second term. "But make love to me, too. Learn how."

His fingers slip free, and the head of his cock presses against me. "You're the one who needs to learn how." His hands shove my legs together and his cock fucks through the space between my thighs. "You're all dire and harsh."

"I am?!" I scoff, the water getting too hot now. "You don't do gentle, remember?"

Gently, just to defy me, his hands massage my hips, his cock ruts through my thighs, and his tongue slowly licks the side of my neck. "I do," he whispers. "You're the one who turns everything so harsh."

Liar. Partially. We both do.

Krypt pulls my wet shirt over my head, and I spin in his hold, letting my soggy pants slap to the tile floor. Looking him straight in his eyes, I pull his shirt off and push his pants down, reaching around to caress his taut ass. In the mirror behind him, I see our names tattooed onto his back, and everything inside me settles into a calm so comfortable I feel my muscles relax.

"Show me how," Krypt says.

How to do gentle. Make love. Be soft. Intimacy without the depravity.

"We can learn together." I lift my leg and drape it over his hip, pulling him against me.

He grabs my leg and holds it in place, bending slightly to line himself up. When he pushes inside me, it's slow and filling, drawing a hitched breath from both of us. Holding the sides of his neck, I force his face right in front of mine.

"Look at me."

He does, and he doesn't look away. The eye contact that used to scare me with its intensity doesn't do anything but ground me anymore. I've never looked into another person's eyes and seen everything I love before. All of him. His monsters, his sexual vulnerability and the way he gets angry about being embarrassed by it, and the way he looks back at me, like he's never met someone who wants to see these parts of him.

When he's all the way inside me, I let out a breath, parting my lips. I might not be able to wash my own body or use my own soap, but with the level of comfort and safety I feel, it doesn't matter. Krypt will wash me of my sins and decorate me with new ones just to cleanse me forever.

"I love you," I whisper.

Then the softness turns to obsession, and I know he loves me back.

THE END.

Rank next.

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+++ RANK+++

DIRECTOR

TAKE OVER VILE HOUSE, they said.

It'll be fun, they said.

Yeah, because leading a group of ten psychotic, impulsive assholes is exactly my definition of fun.

Nothing but fucking trouble and fires I have to put out. Sometimes literal ones.

Goddammit, I love them all.

“Line up!” I shout as soon as I storm into the con room. Spent the morning being briefed by Media, the one in charge of making sure our crimes, identities, and jobs don’t get leaked. Was not expecting such a shit show, but here we are. Shouldn’t even be surprised at this point.

The ten of them get into rank, half of them snickering, the other half bored. All of them cocky and pissing me off. Kyd giggles because that idiot finds everything funny, and I hate that I love him for it. But Krypt and Ghost? They glare at each other, and I make a mental note to keep an eye on it. They fight, but not deeply, and it upsets everything when they’re off balance. Riot hides a devious grin behind their backs, but I don’t have the time to dissect it right now.

I can’t even look at Ransom at the end of the line. Can’t believe I did that to him. But he needs to learn what it feels like to be at the bottom again because I have plans for him... and he’ll need to keep more than Monster in line to succeed where I want to put him.

“Are you fucking kidding me?!” I snarl once they’re lined up. “With all the shit we have going on, you fucks thought it’d be a good idea to piss me off even more?”

Their faces reveal nothing. I'd like to think I taught them that, but it's just who they are. Kyd is smiling, but it gives nothing away because he's always smiling. Most of them have mastered the blank-faced look, but there's so much hidden under all that numbness. Above all, they fight like cats and dogs, but they're loyal. To each other. I definitely taught them that part.

"Which of you assholes decided it'd be a good idea to steal a lion from the city zoo and release it in Moros?" I point at each of them, but Kyd's hand shoots into the air.

"Full credit. Right here. You know I love lions, Director!"

I do know that. My god. "End of the line."

He skips. "Worth it. His name is Fabrizio, just so we're clear." He hooks his arm through Ransom's once he gets to the end, forcing him to do a twirl. "Can I bring him home? I'll feed him and walk him, and he can sleep in my room!"

I pinch the bridge of my nose. I don't even want to ask if he knows where *Fabrizio* is now. Media got a report of a lion being in the tunnels under Trigger Mountain, so I'll make him deal with that later.

Looking at Seven, because I consider him to be the most reasonable, I ask, "And who trapped seven tourists in the Asylum and called it an escape room event?"

His lips twitch, but his eyes give nothing away. "Hey, if seven people signed up willingly, what's the problem?"

"Did they get out?" I ask. I already know the answer.

"It was Devil's Night," Glitch says, drawing my attention to his handsome face. "Not our fault they went in for a thrill."

Bet they got the thrill of their lives. Scared to death, I hope not literally. "Bet you got a damn thrill too, didn't you?"

Again, his lips twitch.

I look down the line, trying to read their eyes. These deceptive, brilliant, brutal men are my family, but being in charge of them is a task no man would take on willingly. They listen, but only when they think the idea is their own. They fall in line, but only when the punishment annoys them enough to do so. They get the jobs done, but only because they love lording their power over everyone else. They work together as a unit because I've trained them to.

“Facts?” I ask, knowing he’s biting his tongue, wanting to regurgitate everything he knows. Despite his mind and everything it holds, he’s just as loyal as the rest of them.

“Hello,” he says predictably. Then he literally pinches his lips closed with his thumb and finger, and Menace laughs, reaching around Riot to tug Facts into a loving chokehold. Menace kisses his cheek and whispers something in his ear. Facts blurts, “They all got out.”

Riot clamps a hand over Facts’ mouth, grinning. “Don’t look at me. I was... otherwise occupied.” Riot’s eyes shift to Ghost, and once again, I make a mental note to keep an eye on their dark level of rivalry.

I made a deal with them a long time ago. Ghost and Riot are brethren but Soren and Killian can fight all they want as long as it doesn’t interfere with Vile House work.

“Fuck you, Riot,” Ghost snaps, turning to glare at his best friend like it’s somehow Krypt’s fault.

“Top rank to whoever tells me what happened with those seven tourists,” I bait them, knowing they won’t take it. “Only one of them has been heard from this morning.”

“Which one?” Monster asks, glaring at me. He’s the hardest one of this bunch. He’s got the deepest abyss of damaged anger within him, and he doesn’t like me because I’m above Ransom. He respects me, but nothing, other than whatever Ransom does to him, calms him down enough to function as a human being. Out of all my Vile Boys, Monster’s story is the one that breaks my heart the most. He’s been with me in Vile House since he was eight years old, and he’s done a lot of healing in that time, but he’s still warped to a degree I can’t penetrate. And his level of healing isn’t... logical. I love him as if he were my own.

“Gabriel Lucero,” I tell them, watching their reactions closely.

Krypt, Ghost, Riot, and Menace don’t react. Kyd smiles wider. Ransom watches Monster. Glitch and Seven glance at each other. Facts jitters.

Okay, so it was Seven and Glitch. “Sit down.” So much for Seven being the most reasonable...

They all make their way to the giant table in the middle of the room, and now that they don’t have to be in rank, they separate themselves based on current spats. It’s funny to watch how their opinions of each other change from day to day. When you put ten egotistical men in a room for all

their God complexes to mingle and war, their moods change depending on something as simple as a grin or a smirk aimed their way.

While they're in rank, I stand. When we're at the table, I sit at the head. I learned a long time ago to bring myself to their level while we talk about serious issues. It puts them at ease and makes them more responsive to conversation. Sitting, I look at my boys.

"I'll deal with Devil's Night punishments later. First, we have a vote."

They all perk up. Even Monster.

"Krypt put in a request for Remi to move into Vile House permanently. In favour?"

Everyone gets a say because it's their identities, personalities, and lifestyles at risk. They're bad people, but they're also vulnerable people, and when they're here, in the house they feel safe in, that's when their vulnerabilities come out. Bringing in new people is hard on some of them.

"Vote, yes," Ghost says first. "Since he burned my brother's house down, and I won't let Remi live with my mom."

"A hundred yeses because he's my bestie!" Kyd shouts. "He'll like Fabrizio."

Krypt looks at the table. He's not a submissive person, and having his eyes cast downward isn't a submissive act. He's restraining himself. Holding his inner beasts at bay. Reminding himself to calm down without the use of weed. Remi taught him that, and I've never been happier for Krypt.

"Yes," Riot says. "He's good for my brother. He's family."

"My vote is yes," Menace says. "Remi belongs here."

"Yes from me, too," Glitch says. "He fits."

"Hello." Facts stands. "I would like to vote yes." He sits back down. He stands back up. "Because he makes Krypt happy."

"Happy?" Krypt snorts, looking up at Facts.

"You smile sometimes. Three times that I've noted," Facts adds. "Now that you have him."

Krypt looks back down. There's that vulnerability, like smiling somehow makes him weak.

"He's a yes from me," Ransom adds. "Love Remi." Krypt growls, and Ransom grins.

"I vote yes, too," Seven says, nodding.

Monster is the last to answer, and everyone knows why. He looks at Krypt for a long time, no one interrupting because we all know what he's thinking. Monster is twisted, and his view of the world is entirely wrong, but it makes perfect sense to him.

"Is he weak?" Monster asks.

"Not anymore," Krypt answers.

Monster tilts his head, challenging Krypt to change his answer. Monster has a few triggers, and anyone vulnerable enough not to be able to protect themselves is his biggest one. Kids and pets are particularly hard for him. He wants to save anyone who can't save themselves, but his idea of saving them isn't logical. He'd rather kill a kid and grant them the gift of death than let them live in a bad situation. We're working on it, but he's still very much a work in progress.

"Is he suicidal?" Monster asks.

Krypt looks him right in the eyes. "Not anymore."

Monster's teeth clench. "Yes."

A unanimous vote. "Remi moves in for good, then." I smile at my boys, proud of them. "Next order of business. Axel Graves and Reaper Corp."

Kyd sighs.

Everyone else straightens up.

CURRENT RANK

1. Seven
2. Ghost
3. Menace
4. Riot
5. Facts
6. Glitch
7. Monster
8. Krypt
9. Ransom
10. Kyd

VILE BOY NAMES

RANSOM ->

SEVEN ->

GLITCH ->

GHOST ->

KRYPT ->

MENACE ->

RIOT ->

KYD ->

MONSTER ->

FACTS ->

SOREN SAUDER

KEEGAN HALLOWS

MASON

KILLIAN HALLOWS

MORE REVEALED AS THE SERIES GOES

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+++DEVIL'S NIGHT BONUS SCENE+++

REMI

There's a house in the middle of town. A big house, old and gothic, with an ominous air about it that has two opposite effects on people: it repels them, or it draws them in.

Well, I'm fucking drawn in. I live here now. A lunatic burned mine to the ground, stole my independence, and made me one hundred percent reliant on him. I should be ashamed of how weak that makes me, but I'm long past shame. I still have some dignity left, so I'll take my wins where I can get them.

The Vile Boys all greet me by name with varying degrees of warmth as Krypt leads me through the cafeteria-style dining area. I used to take offence to Glitch's twitchy eye contact or Facts' awkward greetings, and I got worried that Monster didn't like me because he never smiled and never said hello, just offered a dip of his chin and moved on. I know them now.

Glitch isn't rude, he's just introverted until he gets to know someone. Facts really is awkward, but it has nothing to do with me and everything to do with who he is, and Monster doesn't hate me. He hates everyone. Krypt told me that Monster won't get close to anything or anyone with a vulnerability, which, let's be real, is everyone. He doesn't like weakness, not because he's an asshole, but because he can't emotionally handle something that can't defend itself. Before I met him, I never knew that was a thing.

But I'm comfortable here now. I like Vile House. I like the strange men who live in it and the recruits who keep it running, and I like Director, Medic, and Psych. Mostly, I like living with Krypt. I might be clingy, but he's clingier, so fuck it. We know it's not healthy, and we're okay being sick.

I sit down at one of the long tables with Menace since I don't know where Riot and Ghost are, but Krypt shakes his head at me in warning. "Remiel."

Menace laughs.

God. I get up and join him at the serving table. "What? I can't sit?"

"You expect me to serve you?"

He does every other night.

"We aren't staying." He hands me an insulated thermos. "Make your tea or whatever. We're going out."

I glance around, noticing for the first time that the guys are on edge. It's Devil's Night, and they're all twisted enough to take part in something. What does Krypt have in mind?

After making a tea and Krypt taking it to seal the lid, he pushes me out of the cafeteria and leads me through the tunnels to the asylum.

"How's your therapy going?" he asks as our footsteps reverberate off the walls. I'm comfortable in this darkness with him because he isn't chasing me through it.

"Fine. It's weird not knowing my psychiatrist's name, though. She told me just to call her Psych."

"We all call her Psych. You're Vile now, so you play by our rules."

"She thinks the medications will help, and I'll see her once a week to check in on how they're making me feel until we get the dose right. What if they make me... numb and boring?"

"Then I'll force you to feel and make your life not boring," Krypt snaps at me. His voice softens when he says, "I'm supposed to see her again next week."

"Supposed to?"

"Don't want to anymore."

"Why not?" I shift the thermos to my other hand so I can touch him. I snag the back of his shirt, and he lets me hold on.

"Because I used to really want a diagnosis. Fucking confused by my own mind."

“You don’t anymore?”

“Don’t feel so confused anymore.” I can’t see him clearly since it’s pretty dim in here, but his glistening silver eyes turn in my direction. “I know the difference between hunger and arousal now. Don’t care how fucked up my head is because you get it.”

That’s probably the nicest thing he’s ever said to me. I take a single second to appreciate it, then say, “I’m not your drug, Krypt. You can’t diagnose yourself based on how I see you. We both know my interpretation is about as warped as it can get.”

Krypt pulls me to walk ahead of him, wrapping his arms around my neck. His feet walk on the outside of mine, and we’re unsteady and clumsy, but I love when he does this. “I like your interpretation of me, so that’s the one I’m going with.”

We don’t talk about it again. He won’t let me.

Gregory Malone is still fighting for freedom. He hasn’t lost his mind, given up, or turned feral yet, but he will. Especially because the Vile Boys keep coming to pay him a visit whenever they need an outlet, and eventually, Director and his team of medical professionals will use him, too. Maybe even Dr. Axel Graves. He’s a lab rat now.

The door to his room is iron and wood, but it has bars in it like asylums used to in the olden days. I peer through, watching the man who tried to taunt me into an early grave, getting a sick thrill out of being in control of his next two years. Gregory doesn’t know we’re here yet because his hands are bound and headphones sit on his ears, blaring something that’s probably driving him crazy.

“What’re we doing here?”

Krypt presses up behind me, his hard body leaning against mine. I grip the bars tighter and appreciate every solid inch of him. “You killed the first name on your list, Remiel. What do you want to do with the second?”

Honestly, I thought I’d be happy just knowing he’s here, off the streets, not creeping on me, my brother, and Moros residents anymore. But my breath turns shallow and my mind darkens at Krypt’s question.

What do I want to do with Gregory Malone?

“We could torture him,” Krypt seductively whispers against my ear.

I shiver.

“We could let him loose in these halls and you could stalk him for once.” His hand cups my ass and caresses. “Prey becomes the hunter.”

Tempting.

“We could take him to Trigger Mountain and let him experience The Mad House while the Vile Boys chase him.”

It would be fun to turn him mad.

Gregory Malone is going to go insane here, and after everything he’s done to me, I want his trip to insanity to be long and drawn out. If his mind snaps under that mountain tonight, he won’t appreciate his suffering here as much. I want him clear-minded and thinking there’s still hope for as long as possible. It’ll be so much more rewarding when he finally succumbs to the fate I’ve given him.

The best thing I can do to show Gregory Malone he didn’t win... is to be happy. Alive. Thriving.

I press back against Krypt, feeling diabolical. Water drips somewhere down the hall, a prisoner chatters in the distance, and the lights flicker, casting me in a shaky spotlight that hides my good parts and brings forth the newly awoken monsters inside me. The centre of my chest vibrates, and when I look at Gregory Malone with his forehead to the wall and his ass on the cot, my needs come alive.

“Fuck me,” I tell Krypt. “I want to get off to his demise. He fucking failed, and I want to throw it in his face. I ruined him. He’s here because of me, and I want him to see how *you* made me crazy, not him. I want to come while he cries.”

Krypt’s arm snakes around me from behind, his hand caressing up my chest until it wraps around my throat. “Finally accepting the hero role, Remiel?” he purrs, more seductive than I’ve ever heard him.

“Maybe. It’s the only time I’ve ever earned it.”

“Did you earn it?” he asks, drumming his fingers. “I brought him here. I captured him. Vile House did all the work.”

“I made the bargain.”

He hums to agree, then his fingers clamp around my throat. “No one sees you naked but me, Remiel.”

“Then blindfold him and let him listen.” I let go of the bars and reach back, cupping his hard cock through his pants. “Maybe I’ll fuck you and let him listen.”

Krypt growls right next to my ear. It brings goosebumps to my flesh and sends a pulse of fear down my spine. I moan when his lips land on the side

of my neck and gasp when his teeth clamp down. Pain radiates from the spot, hardening my dick and pooling lust in my gut.

“Figured you’d get pathetically needy,” he says, releasing my skin. His hand dips into his pocket and comes out with a travel-size bottle of lube. “Lube or blood, Remiel?”

Fuck, the thought of blood as lube intrigues me, despite how disgusting and dangerous it is. “Both.” Lube for actual lubrication and blood to sate my nasty curiosity. I rub him through his pants, and he almost breaks my wrist when he grinds against me. I rip my wrist free and groan at the press of his cock against the crack of my ass. He thrusts, and my head hits the bars to Gregory’s room, rattling the door. Whatever he’s listening to must be loud, because he still hasn’t looked in our direction.

“I’m going to tether him to that chair, take the headphones off, and blindfold him after he sees you.” He grinds. “Then I’ll fuck you until you’re screaming in nothing but power and fucking bliss, and when you come, he’ll listen to exactly how crazy I made you. Me, Remiel. Not him. I own your insanity.” Goddamn. My eyes close, anticipating everything and nothing, wanting to put on a show, but already so lost to the performance. Krypt brings me to life and sets me on centre stage, and I’ve never craved a spotlight like his. “Drink your tea, hero. Warm up those vocal cords.”

With a press of his lips to my neck, he releases me and puts on medical gloves. Gregory’s door is unlocked and opened, so I drink my tea while watching Krypt taunt him.

“What’s happening?!” Malone shrieks. I sip, shamelessly rubbing my hard-on against the doorframe. “You!” He snarls at me, spittle flying from his lips. Krypt takes the headphones from his head and tosses them aside, maneuvering Malone onto a steel chair that wobbles. “You put me here! Set me free, Remi Sauder, or I swear to fuck, I’ll—”

Krypt backhands him and tethers him to the chair. “You weren’t about to threaten him, were you?”

“N-no,” Malone stammers. “No, please. I just... let me go. This has gone on long enough. What are you doing?” He tries to break free, but Krypt is relentless, and my tea is sweet and warm. “What is this?! My wife, please! Think of my wife.”

“Your wife agreed to this,” I tell him. “She knows exactly where you are and even set the time limit for how long you’ll be here. You were there. You heard her.”

Why does this turn me on? To see the man who ruined my life, chased my brother to death, and haunted the rest of us like we were his playthings at Krypt's absolute mercy is an aphrodisiac so strong I doubt I'll need much prep. My body is already pliable and begging for it, and if I've come to know anything about myself, I'll taunt Krypt into taking me if I'm ready for him or not.

Am I capable of soft sex? Will we ever make love? Does that dynamic exist between the two of us? Do I want it?

With Malone strapped to the chair, ankles tied to the legs and arms behind his back, he rattles it uselessly. Krypt walks toward me, a blank expression on his face but trouble in his eyes. I love that look because it means he feels something. His stoic expression means he's holding back, but the riotous thrashing in his silver eyes shows exactly how affected he is. He can play nonchalant all he likes; I know what he's feeling. I grin at him, and he clenches his jaw. Malone screams his intolerance in the background.

"How's that tea, hero?"

I look at the thermos, untrusting. Dread pools in my gut. "What'd you do?"

Krypt finally smirks. "You trust too easily, Remiel." He grabs me by the throat and pulls me into the room.

"Krypt," I groan at him. "I don't want to be drugged. I want to be here for this!"

"You will be," he says, pressing me to the stone wall. My back hits hard, and the half-full thermos clatters to the floor and echoes down the hall. "And you're going to love every fucking second of it."

"What'd you give me?" I hold myself up, unsure if my legs are shaky because of what he put in my tea or if it's all in my head.

Krypt pulls the sheets off Malone's bed. They're filthy and unwashed, but he rips a strip off and ties it around Malone's head, covering his eyes. Malone protests the whole time, but I'm too busy taking note of my body and how it feels. I don't feel drugged, but I'm weirdly excited about what's coming. This isn't like the last time he drugged me. My body isn't uncoordinated and numb, and my mind still feels clear.

I'm happy, though. Happier than I should be given the dire circumstances. Light, even. Uncaring and unburdened by worry or fear.

When Malone is bound and blindfolded, Krypt takes off the gloves and circles him. "How does it feel to have him like this, hero? Do you feel

powerful?”

“Yes,” I whisper, fingers digging into the wall.

“What do you want him to know?”

I watch Krypt undo his jacket and take it off, and then I look at Gregory Malone and feel every feeling he ever forced upon me. Fear that he’d win. Grief because of what he did to my brother. Pain because of all the loss he caused. Anger at how ruthlessly he preyed upon the vulnerability of the Sauder curse.

“That he didn’t win,” I say, voice gaining power. “That he fucking failed. That I’m stronger than he is!”

Malone laughs.

“That he’s sick and fucking pathetic, but I’m sicker! I own you now, Malone! You fucking failed!” I snarl at him, coming unhinged.

He laughs again, and Krypt kicks his chair over. He crashes to the floor, wincing through his laughter. “You think you won?”

“I’m here and you’re there! I fucking own you!”

“I’m not your only demon, Remi.”

Krypt kicks him. Blood sprays along the floor, and he spits out a tooth. “I’m his demon, and I fucking promise you, I’m stronger than any other you set on him.”

“His own mother?” Malone says, and my breath freezes.

Casually, Krypt walks into the hallway and comes back with another pair of gloves. “Keep talking, Malone. This is going so well.” He dons them, nodding at my thermos. “Drink up, hero. You’ll need it.”

Apparently, I don’t care what he’s drugging me with. I pick up the tea and take another drink while Krypt sets Malone’s chair upright. I finish the whole damn thermos as Malone mocks me, still more powerful because he can get in my head.

He says my mother killed my dad by pushing him to kill himself. He says he haunts our family because my mom encourages him to. He says he was friends with my mom growing up, and the two of them wanted to play with the Sauder curse. He says he loves my mom and always has. He says I’m next, that my mom will get to me, that nothing, not even Krypt, will save me from what’s coming. He says Soren is almost there, skirting that line between life and death, and he says I’m too naïve to notice.

All the while, he’s lost more teeth, and he no longer needs the blindfold because Krypt has hit him so hard his eyes won’t open. While Krypt preys

on him, this drug preys on me. I'm still too light, but it's conflicted with the fear and anger I didn't feel moments ago. There's a part of me that wants to defy his wife's orders. I want to kill him now instead of waiting for two years.

"Hero," Krypt says, pulling off the gloves again now that Malone is broken and wheezing. "Don't."

"Don't what?" I ask, back still pressed to the wall.

"Don't let the words of one disgusting man overpower the words of me." He tosses the gloves and grips my chin. "You. Are. Mine. Say it."

"I'm yours." I breathe. Hard. Too fast. So deep it makes my head dizzy.

"I will protect you. Say it."

I wet my lips. "You will protect me."

He tilts my chin up and looks straight into my eyes. "Not even death, Remiel. Understand?"

Pliantly, I nod. "But I don't want death. Not anytime soon."

"Finally," Krypt says, taking the empty thermos from me. "Welcome to life, Remiel."

Slowly, he trails his hands down my neck and chest, feeling me gently. I shiver in pleasure and close my eyes to absorb the tickles and tingles. Caught in a slow, euphoric state, I appreciate every second of the way he undresses me like I'm special—precious. The cool, damp air feels nice against my sensitive skin, but his hands overpower that sensation by a million.

"Good and bad, Remiel. This is good." He puts my hand on his chest. "That is bad. Feel them both." He nods to Malone. He tugs me to the doorway and moves my hands up the frame, making me hold on. Behind me, he drops, and I gasp when his hands spread me open and his tongue lands on my hole.

I writhe in pleasure, barely able to keep my legs still as he opens me up and tongue-fucks my ass. It's not something I've ever felt before him, and holy fuck, my cock is leaking from it. It's different from the night in the cave because I'm appreciating it now. His lubed fingers replace his mouth, but he licks his way up my spine. I thrust in time with his fingers, my eyes fluttering shut to appreciate his gentle touch.

"What is this?" I ask, curious. "You've never touched me like this before."

“Don’t mistake gentleness for submission, Remiel. You’ll be crying soon.” His voice, jittery, abrasive, and harsh, lights me on fire. “Do you feel good?”

“Yes,” I moan. “What’d you give me?”

“Ecstasy,” he admits, nudging his dick to my entrance and slicking me in more lube. “You need to learn to associate sex with something positive. You’re too dark, Remiel.”

I squint, confused. “You just said you were going to make me cry.”

His hand wraps around my chin from behind, and he turns my neck until his lips are on mine. “Bite me. Hard enough to bleed.”

I do it because I’m a slave to him. He groans against my lips, and the rust of his blood fills my mouth. When he pulls away, his blood drips down his chin and he lets the rest pool on his tongue. Leaning back, I watch as his bloody spit drips down, landing warmly against my ass.

Both, I told him. Blood and lube. Fuck, he always keeps his word.

“Get off to his demise, Remiel. Come while he cries.”

Gregory Malone whimpers on the floor, listening but unable to see.

Krypt slams forward, burying himself inside me so hard and so deep that I lose my hold on the doorframe. He holds me up, treating me like I’m unbreakable. Because I am unbreakable. I’m fucking Remiel Sauder, defying a curse and owned by the Vile boy in the purple mask.

Bargain fucking met, Krypt.

INSTRUMENTAL MUSIC PLAYED

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KRYPT AND REMI PLAY TOGETHER AT THE AMBIENT RAVEN - CHAPTER 13

Cello & piano

- [BEAUTIFUL Cello and Piano Song!!! Film Score](#)

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REMI PLAYS IN THE ASYLUM - CHAPTER 22

- [The Darkest Cello Music - "Beginning to End"](#)
- <https://open.spotify.com/track/0FEMnf81Od5YSmNUvnnLFB?si=dc312b9a11744b7d>

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REMI PLAYS CELLO IN THE MAD HOUSE UNDER TRIGGER MOUNTAIN - CHAPTER 34

- ["Desolation" by Adam Hurst~ Deep, Dark Cello and Organ Original Music](#)

Music is a very big theme for me with this series. Especially instrumental music. If you want to check out the Vile House Playlists on Spotify, here are the links. The lists will grow as the series goes :)

Vile	House	Vibes:
<u>https://open.spotify.com/playlist/5cbUk64xSXTopcZOhwmo6Y?si=681821cec39a42eb</u>		

Vile	House	Instrumental:
<u>https://open.spotify.com/playlist/4jkPRaefbqy4B77lMBVjUy?si=e2b2b0a742684048</u>		

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THANK YOU!

Thank you so much for reading SICK BARGAIN!

I'm not a one-lane writer, and when I first got the idea for this series (based on their calling card image) I knew I had to let myself go there.

Sick Bargain has been completed for over a year! A year! I first wrote it that long ago, wondering if it would fit my brand in the MM romance realm, and guess what? I did it anyway! Because I love these boys and the harsh vibe of their town, and it's so easy to get swept up in Moros.

I hope you enjoyed Krypt and Remiel and their brand of sickness that heals. My favourite part about them is the psychological reasons behind how they feel and what they crave.

Next up we have Ghost and Riot - and hmm, how are we going to pair up a narcissist and a sociopath??? Let me tell ya, it's pretty volatile, but it only makes those vulnerable parts even better.

Afterall, we still have to end the Sauder Curse, right? Maybe these two can accomplish it ;) - Book 2 picks up right when Riot drugged and took Ghost from The Ambient Raven.

The plot with Reaper Corp will span the entire series, and I'm excited to show you how it all pans out. There are so many layers to these boys, their enemies, and their love interests, and delving into the depth of them is the part I enjoy most.

Like, can we trust Axel Graves? How'd he know about the threat? Why does Facts say hello so often? I promise the reason is heartbreaking. Will Cain ever find out who the guy in the blue mask is? How did Ransom get

his name, and how is Kyd able to be so happily delulu all the time? What's going on with The Misfits, and why is Ghost infiltrating their gang? And most importantly, how do they hook-up without their partners seeing their Vile House tattoo?! HAHA

All those questions will be answered! And so many more.

Like Director, pinch your nose and rub your temples because these Vile Boys are only just getting started on this crazy ride!

As always, thank you for being here :)

Nordika

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ALSO BY NORDIKA NIGHT

DARKER READS:

Alter Arlo —> [click here](#)

- So, you're craving something dark and twisty, eh? Well, come to this dark dystopian world and meet the boys! This one is psychological, has 2 couples, and comes with a twist that you might see coming. Might not. Go find out! The clues are all there if you look for them.

LIGHTER BUT STILL GRITTY READS:

THE WEEKDAY WEIRDOS SERIES:

- **RED FLAGS & TUESDAYS** —> [click here](#)

Reid and Atticus are battling a slew of Tuesdays and a whole bunch of red flags! Atticus is hard to get, but Reid isn't gonna stop trying. Together, they learn what romance means... to them. It isn't conventional ;)

- **SOBER DOPE & SUNDAYS** —> [click here](#)

Gage is out of rehab for the 8th (!!) time, and he's bound and determined to keep his shit together. Luckily for him, his new neighbour is a neurotic ramblor that becomes his perfect sober companion. They try to fight it, but fate has other things in mind :)

Garron Park & Lot 62 —> [click here](#)

- Meet Maddox and Devon, two rivals. Both in life and motocross. Their trailer park lives aren't easy, but together, they find a way to make things a bit more exciting.

- Not only do they start as rivals, but they stay rivals. This enemies to still enemies but also lovers story is full of tension and aggressive love languages.

Little Demon in the Details —> [click here](#)

- Craving a snarky brat that loves button pushing? Come meet Mercer! He's a little demon by nature, but he meets his match in Blake, the lethal man with the patience of a saint. Don't you dare call him daddy, though. Seriously. Don't. Blake doesn't like it.

- Their story is all about empowerment and a rise to the top despite all that is against them. There's spice, brattitude, and a burnt grilled cheese sandwich.

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NORDIKA NIGHT

Nordika Night doesn't know wtf she's doing most of the time, but that's life.

Writer of gritty MM romance in all tropes and hopefully lots of genres, she's still finding her lane.

Canadian.

Coffee lover.

Writing buddy: Waylon, her mastiff!

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I'm looking forward to what's next, grateful to the past, and trying to enjoy the present without letting it overwhelm me!

Nordika Night xo



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CONTENT GUIDE

INFO

This is a **CONTEMPORARY DARK MM ROMANCE** that centres around a group of guys that belong to Vile House, one of the societies in town. Each book will focus on one of the Vile Boys and will all be MM dark/darkish romances with different content warnings each.

I cannot judge the level of darkness against what your comfort levels and feelings are, so please read the content guide and take them seriously. This is darker than Alter Arlo, and not even in the same league as Little Demon in the Details or the From Nothing series. **THIS SERIES IS NOTHING LIKE THEM AND WAY DARKER.**

STORYLINE: dark themes, setting, environment

ROMANCE: dark, not healthy, twisted together, psychological reasons behind feelings

This is a series, so while each book ends on a positive note for the couple, some plotline answers and details aren't revealed until later in the series. Everything is interconnected, so reading in order offers the best understanding and experience.

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LISTED CONTENT GUIDES FOR BOOK 1

will be different for each book

- non/con, dub/con, SA, lack of consent, r@pe (between MCs, orally and with fingers)

- knife play, bl00d play, fear play (not always wanted)
- st@lking, possessive/obsessive/jealous behaviour
- ownership/control/power dynamics, bargains/deals
- dark society with a twisted ideal
- unprotected sex including sex that involves blood
- violence, murder, pain, fear
- a creepy town with a dark history and an unconventional way of life
- asylum setting (vague in this book)
- brainwashing, mind-control, drugging, degradation
- insane, morally grey main characters (some with psych diagnoses that won't be revealed until later in the series) who are sometimes redeemable but not always
 - societies, brotherhoods, g-a-n-gs, crews, c-u-l-t-s
 - hidden identities and some characters have two names (a birth name and a society given name)
 - descriptive scenes of fear, heights, pain, emotional upset, mental health, rough sex, and body modification
 - an initiation tradition that loosely resembles 'The Purge', including humans being hunted through town
 - Frequent mention of su-i-cide, and a heavy theme that revolves around avoiding death by su-i-cide, su-i-cide attempt
 - This is not a traditional romance. The main characters will be in a relationship, but the relationship isn't rooted in romantic love. Think: codependency, twisted together, my sickness feeds your sickness, it hurts to heal together

MOROS (the town) is entirely fictional. It is based *somewhere* in North America, but nowhere specific. No geolocation. The themes and content are from my own mind and are not meant to be a healthy guide.

Vile House is an eight book series with a conclusion (HEA - according to what suits them as people) for each couple, but the plot of the series continues throughout all 8 books. No romantic cliffhangers, but sometimes there will be storyline cliffhangers.

It is written in Canadian English - a mix of British and American.

Back to chapter one —> [Chapter 1](#)

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